

CREATED BY
RUSS MORRISSEY

ACE!

Omnibus

With foreword by
Sandy Petersen,
author of the
**Ghostbusters
RPG**

INTRODUCING THE
AWFULLY CHEERFUL ENGINE!
A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF ACTION COMEDY

The Awfully Cheerful Engine

By Russ Morrissey

Cover Art Phil Stone

Artists Claudio Pozas, bomg, Alexander_P, Savage Mojo, Rick Hershey, Jacob Blackmon, Xanditz

Playtesters Betsy Rosenblatt, Kevin Kulp, Alex White, Scott Moore, Jenn Platt

Spirits of Manhattan

By David F. Chapman
and Russ Morrissey

Cover Art Jason Juta

Artists Rafael Benjamin, Meshon Cantril, Mik Holmes, Yihyoung Li, Rachel Maduro

Cartography Meshon Cantril, Mik Holmes

Playtesters Betsy Rosenblatt, Kevin Kulp, Alex White, Scott Moore, Jenn Platt

Montana Drones

By Marc Langworthy

Cover Art Alba Palacio

Artists Xanditz, Alba Palacio, Phil Stone, Ellis Goodson

Playtesters Betsy Rosenblatt, Kevin Kulp, Alex White, Scott Moore, Jenn Platt

Strange Science

By Dave Chapman

Cover Art Alba Palacio

Artists Xanditz, Alba Palacio, Phil Stone, Ellis Goodson, pixabay.com

Playtesters Betsy Rosenblatt, Kevin Kulp, Alex White, Scott Moore, Jenn Platt

Beam Me Up

By Marc Langworthy

Cover Art Shutterstock

Artists Xanditz, Alba Palacio, Phil Stone, Ellis Goodson

Playtesters Betsy Rosenblatt, Kevin Kulp, Alex White, Scott Moore, Jenn Platt

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By Marc Langworthy

Cover Art Phil Stone

Artists Phil Stone, Ellis Goodson, Rita Marfoldi, Rafael Benjamin, Sade

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By Walt Ciechanowski

Cover Art Phil Stone

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By Ben Rogers

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By Russ Morrissey

Cover Art Phil Stone

Artists Phil Stone, XavierDesign, Vectorpocket, Pretty Vector, Scc.comics, funnybear36, Formyline, klaksun, 21studiodesign, goodstudio, klyaksun, Sararoom Design, Angeles, Teguh Mujion, HitToon, Macrovector, pixabay.com

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ACE!
Issue 1

AWFULLY CHEERFUL ENGINE!

Well, the nice people behind the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* asked me to write a

foreword for their terrifyingly fun little game. They said they chose me because of my boyish good looks, but I refused to send them a photograph anyway. So ... things came up, and I wasn't able to write that foreword after all. Sorry guys. This is my explanation why.

I decided that before sitting down to the gruesome endeavor of writing the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* foreword, I'd stop by the store and get some snacks. You know – pork rinds, crappy 7-11 nachos, diet Dr Pepper. To fortify the inner man for the task. Before I left, I called to my wife upstairs. "Hey, you want something from the store?" She was in the shower, and all I heard was "garble garble Red Monkeys burble." Red monkeys? Must be some new thing. Maybe a brand of glue for one of her projects? Who knew.

Anyway, I walked into the store, and, having no idea what red monkeys were, walked over to the proprietor and asked, "Do you have any red monkeys?"

"WHAT did you ask?!" he shouted, his face turning as red as a monkey.

"Red monkeys, dude. Got some?" I was still oblivious.

"Get out of here at once or I'll call the cops!" he hissed. I was appalled. I backed up slowly, but he charged forward, literally grabbed me by my collar and the seat of my pants and threw me onto the sidewalk. Holy smokes, I didn't expect that.

There was a cop car in the convenience store parking lot, and he was staring, so I walked over. "That guy just threw me out of his store for no reason!"

Naturally, the cop asked, "No reason?"

I told him, "Yeah, all I did was ask if he had any red monkeys."

The cop's eyes bugged out of his head. "You pervert! You're going down!" He rolled out of the cop car, fast as anything and clubbed me over the head with his tonfa baton. When I came to, he'd handcuffed me and dragged me into the back seat of the car.

"Wait!" I yelled. "I didn't do anything. I just want to get home and write the foreword for the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* game! It's amazingly entertaining! They did a lot of yeoman work on it, and it needs that foreword!" All I saw was the back of his bullet-head, hunched over the steering wheel.

They threw me into a cell. I called my lawyer, and he asked for an immediate hearing. That afternoon me and my lawyer went before the judge.

"Why is this indictment so rushed?" asked the judge.

My lawyer explained on my behalf. "Sandy has responsibilities. He needs to write his foreword for the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* – it's a roleplaying game of parodies on well-known topics. You know, like Ghostbusters, Indiana Jones, Stranger Things, Star Trek, and so forth. Everyone who plays it loves it."

The judge nodded sagely, "Okay, let's get on with it."

My lawyer put me on the stand, and I said, "Look, the cop clubbed me and arrested me. He didn't even give me a reason. I'm sure it's some misunderstanding. I love cops! Just let me go and we'll hear no more of it, though it would be nice if you paid my lawyer's fee."

The judge said, "Well, what had you done just previous to your arrest?"

Like an idiot I said, "I told him I was looking for red monkeys."

The judge's face darkened. "What?! That's it, sonny boy. I ought to sentence you to death! It's life, for you anyway."

"What?" I shrieked. "How can you do that? This is just a hearing! What happened to all the delays and blockages and left-wing advocates that talk radio assures me keeps capital punishment from its full effect?!"

I turned towards my lawyer, but he was scowling too. He declaimed pompously, "You'll get no argument from me, your honor. Lock him up and throw away the key. Or whatever. I withdraw my services."

Stunned, the bailiff dragged me back to my cell. I asked for a phone call, and I used it to tell Morrur, at the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!*, that my foreword would be a little delayed. Sorry about that. Morrur said



they'd hold open the slot as long as possible. If I was too late, though, they'd have to get Harlan Ellison instead. I didn't have the heart to tell him that Harlan had passed away a couple of years ago. I got the impression that Morrur wasn't "with it" if you know what I mean.

Anyway, the next day I was sent to the state prison. What a nightmare. This huge guy, buff from years of the prison work-out gym, shoved me in the courtyard, and asked me what I was in for. He could tell I didn't belong I guess. I said, "Look, all I did was ask about red monkeys." Then I flinched.

But the guy flinched instead. "You were looking for red monkeys! Whoa." He backed off. Huh.

The next day I asked for a pencil and paper so I could write that damn foreword for the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* They gave me a crayon, not a pencil, so I wouldn't kill myself with it. I guess they'd seen that scene in *The Dark Knight* once too often.

While I was FINALLY writing the foreword, the huge guy came sneaking back. He said, "Look, Sandy. You want out of here?"

"DO I? You know it!" I ejaculated.

"Well we're planning a break for tomorrow night. The guys all agreed they want you in on it as extra muscle." I wondered, extra muscle? I'm 65 years old and my only workout is carrying cases of Mountain Dew Code Red to my drink fridge. But hey a chance to get out of here? I'd take it.

The next day there was a huge prison riot. You probably read about it. About a dozen guards were hurt, and 3 inmates were killed. But, in the confusion, two of us managed to get over the wall and outside without being noticed. We ran into the scrubby Texas woods.

The other escapee turned to me and said, "Look, you give me the heebie jeebies, so let's split up. I'm headed to Mexico. You go just south – here's why. The answer to your questions is down there, in Ding Dong. Go find it."

Yes, Ding Dong, TX is a real place. Look it up. The Gatesville Correctional Facility is only about 40 miles away, so I headed there. Obviously I just had to know what the hell was a red monkey. Oh, and Morrur – if you're reading this, yes I managed to write most of your foreword with my crayon, but in the escape, it got left behind. Probably burned to ashes in the fire. Sorry about that.

Anyway, after a few adventures you don't want to hear about, I made my way into Ding Dong, which is pretty ding dang small, but it did have a few buildings. There was the fire station, a Country Pride market, and Holy Crap, right there across the freeway, a small building had a hand-painted sign that said DESMOND ZZYPT, LICENSED DISTRIBUTOR FOR RED MONKEY PRODUCTS

My mind was focused. My body was ready. All I could see was that sign, looming mightily before me. I remember wondering why the guy didn't use red paint for his sign, but it was just the usual black on yellow. I staggered across the highway. I never heard the air horn.

Halfway over, a semi hit me straight up. Killed me dead as a doornail. Always wondered about that phrase. You'd think a coffin nail would be deader than a doornail. Anyway, what with being dead, I feel I'm off the hook for writing the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!*'s foreword. This message is being sent to the well-known medium Lady Zenobia. She says she'll pass it along to Morrus, so he can try to get Harlan Ellison instead (snigger).

Sandy Petersen, Author *Ghostbusters RPG*

Sandy Petersen is one of the authors of 1986's award-winning *Ghostbusters* roleplaying game. Not only was that frightfully cheerful roleplaying game the first ever RPG to use a dice pool mechanic, it was also one of the main inspirations for the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!*

Introduction

This tabletop roleplaying game, which we're calling *ACE!* with an exclamation point, is one of fast, cinematic, action comedy. With the emphasis on comedy. To play you need a handful of six-sided dice, a pen, and some paper. Each player plays one Hero, except for one player who takes the role of the Director. Think of *ACE!* as an irreverent, fun-packed movie. You might play as ghost hunters in New York City, a band of plucky galactic guardians, vampire slayers, or soldiers of fortune in the Los Angeles underground. Heck, you might even be cartoon animals. Good grief!

What's a Roleplaying Game?

A roleplaying game is a social game where a group of friends get together and pretend to be monsters and elves and spacemen. One of the players, who we call the Director, describes the story, and the other players, who are the Heroes, tell the Director what they are doing. Sometimes they roll dice to see if they manage to do the thing they want to do.

Here's an example of play to help you get the idea!

James, Leonard, and Nichelle are playing Indiana Bones (a Cowardly Dog), Dr. TikTok (a Cheerful Robot), and Karlov the Blue (an Elderly Wizard). Sasha is the Director. A bunch of Tommy Gun wielding apes wearing prohibition era gangster suits have taken over a department store, led by a gorilla called Bob Hope. The Heroes are here to save the day!



The Director: OK, you've reached the end of the street. You can see the department store at the other end. On the roof of a parking garage to your right you can see an ape looking down at you, a Tommy Gun in hand. And on top of the department store is another ape... this one with what looks like a bazooka!

Indiana Bones: Yikes! Is there anywhere I can hide?

Karlov the Blue: You're such a coward, Indiana!

Director: Yes, there's a bunch of cars in



C'mon kid,
let's kick some
@\$\$!!

A.C.E.!
AWFULLY
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ENGINE

the street. Most of them are riddled with bullet holes!

Indiana: OK, I'm hiding behind a car so the apes can't see me.

Director: Let's see how well you do! Make a Moves roll. I'll have the apes make a Smarts check.

Indiana: I got a 12!

Director: That beats the apes! You're well hidden, Indiana! Also you get a Karma point for playing your trait.

Dr. TikTok: This is such fun! Talking apes! I'm going to call up to the one on the garage and try to talk him out of his poor life choices. I'm sure I can turn his path around!

Director: Hmm. OK, it won't be easy, but I guess Dr. TikTok is an eternal optimist! Make a Style check.

Dr. TikTok: I rolled 9!

Director: Sadly, that's not enough. The ape responds by opening fire with his Tommy Gun, spraying you with hot lead! What's your Defence?

Dr. TikTok: My Defence is 10.

Director: The bullets ping all around you, but you emerge unscathed - this time, at least! But the ape with the bazooka appears to be taking aim!

Karlov: Time for a spell! I'm sending a swarm of bees at the ape with the bazooka!

It's Multigenre!

Some roleplaying games are strictly fantasy or sci-fi. They have a world or setting which defines the characters you can play and the types of adventure you can have.

Not this one.

This is a multi-dimensional, time-hopping, genre-mashing, pan-galactic portal into any type of adventure you can imagine! Want to play in a fantasy world full of elves and orcs? Crew a starship as it explores the galaxy? Hunt vampires in Victorian London? Play as animal detectives, robot cowboys, wizards, ninjas, or time traveling bounty hunters? The only limit is your imagination, and the requirement that you have *fun*.

Your Director can make these adventures up for you. To help you on your way, you can also buy adventures from us. Like this book, they come in a handy comic-book sized format, and each one contains a new world to play in, new Hero roles to adopt, new monsters and villains to defeat, and an entire adventure your Director can run for you. The first one is called *Spirits of Manhattan*.

About This Book

This book is divided into the following sections.

INTRODUCTION. This bit. You're reading it right now.

CHAPTER 1: CREATING YOUR HERO.
How to create your Hero.

CHAPTER 2: HOW TO PLAY. The basic rules of the games.

CHAPTER 3: FOR THE DIRECTOR. A veritable plethora of villains and monsters.

Words Have Power!

DIRECTOR. The person in charge of the game. Y'know—like a director.

EXTRA. All characters, villains, and monsters played by the Director.

FOCUS. An area of specialization or expertise related to a Stat.

HERO. A character played by one of the players in the game. That's you!

KARMA. An expendable resource which you can use in tricky situations.

ROLE. This is the thing that defines who your character is—such as a cowboy, a robot, or a talking dog!

STAT. Four values which describe your core qualities. Because we all know people can be fully summarized with four numbers.

TRAIT. This is a characteristic that your Hero has, such as Brave, Squeamish, or Cheerful.



Chapter 1: Creating Your Hero.

A.C.E.!
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ENGINE

When you play this game, you'll be taking on the role of a Hero with a capital-H. In this book, when we say 'Hero' we mean a character, or persona, adopted by a player in the game. If you've played other games, which you probably have, 'Hero' just means "character". But these are goddamn Heroes!

First things first, you should decide who your Hero is. A grizzled detective, a heroic turtle, a paranormal scientist, an emotionless robot? Your Hero is whoever you want them to be. Once you've decided who your Hero is, you can use the following process to 'build' them!

Hero Checklist

To create your Hero, follow these steps.

1. Choose your Role.
2. Spend 12 points between your four Stats. Each Stat must be between 1 and 5.
3. For each Stat, write down one Focus.
4. Work out your Defence and your Health.
5. Choose a Trait.
6. Oh, and don't forget to give your character a name! Otherwise how will they make reservations at restaurants?

Name Bertram Gilmore			
Trait/Role Squeamish Scientist			
Health 2 Defence 9			
Stat	Dice	Focus	Dice
Smarts	5	Physics	7
Moves	3	Shooting	5
Style	2	Persuasion	4
Brawn	2	Climbing	4

1. Role

First, select your Role. Your Role is what makes you 'you'; it's the thing that really stands out about you. This isn't an exhaustive list, but it's a good start! Of course, not all Roles are appropriate for all games, so check with the Director before having a talking dog show up in their 1920s gangster game.

Don't worry too much right now about the technical stuff. Just pick a Role that appeals to you. You'll learn what they mean later. These Roles are divided into categories for ease of use, but don't feel restricted by those categories.

The list below is a generic list; specific worlds and settings may have different Roles available.

For the sake of clarity, we assume that all creature types are sentient and can talk. Though we don't guarantee that they have anything interesting to say.

TALKING ANIMALS

- ★ **APE.** You're a walking, talking ape! You can jump 30 feet in the air with no effort. Also, when you throw things, you do an extra point of damage!
- ★ **CAT.** Agile and sneaky though you are, your main power is your nine lives! Roll a die; that's how many lives you have left. When you would normally be Knocked Out, instead you remain at 1 Health.
- ★ **CROW.** You can fly. That's good, isn't it? It doesn't have to be a crow; you can pick a different bird if you want.
- ★ **DOG.** A loyal companion, if there's something to smell you can always smell it. Also, sometimes you smell.
- ★ **KANGAROO.** Kangaroos pack one heck of a punch! You punch does an extra point of damage. Most people try to ignore the boxing gloves.
- ★ **TURTLE.** A hero in a half shell, you reduce all damage done to you by 1 point.





I'm a monster!
Rawr!

A.C.E.!
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SPECIES

- **ALIEN.** You have psychic powers! You have a Power stat, although you don't get extra points to distribute.
- **DWARF.** Grumpy, and with a Scottish accent (if you want), you can appraise the value of things with a single glance.
- **ELF.** You're very sneaky, and when in natural surroundings, you can be effectively invisible.
- **GHOST.** You don't take damage unless its from a holy source or some special sci-fi ecto-gadget. But you also can't pick things up. So there's that.
- **GOBLIN.** Vicious little scrapper, you can snatch small items from your opponent instead of attacking.
- **GOLEM.** You may be slow (you always go last in the turn) but you also take half damage (round up) because you're, like, made of stone or metal or something.
- **HOBBIT.** You're a brave little hobbit. Hobbits have tremendous reserves of courage, so you might be scared, but you are never affected by fear.
- **MONSTER.** Grrr! I'm a monster! You're very scary. If you make a Style check against somebody's Style, they have to run away for a minute. You can only do it to them once though.
- **OGRE.** Big, scary ogre. If you don't put loads of points into your Brawn Stat you're going wrong somewhere. Anyway, you get an extra +1 to your Brawn Stat, and an extra +2 Health.
- **ROBOT.** I AM A ROBOT! You're basically immune to fear and mental stuff. Cuz you're a robot.
- **VAMPIRE.** Creature of the night! When you make an unarmed melee attack, you gain 1 Health as you suck your victim's blood. But you can't go out in the sunlight.
- **WEREWOLF.** You take double damage from silver weapons, but you do get to turn into a wolf at night. You have the same stats, but you're a wolf.

Let's make
magic happen!



FANTASY

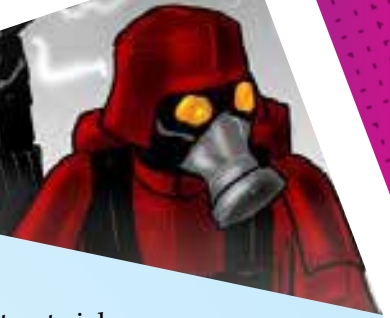
- **ALCHEMIST.** You know potions and stuff. You can spend an hour to make a potion that cures any ailment, curse, or disease.
- **ASSASSIN.** You're so good at killing people. You do double damage on your first attack against somebody.
- **BARBARIAN.** In tune with nature and good at smashing stuff. When outdoors, in a natural environment add 1 to all your damage scores.
- **CLERIC.** You can turn the undead. Make a Style check vs. their Defence. If you succeed they can't come within 10 feet of you for an hour.
- **DRUID.** You can speak to animals. That doesn't make them suddenly intelligent, though.
- **KNIGHT.** Chivalry is your middle name. You can take damage for an adjacent ally.
- **NINJA.** You can turn invisible for a minute once a day.
- **OUTLAW.** You're wanted by the law! Wait, that's not a useful ability. But you do have a free hideout where you can't be found.
- **PIRATE.** Scourge of the Seven Seas! Aaar matey! You have either a hook hand (+1 unarmed damage) or a parrot. Or both, if you like.
- **RANGER.** You are amazing at tracking things. In outdoor environments you can stay on the trail of another person or creature as long as you are no more than a day behind.
- **SAMURAI.** You can spend a Karma point to use your Ki! When you do that, your attack with your deadly katana does double damage.
- **SLAYER.** What do you slay? Vampires? Probably. You do double damage to the thing you slay. No, you can't choose humans.
- **WIZARD.** You can do magic! You have a Power stat, although you don't get extra points to distribute.

OCCUPATIONS

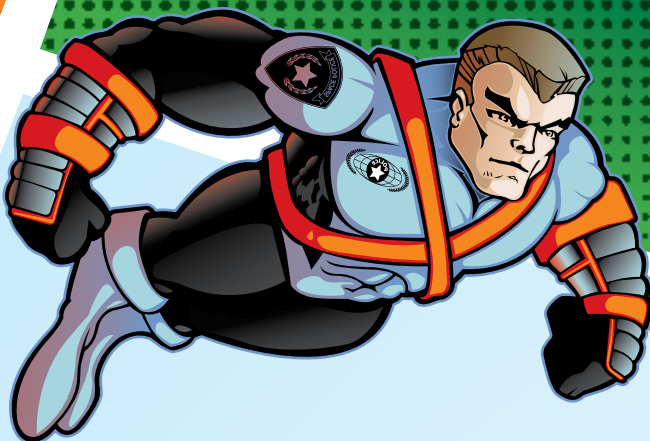
- **ACTOR.** Star of stage and screen, you are great at pretending to be somebody else. Your disguises always work.
- **ARCHAEOLOGIST.** You've raided tombs and lost arks. If there's a trap, you can spend a Karma point to circumvent it.

I should have become a lawyer as my mother wanted...

A.C.E.!
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- **ASTRONAUT.** All that time in zero-g means you just don't get sick any more. You're immune to the feeling of nausea.
- **ATHLETE.** You can move twice as far in your turn. Normally you can move 10 feet per point of Moves, but you're an Athlete — you can move 20 feet per point of Moves!
- **BOUNTY HUNTER.** You can spend a day, and at the end of it determine the location of any individual person or creature. Catching them might be another matter!
- **BOXER.** With a quick One-Two, and swift K.O., you really know how to punch. Your unarmed damage increases by 1. And also, once per day, when you would normally be Knocked Out, you can choose to remain on 1 Health.
- **BURGLAR.** Sneaky does it! Up that wall, through the window, crack the safe! Locks mean nothing to you.
- **CHEF.** You can cook up an amazing meal in an hour, which gives everybody 1 Health back. Plus you do +1 damage with knives.
- **CON ARTIST.** Liar, liar, pants on fire! You have a collection of very convincing fake IDs, and can pull out any one you need at a moment's notice.
- **COWBOY.** Yeehaw! Fastest gun in the West! When deciding who gets to go first, you get a quick shot in before it all kicks off.
- **DETECTIVE.** Are there any clues? If there are, you spot them automatically. You don't even have to roll any dice!
- **DOCTOR.** Medic! You can heal people. For every Karma point you spend, you heal somebody (or yourself) one point of damage. This takes you a minute, but you can spend as much Karma as you like.
- **ENGINEER.** If something is broken, you can fix it within an hour. Well, within reason. Not like the Golden Gate Bridge or something, but a vending machine or a car.
- **GAMBLER.** You rely on luck. Any time when there's equal chances of something, you can spend a Karma point and it works out in your favor.
- **GANGSTER.** You know how to make someone an offer they can't refuse. You gain the Intimidation Focus for free, in addition to whatever other Focus you choose for your Brawn Stat.
- **HACKER.** Breaking into computer systems is what you do. You can circumvent computer security. It usually takes you about an hour.



- **HERMIT.** You live alone. People aren't much use to you. When you're acting alone, without allies, you get an extra die.
- **INVENTOR.** A gadget for every occasion. You can spend a Karma point to pull out a gadget which helps you with your next dice roll. You have to describe the gadget. Basically, you get double value from Karma points - two extra dice instead of one.
- **MUSICIAN.** Sing me a song, oh music man! You can make music, and everyone who can hear it is affected. Roll your Style Stat vs. their Smarts Stat, or they are basically dazed for a minute. Unless you do something to snap them out of it like hit them or make a loud noise. After the minute they can't be affected again.
- **PILOT.** You know how to fly planes. Or spaceships.
- **PRIEST.** The undead cannot harm you. They're still pretty scary, though.
- **PROFESSOR.** You know stuff. You get free Focuses in History, Languages, and Theology.
- **REPORTER.** Nothing can keep you from that scoop! You know how to ask the right question. Once per day, you can ask an Extra a question. You get the answer if they know it. Just the one question, mind, so choose wisely!
- **SCIENTIST.** If a monster has a weakness, you know it automatically. It's just a question of physics.
- **SMUGGLER.** You're pretty good at hiding things. If you have something hidden about your person, or in your vehicle, or your spaceship, or your... well, you get the idea. Anyway, they won't find it.
- **SOLDIER.** You are great at tactics. When deciding who goes first, it's you.
- **SPY.** You know how to make the bad guy give you a monologue explaining their whole plan. Weirdly, time kinda freezes while they do it. Then they laugh manically, or something.
- **STUDENT.** Funny how heroes often seem to be high school kids! You have homework, and the principal is on your back. But you can pretty much get away with stuff because you're a kid. People just overlook you. More fool them!
- **STUNTMAN.** You never seem to get injured. You take damage, but you always manage to get up again—you recover ALL your Health every day.



SUPERHEROES

- **SPEEDSTER.** You go fast. Real fast. Each turn you get two actions instead of one.
- **VIGILANTE.** Dark crusader of the night? Ex-cop out for revenge? The criminals are all afraid of you, and rightly so. I mean, *we're* afraid of you and we're just the writers of this game. Once per day you can make a Style roll vs. a criminal's Smarts, and if you win they basically surrender and beg you not to hurt them. If you lose, they laugh and probably try to kill you, and you can't use this ability against them ever again.

Don't like any of the suggestions on this list? Hey, just invent your own! All the different worlds and settings will have a recommended list of Roles, along with some new ones.

What Does My Role Do?

Your Role gives you one special ability—a thing that only you can do. You should write that down somewhere so you don't forget. I mean, if you want. We're not trying to tell you what to do.

I Want Two Roles!

You want to be a Ninja Turtle? Or an Elf Ranger? Or a Druid Astronaut? Wait, *really?* A *Druid Astronaut*? You can do that. But you only get one of the Role abilities. Your Ninja Turtle can turn invisible *or* absorb damage with its shell, but not both. Your secondary Role is just descriptive, but it's still awesome.

2. Stats!

Now for some numbers! Your Hero has four Stats: Smarts, Moves, Style, and Brawn. A score of 3 in a Stat is equal to an average human adult. You have 12 points to divide between these four Stats in any way you wish, but you cannot put more than 5 in a Stat, and no Stat can be less than 2.

- **SMARTS** measures how clever, perceptive, and knowledgeable you are. You might use Smarts to crack a cypher, remember an obscure fact, or spot a trap.

- **MOVES** measures how quick, accurate, and agile you are. You would use Moves to win a race, shoot a pistol, ride a horse, or balance on a tightrope.
- **STYLE** measures how cool, stylish and charismatic you are. Style is used to trick a guard, seduce a villain, or sing a song.
- **BRAWN** measures how strong and tough you are. Brawn is used to hit things, lift things, or withstand damage.

It's Supernatural!

Some games feature a fifth Stat called Power. This represents magic, psionic power, or similar abilities. It works like the other Stats. But it's magic. Or something.

Power can be used to do anything that the other Stats can do. You can shoot a ninja with an energy bolt, read somebody's mind, levitate up a wall. Whatever you want. But it has limits—every time you use it, you spend a Karma point, and when your Karma expires, you can't use your Power any more. So ration your Power, and choose when to use it!

Not every Hero gets a Power Stat. You only get one if your Role says you do. Y'know. Wizards, Aliens, stuff like that. Some monsters, ghosts and other Extras also have a Power Stat.

3. Focus

A Focus is an area of expertise or special talent. For each Stat, you have one Focus. For example, your Smarts Focus might be History, or your Moves Focus might be Shooting. There's a list of available Focuses below, and you should note each Focus next to its related Stat. In academic terms, a Focus is like a Bachelor's Degree, although of course many areas of expertise don't come with fancy certificates.





Here's an example Hero—Bertram, a starship science officer. Let's give Bertram four Stats and assign some Focuses. He's great at physics, as he's a scientist; he gets some training in shooting as a starship officer. He's not super charming, but he's had some training in diplomacy, and his hobby is rock climbing. We've given him the following Focuses:

Smarts 5 (Physics)

Moves 3 (Shooting)

Style 2 (Persuasion)

Brawn 2 (Climbing)

All monsters and villains, collectively known as Extras, have Stats like this too. A mighty Tyrannosaurus Rex has a Brawn Stat of 10. Extras might not always have Focuses in every Stat and they might have unusual Focuses. The T-Rex also has more Health than you'd expect, because it is a large creature. But we'll talk more about monsters and stuff later. We're getting off-topic!

List of Focuses

What follows is a list of Focuses available for each Stat.

Smarts. Accounting, Archeology, Astronomy, Biology, Bureaucracy, Botany, Chemistry, Chess, Computers, Cooking, Electronics, Empathy, Engineering, Gaming, History, Languages, Law, Mathematics, Medicine, Nature, Occultism, Parapsychology, Perception, Physics, Theology, Zoology.

Moves. Acrobatics, Dodging, Driving, Juggling, Piloting, Riding, Running, Sailing, Shooting*, Stealth, Surfing, Thievery.

Style. Animals, Bluffing, Dancing, Disguise, Fashion, Flirting, Gambling, Music, Persuasion, Public Speaking, Singing, Wealth.

Brawn. Brawling*, Bodybuilding, Breaking Stuff, Construction, Climbing, Drinking, Eating, Intimidating, Jumping, Lifting, Sports, Stamina, Swimming, Tough.

Power. Fire, Insects, Ice, Plants, Light, Darkness, Mind.

* *Brawling is a word for any melee combat, whether armed or not. Shooting is a word for any ranged combat.*

If you want a Focus not listed above, ask the Director. They might say yes! And don't worry, you can also buy more Focuses later in the game as your Hero advances and learns new skills.

4. Defence & Health

You also have a Health score equal to your Brawn Stat. Your Health is reduced when you take damage, and you are Knocked Out when it reaches zero. The average person can take a punch, but a couple of punches or a knife will take them out. If you have Tough as your Brawn Focus, you can add 2 to your Health.

You don't die in *ACE*! When you're Knocked Out, you're just out of the action for five minutes, after which you wake up with 1 Health.

Defence. Moves $\times$ 3. Add 6 if your Moves Focus is Dodging.

Health. Equal to Brawn. Add 2 if your Brawn Focus is Tough.

Next, you need to calculate your Defence. This is equal to your Moves Stat multiplied by 3. If you have a Moves Focus of Dodging, you can add 6 to your Defense.

The lowest your Defence can be is 8. If it ends up less than 8, increase it to 8. That's basically how hard it is to hit a target standing still.

5. Trait

Finally, you should choose a Trait. While your Role gives you a special ability, your Trait introduces a complication. The list of Traits follows.

Oh, and one more thing—no two Heroes in your group can have the same Trait! That would just be boring, and we don't want that do we? Celebrate the variety and enjoy your differences!

On your Hero ID Card, you will write your Trait and your Role. Your Trait is always an adjective, and your Role is always a noun, so you write something like "Squeamish Scientist" or "Paranoid Robot". These two words effectively describe you. You should use them when you introduce your Hero to the other players.





List of Traits

Abrasive	Affable
Angry	Apologetic
Brave	Beautiful
Cautious	Cheerful
Clumsy	Cocky
Cowardly	Cynical
Elderly	Evil
Greedy	Gullible
Forgetful	Hardy
Heroic	Honest
Impulsive	Inattentive
Kindly	Larcenous
Lazy	Logical
Lustful	Naive
Obsessive	Optimistic
Paranoid	Phobic
Punk Rock	Quiet
Sentimental	Smelly
Squeamish	Teenage
Tiny	Unlucky
Vain	

Karma

You start play with 6 Karma points. You can spend these points during play for a number of effects.

- ★ **ADD AN EXTRA DIE TO A DICE ROLL.** For each Karma point you spend, you can add an extra die. You can choose to do this after you fail a roll, and you can add the extra dice one at a time as many times as you need to. If this means you end up doing something palpably impossible, you should come up with a reason why you were able to do that - if you managed to break down the iron gate to an impenetrable fortress, you might describe how the lock had rusted, or how a guard left it slightly ajar.
- ★ **REDUCE DAMAGE FROM AN ATTACK.** You can only do this at the same time as the attack. For each Karma point you spend, the attack's damage is reduced by one point. You should describe out loud how the damage was reduced — did the knife stick in your wallet? Did you land on a convenient haystack?
- ★ **NEGATE THE CALAMITY DIE.** Of course, Calamity Dice are fun, so we don't encourage this. Heck, why did we even give you the option? Bad game designer, bad!
- ★ **INSTIGATE A FLASHBACK.** In a Flashback you describe an action you took *before* the current events which has an effect on the current situation. Perhaps you describe how you acquired a useful item, or mention how you locked that door. The action you describe must be one you were capable of (using the normal rules - so if you want to use a Flashback to have a car handy, you'd need to make Style roll as described in the Gear section below). You can flashback as far as you like, even way back to your childhood.

You should gather a pile of beads or similar items to represent your Karma. As you spend Karma, discard the beads.

Regaining Karma And now you're wondering how you regain that Karma you've spent? It's easy! You regain it by invoking your Trait! What does that mean? It means that every time you take a significant action which reflects your Trait, the Director might award you a Karma point. However, you cannot go above 10 Karma points. So you may as well spend 'em while you've got 'em!

Gear

You have all the regular stuff that your Role would suggest. If you're a Soldier, you have a rifle and uniform; if you're a Samurai, you have a sword. Whoever you are, you almost certainly have underpants. Some published adventures might also grant you a free starting kit. If you need something specific, ask the Director if it's reasonable that you should have it. If they say no, ask again. If they still say no, then I guess that's that. At least you tried!

We don't track money in *ACE*! That's not a lot of fun. But if you want to buy something special, you can roll your Style Stat (this is where the Wealth Focus shines!) against the value of the item (in gold, dollars, credits, turnips, or whatever currency you use). Each time you do this, you have to spend a Karma point, even if you fail.

Amount	Difficulty	Example
Up to 10	-	Candy bar, dagger, basic meal
Up to 1,000	10	Bicycle, suit of armor, ray gun, healing potion
Up to 10,000	20	Cheap car, magic sword
Up to 100,000	30	Luxury car, masterpiece art, small ship
Up to 1,000,000	40	House, helicopter

How much does gear cost? Great question! It doesn't actually matter, because you're not tracking money. The Director will need to assign a given item a Target Number based on the table above. We've listed a few examples below

Normal (10)

- **COMMUNICATOR.** Think a smartphone, but without any apps. But it can reach space.
- **GRAPPLE GUN.** With one action, ascend 30' up to a location you can stand.
- **HEALING POTION.** This adds +1 Health.
- **WEAPON.** Sword, pistol, rifle, etc.

Hard (20)

- **HORSE.** While on it you have Moves 8.
- **MAGIC ARMOR.** You get +2 Defence.





- **MAGIC SWORD.** It does +1 damage.
- **PROTECTIVE AMULET.** This protects you completely once from one instance of harm. Then it's useless to you, although somebody else can use it.
- **"SPIRIT STOPPER" ANTI-PLASM PARTICLE THROWER.** Does 2 damage, and can affect ghosts. Makes a hell of a mess, though.
- **THERMAL DETONATOR.** Bomb which does 3 damage to everybody within 30 feet. Also see Holy Hand Grenade.
- **TRICORDER.** Grants +1d6 to all Science rolls.
- **WAND.** Gives you an extra die on Power rolls.
- **X-RAY GLASSES.** They do what they say. Can't see though lead, because that's what it says in *Superman*.

Herculean (30)

- **INVISIBILITY CLOAK.** Or ring. Could be either. The latter might be evil. Elves probably make the former.
- **STAFF OF POWER.** The top lights up a 30 foot radius. And it gives you 3 extra Karma points which you can use to cast spells only.
- **TALKING CAR.** It obeys your commands and drives itself. Can be a bit sarcastic at times.

Impossible (40)

- **HOLY GRAIL.** No, you can't have that.
- **FLYING CARPET.** It flies and you can ride it. It might be a broomstick. Or a jetpack. Or even some winged sandals.

Advancement

At the end of each adventure you can increase one Stat by one point, or you can learn one new Focus. If your Brawn or Moves increase, then your Health or Defence increase accordingly.

Chapter 2: How to Play

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When you want to do something, and the success of that action is in question, you roll a number of dice equal to an appropriate Stat and add up the total on all the dice. You might roll dice to jump a car over a canyon, shoot an orc with a bow, fill out a tax form, or hack the electronic lock of a cell door. For example, if Bertram were to try lifting a log, he would roll two dice, because his Brawn Stat is 2.

However, if the activity is related to your Focus, you get to roll an extra two dice! If Bertram was trying to climb a wall, he'd roll four dice—two for his Brawn Stat and another two because his Brawn Focus is Climbing.

Every task has a Target Number, and if your dice roll equals or exceeds that number, you succeed at the task.

Most normal tasks require a total roll of 10 or more. Hard tasks require a roll of 20, Herculean tasks need 30, while Impossible tasks need a 40. OK, technically they're not impossible; but they're really, really hard.

Difficulty	Target Number	Example
Easy	No roll needed	Pick up a book, drive down the street, climb a ladder
Normal	10 or more	Climb a rope, build a campfire, parallel parking
Hard	20 or more	Break down a door, scale a cliff, pick a lock
Herculean	30 or more	Walk a tightrope, fill out a tax form, jump a car across a canyon
Impossible	40 or more	Lift a car , derive the Theory of Relativity

The most you will likely be rolling for your specialty (at least at start) is 7 dice, if you have a Stat of 5 and a corresponding Focus, with an average roll of about 25. Without a Focus, the most you'd likely roll is 5 dice, with an average roll of about 18.

Sixes Explode!

When you roll your dice, any sixes that you roll you can roll again, adding the new number to the original six. If that reroll is a six, you do it again, until you stop rolling sixes. In this way, there's

always a chance,
however small, of you
accomplishing any task.

Opposed Actions

Target Numbers are used when there's only one Hero involved in an action. Sometimes when two Heroes or Extras are taking competing actions you don't use a Target Number. In these situations, both opponents roll and the highest wins. On a draw, they roll again.

A good example is an arm wrestle. Both opponents would roll their Brawn Stat. However, the two stats don't have to be the same. If a Hero is trying to hide from a guard, the guard might roll his Smarts Stat vs. the Hero's Moves Stat. The same would apply to an attempt to pickpocket somebody or a footrace.

Circumstances

You may be granted an extra die if the Director decides that circumstances favor you in some way, or you may have a die deducted if they decide that the circumstances hinder you. Climbing that wall in the pouring rain, for example, would hinder you; Bertram would only roll three dice instead of four.

The Calamity Die

One of your dice is the Calamity Die. It helps if one of them is a different color so you can easily tell which it is. If you fail, and the Calamity Die rolls a 1, then a Calamity occurs. The Director will ask your so-called 'friends' to decide the nature of the Calamity. Calamities are usually funny; at least, they are for everybody else. We're fond of inserting inconveniently placed trapdoors!

Fighting!

If you get into a fight (and you probably will get into a fight), you will either be fighting hand-to-hand (melee) or shooting (ranged) at your enemies.

A melee attack is made by rolling your Brawn Stat. A ranged attack is made by rolling your Moves Stat. You can add a Focus such as Brawling or Shooting if you have them—all hand-to-hand combat, even with weapons, is covered by Brawling, and all ranged combat, even when throwing items, is covered by Shooting.

When you attack something, you're basically making an opposed roll versus the target's Moves Stat. However, this happens so often (it's the inherently violent nature of humankind; it makes us quite sad) that we just use the average roll of the target's Moves for convenience. We call this average number 'Defence', and it's equal to the target's Moves Stat times 3. You could roll the opposed roll longhand if you wanted to, but this way's faster, and we're all about the fun, action-packed mayhem!

There are a couple of circumstances which come up in combat frequently. These are applied just like any other circumstance—they add or deduct one die from your roll.

- **LONG RANGE (-)** deducts one die from your roll.
- **HIGH GROUND (+)** adds one die to your roll.
- **PRONE OPPONENTS (+/-)** add one die to your roll if you are making a melee attack against them, but deduct one die if you are making a ranged attack.

When you hit your opponent, they lose Health. When their Health reaches zero, they are Knocked Out. The amount of Health they lose is based on the attack itself. A punch might do 1 damage, a knife does 2 damage, and a gun does 3 damage.

Brawn Stat	Unarmed Damage
1-5	1
6-10	2
11-15	3
16-20	4

Unarmed damage (including that from monsters) is equal to 1 point for each 5 points of your Brawn Stat or part thereof. You can include the dice for your Focus in that calculation if it's appropriate; an expert martial-artist might do more damage through skill than raw strength.

Here are the damage values of some common weapons. The weapon descriptions are left to you—a pistol might be a regular ballistic weapon, or a laser pistol, and the same might be said of swords.





Weapon	Damage	Weapon	Damage
Bazooka	5	Machine Gun	4
Bow	2	Pistol	3
Club	2	Rifle	3
Grenade	4	Spear	2
Knife	2	Sword	3

Recovery

You naturally recover your Health at a rate of 1 point per day. If you are under medical care (by somebody with a Medicine focus, or in a hospital) you recover at a rate of 2 points per day.

You probably won't die. It's the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!*, after all. When you reach zero Health and are Knocked Out, you wake up with 1 Health (and probably a sore head) five minutes later.

Who Goes First?

We knew you'd ask that! That's why we decided to write down the answer and put it in this book. Cool, eh? We're full of clever ideas like that.

The Hero or Extra with the highest Moves Stat goes first. They take one action. Then they decide who goes next. When that Hero or Extra has taken their turn, they decide who comes after them, and so on until everybody has taken a turn. Then the process starts anew with the most Moves combatant again.

If two or more people have the same Moves Stat, compare those peoples' Smarts Stat. If they still have the same scores, move on to the Style Stat, because cool people go first. If *that's* the same (*really?*), try the Brawn Stat.

After that we give up.

What Can You Do On Your Turn?

Anything! Well, OK, maybe not anything. That was a lie. You can't lasso the sun or make pineapple a good pizza topping. But you can try to do most things. Of course, that doesn't mean you'll succeed!

You can take one action on your turn. You can also move. So that's two things, really. No, we're not trying to confuse you; it's just a natural talent. You can move and you can take one other action.

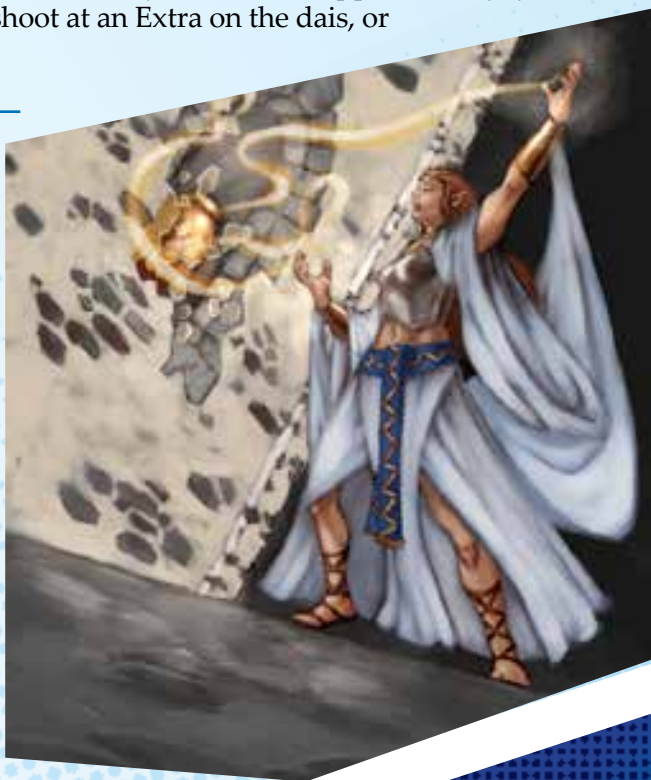
When you move, the Director will tell you how far you can reasonably move. We don't want to be too picky about it! The Director should divide the area into various 'zones'; when you move, you can move into an adjacent zone. Anybody in the same zone can fight each other in dramatic hand-to-hand combat; otherwise you'll have to shoot them or throw something.

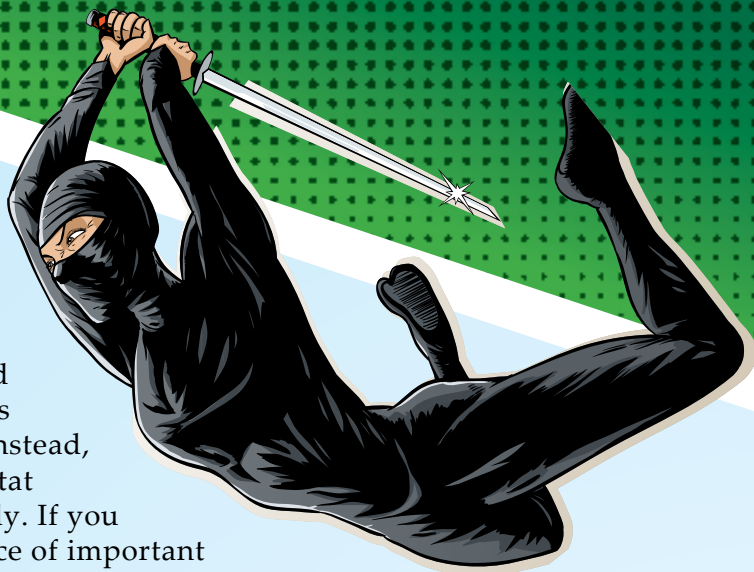
For example, in a fantasy game, a fight might take place at an evil necromancer's temple. The zones would be the main temple floor, the dais at one end of the temple, the upper balcony, and the graveyard outside. If you're on the upper balcony, you might fight an Extra on the balcony, shoot at an Extra on the dais, or rush down to the main temple floor.

Using Magic

Your Power Stat is a 'universal' stat. You can do all sorts of things with it! Want to read somebody's mind? Throw a bolt of arcane energy? Run really fast or dodge an attack?

Anything you can do with another Stat, you can do with Power; the only caveat is that you have to spend a Karma point each time you do so. You do it exactly the same way as you would normally, but you use your Power Stat instead.





If you came across a locked door it would normally take a Moves roll to pick the lock. Instead, you use your Power Stat and unlock it magically. If you wanted to know a piece of important information, you would normally use your Brains Stat. Not you! You can use your Power Stat instead and pluck the information from the ether (or something).

You can also use Power to do something you wouldn't normally be able to do. The Director will adjudicate it, but often this will simply be a Power roll versus a Difficulty, or an opposed Power roll versus one Stat from your opponent. You might read an informant's mind by making a Power versus Brains roll.

DAMAGE. If you need to figure out damage from your Power attack when you throw an arcane bolt or fry some poor creep's mind, it's really simple: you do 1 point of damage. If you want to increase it, you can pump more Karma into it; for every Karma point you use, you do 1 point of damage.

HEALING. Healing is the exact opposite of damage. Heal 1 point for each point of Karma.

PROTECTION. Use your Power instead of Moves to determine the Defence of you or an ally.

What is Power?

So, what exactly is Power? Well, it's whatever you want it to be. Magic, sorcery, faith, prayer, psionics, chi, ki, the Force? You decide!

It's up to you what your Power looks like, or how it manifests. Do a million insects eat that lock away, or does the door silently slide open with a wave of your hand? That's entirely your decision! It helps to choose a 'theme' for your Hero's power and describe it consistently; that theme would constitute your Power Focus.

You should check with the Director about what's appropriate for the world you're in. Unless it's bees. Bees are always appropriate.

Chapter 3: Extras

A.C.E.!!
AWFULLY
CHEERFUL
ENGINE

This chapter is for the Director. It contains a bunch of Extras to use in your game. It's an eclectic selection, mixing fantasy monsters with sci-fi aliens and robots, and everything in between, so whatever your adventure is about, you should find something that fits.

The first important Extra is the Mook. This Extra represents most civilians, workers, and peasants, fantasy, modern and sci-fi, who don't have a starring role (or often even a name) in your adventure. The Mook will have a Focus, but this will vary from person to person.

Mooks don't usually have Stats as good as Heroes, and they always have only 1 Health, meaning that you can knock them out with a single punch like the goddamn Hero that you are!

Choose one Focus when you use a Mook. A nightclub bouncer might have Brawn (Brawling), a truck driver might have Moves (Driving), or a nurse might have Smarts (Medicine). In a fantasy world, a farmer might have Smarts (Nature) or Style (Animals), a guard might have Smarts (Perception), and a minstrel might have Style (Music). The Mook rolls four dice when using their Focus.

Mook

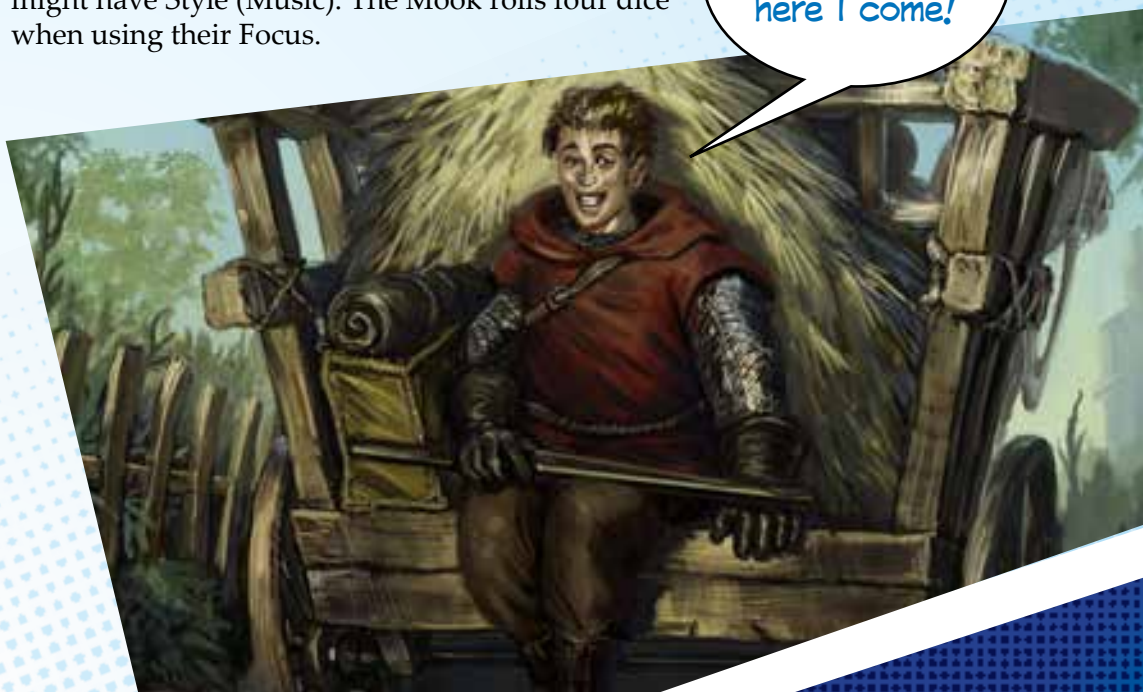
SMARTS 2	MOVES 2
STYLE 2	BRAWN 2

Health 1 **Defence 8**

Brawling 2 (1 damage)

Add any Focus in one Stat.

A life of
adventure -
here I come!



The following
is a selection of specific
extras.

Assassin

SMARTS 3 **MOVES** 5 (Stealth)
STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 2 (Brawling)
Health 2 **Defence** 16
Knife 4 (2 damage, double on first strike)

Barbarian

SMARTS 2 (Nature) **MOVES** 4 (Running)
STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 4 (Brawling)
Health 4 **Defence** 12
Battle-axe 7 (3 damage)

Bear

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 1
STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 8
Health 8 **Defence** 8
Claws 8 (2 damage)

Blaster Turret

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 1
STYLE 1 **BRAWN** 8
Health 2 **Defence** 8
Guns 3 (2 damage)

Carnivorous Plant

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 2
STYLE 1 **BRAWN** 6 (Brawling)
Health 6 **Defence** 8
Lashing vines 8 (2 damage, 15-foot range, grabs
target requiring a melee attack to escape)

Cop

SMARTS 3 (Perception) **MOVES** 3 (Shooting)
STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 3
Health 3 **Defence** 8
Brawling 3 (1 damage)
Pistol 5 (2 damage)





Dark Lord

SMARTS 5 **MOVES** 6 (Acrobatics)
STYLE 6 **BRAWN** 5 (Brawling)
POWER 6 (Telekinesis)
Health 5 **Defence** 18
Laser sword 7 (3 damage)
Psychic choke 8 (1 damage, 30-foot range)

Dragon

SMARTS 6 **MOVES** 3 (Flying)
STYLE 6 **BRAWN** 12 (Brawling)
Health 24 **Defence** 9
Bite 14 (3 damage)
Fire breath 4 (2 damage to a 30 foot cone)

Firemage

SMARTS 6 **MOVES** 2
STYLE 4 **BRAWN** 2
POWER 5 (Fire 7)
Health 2 **Defence** 8
Firebolt 7 (1 damage, 30' range)

Ghostly Shrieker

SMARTS 2 **MOVES** 4 (Flying)
STYLE 3 **BRAWN** -
Health 3 **Defence** 12 — incorporeal
Shriek 3 (1 damage to all within 30 feet)

Giant Spider

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 6 (Webs)
STYLE 1 **BRAWN** 5
Health 5 **Defence** 18
Poison bite 5 (2 damage, makes target Sick)
Sticky Web 8 (0 damage, 30-foot range, restrains target, needs Brawn 10 check to escape)



Goblin

SMARTS 1

STYLE 1

Health 1 **Defence** 15

Knife 3 (2 damage)

MOVES 5 (Thievery)

BRAWN 1 (Brawling)

Hunter-Killer Cyborg

SMARTS 4 (Tracking)

STYLE 2

Health 6 **Defence** 12

Brawling 8 (2 damage)

Uzi 6 (3 damage)

MOVES 4 (Shooting)

BRAWN 6 (Brawling)

Necromancer

SMARTS 6

STYLE 4

POWER 5 (Necromancy 7)

Health 2 **Defence** 8

Chilling grasp 2 (2 damage)

Use an action to summon one zombie within 30-feet. Can have up to three zombies at one time.

MOVES 2

BRAWN 2

Ninja

SMARTS 2

STYLE 2

Health 3 **Defence** 18

Sword 5 (2 damage)

Turn invisible for up to one minute.

MOVES 6 (Climbing)

BRAWN 3 (Brawling)

Orc

SMARTS 2

STYLE 2

Health 5 **Defence** 8

Spiked club 7 (2 damage)

MOVES 2

BRAWN 5 (Brawling)

Soldier

SMARTS 2

STYLE 2

Health 3 **Defence** 9

Brawling 5 (2 damage) **Rifle** 7 (3 damage)

MOVES 5 (Shooting)

BRAWN 3 (Brawling)





Troll

SMARTS 1

STYLE 1

POWER 5 (Fire 7)

MOVES 3

BRAWN 7

Health 7 **Defence** 9

Brawling 7 (2 damage)

Regenerate 1 Health each round; killed by sunlight

Tyrannosaur

SMARTS 1

STYLE 2

Health 20 **Defence** 8

Bite 12 (4 damage)

MOVES 1

BRAWN 10 (Brawling)

Vampire

SMARTS 6

STYLE 6 (Seduction)

Health 8 **Defence** 24

Bite 10 (2 damage, recover 1 Health)

Killed by sunlight. Can turn into a bat or a wolf.

MOVES 8

BRAWN 8 (Brawling)

Wolf

SMARTS 1 (Tracking)

STYLE 2

Health 3 **Defence** 18

Bite 3 (1 damage)

When attacking in a group of 4 or more wolves, each gains +1 die to attacks.

MOVES 6

BRAWN 3

Zombie

SMARTS 1

STYLE 1

Health 2 **Defence** 8

Bite 2 (1 damage)

Victim becomes a zombie if reduced to 0 Health

MOVES 1

BRAWN 2

Adventures

So, now you know the rules. Didn't take long, did it? And I bet you're wondering now what happens next?

The *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* comes with a bunch of separate adventures. Each adventure is a different genre — *Spirits of Manhattan* lets you play ghost hunters in the Big Apple, *Accidental Anthropomorphic Heroes* has you play vigilante animals, *Below Decks* is about starship officers exploring the galaxy, and so on. You'll play different Heroes each time you play a new adventure, and the adventures are designed to be played in a single session (or maybe two, if you're taking your time!)

Keep an eye out for more adventures for ACE!

Inspiration

I can't forget to thank the giants who came before me, and whose work inspired this game. You'll see DNA from the 1980s *Ghostbusters* roleplaying game by Sandy Petersen, Lynn Willis, and Greg Stafford, and from more modern games like Monte Cook's *Numenera*. You'll also see elements of my own *What's OLD is NEW* system, along with a host of pop culture influences including, but certainly not limited to:

- *Ghostbusters*
- *Dangermouse*
- *Guardians of the Galaxy*
- *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*
- *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*
- *Back to the Future*
- *Bill & Ted*
- *Rick & Morty*
- *Terry Pratchett's Discworld*
- *Star Trek*
- *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles*





A.C.E.!!
AWFULLY
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ENGINE

ACE! ID CARD

Name _____

Trait/Role _____

Health _____ Defence _____

Stat	Dice	Focus	Dice
Smarts	_____	_____	_____
Moves	_____	_____	_____
Style	_____	_____	_____
Brawn	_____	_____	_____
Power	_____	_____	_____

ACE! ID CARD

Name _____

Trait/Role _____

Health _____ Defence _____

Stat	Dice	Focus	Dice
Smarts	_____	_____	_____
Moves	_____	_____	_____
Style	_____	_____	_____
Brawn	_____	_____	_____
Power	_____	_____	_____



ACE!
Issue 2

SPIRITS of Manhattan

DAVE CHAPMAN ■ RUSS MORRISSEY

INTRODUCTION

ABOUT
SPIRITS OF MANHATTAN

Remember 1984? Some of you may. An actor was President of the United States. Bruce Springsteen was the biggest name in music, and you could listen to his tape on your Walkman. It was also the time when a gate to a hell dimension nearly opened up in the middle of New York, unleashing undead horrors upon the world. But thankfully, a team of dedicated, if reluctant, specialists with incredibly dangerous equipment risked everything to save the city, and the world. After that act of brave stupidity, there was only one team to contact if you needed saving - the Ghostbreakers!

This book is divided into two sections:

THE SETTING: The first part of the book looks at the overall setting, and describes your Heroes, the cool technology, the paranormal threats, and serious, grounded science.

THE ADVENTURE: This is where you'll find the complete adventure, *Spirits of Manhattan*. It takes you from the formation of the Heroes, through to the epic finale where the Ghostbreakers must battle the forces of evil to save New York.

Tone

We're not going to lie - this is not your average roleplaying adventure. If you're expecting to wander from room to room, fighting nasties and stealing their gold, there's a whole heap of games out there for you. This is *Ghostbreakers*: there will be scares, there will be laughs, and a lot of the science won't add up - but it's all part of the fun!

It's not dark or serious. Buildings can fall on the Heroes, or they can be transformed into giant cougars [*Seriously, we saw it happen once, and it wasn't pretty.*] But in the end they will be fine. Maybe a little scratched up, or covered in strawberry yogurt, but they'll survive and live to catch some more spooky critters another day.



PURE - Protection of Undead Returned Entities

PURE is a rights organization seeking to ensure better treatment of the ghosts that the Ghostbreakers capture. Their leader, Emily Waterhouse, is keen to shut down the Ghostbreakers, citing their unlawful imprisonment of restless entities. The team will need to assure her that the ghosts caught are treated well and each individual case is investigated with the hope of resolving the issues that have prevented them from “moving on”. It’s only if the ghost’s motivations are inherently evil (taking over the world, destroying the world, eating the world, that sort of thing) that the spirit is exiled to a hell dimension.

The Ghostbreakers

At the core of *Spirits of Manhattan* are the Ghostbreakers themselves, a group of paranormal exterminators who operate in the Big Apple. However, it could be that you want to create your own story, battling the supernatural in a different location. Supernatural threats can be found all over the world, and what are four investigators in New York going to do when there’s a demonic incursion in the middle of London, or a cult of fitness instructors summon the unimaginable in the middle of California. They need their own Heroes, right?

The Ghostbreaking technology was copyrighted, and the blueprints are available (or complete working devices for a hefty additional charge) to those wishing to form their own franchise. All your group needs is a bit of start up capital - you can remortgage your parent’s house, or maybe hope for a lottery win - set up a base of operations, and purchase the blueprints (did you see the bit about buying the devices for a hefty, I mean reasonable, price?) and you’re good to go. You’ll probably need a vehicle, and somewhere to set up the containment/disposal facilities, but that’s half of the fun of running your own franchise.

Choose Your Role

You mean hunting the supernatural and paranormal isn’t your first career choice? Who wouldn’t want to do that for a living? We guess you have to have tried something else first, before you discovered the joys of ghost hunting. Thankfully, the Ghostbreakers are equal opportunity employers and will accept just about anyone into their franchises, as long as they are willing and able to cough up the necessary funds.

Just like in any other *ACE!* game, your first step is to choose your Role. Generally, your Heroes should be blue-collar workers or academics with a hefty dollop of that New York attitude! You can choose any of the Roles from the Occupations list in

the ACE! core rules with the Director's permission. Or, if they don't approve, you could just bribe them with chocolate or something until they see things your way. The Roles listed below are especially suitable, but, hey, we're not trying to tell you what to do *[aside - yes, we are]*.



GHOST. You don't take damage unless its from a holy source or some special sci-fi ecto-gadget. But you also can't pick things up. So there's that.

DEMONOLOGIST. You know how to hurt demons. You do an extra point of damage whenever you successfully attack a demon.

DOCTOR. Medic! You can heal people. For every Karma point you spend, you heal somebody (or yourself) one point of damage. This takes you a minute.



ENGINEER. If something is broken, you can fix it within an hour. Well, within reason. Not like the Golden Gate Bridge or something, but a vending machine or a car.



EXORCIST. By chanting prayers and holding forth the symbol of your faith, you can make a Style attack against a ghost or demon's Defence, and if you are successful you do 1 point of damage to them and they cannot approach you for one minute.

INVENTOR. A gadget for every occasion. You can spend a Karma point to pull out a gadget which helps you with your next dice roll. You have to describe the gadget. Basically, you get double value from Karma points - two extra dice instead of one.

PRIEST. The undead cannot harm you directly (though if one drops a piano on your head, pianos can definitely still harm you!) They're still pretty scary, though.

PROFESSOR. You know stuff. You get free Focuses in History, Languages, and Theology.





Let's reverse
the particle
stream...

SCIENTIST. If a monster has a weakness, you know it automatically. It's just a question of physics.

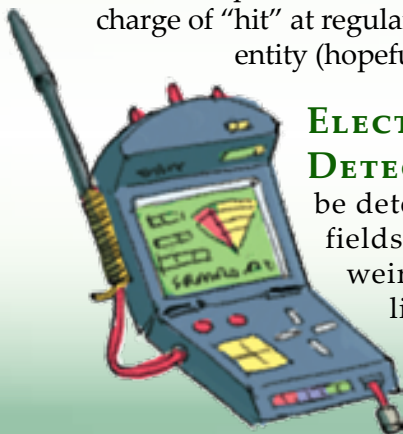
STUDENT. Funny how Heroes often seem to be high school kids! You have homework, and the principal is on your back. But you can pretty much get away with stuff because you're a kid. People just overlook you. More fool them!

Technology

Spirits of Manhattan is a bit of a mixed bag when it comes to technology. On one hand, this is the 1980s - no internet, no mobile phones (unless you count ones the size of a brick, or those that were attached to your car). Computers were big and slow, Apple's first home computer was just launching, and the smaller home computers were glorified games consoles.

On the other hand, some of the technology is far more advanced than possible even today. The anti-plasma pack is basically a miniature particle collider, and far beyond scientific advances today.

ANTI-PLASM BINDERS. The effects of the anti-plasm particle thrower are temporary, and a spirit defeated by repeated blasts will eventually recover and resume haunting. Once a ghost has become weak enough, Anti-Plasm Binders can be used to keep the entity in its trapped state. These binders act as a boost to the effects of the anti-plasm throwers, applying a charge of "hit" at regular intervals, keeping the entity (hopefully) immobilized.



ELECTROMAGNETIC FIELD (EMF)

DETECTOR. Spirits, specters and ghosts can be detected by changes in the electromagnetic fields that surround us. You know something weird is going on when the detector's lights flash and the alarms sound.





GHOSTMOBILE. This is a disused Range Rover Popemobile, originally made for the British visit of Pope John Paul II in 1982. The reinforced glass rear has been covered in warding and binding symbols, and Anti-Plasm nodes to keep a ghost trapped.

SPIRIT-SPECTACLES GOGGLES.

These allow the wearer to see incorporeal spirits before they have fully visually materialized. The goggles also detect the percentage of 'Health' in a non-corporeal entity, which gives the wearer an insight into how close to defeat the spirit is after being hit by the anti-plasm thrower.



Collateral Damage!

When the wielder misses with an anti-plasm beam, collateral damage always occurs. Track damage as normal and multiply it by 100; this is the amount of dollar damage that has been accrued. In an extended battle, this figure can get quite significant!

It is recommended that you ensure that the owner of the property where the ghost has been sighted signs a damage waiver, stating that they understand that any damage sustained to the property during the course of the ghost's capture is not your responsibility.

"SPIRIT STOPPER"

ANTI-PLASM PARTICLE THROWER.

This heavyweight backpack houses a miniature particle collider that produces anti-matter particles. The scientists explained this to us, but let's face it, we're game designers, not theoretical physicists and a lot of what they were saying went over our heads. We made some notes, and tried to make sense of it, but it really was like listening to Shakespeare being recited in ancient Greek. What we did catch was that the originating particles that are used for the reaction come from ectoplasmic





residue, creating a stream of “anti-plasm” particles. This stream reacts with the positive ectoplasmic energy that makes up your average ghost and gradually weakens them. Blah, blah, blah, something else was said... I think the word “dangerous” was used a bit, but we got distracted by the snacks.

These weapons affect incorporeal (and corporeal!) creatures fully, doing 2 damage on a hit. When the incorporeal creature is reduced to zero Health, it is defeated, and ready to be transported back to the containment field at HQ.

Getting hit by one of the streams accidentally is not at all pleasant. The damage is painful, explosive, and will probably hurl you through a nearby wall. If it doesn't kill you, you'll probably wish it had killed you for a while until the paramedics dose you up with painkillers.

These experimental weapons are unwieldy, inaccurate, and - let's face it - often held together with duct tape. No wonder so much collateral damage gets caused!

Tobias' Guide to Ghosts, Spooks, and Specters

The Ghostbreakers are all about catching, trapping and removing ghosts. So let's look at the ghosts themselves, and crack open that ominous tome - *Tobias' Guide to Ghosts, Spooks, and Specters*.

Tobias' Guide lists a ghost as a restless spirit - the spirit of someone who has unfinished business and is unable, or unwilling, to move on. They hang around (usually literally, floating about) and often repeat a task, protect a location, or seek out a particular person. Their motivations are varied, but it is often the key to understanding them.

They come in all shapes and sizes, and while some can be a simple blast-and-catch call, some can lead to serious investigation, hours of staking out a location with high tech sensors, just to try to get the pesky poltergeist out of the building. Some of it can be boring - it is a job after all. But the variety of spooks and ghouls out there keeps it interesting. You never know what you're going to face when you get that call.

Most creatures handled by the Ghostbreakers are incorporeal ghosts, but occasionally they may find themselves up against corporeal monstrosities, such as the ominous Terror Dogs. These creatures are usually classified as demons, rather than spirits.

What follows is an excerpt from that classic tome, *Tobias' Guide to Ghosts, Spooks, and Specters*. The full book was published in 1947, and is exactly 999 pages long.

EMF Class

Your EMF detector, in addition to being able to detect the presence of supernatural activity, is also able to detect its strength.

Every ghost has an EMF Class. This is a scale which measures the ghost's power, and is equal to the ghost's Power Stat. A EMF Class I ghost is little more than a nuisance - a spectral presence that makes it feel cold at times, or hides the TV remote. EMF Classes of VIII or more are very dangerous, and those of X or higher are terrifyingly powerful. Higher EMF Classes are possible, but then we're getting into really bad territory - we're talking demons, demigods, and things beyond our imagination. And I don't know about you, but I can imagine quite a bit.

Ghostly Properties

Spirits generally share the following properties.

INCORPOREAL. Spirits are incorporeal.

This means that they can pass through solid objects, and are immune to all forms of damage except for anti-plasm and holy damage (the latter being provided by holy water and some magical spells or blessed weapons).

IMMORTAL. Spirits cannot be killed. If you can somehow reduce them to 0 Health or below (by using anti-plasm weapons), they can be captured. A ghosts' Health recovers 1 point per round automatically. When the ghost's Health recovers above zero, they will start to move again.

FLIGHT. Spirits can freely fly, although many are locked into old habits and do not.

What year
is it?



A Ghostly Glossary

The following terms are used to describe ghosts. This is usually combined with the spirit's EMF Class, such as a "Class VII freeroaming apparition". That way you can sound clever and scientific, even when you have no idea what you're talking about. We won't tell anyone.

APPARITION. This is a ghost which has the appearance of a living creature or person.

DEMON. A demon is a corporeal supernatural entity, usually from another plane of existence or dimension.

ECHO. An echo is a manifestation with little effect on the real world; it may appear as a temperature change or unexplained sound.

FOCUSED. This is a ghost which is linked to a specific location.

FREE-ROAMING. This is a ghost which is not linked to a specific location.

FULL TORSO. A full manifestation including an entire body.

PARTIAL. A partial manifestation such as a disembodied voice, ghostly hands, and so on.

REPEATING. This is a ghost which appears at certain times or intervals.

SPECIFIC. A specific apparition is the ghost of a known individual.

VAPOR. This is a ghost without a distinct form, or a form similar to a "blob".

Demonic Properties

Demons have slightly different properties to spirits. For a start, they are usually corporeal. That means you can hit them with stuff. It also means they can hit you with stuff.

IMMORTAL. Demons cannot be killed. If you can somehow reduce them to 0 Health (by using anti-plasm, silver, or holy weapons), they are banished from the world for 99 years.

REALMS OF FIRE. Demons are immune to fire.

CORPOREAL. Unlike spirits, demons are corporeal. However, they are immune to ballistic damage, which means the police and the military are not equipped to deal with them. Indeed, demons are immune to weapons which do not do holy damage (such as holy water, which causes them 1 damage per dose) or which are not made of silver. Anti-plasm affects them fully, of course.

Demonkin

Minor demonic minions and servants.

SMARTS 2

MOVES 3

STYLE 2

BRAWN 3

POWER 3

Health 3 **Defence** 9

Claws 3 (1 damage)

Demonkin possess the qualities noted in 'Demonic Properties', above.

Firemage

Flame throwing sorcerers!

SMARTS 6

MOVES 2

STYLE 4

BRAWN 2

POWER 5 (Fire 7)

Health 2 **Defence** 8

Firebolt 7 (1 damage, 30' range)

Ghostly Creep

Sneaky ghost which likes to haunt people.

SMARTS 2

MOVES 4

STYLE 2

BRAWN 0

POWER 3

Health 3 **Defence** 12

Sudden lurch (1 damage)

The Ghostly Creep can turn invisible at-will.

The Ghostly Creep possesses the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

I'm gonna eat
your brain!



Gozarr the Devourer

Immensely powerful godlike demon from another dimension.

SMARTS 8 **MOVES** 3
STYLE 6 **BRAWN** 10
POWER 10

Health 10 **Defence** 9
Claws & tail (3 damage)

Gozarr possesses the qualities noted in 'Demonic Properties', above.

Roar as a Power attack vs Style; causes those affected to run away.

Quake is a Power attack vs. Moves to all nearby; 1 damage and knocked down.

Grim Reaper

A dark hooded figure with a wicked scythe.

SMARTS 5 **MOVES** 5
STYLE 6 **BRAWN** 0
POWER 6

Health 6 **Defence** 15
Spectral scythe (3 damage)

The Grim Reaper possesses the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

When the Grim Reaper reduces a target to 0 Health, it dies instantly. Scary!

Napolitano Brothers

A pair of floating ghosts strapped into electric chairs.

SMARTS 2 **MOVES** 5
STYLE 3 **BRAWN** 0
POWER 4

Health 4 **Defence** 15
Electric blast (1 damage)

The Napolitano Brothers possess the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

Phantasmal Drake

A large phantasmal dragon.

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 6
STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 0
POWER 8

Health 8 **Defence** 18
Claw (2 damage)

The Phantasmal Drakes possesses the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

Phantasmal Horror

A placid looking ghost which suddenly reveals its horrific nature.

SMARTS 2 **MOVES** 2
STYLE 3 **BRAWN** 0
POWER 5

Health 5 **Defence** 8
Manifest 5 (victim must run away)

The Phantasmal Horror possesses the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.



Shrieker

A nasty little spirit with a big voice

SMARTS 2

MOVES 3

STYLE 3

BRAWN 0

POWER 4

Health 4 **Defence** 9

Shriek (1 damage to everybody nearby)

Shriekers possess the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

Slime Bucket

A nasty little spirit with a big voice

SMARTS 1

MOVES 6

STYLE 1

BRAWN 0

POWER 3

Health 4 **Defence** 18

Slimer (1 damage, victim is immobilized for 1 minute)

The Slime Bucket possesses the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

Terror Dog

Demonic hellhounds which serve evil powers.

SMARTS 1

MOVES 4

STYLE 3

BRAWN 6

POWER 4

Health 6 **Defence** 12

Fire breath (2 damage)

Terror Dogs possess the qualities noted in 'Demonic Properties', above.

Trickster Spirit

Cunning and manipulative ghosts..

SMARTS 6

MOVES 5

STYLE 6

BRAWN 0

POWER 6

Health 6 **Defence** 15

Telekinesis (1 damage)

Tricksters possess the qualities noted in 'Ghostly Properties', above.

Tricksters can teleport to a location they can see nearby.

Tricksters can make Power vs. Style checks to make a target charmed or angry.





Spirits of Manhattan

Here we are with the bit you've been waiting for, the main event, the adventure itself, *Spirits of Manhattan*! Like many adventures it can be broken down into three acts, and each of those broken down into a number of scenes.

Needless to say, if you're planning on being a player of this adventure, stop reading now. It's really for the Director's eyes only. It's for your own good in the long run as you won't enjoy it half as much if you know what's coming!

Right, get ready. Stock up with popcorn and fizz, the trailers are nearly over.

It'd time got our feature presentation...

Act One: Who You Gonna Call?

Detour of Duty

In one neglected corner of Columbia University Medical Center is what used to be a University Psychiatric Hospital. You're conducting an experiment on a volunteer student (John Tremayne - not that it matters. He's a first year psychology student, and a bit of a pretty-boy. He's probably going to fail, but volunteering for this research project may bring his grades up). John is being lowered into a vertical isolation tank filled with body temperature salt water. He looks quite panicked! EEG and ECG monitors are whirring, printing a stream of paper with little spikes scratched onto it.

If you haven't played an ACE! game before, you can use this opportunity to get used to the system. You can have a Hero try a roll to attempt to send a mental image of something to the poor, helpless John. Roll a Style check and if it beats John's Smarts roll of 10 then the message gets through.

A Few Words Before We Start

When NPCs, ghosts, and other demons are referred to in **bold** in this adventure, this is a direction to the Director to look up their game statistics. These can be found on pages 9-11 of this booklet.

When you see shaded text in italics, the Director should read it aloud to the other players.

The Heroes are ready. They've loaded the equipment into the prepared Ghostmobile, and they've posted fliers around the university with their phone number, telling the faculty and students to call if they see anything weird. Now they're just sitting around waiting for that call... when something unexpected happens.

You're all ready. The packs are working, the holding cell is primed, and the "Ghostmobile", for want of a better name, is warded and rigged for containment. You've posted cool fliers around the university - classy posters that ask anyone who sees anything out of the ordinary, or remotely paranormal, to contact you at the phone number provided.

There have been a couple of prank calls, only to be expected posting your number on the wall of a university. But mostly, it's been pretty quiet.

When, late one night, sitting around the lab watching the final season of Happy Days, it happens...

The phone suddenly rings.

"Hi. I saw your flier about paranormal activity?" says a quiet voice.

When questioned, the voice answers:

"Yeah, in the Chapel, you know, St. Peter's Chapel on campus? There's a woman there, but you can see through her!"

St. Peter's Chapel is a picturesque building in the heart of the Columbia University campus, close to the Butler Library. It's a lovely building, in the traditional cross shape with a dramatic Italian-style dome over the center.

Getting there is easy. The Heroes have a Ghostmobile, as yet untested. It's parked right outside.

You can try some dice rolling again here if you like, to get used to it if you haven't played this system before. Have the driver make a Moves (10) roll to get through the traffic from the Medical Center to the Chapel. If they succeed, they get there super-quick; if they fail, it's a slow frustrating journey through dense traffic. It doesn't really matter, really. We're just painting a picture here.





Run Some Red Lights!

There will be multiple times in the game when you're traveling from one part of the city to another, usually on an urgent call by some poor citizen who needs saving from something terrible. You put your foot down, hit the sirens and weave through the traffic.

However, you could throw some extra elements into the mix. Roll a single die!

- 1 - Roadworks.** You know where you're going but you know that city works have dug up one of the main streets that you need to use. Traffic's going to be backed up on the surrounding ones, so getting there is going to be a real pain in the ass. Have the driver make a Smarts (10) roll to calculate a better route.
- 2 - Flatbed.** A flatbed truck has broken down in the street ahead, strangely stacked high with wooden crates full of chickens. What it's doing in the middle of New York I don't know, but it's there, and it's in the way. You're going to have to swerve around it, mounting the sidewalk and hoping the pedestrians dive out of the way. Make a Moves (10) roll to swerve clear.
- 3 - Glass.** A couple of guys are carrying a huge sheet of glass across the street ready to fit it into a store front. They're using those little sucker handles, and they're right in the road as you turn the corner. You can make a Smarts (10) roll to spot it, but failing will mean you drive straight through and thoroughly cheese-off those workers. They'll claim for damages from Ghostbreakers in a few days.
- 4 - Fruit Cart.** Time is running out and you've taken a short cut, but the street is narrow and looks like part of it has been closed for some sort of market. There's something blocking the road, like a taco truck or something, and the only way through is going to be mounting the sidewalk and plowing through that fruit cart. Have the driver make a Moves roll - 10 if they want to smash through the cart and have melons explode everywhere (they'll probably have to pay for that later!) or 15 if they want to swerve to the opposite sidewalk where it's clear.
- 5 - Wetworks.** Like the roadworks above (1) there's a section of street having work done on it, though it was a surprise and wasn't something that could be planned for. The driver can either make the Smarts (10) rolls like before to think of a way around, or keep going. The roadworks are nearly done, and they've already filled in the hole. If you put your foot down and drive over it fast enough, you won't sink. Surely? Make a Moves (15) roll to gun it over the concrete, spraying the workers, and continuing to the call. Fail, and the car will get stuck and you'll have to pay to have it removed, repaired, and reimburse the city for the damage you've caused.
- 6 - Nuns!** Suddenly a line of nuns, or ducks, or a cat, or a kid with a ball, appears ahead of you in the street. What the hell are they doing there? It's going to take some quick reactions to swerve out of the way, and you'll probably end up on the sidewalk, knocking over a load of garbage bins, newspaper stands or mailboxes. It's a Moves (15) roll!

Feel free to mix it up, create some new ones, go crazy!

The Chapel

As mentioned, the chapel itself is a simple cross shaped floorplan with a glorious dome over the center. When the Heroes arrive, they don't even need to get in the door before the EMF detector starts registering some activity.

Inside the chapel, sitting on a pew near the altar is a woman wearing clothing that went out of fashion at the end of the 19th Century. She sits, looking pretty miserable, and slightly translucent. As the Heroes approach, even the slightest noise in the chapel will startle her. If the players wish, they can make Moves rolls to try to approach as quietly as possible, though the Director should have the main doors of the chapel slam shut as they get close.

Once startled, the ghost - Emeline Holt - will stand up, turn to the Heroes, and scream! As a ghost, Emeline uses the stats of a **shrieker**. Cracks start appearing in the expensive stained glass. She needs to be silenced!

Now's the chance to try out the equipment. You know the drill! Blast it, bind it, and get it into the car.

Unwanted Guests

During the process of catching Emeline, the blasting noises and flashing lights radiating from the chapel will alert campus security.

Just as the Heroes put the binders on Emeline and bundle her into the back of the Ghostmobile, campus security

Doing you a solid

When hit by the particle beams, once Emeline gets to the usual level that will have trapped her, she becomes semi-corporeal. This is due to a glitch in the particle-throwers combined with a one-in-a-million chance.

Why is this a bad thing? Well, besides the wonders of movie logic, Emeline is harmless. She's got a scream that can shatter glass, and is pretty scary when she starts hollering. But in the long run, she's just a lost soul who is still pining for her Edward who never returned to her home town.

Once trapped, she's still harmless, if a little sad. She's not really had anything to do except wander the city, looking for Edward, not realising he died over 200 years ago. Once she realizes he's gone, and comes to terms with the fact that she can't move on (she can't be killed in her current form - she's technically undead), she just wants to be distracted from her plight. She'll ask the Heroes if there's anything she can do to help, even though she's a woman out of her time. Lacking many other skills, Emeline will offer to be the receptionist.

The glitch never occurs again.



arrives, along with Dean Anderson. They've probably caused a lot of damage to the chapel with their particle beams (you have been tracking that, right?), and the security team is not going to be happy.

Luckily, the dean takes the Heroes aside and calms the security patrol. The players can try to explain what has happened, and tell the dean that they have been successful... well, almost. Have the Heroes make a Style roll to get their side of the story across.

Security want the Heroes arrested, and want to free Emeline, but the dean will explain everything to the security patrol, and promise that those responsible will pay for the repairs to the chapel.

The patrol drives off, and leaves the dean (who has an ulterior motive, remember) with the Heroes.



"So, you did it. You finally caught a ghost," the dean says.

The dean is keen for them to go into business.

"You're going into business. I can see it now - Paranormal Exterminators. Catch the ghosts, get paid. How else are you going to pay for the damage to the chapel? And next time, have the tenant sign a damage waiver. I'll send over someone who can help with the paperwork and manage your finances tomorrow."

He has it all thought out.

"No need to thank me. This is big. It'll put the university at the forefront, proving life after death. Well. Maybe next one. This poor girl looks like an overenthusiastic renfair patron. She doesn't look like a ghost. I know what you said, but you can't show her to the

press to say you caught a ghost... Maybe next one. Let me know how you get on." And with that, the dean strides off to find the distraught university chaplain.

Remind the Heroes that their poor research subject, John, is still in the sensory deprivation tank, and suggest that they head back to the lab.

Back at the lab, you settle down and try to calm your nerves. When you let John out of the water tank he looks dazed and confused.

"Did it work? Felt like I was in there for days!"

Now it's time to discuss what they are going to do next. Finally, proof of life-after-death! An actual ghost! Sending this to the press, or having an announcement at the board or a reveal to the academic big-wigs is going to result in a lot of denial, disbelief and ridicule. No one is going to believe them, and Dean Anderson isn't going to risk his career to back them up - at least, not just yet. He has an ulterior motive going on.

The Library!

Suddenly, the phone rings! There has been a sighting at the University Library. Right on your doorstep! This could be proof!

The Heroes need to get to the library. You can use the same process you used when they rushed to the chapel.

The library is huge, and as they enter the Heroes can see the chief librarian, Gillian Templemere, talking to a familiar face.

Inside the main foyer you can see the reception desk and a familiar face — the dean of the University, Richard Anderson.

The dean heard about the ghostly activity and rushed to the site.

THE LIBRARY GHOST

The head librarian, Gillian Templemere, says the ghost has been spotted in the rare manuscripts department in the basement, and points the Heroes down there. The dean, Richard Anderson, says it'll look very good for their future funding if they look into the haunting and can deal with it.

Then it's going to be up to the players to sneak around the shelves, the offices, the filing cabinets, and try to spot the specter. The Director can have them sneak about, lure them in certain directions with spikes in the EMF readings, have some books float about a bit, some pens hovering in mid air. That sort of thing. The key encounters that are essential are:



What's really going on?

First of all, yes, there was a supernatural incursion at the library. The Butler Library houses an extensive rare manuscripts department in the basement, and it is here that the important tome - *Zephron's Guide to Hells and Purgatories* - is housed. About a month ago, a bunch of students from the university's horror movie club got drunk and snuck into the basement, found the book, and read aloud one of the passages. The president of the club, Emily Waterhouse (yes, that Emily Waterhouse, leader of PURE - we'll come to that in a moment) was there as her boyfriend, Colin Vaughn, read the passage from the book.

Weird things started happening, lights started popping, books flew about, slime started oozing from the walls. The head librarian, Gillian Templemere, called the dean immediately and both arrived just as the portal opened. A number of entities broke through, and leaped into the host bodies they found waiting. The more sober, the better for these spirits! Oh, the irony, so the dean, the librarian, and Emily were the first to be possessed.

A plucky and nerdy business student, horror movie club member and library volunteer (who had access and let the club into the restricted rare manuscripts department) Patrick Dickens, immediately panicked. Worried he was going to get expelled, he ran from the scene grabbing the copy of *Zephron's Guide* on the way.

The shock of the ritual working, and the arrival of the dean meant that Colin stopped the ritual before it could be completed, and dropped the book. The fabric of reality keeping our world from the Nether has been damaged, and the portal can now only be opened in that location as the barrier between worlds is weakened. This is something the Ghostbreakers will discover when they start shipping the evil entities back to the Nether as part of their business, but that'll probably be after this adventure has finished.

The rest of the club were so drunk and passed out from the energies they simply woke the following morning with hangovers, mysteriously back in their respective dorms. The three possessed individuals, the dean, the librarian, and Emily, woke in their beds, a bit confused but now possessed by three highly competitive entities.

These entities are not always controlling them, but can exert some influence on their actions. They're not incredibly powerful, but they want the portal to be opened permanently, to unleash all of the Nether on Earth, and to free their "god" - Gozarr the Devourer. If one can do it before the other two, gaining Gozarr's approval and the praise and benefits that comes with it, well, so be it...

Those possessed during this incursion will be working, sometimes without their hosts' knowledge, towards opening that portal again to release Gozarr. Other things came through at the same time, one of which is the spook that's haunting the library at the start of this story. However, the three key entities are:

Callor The Keeper. Guardian of the portal. An ever vigilant sentry keeping watch over who enters the Nether and releasing the denizens upon the unsuspecting. Callor was hurled from the Nether unintentionally when the ritual was interrupted, and has taken up residence in Gillian Templemere, the head librarian (civilian).

Liril The Purifier. A violent and vengeful entity that thrives off of the destruction of those unworthy to serve or feed Gozarr the Devourer. Liril was released onto our world and leaped into the body of Emily Waterhouse (occultist) from the horror movie club. She will form PURE later in the adventure, in an effort to encourage the Ghostbreakers to open the portal regularly, hoping to repair the connection between our world and the Nether.

Unthag The Servant. Gozarr's second in command, and weasley little suck-up. Unthag lives to serve his master, to do his bidding, and, now he's on Earth, to bring his master through to our realm to give him a whole dimension to devour. He's hoping that this act will please his master enough to be rewarded with his own hell dimension to rule, or to rule over the remains of this one once Gozarr has had his fill. Unthag broke through the portal and inhabits the body of the dean, Richard Anderson (functionary). He will give the Ghostbreakers the go ahead to continue their business, hoping to steer them into unwittingly opening the portal.

ECTOPLASMIC RESIDUE. The first thing that needs to happen in the rare manuscripts section of the library is the discovery of ectoplasmic residue. At some point of their sneaking around, the EMF readings will spike and send them down an aisle of books that are dripping with ectoplasm. The goo is running slowly down the books as the Ghostbreakers pass it. As they pass the area, the ectoplasm continues to flow, increasing in ferocity until it is oozing out from under the stacks into neighboring aisles. (Don't worry, it'll stop when they move to the next bit, they're not going to get flooded. But it'll look creepy and cool).

THE GHOST ENCOUNTER. After searching the library, following the EMF readings and wandering around a bit, seeing some weirdness, the final encounter is the ghost itself. This isn't a librarian as you would expect (remember, the head librarian is actually possessed by Callor The Keeper). It is just a minion



that escaped when the portal opened. Although not actually a librarian, this ghost uses the stats of a **phantasmal horror**.

The creature looks like a wizened old man, about three feet tall, with ridiculously oversized spectacles. He shuffles through the stacks, picking up random books, and flicking through the pages. He squints at the text, sometimes lifts his glasses (not that it'll make much difference) and when he discovers it's not the book he's after, tosses it aside and moves onto the next one.

He's looking for the copy of *Zephron's Guide* that opened the portal, but he's not going to find it. Patrick Dickens has run off with it, and is hoping to find a way to use it to get rid of those nasties that he saw come through the portal and possess people.

The creature, we'll call him Magoozer, isn't violent or scary, unless the Ghostbreakers make a lot of noise or disturb his search. Approaching him, talking to him, or waving bleeping EMF detectors in his face is going to result in escalating responses.

Shuuush.

Can't you see
I'm reading?





First time will result in a “Shuuush. Can’t you see I’m reading?” in a cracked, old voice.

The second time will result in him turning to the Ghostbreakers, looking annoyed. He lifts his glasses to reveal red, glowing eyes. He snarls, annoyed, with a growl like a gigantic leopard from another dimension.

Third time’s the charm. Magoozer will unleash hell upon them, transforming into a giant, terrifying, tentacle-faced nasty. He will hurl dozens of books at them, unleash streams of ectoplasm from his face, trying to hurl the Ghostbreakers out of the library by using his Manifest ability to scare them witless.

The Heroes can now let loose with their equipment. Either they’ll catch the ghost, or they’ll be driven from the library in terror. Let’s hope it’s the former!

However, when they leave the library, with the Magoozer corporeal and bound by anti-plasm binders, they will be greeted by the campus security again, and a handful of reporters from various news networks. The dean, seeing a marketing opportunity, has called the press. If the Heroes were successful in catching the freaky looking thing in the library, the presence of the press will be excellent publicity for this venture. If not, they’re going to look pretty foolish plastered all over the front pages of tomorrow’s newspaper as they flee the building in terror!

There is, however, an additional element that can be important here. In the crowd, a voice can be heard shouting at the Heroes.

“You gotta help me. Weird things have happened in that library. I went there with my girlfriend and she changed, she dumped me and... she’s just different, man.”



The voice is Colin Vaughn, Emily Waterhouse's (now ex-) boyfriend. He was the one who read from *Zephron's Guide* in the library that night, and opened the portal. He was really drunk (though sober enough to read) and once the portal opened he passed out. When he woke, he was back home, and couldn't remember much about that night. He remembers the horror film club meet where they watched *The Nasty Dead* on VHS and drank a few too many, and it all gets fuzzy after that.

Since then, Emily has become possessed and the first thing she did was refuse to take Colin's calls. She has more important things to do now, like opening a portal to unleash **GOZARR THE DEVOURER** onto our world.

Colin can visit the Ghostbreaker's HQ and tell his story at a later date if they wish to listen to him. They could just think he's crazy and ignore him completely, but if your Heroes enjoy the more investigative side of things, they could hear him out and do some research into the events of that night. Who knows, it could be important?



Act Two: We're In Business!

After the encounter in the library, the Heroes will probably want to head to a bar, for a stiff drink. They'll make it back to the lab at some point.

The following day, it's all about getting things in place. You can run through the following scenes fairly quickly to get back to the action. Hey, why not play some motivational 80s music again in the background? Not so much a montage, more an excuse to add another track to the soundtrack album!

Giving Emeline a Chance

Emeline is not hostile at all. She doesn't really need the binders, and now she's semi-corporeal she just wants to find Edward. After some talking with the Heroes, and some explanation of what happened, she realizes her fate and that she's just kinda stuck. It's not a great situation for her, but she's determined to make the best of a bad situation and volunteers to help the Heroes with their paperwork and reception duties.

Of course, technology has changed since 1876, so you can play with understanding telephones, and what a car, or television, is for comedic effect.

Spy in the Spook House

PATRICK DICKENS arrives at the Ghostbreaker's headquarters.

He's been sent by Dean Anderson to look after the business side of things (and secretly to spy on the Ghostbreakers' actions, though he doesn't really know what he's looking for). He brings money to help with the basic business set up for the Ghostbreakers. Not much, but enough to get logos on the car, and on the building. Some flashing lights and sirens, some nice headed notepaper, damage release forms, and those lovely business cards for the Heroes (though nothing too fancy - just black print on white with the logo. No "egg shell" or "bone" with pale nimbus embossed type). Patrick volunteered to the dean as he's a bit of a suck-up and overheard him talking on the phone about needing someone to help with the Ghostbreakers business. Also, he needs help researching the book he has in his bag - *Zephron's Guide to Hells and Purgatories* - that he's hoping to use to expel the spirit possessing Emily.



Hey, bro!

Nice ride!



Cleaning Up the City

After the Ghostbreakers catch Magoozer in the library and take him back to the base (successfully imprisoning him in one of the holding cells), then the Heroes are really in business. The TV runs stories about the new paranormal exterminators, late night talk shows want to get them on, news coverage of the incident goes worldwide, and soon they start getting calls from all over the city from people witnessing strange things.

Directors can add as many ghostly encounters and calls as they like, creating their own locations and paranormal nasties to keep the Heroes occupied. Below are three of the call-outs the Heroes respond to in *Spirits of Manhattan*: The Glitzman Hotel, Engine 30 Fire Station, and Heebie-Jeebies.

The Glitzman Hotel

One of the earliest cases the Ghostbreakers have to deal with is at the prestigious Glitzman Hotel on Park Avenue.

"Hello, is that the 'Ghostbreakers'? This is Stephan Gellar, the manager of the Glitzman hotel on Park Avenue. We have a small problem and would like it to be dealt with discretely."

You can add the usual complications to the drive over to the hotel as before, or let the Heroes arrive without incident. That's purely up to you and whether you've had your coffee for the evening.



At the hotel, the Ghostmobile can park outside where the valet will give the car a suitably confused look. Inside the hotel, the manager Stephan Gellar rushes out to meet them.

"Come, quickly. I was hoping you'd use the staff entrance, but the elevators are this way. Come." Stephan ushers you into the elevator and presses the button for the 14th floor.

"We've had a ghost problem here for many years, but up until now it has been only one night a year. February 14th."

"Valentines Day..." says Aurora with a sense of deadpan sarcasm, *"What a monster."*

"Indeed. He's a well documented pest. A tabloid photographer who fell from the 13th, sorry, 14th floor after getting into a fight with the subject of one of his 'exposés'. But it's not Valentines Day now. He's been plaguing our guests every night for the last week, and he's not just on the 13th, sorry, 14th floor. Just deal with him, it, as discretely as possible."

The first task is getting the manager to sign the damage release form. They don't want to get sued on their first big job for trashing the place, and the likelihood of them destroying a lot of those lovely art deco features that decorate the halls and rooms is quite high.

A bit of convincing will be required, though they're not short of some idle threats of leaving the ghost to cause havoc every night until the end of time. Eventually, Gellar will sign. This isn't an excuse for the Ghostbreakers to cause unnecessary damage, but anything damaged in the line of catching the ghost of Will Mapleton will have to be paid for by the hotel insurance, rather than by the Ghostbreakers themselves.

When attacked by the Ghostbreakers, the spook will flee through the walls of the rooms on that floor, to a chorus of screams and shouts from the hotel guests. The Ghostbreakers can follow down the corridors with EMF detectors at the ready, or give chase through the rooms with their adjoining doors. After all, those doors are quite fragile compared to the blast of a particle launcher.

With the Ghostbreakers facing off against Will Mapleton's ghost down the main corridor, the spook will look cornered. He recognizes the window at the end of the corridor from which he fell all those years ago. Not wanting to go the same way, he holds his nose as if he's going to dive into a swimming pool and jumps in the air.

Being incorporeal, Mapleton will sink through the floor to the floor below. And will keep going until he reaches the ground floor and the fancy Atlantic Restaurant area of the hotel.



With the battle relocated to the restaurant, there's plenty of opportunity to blow stuff up as the packed restaurant evacuates its richest and fanciest patrons out onto the street and the hotel lobby. Here, Will makes his final stand before being captured, and the hotel will have some major repairs to do, as well as paying the Ghostbreakers for their services.

There's a good chance the press will arrive for the final conflict. Maybe even the police, though there's nothing they can do as the Ghostbreakers were legally hired for the task and a waiver has been signed in case of damage.

Will Mapleton

This ghost of a sleazy photographer only appears when romance is in the offing. It has the stats of a **ghostly creep**, but instead of its invisibility ability, it has a flashbulb attack:

Flashbulb 5 (no damage; victim is blinded for one minute)

Engine 30 Fire Station

When the Heroes are returning from their job at the Glitzman Hotel, the Ghostmobile is diverted due to some roadworks down 100th St.

Well that was successful. The ghost of Will Mapleton successfully trapped in the back of the car, you head back to headquarters. Unfortunately, there a burst water main and the city works have set up a long and complicated diversion across half of the city.

Stuck in some traffic on West 100th St, there's a strange moment when the car radio suddenly bursts into life playing that old disco tune, Disco Inferno. It only plays for a few seconds before turning itself off again. Weird.

You can have the Heroes make some rolls to see if they notice anything strange or out of the ordinary. The sciency types (c'mon, that's a real word isn't it?) may choose to whip out those EMF detectors. They will certainly light up when pointed in the direction of the fire station.

If they succeed, they'll notice a couple of figures waving from the windows on the first floor of the fire station...

You notice in the first floor window of the Engine 30 Fire Station there are a couple of people waving. Ah, adoring fans! It must be! Word of your brave exploits, ridding the world of paranormal menace has obviously reached the other emergency services and our brave firefighters are showing their appreciation.

As you look, you notice the waving getting more and more frantic, until eventually you see one of the figures lifting a chair and start bashing it against the window a few times before it breaks, sending the chair and shards of glass showering onto the sidewalk below.



Suddenly, a ghostly figure in firefighting uniform, complete with respirator, bursts through the doors at the front of the building, and floats up to the first floor. It pulls off its respirator mask, and in a strange, echoing voice, says, "No, no, no! You mustn't do that. It's a long fall and you could hurt yourself on all of that broken glass!"



As you watch, the glass fragments rise from the ground and the window begins reassembling itself in front of the protesting firefighters inside.

The ghost in question is Stella Henderson, a **trickster spirit**, the chief of this station who lead her team into a nasty blaze at an auto-repair shop in 1982. The gas tanks caught and Stella, along with some of her squad, were lost to the tragic explosion.

Stella returned to the Engine 30 Fire Station a few months later, and her actions were initially quite simple and innocent. The words "Be careful out there" were written on the briefing board, the equipment always seems unnaturally tidy and well stored. Sometimes items would be moved or damaged, and when investigated they were discovered to be faulty - the damage preventing their use and possibly saving a crewmember's life.

Some of the Heroes had an idea who was behind it, but didn't want to appear foolish. Then, Stella started manifesting. Telling the crew to be careful, not to take any risks. Then it escalated. After a crewmember was injured by a falling beam, Stella decided it was too dangerous out there, and the only way to prevent any more lives being lost would be to stop the engine from responding to any calls.



The station doors would mysteriously lock themselves, the tires on the engine would be let down, and this interference continued until now - Stella won't even let the crew leave the building. This is a common trait with ghosts. They may have good intentions, but the longer they hang around and fail to "move on", their actions become more and more extreme and distorted.

Now it is down to the Ghostbreakers to help the crew do their job of saving lives and putting out fires, by catching Stella once and for all and helping her to finally move on.

The Thin Red (Tape) Line!

The first real trick is getting that release form signed. It's all well and good blasting your way into the fire station to rescue those poor firefighters, but if you've blown the doors off with a particle blast before they've signed a release form, you're just leaving yourself open to legal action.

There are a few ways around this. Of course, this will all depend upon the Ghostbreakers remembering the release forms before they waded in. The easiest way to get a release form signed is to get someone outside of the building to sign it. They will have to be part of the Fire Department, so a quick trip over to the nearby phone kiosk and a call through to the FDNY will do. Within thirty minutes a representative from the Manhattan Borough Command will be there to sign the release form and the Heroes can get on with trapping the ghost.

Another way around it is to get someone inside to sign the form. Popping over the road to "Just the Fax, Ma'am" fax and photocopying bureau will mean the Ghostbreakers can fax a copy of the release form to the squad inside the fire station. They can then sign the form and either fax it back, or simply hold it up to the window so the Ghostbreakers can see it is signed.

The only other way around all of the paperwork is to catch Stella's ghost *outside* the fire station. In her introduction she's already come outside the building to ensure the squad do not escape through the window. If the firefighters can be convinced to make another attempt like this, Stella will once more phase through the main doors at the front of the building and repair the window. This is a prime opportunity to blast her while she's outside.

Whatever route they choose, whether it is one of these or simply trying to sneak into the building via the sewers or some other genius plan, it should be a simple bag and tag job from there out.

Not on My Watch!

Initially, Stella will not attack the Ghostbreakers unless they put the firefighters inside at risk. However, she will defend herself if directly attacked, and after a few hits she'll retaliate. It's a dirty job, but someone's gotta do it.

She will use her telekinesis to throw the Ghostbreakers about, make firehoses coil and attack like snakes, fire jets of high pressure water at them, but she won't try to kill the Ghostbreakers, no matter what they do. So no launching fire axes at the Heroes! Stella is all about saving lives, not taking them.

Eventually, the Heroes will succeed and catch Stella, and she can be safely stored in the back of the Ghostmobile along with the ghost of Will Mapleton. Who knows, they may get along. The fire fighters, while glad to see Stella removed safely from the building, and able to perform their brave duties once more, will ask the Ghostbreakers to ensure her wellbeing.

"She may have kept us prisoner, but her heart was in the right place. And, after all, she was one of the team. Make sure she's treated well. Y'know, help her move on and find peace."

Heebie-Jeebies

There's a call from the manager of Heebie-Jeebies, one of the coolest and most iconic music venues in Manhattan. All the best punk and new wave bands started there, and it has become legendary among music fans worldwide. A call from Wilhelmena "Billy" Reeves explains that she has a problem with a "drummer that went all Spinal Tap" and exploded in their garage trying out some new pyrotechnics on their drum kit a month before their breakout gig at Heebie-Jeebies. Now, he's determined to be recognized and get that record deal, even though he's dead. He keep showing up during gigs, performing epic ten-minute drum solos while other bands are trying to perform.

Pity is, the drummer - Jess Hardacre, a **shrieker** - is actually really good, but he's getting in the way and interrupting the living groups that are trying to perform.

Time for the Ghostbreakers to 'break' into the music scene!

This should be a simple bag and tag for the Heroes, with a pretty small venue that's packed with music lovers of every persuasion. It's going to be a squeeze, and the Heroes will have to be careful where they are pointing their anti-plasm beams, but it should be pretty simple. Jess will try to defend himself with sonic attacks, and bashing the Heroes with his drumsticks, but he's not really a danger to them.



Act Three: To Heck with That!

The final act has a fairly quiet beginning, leading to the big finale. The three possessing entities want that portal opened to release Gozarr the Devourer, but Patrick has a plan of his own. Plus the cells are starting to look a little full, and someone has something to say about that.

The PURE Solution

A few days after their high profile catches at the Glitzman Hotel, Engine 30 Firestation, and Heebie-Jeebies, the Heroes receive a knock on the door...

It has been a couple of days since the press arrived at the Glitzman Hotel to cover your Heroic capture of the ghost of Will Mapleton. There have been a few calls from newspapers and TV news channels wanting to run a feature on the Ghostbreakers. Even a call from the Jim Arnold Show on WOR-TV asking you to appear on one of his late night talk shows.

It's late morning and you are slowly waking from another eventful night of ghost hunting and trapping. Patrick, the team accountant, is already at work looking at the finances and logistics of the business, as well as trying to teach Emeline a little about filing. He notices your arrival with eagerness. There's obviously something on his mind.

"I'm really glad to catch you. While the business is doing great - you're certainly earning enough to keep this running nicely - there's something I've been getting worried about. You've caught a few ghosts now, but there are only twelve containment cells in the basement. What happens when we run out of space?"

Just then, there's a knock on the main door of the building.

Outside is cool and nerdy **EMILY WATERHOUSE**. Remember, this is the first time the Heroes will have met her, so they will know nothing of her connection to the weird happenings at the library.

You open the door to a pretty and efficient looking young lady with big hair and glasses. She's wearing a grey business suit and carrying a folder of paperwork.

Hello,
I'm PURE.



"Hello, I'm PURE. I mean, I'm from PURE. My name's Emily and I was hoping to help some of the people here if you can give me a few minutes of your time?"

Hopefully, the Heroes will invite her in.

"Thank you for seeing me. As I said, I'm from PURE. That is the Protection of Undead Returned Entities. We're an organization that saw you on the news and we're concerned about these spirits and what happens to them after you have removed them from the scene of their return."

Emily asks to see the containment facilities to ensure the ghosts are not being harmed, just kept isolated.

"I can see that they are being safely and 'humanely' kept in your facilities, doctor. It is 'doctor' isn't it? But what is going to happen to them? Even dangerous criminals are given counselling, training, and a form of rehabilitation to allow them to eventually return to society after they have paid their debt. You can't expect to keep these entities against their will indefinitely, can you?"

The conversation will lead in a few directions. The key points the Director needs to get over are that ghosts haunt because there is unresolved 'business' that prevents them moving on, and once that is satisfied, they will depart this plane of existence.

Patrick will overhear all of this conversation and will volunteer to try to help once Emily has gone, doing research into the ghosts' cases - who they were, what they wanted, etc. to try to assess what the ghost needs to resolve its issues and move on. However, and here's a big warning for the Director, *Patrick will not make his presence known to Emily!* Simple reason is that Emily will recognize him from the horror movie club, remember him being there on the night the portal opened, and start to ask questions. She doesn't know that Patrick has *Zephron's Guide* hidden in Ghostbreakers HQ, and he's not going to let on.

Unexpected Withdrawals

While the Ghostbreakers are off on their next call, Patrick will be talking to Magoozer, his first subject in 'trying to get the ghosts resolved'. Of course, this is mostly because Patrick wants to know how to use the book to get the possessing spirits out of Emily, the dean and the head librarian. Magoozer is lying as always, and has convinced Patrick that the best way to get the three free from their possession is to get them back to the place it happened, along with the book.

Before the Ghostbreakers return, he'll sneak off and kidnap Gillian Templemere, the head librarian.



BACK TO BASE-ICS

You can pad things here with a few short missions. When the players start to look at their phones instead of you, read out the following.

You return back to Ghostbreakers HQ, with a trapped ghost securely bound. He walks in front of you while you usher him in, particle throwers poking towards him as he mutters, "Okay, I'm goin', man. Don't be such a downer!"

Emeline waves over to you, holding many pieces of paper. She follows as you lead the spook to the containment cells.

"I've been receiving telephone calls, and as you instructed, I've been taking messages for you. You had a call from Emily Waterhouse who wanted to make sure that the ghosts were being treated well and that you had started the procedures to help them to move on.

You also had a call from Marilyn Sanchez. She's a librarian at the Butler library who says there have been more reports of thunderous booms and knocking sounds. Some have knocked books off of the shelves. She said there haven't been any ghost sightings, not since you removed that disgusting creature from the rare manuscripts department, but she asked if the knocking was a normal after effect?

There was also a call from your urologist who said it shouldn't glow green like that and you should book an appointment as soon as possible. I don't know what that means, or what a urologist is, but it sounded important.

Lastly, you've another call out once you've dealt with this unfortunate gentleman. Reports of a spectral taxi speeding up and down the entire length of Broadway."

Lots of information to deal with here. Let's take it all stage by stage.





PURE DATES

The following morning there is a **GROUP OF PROTESTERS** camped outside the building with signs saying witty things like “Where’s your Spirit of Freedom?”, “Death is not a life sentence” and “Be good hosts to our ghosts”. You can come up with others, but you get the idea.

SILENCE IN THE LIBRARY

It’s true there are knocks and booms at the library. This is Gozarr trying to break into our reality. The Ghostbreakers can go and investigate, but they won’t find anything. The EMF detector will spike a few times, and there will be a few books on the floor, but that may just be lazy students. Unable to find anything concrete, the Ghostbreakers can move onto the next case or head home.

The only interesting bit of information is that Marilyn Sanchez is a library assistant at the Butler Library, and she’s having to manage things as Gillian Templemere has phoned in sick. If the Ghostbreakers get suspicious and do some investigating, they can uncover Gillian’s home address. Checking it out they’ll find no sign of Gillian, but signs of a small struggle.

GLOWING RESULTS!

The urologist who called will do some more tests, and determine that it’s not dangerous. It’s just an unfortunate side-effect. She suggests that the Heroes buy some suits with biohazard protection as soon as they can afford it.

GHOST-CHASERS!

The final element is the spectral taxi that is speeding up and down Broadway. This has some additional problems with the sheer size of the ghost. It’s not just the ghostly cabbie that needs to be caught - the car is part of the ghostly apparition! Luckily, blasting the taxi with anti-plasm particle streams will blow the taxi to pieces and leave the cabbie as more manageable and catchable ghost.

The trick is going to be catching up to it. The cabbie is Elroy McHale, and he’s determined to pick up his passengers and get them to their destination on time. Only problem is, he crashed and died after speeding to get to his pick up, so never arrived. The cab has been spotted at the same time every night for the last three or four nights (11:57pm) hurtling up Broadway from the Woolworth Building, running the majority of the length of Broadway, straight past Columbia University, over Broadway Bridge, before reenacting his crash at the junction with the Henry Hudson Parkway in the Bronx.



The yellow cab glows with spectral light as it careens through traffic at high speed, with its ghostly driver gripping the wheel and leaning forwards, egging the car to go faster. It passes through the traffic as a ghost would through walls, though the sight of the cab driving at them is enough to make drivers swerve out of the way. It's going to be difficult to keep up with it long enough to blast it. Saying that, it shouldn't be too difficult for the Heroes to drive. They're used to driving in Manhattan traffic, right?

Directors should feel free to throw in some random obstacles. It doesn't matter the time of night, car chases are always better with the traditional crates of vegetables, people carrying panes of glass, piles of random cardboard boxes, driving over mailboxes/newspaper vending boxes, or procession of nuns in the road.

Get outta my way, bozo!

The driver will have to make Moves checks to avoid the obstacles and to narrow the gap between themselves and the ghost cab. When they're within range of the taxi, the passengers can hang out of the windows and open fire with the anti-plasm throwers (DEFENCE 15, Health 8). Once the cab reaches zero Health, it will crumble to pieces and leave the dazed Elroy, a **phantasmal horror**, in the street, ready to be captured - after a standup fight of course!

Gates and Fates

Here we are, the final part of *Spirits of Manhattan*. All of the pieces are in play, and everything is building to this final act. It's going to get big and messy, but the Ghostbreakers should come out heroes of the city - if they don't screw it up too badly.

How Did We Get Here?

First of all, let's just check everything's going to plan. While the Ghostbreakers are out dealing with the ghostly cab, Patrick will sneak out again and kidnap the dean. He's been talking to Magoozer as part of his "help the ghosts resolve their issues" thing, and Magoozer has been telling him the best way to remove the entities that are possessing Emily, the dean, and the head librarian. Magoozer's solution is to get all three of them back to the scene of the portal opening - the rare manuscript department of the Butler Library. Restrained, the three will not put up a fight. Magoozer will even help if necessary,



he was only after the book to seal the portal permanently - at least, that's what he's told Patrick. Once they're all in the library, reading the passage from the book will open the portal, reverse the possession, and Patrick's friends will be returned to normal. The curtain falls, Patrick is a hero, and Emily will shower him with unending praise and her eternal admiration.

What a sucker. Magoozer's plan is just to get the portal open. If Patrick feels like he needs the three possessed victims there to get them dispossessed, that's fine. The key is getting the book to the library and trick the unwitting fool into reading from that passage again. The portal will open and Gozarr the Devourer will be free to reign over the Earth... before devouring every living soul. Magoozer will be thanked by his master, and rewarded. Hurrah!

At least, that's the plan. Magoozer and Patrick are going to do this behind the scenes, and the Ghostbreakers will probably find out with just enough time to get to the scene and put a stop to it. Hopefully. For the sake of our world.

Contingency Plans

If Patrick has been discovered, or things aren't going to plan, the Director can get creative. Emily can follow through with her plan of freeing Magoozer (who knows where Patrick has been hiding the copy of *Zephron's Guide to Hells and Purgatories* if necessary), releasing all of the ghosts in Ghostbreakers HQ and calling it an act of PURE. Once Magoozer is free, she'll head to the library with him and they can start opening the portal.

Other ways to progress involve the Ghostbreakers finding the book at the HQ and returning it to the library where, once rescued from the storage closet, Gillian Templemere the head librarian, will use it to open the portal. Or even the dean can disable Patrick and set about opening the portal himself. As long as the book gets to the library with one of the three possessed Heroes, Patrick, or Magoozer, then the big final scene can go ahead.

If someone has the bright idea of destroying the book before now, Patrick will have made a Xerox copy of it just in case this happens. The portal will be terribly unstable, but it'll work.

Don't worry. If something comes up to scupper your plans for the finale, call it a night and have a think between sessions. There's bound to be a way around it. We have faith in you. Just think like a crazed demonic entity hellbent on global destruction and the end of life as we know it - just another day in the office for your average Director!

DIGGING YOUR SCENE

The night following the taxi chase New York is inundated with spectral encounters.

The phone is ringing. Every line is flashing like a Christmas Tree. There is a rumble of thunder, but it goes on impossibly long. That's not thunder. It's something else. Looking out of the window you can see dark stormclouds moving in a strange pattern, radiating from somewhere south of HQ.

Emeline answers the phone multiple times while you look on in awe and confusion...

"All the calls. They're all the same. Something bad is happening on campus. At the library..."

The Ghostbreakers need to get to the library. Directors can add obstacles and driving tasks on the way if they feel like it, but the players will probably just want to get to the big finale.

RETURNING BORROWED ITEMS

The Butler Library is shrouded in darkness. Clouds roil and lightning flickers like the end of an epic Spielberg movie, the eye of the deafening storm swirls directly above the campus library building. You've a strange feeling you know just where to go...

Inside the building the books are floating in a cyclone of paper and pages torn from spines. The librarian is going to be seriously pissed. The stairs to the basement, and the rare manuscript department, are a slow running waterfall of ectoplasm. Not thick enough to be dangerous, but enough to make you nervous. You really need to get those biohazard suits.

In the basement the cyclone isn't as dramatic, but the centre of the storm is obvious. Laid on the floor, bound and gagged lay the dean, Richard Anderson; the head librarian, Gillian Templemere; and the head of PURE, Emily Waterhouse. In the middle of the triangle of victims is Patrick Dickens, and Magoozer.

"There," says Magoozer, "It is done. Thank you Patrick, for your help."

"Patrick, what the hell have you done?" shouts Aurora.

"It was the only way to free them. Didn't you realize? They were possessed! Creatures from the Nether have been controlling their actions. Now we can return those creatures to the Nether and they will be released!"

A glowing portal opens in the middle of the air, and the stench of sulphur and fire blasts into the room. It's gross.



Suddenly, green lightning arcs from the portal and strikes Patrick. He stands, shuddering with the power that courses through his body.

"Urrrglegurgle," Patrick convulses.

The Ghostbreakers can do whatever they want here. The obvious choice would be to shoot something - either Patrick, Magoozer or the portal. For Magoozer, use the same stats as his initial encounter. If you're worried that the players are going to have difficulty, you can have Magoozer already injured, the stresses of opening the portal having taken their toll on his body.

Shooting the portal will have very little effect. Though it looks cool, and the Ghostbreakers will feel better for shooting at something.

Patrick will be the living receptacle for Gozarr the Devourer. His hair will stand on end like an 80's supermodel, and his nerdy suit and tie will glow with energy. He'll roar at them, shouting:

"I, Gozarr the Devourer, will consume your world. I will feast on your population, I will gorge myself on your souls, and when I am sated all that will be left will be misery and despair."

He can attack with blasts of energy, green fire flashing from his hands. Use the stats below for Patrick in his possessed form. He's not particularly strong, as it's not the whole of Gozarr. Just a fragment of the entity possessing him.

For stats, refer to the monsters in this booklet.

Patzarr (Patrick Dickens Possessed by Gozarr the Devourer) is a **firemage**.

Callor The Keeper (freed from inhabiting Gillian Templemere) is a **phantasmal horror**.

Liril The Purifier (freed from inhabiting Emily Waterhouse) is a **trickster spirit**.

Unthag The Servant (freed from inhabiting Richard Anderson) is a **shrieker**.

If Patrick/Gozarr (let's call him Patzarr!) starts to weaken, he can shoot fireballs at the three possessed souls on the floor, severing their ties. They can join the battle, though they are not dangerous in this state. A few blasts and the hosts will crumple unconscious to the floor. Carlos can exorcise them quickly with just a splash of holy water and a couple of passages from the bible. It should be quick and pretty simple, allowing the possessing entities to roam free to be blasted by the Heroes.

It's not going to be easy, and if the Director finds that the players are having difficulty they should feel free to rein in the attacks or have them try to flee through the portal.

Patzarr can be handled with a few blasts that will probably take him down, and **CARLOS** can perform an exorcism to remove Gozarr's presence from the host body. However, once free from Patrick's body, Gozarr doesn't manifest as a physical entity. At least not yet.

WE'VE GOT BIGGER PROBLEMS

This is the big, dramatic ending. The moment you've been waiting for... I hope you're ready for it, as it's going to take a little bit of creativity on the Director's part.

Good luck.

You're gonna need it!

Patrick is unconscious, but he's free from Gozarr. The green energy no longer courses through him, and his hair no longer stands straight up like a fashion model, though that may be a look Patrick decides to keep in the future.

You did it. Though that portal is still open, swirling dangerously in the middle of the library.

Suddenly, a booming voice echoes through the building, and the surrounding streets.

"Puny mortals, you have my book. I will take one of yours. Choose one and face me, or you shall live nevermore."

In *Ghostbreakers: Spirits of Manhattan* Miles mentally makes the choice inspired by Gozarr's words. His mental train of thought goes from "nevermore" to *The Raven*, by Edgar Allen Poe, and thinks of his copy of the *Complete Tales and Poems of Edgar Allen Poe* sitting on his bookshelf at home. Gozarr sees this in Miles' mind and manifests as a 100ft tall version of Edgar Allen Poe, striding through the city, picking up cars, quoting *The Tell-Tale Heart* and *The Pit and the Pendulum* while stomping towards the library to destroy the Ghostbreakers.

This is where the players and the Director can shake things up a bit. It doesn't have to be Edgar Allen Poe. If the players can't think of anything, the Director can simply go with *Spirits of Manhattan* and say Miles had the same train of thought. However, if the players fancy they can pick something else. A 100ft tall *Alice* from *Alice in Wonderland*? Cthulhu or H.P. Lovecraft himself? Aslan? Gandalf? Stephen King? Absolutely anything. As long as the book was published before 1984, so no Harry Potter or Edward Cullen please.

It doesn't have to be fiction, if the players decide to go for *On The Origin of Species* you could have a 100ft tall 'missing link' or Darwin himself? The biography of Elvis or Marilyn Monroe, the history of



the Tudor kings? Anything is possible, as long as it's fun, amusing, and not offensive to anyone. Discuss with the players what they fancy choosing, and make sure everyone's happy with their choice.

The stats for the 100ft tall Gozarr manifestation will be the same, just the appearance will be different.

The screams and the crashes seem to get closer. The floor vibrates with each boom, until there is the sound of horrible cracking and tearing. Suddenly, the ceiling of the basement rips open. The floors above have been torn aside and looming into the basement through the gaping hole above is a giant (Edgar Allen Poe). It roars at you 'Quoth the Raven!!!!' and it reaches towards you.

Miles turns to the others. "There's only one way I can see to stop this. We need to suck him and the other entities back into the portal. If we switch the mix on the particle throwers, switch off the anti-plasm mix, we'll be firing pure antimatter into the portal. It'll react, and create a miniature black hole, that'll suck our friend (Edgar) in and stop the energies coming through to our plane. We may get sucked in with him, or we could implode the entire planet, but it's the only idea I have."

"Sounds like a plan! Let's save this city! Or, you know, destroy it trying!"

A simple flick of a switch on the controls and a normal roll to hit the portal is needed. It's pretty easy, but if they've survived this long they've done all the hard work already.

The particle streams blast into the portal, and there is a horrific scream from (Edgar Allen Poe). Through the portal, in the heat of the fires and sulphur blasts, a sphere of blackness forms, so black, so eternally dark, you can feel your very soul being sucked in. The fires are drawn in, as are the books and debris from the destroyed side of the library. (Edgar Allen Poe) reaches into the portal to try to stop it, but (his) hand is sucked into the blackness. The screams are deafening. The portal starts to shrink, and you put down the particle cannons, letting them hang as you grab for the nearest stable object - the remains of the support pillars, door frames, anything.

As quickly as it started, (Edgar Allen Poe) is gone. Sucked into the black sphere. Magoozer tumbles in after him, along with the physical forms of the three entities ripped from the possessed victims. The portal snaps shut thankfully before the unconscious bodies of Patrick, Emily, Dean Anderson, and Gillian the librarian, are lost as well. As the portal closes, the books and debris that spiralled around you falls to the floor in a shower of brick and paper. It is over.

Giant Gozarr

Gozarr's stats can be found in *Tobias' Guide to Ghosts, Spooks, and Specters* (page 10). Its stats remain the same whatever form it takes.

The Ghostbreakers will not stand a chance in a stand-up fight with Gozarr. The only way to defeat it is to reverse the portal and create a black hole.

THE END OF THE BEGINNING

That's it! The Ghostbreakers have succeeded. The authorities rush to the scene, and a huge clean up effort begins. It'll take months to repair the library. Though most of the books can be replaced, the books in the rare manuscript library were often one-of-a-kinds and irreplaceable.

Directors who wish to continue the story like *Spirits of Manhattans* will have *Zephron's Guide to Hells and Purgatories* survive (or maybe Patrick's Xerox copy of it) so that the Ghostbreakers can open portals (very briefly) and expel unwanted and unredeemable entities out of our plane.

Emily will remember very little of what happened and is quickly reunited with Colin. Gillian

remembers very little too, though seems to remember being kidnapped and tied up for some reason. The dean remembers more, but will need convincing that the Ghostbreakers are worth funding, and their research can be valuable for humankind. Patrick is a strange case - he wasn't possessed, but had good intentions at heart. Good intentions that nearly had most of Manhattan sucked into a hell dimension. He'll continue to work with the Ghostbreakers, hoping to make up for what he's done and working towards his degree.

Plot Hooks

If you'd like to continue the adventures of the Ghostbreakers, you need look no further than this string of sequels that can follow *Spirits of Manhattan*! Use these plots to spin off into your own adventures!

GHOSTBREAKERS II: ECTOPLASMIC BOOGALOO

Ghostbreakers II continues the story with the Heroes firmly established as the go-to people for paranormal investigation. This adventure features a haunted wax cylinder that holds the recording of a seance held in 1922. Experimental music artist, Karl Klang, and his electronica group *Das Robotica*, become obsessed after hearing



the cylinder's recording and start to use samples of the seance on their records. When played backwards, the record can summon evil entities from the Nether, but can the Ghostbreakers realize what connects the sudden spate of paranormal activity, and destroy the original recording before everyone electro-dances their way to infernal possession?

GHOSTBREAKERS III: THROUGH THE NETHER

After a simple ejection of an unredeemable spirit into the Nether goes horribly wrong, Carlos finds himself trapped in the hell dimension, unable to escape. By the time the Heroes open the portal again, minutes later in our world, Carlos is nowhere to be found. The rest of the Ghostbreakers must venture into the Nether to rescue him from his own personal hell. It's like Dante's Inferno with more gags!

GHOSTBREAKERS IV: SEEMS LIKE TEEN SPIRITS

Ghostbreakers IV: Seems Like Teen Spirits is surely low point of the series. The original Heroes didn't want to do another sequel, but were convinced to make a small appearance setting up a new team - a group of jocks desperate to raise their grade average at the University. The dean assigns the group to take over while the original Heroes are out of the country on a big paranormal mission. However, the new Heroes head off down the coast to investigate the strange happenings at a summercamp in Ocala National Forest in Florida, against the dean's wishes. There, they try to investigate the scary happenings that are plaguing the camp. Fearing a supernaturally infused serial killer like in the horror movies, the new Heroes unwittingly trap a peaceful nature spirit and threaten to turn Florida into a new island state!

THE GHOSTBREAKERS PROJECT

This adventure features the Heroes' original lineup as they discover a hidden basement in the Ghostbreakers HQ. Seems the legendary weird doctor, Victor Daniels, whose bizarre experiments in the 70s lead to his conviction and the closure of the psychiatric department, was not working alone. Victor was being influenced by the spirit of an older doctor who worked at the same location in the 1920s. The ancient ward, hidden below the basement and bricked off for decades, is the home for more paranormal activity, and the Ghostbreakers have to clean their own house.





ACE!

Issue 3

MONTANA DRONES **AND THE RAIDERS OF THE CUTTY SARK**

MARC LANGWORTHY

Introduction

It is 1936 and the world is in a period of transition. The television is beginning to make its mark across the globe, zeppelins start ferrying people between Europe and the U.S., and Roosevelt wins a second term as President in a landslide election. If that isn't bad enough, some evil guy with a dodgy moustache is eyeing up the whole of Europe as his prize. Despite all the uncertainty across the globe, or perhaps because of it, faster methods of intercontinental travel and new technologies that are being unveiled at a dizzying pace make this an exciting time for adventure and exploration, particularly where past civilisations are concerned.

It seems like every major power is trying to vacuum up as many ancient artefacts and relics as they can lay their hands on, which means the race is often on to ensure such items don't fall into the wrong hands. Wary of sending the world over a tipping point, however, some global powers work through freelance agents as a means to protect and recover these powerful symbols. Enter Dr Abigail Elizabeth Joens, Professor of History at Halcyon Hall. Better known to her agency counterparts as Montana Drones.

At the request of Army Intelligence, Montana and her team travel the globe in search of lost or hidden artefacts, often exploring dangerous sites and racing against hostile enemy agents to keep the objects of their quests from falling into the wrong hands. Striking locations, exciting chases, dangerous enemies and monotonous classroom lectures await!

Overview

This book is divided into two sections:

The Story and Setting: The first part of the book introduces the original story as portrayed in the 1981 film of the same name – the first of a series of films that follow Montana's adventures. You'll also find some new options for Heroes here and an update for equipment in this era.

The Adventure: This is the complete adventure, *Raiders of the Cutty-Sark*. You can jump straight into the action using the free PDF of Montana and her friends or create your own crew.

Tone

Much like our other *ACE!* instalments, this adventure doesn't involve strolling from room to room fighting nasties and stealing their loot. Well, there is a bit of dungeon delving, but it involves an exciting escape from a perilous trap instead. And in this adventure, you have to protect the treasure, not steal it.

Raiders of the Cutty-Sark is designed to be light, fun, and exciting, not dark and serious. There will be fist fights, shoot outs, chases, and strange occurrences. The Heroes can be in mortal danger one moment and punching Nazis the next. Oh, and watch out for tentacles.

Synopsis

The story opens with the Heroes delving deeply into hidden chambers of the Soldier Tomb complex in Petra, where they are searching for the corselet of Mégès. A daring escape from the tomb's deadly traps deposits the group into the hands of the Muhtasim desert nomads and the scoundrel who is leading them, the eccentric tomb raider and unrepentant rival in artefact hunting, Eric Freeman. The crew need to choose between making their escape, convincing the Muhtasim nomads that Eric plans to use the corselet for his own nefarious ends, or battling it out.

With the Petra situation dealt with, or not, the Heroes land back at Halcyon Hall, where the days soon drift back into the doldrum of classroom lectures and case studies. Dr Abigail earned the nickname 'Drones' for a good reason you know. Not all is well in the hallowed corridors of Halcyon Hall, however, as a strange idol begins to make its presence felt. The Professor of Astronomy at Halcyon, Armitage Henry, has recently returned from a South American expedition himself. Unfortunately, the bizarre statue he brought back has awakened and its cosmic tendrils soon begin menacing the college and its members. Can the Heroes deal with the weird occurrences and locate the idol in time, or will the entity it is attempting to summon break through and wreak havoc?

Halcyon Hall begins to pull itself back together in the aftermath of 'the idol incident', although there is seemingly no rest for our intrepid crew. Officers from Army Intelligence arrive and request their help in a matter of international security. The Nazis are close to locating the Cutty-Sark, the famous shift worn by the young witch described in Robert Burns's poem, Tam o' Shanter. Even if the chemise doesn't hold any of the occult powers connected to it, the Nazis believe it to possess some kind of sorcery. Their claiming of it would be a major political coup over the U.K.'s sovereignty. The Führer would literally be able to wipe the Prime Minister's nose with it. In a joint effort to avoid direct confrontation, the U.S. and U.K. have agreed to use independent agents to thwart the Nazi's efforts. The race is on to retrieve an item of significant national import. Does the Cutty-Sark possess any of its storied powers, however, and just how might the Nazis try to harness those abilities? Can the Heroes save the U.K. from having its face scrubbed by an ancient, mildewed undergarment?



Creating Your Own Artefact Hunters

If you would like to get playing without delay, you can use the free pdf containing character sheets for Montana and her crew. If you do decide to create your own characters, any one of the Roles from the *ACE!* core rules will work for this adventure. You can also use the new Roles presented here. Just be prepared to hear 'Fwah, fwah' a lot if someone rolls with the socialite.

New Occupations

Botanist. You love plants. Prickly, poisonous, or perfumed, you appreciate them all and often talk to as if they're old friends. You can identify any plant without a roll and often talk to them, including substances made from plants. We're looking at you, poisons. Also, plant creatures won't attack you. Everyone else is fair game, though.

Double-Agent. You're a bit like a spy, only you enjoy dressing up in the uniform of the bad guys and gals. If you put on an enemy uniform to fool your foes, your disguise always works.

Socialite. You are one of the social elite. Or perhaps your fame or notoriety means you get invited to all the top parties. Either way, your name is *always* on the guest list.

Witch. You made a deal with the devil. It cost you your soul, but hey, at least you gained some supernatural gifts. You have a Power stat. You can also use your Evil Eye to steal Karma from others. Make an opposed roll against a target's Smarts. If it succeeds, the target loses 1 Karma point and you gain 1. You still gain 1 Karma from Mooks and Extras even if they don't have any to lose. You can't use your Evil Eye on other Heroes, and you can only use it on each Mook or Extra once.

Gear & Technology

In 1936, despite being the size of a dressing table and almost as rare as hen's teeth, television is just beginning to become practical, telephones are the old dial type but the cost of a call means it's still cheaper to send a telegram, and the first jet engine has yet to be built and tested. Also, if you'd like to learn something, you can't just jump on the internet and look it up as there aren't any computers. At all. Instead, you'll need to find it the old-fashioned way: research and fact finding. Yeah, we know that last thing is a distant concept in our own modern age.

Cost

Things were a lot cheaper to buy in 1936, but then the average wage was also a *lot* lower. The table on the next page uses the costs presented in the table on p. 16 of the *ACE!* core rules as a reference — we like to opt to keep things simple by matching them up. If you'd like to use prices that are more reflective of the 1930s, divide the Amount column by 10.

New Cast, Same Story

The adventure as written assumes that you are using the pregenerated Heroes, Montana Drones, Lou Doble, Jonah Henry Jr, and Johnnie Cobbler. These are available as a free download from awfullycheerfulengine.com. If you aren't, there are a few steps you need to take for things to make sense in relation to the Heroes. Just make sure you change the title of the film also. That way it's their story and not Montana's. She might get a bit funny about it otherwise.

As the Heroes are based out of Halcyon Hall, New York, ask the players to pick a role amongst the college staff. One of them should probably take Montana's place as the Professor of History but this isn't entirely necessary, so long as one of the Heroes has a good reason to be a globetrotting treasure hunter. Oh, and ask the Heroes to choose one of them to be a new rival for Eric, too. He likes to have someone to focus his smugly superior attitude on.

A man wearing a brown hat, a light-colored short-sleeved shirt, and dark suspenders stands with his back to the viewer. He is in a large, ancient stone ruin with massive pillars and arches. A speech bubble above him contains the text "What skill should I use now?".

What skill
should I use
now?

Listed by difficulty to obtain, here's a breakdown of some of the gear and services available to your characters.

Amount	Difficulty	Example
Up to \$ 10	-	Send a telegram, buy a second-hand revolver or bullwhip
Up to \$ 1,000	10	Place a telephone call, buy a pistol or motorbike
Up to \$ 10,000	20	Buy a television set, purchase a ticket for international flight
Up to \$ 100,000	30	Buy a house or a luxury car
Up to \$ 1,000,000	40	Buy your own ship or airplane

Raiders of the Cutty-Sark

Have you grabbed your popcorn and soda? The main show is about to begin! Like most adventures, *Raiders* is broken down into a number of acts and scenes.

If you are planning on playing in this classic action story, stop reading now! You get to be the actor in the scenes and the Director will guide you through them. Unlike acting in pre-scripted movies, the dialogue in this one is ad-libbed, and the scenes are revealed as you go. Don't risk spoiling the plot beforehand.

Act One | Buried Secrets

The opening credits have rolled and the camera fades in on the opening to the Siq, the narrow, steep-sided ravine that leads into the ancient ruins of Petra. Easily spottable by their fedora and panama hats, the Heroes disappear into the gloom of the canyon.

Your pilot, Jack, has landed his plane as close to your goal as possible in the hot desert basin in this southern region of Jordan. The rocky, dust-blown bowl wouldn't have been your first choice for another relic hunt, but Jonah seems to think he has found something in the College's records. A clue that points to an ancient Greek artefact being hidden here in the days when the Roman Empire spread its wings this far. Local legends and lore offer all sorts of tall tales regarding the ancient ruins but you have grown excited about one in particular. Fragments of ancient texts that have been translated multiple times refer to offering the spirits of the tomb a donation and prayer on the first moon of Parthenos. Those who do will be admitted. You are so certain of this leading to a new discovery, you've made sure that you've brought a gift to placate the 'ghosts' of the Soldier Tomb.

If you haven't played an ACE! game before, you can use this opportunity to get used to the system. You can have a Hero try a roll to determine exactly where the Soldier Tomb is located within Petra's twisting gullies. Have someone roll a Smarts check. If it beats a Target Number of 10, they know which way is up on the map and manage to lead the team to the right location. If they don't succeed, maybe they upset a scorpion or rattle a snake that then needs to be calmed down or avoided. Or it could just take them longer to find. That's the beauty, it's up to you!

First Moon of Parthenos → First moon of Virgo. In 1936, that's September 1st!

Following translations back, something about the word 'admits' seems off. Could it mean Admetes of Troy?

The Heroes arrive at the Soldier Tomb with survey and digging equipment to hand, plus the all-important gift to placate the rumoured spirits within. We've left the choice of gift up to the team. It could be a golden fertility idol, a single malt Scotch whisky from the Victorian era (although Johnnie will probably have something to say about that if he's in play), or maybe even something personal to one of the heroes. Whatever they decide upon should be relevant but irreverent.

The cool interior of the tomb offers welcome relief from the sun and heat. You brought plenty of torches, so the sparse interior of the main room and smaller antechamber are well lit. Your notes mention leaving the offering on the pedestal in the side chamber, then praying on the bench in the main chamber when 'the voices begin to wail'. At least, you think that's what the translation means!

TAKING LIBERTIES

Much like the 1981 film itself, we've taken a few liberties concerning the locations that are used and the secrets that are hidden there. For instance, while we know Montana was a successful treasure hunter and did indeed visit Petra, there is no record anywhere of hidden tunnels or chambers below the Soldier Tomb. It would be a pretty short adventure (and movie) if there weren't secret doors and concealed relics, however, so we've loosely followed the embellishment of the film and added in some bits or changed others that you probably shouldn't expect to relate to real life. Though it would be cool if there were some secret tunnels hidden below Petra waiting to be discovered. Not so cool on the otherworldly entity front, though...



You can introduce the Heroes to the system again here if you like, having them make a Smarts 10 roll to choose the right pedestal in the antechamber from the several smooth sandstone blocks that are in there. If they choose wrong, it'll just be a scramble to find the correct one and get back onto the bench when the wind starts to wail (see Ghostly Gifts, below). After that, they'll need to sit and wait for dusk.

Shrieking Ancients

Petra was once inhabited by the ancient Nabataean people, who were renowned for the ability to alter the flow of flash floods that sweep the region and store quantities of them for later use. Perhaps waters regularly swept the region on the first full moon of each September back in antiquity, with a small amount of water diverted into this tomb to provide a miracle. Or maybe ancestral ghosts really did breach the veil and offer portents to their descendants. Either way, the moaning of a rising wind funnelled through hollow tubes at exactly the moment the full moon rises is still enough to scare the pants off the team. Or give them chills, at the very least.

If the Heroes hop on the allocated bench as the wind begins to shriek through the chamber—it's the slightly wobbly stone block in the main chamber—they trigger an ancient mechanism. The machinery only works with some weight on the offering pedestal, the Heroes sat on the bench, and the wind blowing dust and debris loose from its working parts. At least, that's what we're saying. You can have it work any way you like. Just give the Heroes enough clues and time to make sure it does work. Or some dynamite to play with if it doesn't.

A loud sigh adds its timbre to the wind howling around the chambers, followed by a heavy scraping of stone against stone. A small opening has revealed itself at the back of an alcove above one end of the bench. You can pull yourself into it with a standing jump, but it'll be a squeeze getting into the tunnel beyond.

Now for the fun slide through the spider-infested tube. Unless you're an arachnophobe, of course. You can have the Heroes make a Moves 10 roll to pull themselves up into the alcove if you want to test the system again but it isn't necessary. The wall that has slid aside reveals a yawning opening into an extremely smooth circular tunnel that angles and curves downwards. Living torpedo time! For the arachnaphobes of the group, the tube has become home to several large spiders. Luckily, they are harmless enough but their webs stick to everything.

Ghostly Gifts

The short slide along the spiral leaves you in a bit of a spin but otherwise unharmed. After plucking the spiders out of your hair and spitting out their cobwebs, you find yourselves in a roughly hewn tunnel that seems to curve gently upwards. Another, smaller tube is visible near the floor of this dead end, one too small to put more than your arm into.

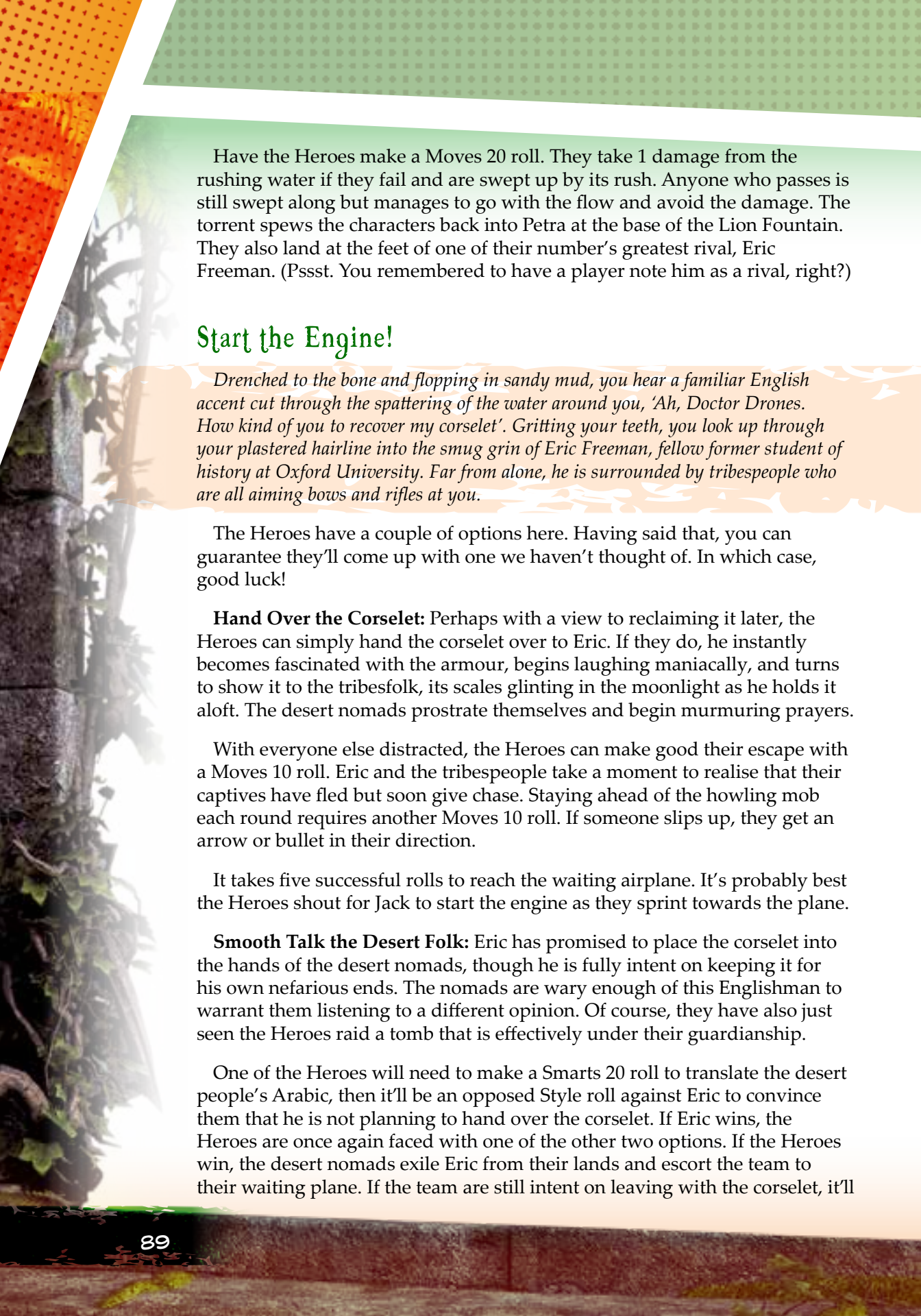
There isn't anything in the tube, but you can bet the next round of coffee that the Heroes will spend *ages* poking around in it. Up the slope it is. Trouble is, whoever built this place didn't just want any old average Joe finding what's hidden here. Pressure plates in the ground trigger spear traps on the ascent. The Heroes can make a single Smarts 20 roll to spot tell-tale signs of the mechanisms that operate the spears as they climb, followed by a single Moves 10 roll to disable them. If they don't spot the mechanisms but still beat 10 on the initial Smarts roll, the characters spot the holes for the spears and gain a +2 bonus to their Defence against them. The spears attack each character with Brawn 3 and inflict 2 damage. Slice and dice!

The slope soon opens into a small chamber lit by moonlight cleverly reflected into the room from aboveground. The moonbeams reflect from a fine suit of scale armour draped on the statue of a Greek god. A Smarts 20 roll identifies the statue as a representation of Mégês, hero of Homer's Iliad, and the armour as his fabled corselet. A legendary treasure indeed!

There is another exit from the chamber. Grabbing the armour from the statue sets off another mechanism that causes a stone slab to slowly start closing it off. And when we say slow, we mean the characters would have enough time to fall into a pit, grab a trailing vine to stop the fall, spend ages trying to pull themselves out and they'd still have enough time to slowly roll under the descending door into the corridor beyond. Yep, they all make it out.

The stone door slams shut behind you, raising a large cloud of dust. As it settles, water begins to trickle then pour from an opening above the door. It won't be long before the entire corridor is flooded!





Have the Heroes make a Moves 20 roll. They take 1 damage from the rushing water if they fail and are swept up by its rush. Anyone who passes is still swept along but manages to go with the flow and avoid the damage. The torrent spews the characters back into Petra at the base of the Lion Fountain. They also land at the feet of one of their number's greatest rival, Eric Freeman. (Pssst. You remembered to have a player note him as a rival, right?)

Start the Engine!

Drenched to the bone and flopping in sandy mud, you hear a familiar English accent cut through the spattering of the water around you, 'Ah, Doctor Drones. How kind of you to recover my corselet'. Gritting your teeth, you look up through your plastered hairline into the smug grin of Eric Freeman, fellow former student of history at Oxford University. Far from alone, he is surrounded by tribespeople who are all aiming bows and rifles at you.

The Heroes have a couple of options here. Having said that, you can guarantee they'll come up with one we haven't thought of. In which case, good luck!

Hand Over the Corselet: Perhaps with a view to reclaiming it later, the Heroes can simply hand the corselet over to Eric. If they do, he instantly becomes fascinated with the armour, begins laughing maniacally, and turns to show it to the tribesfolk, its scales glinting in the moonlight as he holds it aloft. The desert nomads prostrate themselves and begin murmuring prayers.

With everyone else distracted, the Heroes can make good their escape with a Moves 10 roll. Eric and the tribespeople take a moment to realise that their captives have fled but soon give chase. Staying ahead of the howling mob each round requires another Moves 10 roll. If someone slips up, they get an arrow or bullet in their direction.

It takes five successful rolls to reach the waiting airplane. It's probably best the Heroes shout for Jack to start the engine as they sprint towards the plane.

Smooth Talk the Desert Folk: Eric has promised to place the corselet into the hands of the desert nomads, though he is fully intent on keeping it for his own nefarious ends. The nomads are wary enough of this Englishman to warrant them listening to a different opinion. Of course, they have also just seen the Heroes raid a tomb that is effectively under their guardianship.

One of the Heroes will need to make a Smarts 20 roll to translate the desert people's Arabic, then it'll be an opposed Style roll against Eric to convince them that he is not planning to hand over the corselet. If Eric wins, the Heroes are once again faced with one of the other two options. If the Heroes win, the desert nomads exile Eric from their lands and escort the team to their waiting plane. If the team are still intent on leaving with the corselet, it'll

need a Style 40 roll to convince the desert folk that the armour is safer in the team's hands. Either way, at least the corselet has been stopped from falling into the wrong hands.

Fight! As they're surrounded by thirty or more desert nomads, this is the worst possible option for the team. Give them fair warning, but it's their funeral if they insist on attacking. With so many bodies surrounding them, every Hero will suffer 3 damage each round, with the desert folk continuing to attack until everyone is unconscious, even if one or more Heroes surrender.

Of course, it wouldn't be much of a story if that was the end of the movie. If you want, have everyone lose 3 Karma points, then let them wake up with the sun beating down on them and vultures circling above. Battered and bloody, the Heroes find that Jack is fortunately still waiting for them at the plane.

DESERT NOMAD

SMARTS 2 MOVES 2 (Shooting)
STYLE 2 BRAWN 2

Health 1 Defence 8

Brawling 2 (1 damage)

Rifle 4 (3 damage)

ERIC FREEMAN

SMARTS 6 (Occultism)

STYLE 6 (Persuasion)

MOVES 3

BRAWN 2 (Brawling)

Health 2 Defence 9

Brawling 4 (1 damage)

Fencing Sabre 4 (2 damage)

Eric gains +2 to his Defence when he's wearing the corselet of Mégès.

Eric can use the witch's Evil Eye power when he's wearing the Cutty-sark (see p. 20).

Eric's Power score is 3 when wearing the Cutty-sark.

Now for the long trip back to Halcyon Hall. It's likely the Heroes are a bit downbeat over losing out to Eric. Not to worry, at least they have some lecturing to look forward to!



Act Two |

Horror at Halcyon

Tracing their own red line across the map of the world, the Heroes make their way back to Halcyon Hall, Millbrook, New York. They'll need to face the music with the President of Bennett College, Felicia Bennett, for swanning off across the globe at short notice but it isn't long before everyone is settled back into their roles.

The stately halls of Bennett College are a world apart from the dust and heat of ancient Petra but you appreciate the slower pace

and the chance to pause and reflect. The lawns are freshly mown, overdue books have been chased up and booked back in, new clay has been ordered for the art studio, and students are once again falling asleep in history lectures. As the days drift back into a listless blur of lessons, library tickets and lawn maintenance, you all look forward to your weekly sessions of Oubliettes & Occultists with the rest of the team. Which is even more the case this week, as everyone seems to be complaining of nightmares and Professor Henry cancelled his lectures for the day, forcing the rest of the faculty to pick up the slack. Time to roll some dice to discover who or what is behind the terrifying "Beast of Bodmin Moor".

Oubliettes & Occultists

It's late at night, the college is finally tranquil after the day's activities and lectures, and the Heroes are indulging in a game of *Oubliettes & Occultists* in a side room of the library. One of the Heroes—let them choose—enjoys cobbling together adventures from old British folklore then throwing the rest of the team in at the deep end. Tonight, hot on the heels of contending with "the Hairy Hands of Dartmoor", the group are tackling the legendary "Beast of Bodmin Moor". Matters are just getting interesting as the players have just found clues that lead them to believe they might be on the trail of a shapeshifter. At the height of the investigation, strange sounds begin to intrude from the main library in the "real world". Have the Heroes make

a Smarts 20 roll. Those who pass hear a distorted croak and the sound of furniture scraping on the library's wooden floor. If nobody passes, carry on describing the game their Heroes are playing then have everyone make a Smarts 10 roll at a suitable interval. This time, the Heroes hear a crash and a loud croak outside the door of their room.

Opening the door reveals a heart-breaking scene. Well, if you're the librarian, at least. Bookcases have been toppled throughout the library, sending books sprawling everywhere. A frog the size of a rhinoceros sits looking quizzically at the Heroes, its vocal sac expanding and contracting rhythmically. That's when its ginormous tongue flicks out to grapple one of the Heroes.

GIANT FROG

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 2 (Jumping)
STYLE 1 **BRAWN** 5 (Brawling)

Health 5 **Defence** 8
Sticky Tongue 7 (0 damage, 15-foot range, restrains target and pulls them to the frog, needs Brawn 10 check to escape)

Bite 7 (2 damage, only on targets caught by its sticky tongue)

Game Within a Game

If you feel like having a bit of extra fun and your players agree to it, have them create new characters using the super simple *ACE!* character creation system and then play *those* characters as if they were in their main Heroes' shoes. You could even have an extra little bit of fun and have one of the players run the new scenario as the Director. This will need a little work to build a short adventure for *Oubliettes & Occultists* but you can use the game within a game to build up some light tension. Then, wham! The super frog attacks!

Unfortunately, other than the dice from their game, the Heroes are currently unarmed. If Jonah Henry Jr is being used, however, or one of the players chose to take on the role of the librarian, their gear is currently locked in a safe on the other side of the frog. There are also some ancient spears and swords in glass display cases that the Heroes can break free and make us of, though doing so will probably elicit a few snarky comments from the library's caretaker.

Vineacles and Verdigris

With the frog menace dealt with, it soon becomes clear that all is not well throughout the whole of Bennett College. Shattering glass can be heard echoing across the grounds, forming a discordant symphony alongside with the screams of the students coming from within Halcyon Hall. Working their way through vines that have become tentacles coming from within Halcyon Hall.

Charging from the library onto the College's well-maintained grounds reveals a scene from your darkest nightmares. The entire façade of Halcyon Hall is being gripped in thick vines that seem to be squeezing the stonework and slithering through windows. At least, they appear to be vines but they also seem to be pulsating and gyrating like the tentacles of some giant amorphous beast. Screams can be heard from almost every window and you're pretty sure that one or two of the "vinetacles" appear to be holding students aloft triumphantly. Halcyon Hall is in the death-like grip of some truly exotic shrubbery and its pupils and faculty are in desperate need of help. Just what has Johnnie been feeding the plants?

You can have the Heroes roll a Smarts 20 check at this point, with success providing the clue that the thickest of the vinetacles seem to be clustered around the windows of the Natural Sciences wing of the College.

The first task the Heroes might consider is rescuing the hapless students that have been snatched by the grasping vinetacles. Each of the two vinetacles that has a pupil in its grip will also have another on hand to defend itself, meaning the Heroes will need to contend with the first of the pair of appendages before freeing the student from the grip of the second—unless the group split to tackle both at once. Once a tentacle is reduced to zero Health, it gently slithers to the ground and releases its hold. Curiously, the vinetacles don't appear to squeeze any further once they have a victim in their grip. They simply lift their target from the ground and hold them aloft in a gently swaying motion. Almost as if they are waiting for something...

With the students in immediate danger freed, the Heroes will hopefully want to rescue as many folks as they can from within the college. After the initial attack, the screams from within Halcyon Hall have grown eerily silent. The noise of stonework cracking and the creaking of vinetacles as they squeeze the building ever harder adds to the menacing atmosphere. Entering the dark hallways provides an eerie picture of students and professors lashed to walls, furniture and columns by multiple vinetacles, cocooned tightly so that only their feet can be seen. A weird verdigris snakes along the walls, providing a trail back into the college along the path of the grasping vinetacles. A Smarts (10) roll indicates that the green trail and vines lead towards the Natural Sciences wing.

VINETACLES

SMARTS 1	MOVES 2 (Dodging)
STYLE 1	BRAWN 4 (Brawling)

Health 4	Defence 8
Lash 6 (2 damage, 20-foot range, needs Brawn 20 check to escape)	

The Heroes might want to attempt to free each pupil and faculty member in turn. Using fire axes taken from around the college reduces the Defence of each vinetacle by 2. After the fourth or fifth such rescue, however, the entire building begins to shake in a slowly pulsating rhythm. It's pretty clear that the Natural Sciences wing is the source of the tremors. Have the Heroes picked up the fact that they need to head to Natural Sciences? Maybe they should investigate Natural Sciences...

It's All in the Arm(itage)

The Professor of Astronomy at Bennett College, Armitage Henry, has himself just recently returned from an expedition that took him deep into the Amazon jungle. His search for an ancient temple linked with astrological predictions and wonders was a complete success. Unfortunately, the cyclopean shrine he found was best left undisturbed. And he should definitely have left the effigy he brought back to Halcyon Hall in its resting place.

Making their way to Natural Sciences will require the Heroes to undertake quite a bit of jungle clearance to carve a path, especially as the pulsating appendages grow thicker the closer they get. You can have them make the occasional Moves 10 roll to avoid becoming entangled or swiped at by a vinetacle, but the limbs seem to be growing more lethargic. Almost as if they're growing sated.

The main lecture room is carpeted in vinetacles, all of which are emanating from a cocoon-like pod in the centre of the room. Professor Henry is pinned to his chair by vines, his unseeing gaze transfixed on a bizarre bronze effigy crouched on top of his desk. Two trails of verdigris stretch from the statue towards his hands, which are currently splayed on the desk. There's also a large, pulsating vinetacle trailing from the pod to the effigy, with small fronds attached to the statue's back.

Pulling Armitage from the desk won't affect whatever is transpiring. It's too far along for that. He can be dragged away but his vacant gaze remains fixed towards the statue no matter where he's taken. Attacking the large vinetacle that stretches





KUFOOLOO

SMARTS 3 **MOVES 4** (Acrobatics)
STYLE 3 **BRAWN 6** (Tough)

Health 8 **Defence 12**
Claw 6 (2 damage)

from the pod to the effigy or the pod itself will eventually cause the cocoon to explode in a shower or slimy gloop and plant-like matter. The half-formed creature inside, which we'll call kufooloo, then flops out to attack. Eight stunted tentacles propel a stocky torso with half-formed wings jutting from its back. It's broad rubbery head also seems to have tentacles growing from its jawline.

Award the Heroes a Karma point once the creature is defeated. Kicking

Kufooloo's butt is a pretty mean feat! The vinetacles throughout the school start turning into mush as soon as the creature dies. Army trucks also roll in not long after, plus a team of four experts in suits. Two of the four carefully recover the effigy using extremely long tongs, thick leather gloves and oversized goggles, while the other two take the Heroes aside. They appear to barely bat an eyelid at the mess the school is in, but they do need the Heroe's help with something else. Seems like unmasking the "Beast of Bodmin Moor" will need to wait!

Act Three | A Breath of Fresh Ayr

It's now late fall 1936 and Hitler is trying his utmost to woo the British into forming a coalition. Unfortunately for him, Adolf's ambassador to the U.K. is unwittingly doing his best to annoy the establishment, so things aren't looking too rosy. The ambassador's social gaffes are diverting attention from more clandestine affairs, however.

The U.S. Embassy in London have caught wind of something afoot, codenamed Operation: Scymitar. One Eric Freeman has also been seen meeting with Nazi agents, leading the operatives to believe that they're planning to steal something of historic national importance. British Intelligence are barely able tie their own shoestrings, so they've agreed to let the U.S. investigate independently. Knowing that the Heroes have connections in the U.K. (they do... of course they do!) and an understanding of how Freeman operates, U.S. Army Intelligence have 'requested' that they investigate. Luckily, it seems like the college will be closed for a short while!

Lords and Ladies

The gentle drone of the Hindenburg zeppelin traced a lazy red line from New York to Berlin. Unfortunately, there is no time for sight-seeing or signature collecting on this trip. After a short hop to Paris by rail, you then caught a flight to London. After that, it took a few hours for your ears to stop ringing enough for you to be able to hear the intelligence operative trying to brief you, one Agent Hudson. The German Ambassador is hosting a party for the entitled at the embassy in London. Although they can't get you on the official guest list themselves, they know someone in your group has the social connections to make your arrival seem natural.





Despite being labelled a party, it's a bit of a sombre affair, with nobles and officers gathered around in small groups that whisper to each other in hushed tones. In fact, the Heroes would probably have more fun at their own funeral. They will likely need to cause a distraction or identify a German agent and attempt to glean some information. If there is a Socialite amongst the Heroes, some of the aristocrats here will have heard of their work and know of their connections. A Style (20) roll will allow them to cause enough of a stir to switch most of the attendees' focus in her direction for a while. After that, it's a Moves 20 roll for anyone attempting to sneak away in

search of clues on Operation: Scymitar.

Identifying and charming an enemy agent is a little harder, needing a Smarts 20 roll to determine who to approach and a Herculean 30 roll to get them talking enough to let some details of the plan to slip. The Nazi agent could be anyone ranging from a wine servant to high-ranking military officer, it's completely up to you. Just keep it light-hearted and try to have some fun with it. You might also want to reduce the difficulty on the persuasion roll if the players roleplay the scene particularly well.

Notes on Operation: Scymitar can be found upstairs in a locked room. If the Heroes don't think about stealing some keys, it's a Moves 20 roll to break in. The notes reveal that an undercover expedition will be leaving for the Scottish town of Ayr in the morning, where they plan to recover an ancient shawl that they believe to be a source of occult power. Namely, the Cutty-Sark described in the Tam o'Shanter poem. The notes also say that Eric Freeman has been appointed as an advisor to the trip. Who would have guessed it?

It should be fairly easy for the Heroes to slip away once they have the information but not before there is a suitably tense moment as Eric spots them. He'll suspect they're up to something but won't be able to prove anything. Cue intense stares across the ballroom floor and some witty yet threatening banter.

But what if the Heroes are discovered, we hear you cry! There should be plenty of opportunity for the Heroes to use Karma on retconning their previous hours through flashbacks. Maybe they visited an English noble beforehand and gained their agreement in providing a convincing cover story in case of discovery. Or perhaps they studied the blueprints and found a secret escape route. You might also want them captured, just make sure to provide an opportunity for them to escape if they are. In the latter case, it's likely they'll be chasing the Nazis instead of dashing ahead of them in the next scene.

What's the Rub?

Eric Freeman is the real driving force behind the search for the Cutty-sark. He has uncovered a coven in the vicinity of Ayr and believes they possess the relic. He can't very well go knocking on their door to ask for it, so he's brought in the big boys to help. Why does he want it? He's taken to wearing the corselet of Mègès at every opportunity. Trouble is, it chafes him like crazy and nothing seems to be able to prevent this. When he caught wind of the coven and their connection to the Cutty-sark, he knew he'd found the perfect garment to supplement the armour. So he convinced the Nazis to help him recover it.

Witches and Nazis and Relics, Oh My!

A quick dash back to the U.S. Embassy led to several frenzied phone calls between Army Intelligence and the Home Office. Finally admitting they had no clue about how to handle the situation, the stuffy chaps at Thames House have agreed to sanction your team in thwarting the Operation: Scymitar plot. Which is why you now find yourself on The Royal Scot, thundering through the British countryside towards Gretna.

Of course, you might need to adjust the above paragraph a little if the Heroes have been captured. It should be a tense train ride with a heavy sense of foreboding. Their enemies won't brazenly attack on the train (unless you want them to) but you can certainly increase the tension a little by describing shadowy figures stopping at the compartment blinds occasionally, or having the enemy agents appear for their own lunch in the dining car while the Heroes are sat eating. Talk about spoiling your lunch!

Murder on the Scottish Express

If you want to have a little extra fun, you could always drop a murder mystery scenario into the train ride. A blood-curdling scream can be heard throughout the train shortly after The Royal Scot enters a long dark tunnel. It's soon revealed that a high-ranking noble or senior politician has met their end. Thankfully, the famous Inspector Sparrow and his moustache just happen to be on board. He initially suspects one of the Heroes – you can retcon a motive or have the murder happen at a moment that could certainly implicate one of the Heroes – but soon ropes them in to help with the investigation. Who carried out the murder and why? We'll leave that up to you. But it may just give the Heroes an early opportunity to fence with their Nazi foes. Not literally... well, maybe. That's also up to you!

The Heroes have a car waiting at Gretna station. The secret service driver chauffeurs them for the last few hours of the journey to Ayr. The address they gleaned from the stolen information leads to a crumbling cottage just outside of Ayr, deep in a copse of trees near some place called Mount Oliphant. Have the players make a Moves 30 roll during the drive. If they pass, they arrive before the Nazis. Failure means they arrive after.

Now this is where things can go wrong. Really, really wrong. The two witches that live in the cottage, Blair and Coira, divined that some people would come looking for the Cutty-Sark. They certainly don't want to give it up, so they called in a 'friend' to help.

If the Heroes arrive first, they can try and convince the old crones to hand over the Cutty-Sark for safekeeping. This will need a *very* convincing speech and a Style 30 roll. If it succeeds, the witches also offer their help in dealing with the Nazi agents. If they don't succeed, they'll need to tackle the witches and their hell hound. Which is right about when the enemy agents arrive.

If the Nazis arrive first, they will have zero success in convincing the witches to hand over the shawl. In this case, the players walk into a pitched battle between the agents, the hell hound and the crones. The last remaining witch is using her evil eye to hex the Nazi agents, while the hell hound is ravaging any it can get its jowls on. Even the trees seem to be lending a hand. There are four remaining enemy agents on the outside of the cottage plus Eric, who has managed to sneak in around the back. This guy's slipperier than an eel!

The Heroes can wade right on in, but this only diverts everyone's attention to them. It'll take 3 rounds of combat before Coira realises she might have some allies in the battle, at which point she yells at the hell hound to attack the agents and tries hexing them again. Then she gets knocked out from behind by Eric, who strolls from the cottage wearing the Cutty-Sark beneath his shiny metal corselet. If this happens, he can now use the Evil Eye power that the witches were able to employ. Time to punch some Nazis!

If the hell hound has been called off from attacking the Heroes, it again begins to savage the enemy agents. Once they are all dealt with, it slinks away into the darkness never to be seen again. Well, unless you'd like to run another scenario for the Heroes, this one called the "Beast of Ayrshire".

Assuming the Heroes deal with the Nazis, it's time to head back to London for tea and medals. Or coffee. Whichever. The secret service driver takes care of the mess at the cottage, while the corselet and Cutty-Sark are crated up and sent to a secure vault in the British Museum once safely handed over on their return. Part of Agent Hudson's agreement with the Brits. He's none too happy about it but there's little he can do.

It's a long slow journey back to Bennett College. This time, maybe you were able to pick up a signature or two on your travels this time. Miraculously, Halcyon Hall seems to have been fully restored by the time you return. Although Professor Henry is back at work, he seems to permanently have a faraway look in his eyes now. You soon settle back into your rhythms of lectures, overdue book letters, and lawn maintenance. Still, you have Oubliettes & Occultists to look forward to. Until your next adventure, at least.

NAZI AGENT

SMARTS 3 **MOVES** 4 (Shooting)
STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 3 (Brawling)

Health 3 **Defence** 12
Brawling 5 (1 damage)
Luger 6 (3 damage)

HELL HOUND

SMARTS 2 **MOVES** 3 (Shooting)
STYLE 1 **BRAWN** 5 (Brawling)

Health 7 **Defence** 9
Bite 7 (1 damage)
Fiery Breath 5 (2 damage, 15' range)

WITCH

SMARTS 6 (Occultism) **MOVES** 2
STYLE 4 **BRAWN** 5

Health 2 **Defence** 8

Evil Eye 7 (Opposed roll against a target's Smarts.
 If it succeeds, the target loses 1 Karma point, and the witch gains it. The witch can then use this to fuel other magical effects, see "Using Magic", p. 22 of ACE!)



ACE!

Issue 4

STRANGE SCIENCE

DAVE CHAPMAN



WELCOME TO WILDEN FALLS

Greetings! And welcome to Wilden Falls, your average American town in the heart of the country. Surrounded by trees, nature, and there's a wonderful waterfall that brings the tourists. It's a quaint little town, whose population of around eight thousand likes things quiet, and without any trouble.

The town itself has a couple of schools (a middle and a high school), a decent selection of shops - though the Mall that sprang up in the new estate quickly failed. The main industry used to be lumber, though just recently we've had a host of new people move into the town to work at the nearby Osterman Labs Research Facility that had been pretty idle since the 60s. It's out on Route 767, but you're best to keep away from that place. I went past there on the way to Aunt Sylvia's barbecue last summer and I felt sick

to my stomach. I don't think it was the grilled chicken, let's put it that way. There's also that power station quite close to it. It's a bit of an eye-sore if you ask me, but that brings in the workers too and what's good for the economy is good for Wilden Falls.

If you're looking for somewhere to stay there's the Lookout Hotel, right next to the waterfall. Now that's a lovely place with a great view.

The rest of the town is as you'd expect. Lots of families, lots of facilities, and all the latest modern conveniences that you'd expect in 1984.

IT'S STRANGE, IT'S SCIENCEY

It's the mid-80s. God, I loved the 80s. Things were so much simpler then - at least it felt like it because I was still at school and didn't have to worry about things like bills, mortgages, or imminent death and destruction. No, the 80s is a time for nostalgia - when we bunked off school to look at a body, rode bikes to escape the government, and hung around with crazy old men who should have a restraining order on them. Ah, yes... those were the days. And those days are the setting for *Strange Science* - a setting and adventure for use with the super-fast and super-fun ACE! system (the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!*)

In *Strange Science* you get to play teenagers attending a school in small-town America. It's all pretty innocent, until weird things start happening at the local research facility, people go missing, and there's a sudden influx of fitness nuts in the town. That's before we get to the time travel, bodysnatching, and portals to other dimensions. Maybe 'strange' isn't strong enough a word for it!

Like other settings and adventures in the *ACE!* range, it's all designed to be fun. It can get a little tense and scary at times, but it's all safe, fun, and hopefully funny. We're talking *Weird Science*, *Real Genius*, *Back to the Future*, *My Science Project*, *Ghostbusters*, and just a hint of *Stranger Things* and *Twin Peaks*. It's all light, funny, and characters can't die. Buildings can collapse on them, or they can be transformed into giant man-eating zucchinis (not that it happens often, but it has happened once before and it wasn't pretty), and they'll be back to normal next scene, dusting themselves off and recovering with a TAB clear before going back into fray.

PLEASE ALLOW ME TO INTRODUCE MYSELF, THE BOOK

Strange Science is a complete setting and adventure for use with the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* (*ACE!*) tabletop roleplaying game. Without that, you may be a little lost, but the system is super simple and light, so if you wanted to adapt it for your own game of *Lovecraftian Horror*tm or *Orcs & Oubliettes*tm, feel free.

THE BOOK IS DIVIDED INTO THREE SECTIONS

First is the introductory bump that you're reading now - and hopefully enjoying. This just really gives you a feel for the rest of the book, and what to expect, and the sort of characters you'll be playing to get the most out of the setting and adventure.

After that comes the setting. This gives you a full rundown of all the places of interest in the quiet little town of Wilden Falls. There will be maps, tour guides, and some interesting gossip about the local residents - you know, the usual who's seeing who, who's secretly seeing who, and who's actually a manifested dream tulpa from a dark, otherworldly place. The usual stuff you'd expect.

Finally, we get to the adventure - *Strange Science*. A cheery little adventure of ancient dairy produce gone wrong. You'll get to investigate the strange things going on in the town, team up with radical excommunicated scientist and use his weird experiments to hopefully thwart the inter-dimensional menace that threatens the residents.

THE KIDS ARE ALRIGHT

At its heart, *Strange Science* is about a group of kids who sneak around, investigate the weird goings on in the town, and generally stick their noses where they don't belong. Just like most kids in these sorts of movies. They can be pre-teen, like *The Goonies* or *Stranger Things*, or teenagers like *Lost Boys* or *The Breakfast Club*. When generating characters you may want to focus on a group of just kids, though having any kind of regular character is possible. So if you want to play the whole thing with the weird townsfolk - and maybe a cool investigating FBI agent, or a quirky tree-hugging local.

It is, however, recommended that you don't go for any vampires, wizards, or talking dogs. But, the whole thing about *ACE!* is that as long as you have fun, it doesn't really matter. You go for it. Play whatever you like.

If you're playing kids as expected - regular, normal kids - you may want to drop the number of points spent on your Stats to 10. Just to reduce the number you'd normally put in Brawn or Smarts. After all, kids aren't usually as strong or smart as their grown counterparts. You can increase their starting Karma to 8 to reflect this, giving them a bit more of a fighting chance.

NEW ROLES

The following new roles are available to Heroes. Yea, basically it's *The Breakfast Club*. If you're old enough to remember that!

Brain. You're clever and you know stuff. Usually the stuff you know is really nerdy. Sometimes it's actually useful. You can spend a Karma point to ask the Director a single 'yes/no' question which they will answer honestly. Oh, and clever clogs -- the question should be about the game, not the Director's personal life!

Cheerleader. Everybody loves you (or at least pretends to). Plus you can do acrobatics and stuff. But mainly, you can cheer people on to be their best selves. You are able to grant your Karma points to your friends.

Outsider. You don't fit in. Always a loner, you have learned to be very observant and you always know when somebody is lying.

Protector. You're in security. All you care



about is helping others. If one of your fellow Heroes takes damage, you can choose to take it for them.

Radio Presenter. A face made for radio, eh? Your weapon of choice is your voice, and you know how to use it. You can make a Style check vs. Smarts to mesmerize somebody for one minute. If it doesn't work, though, they find you really annoying.

Tycoon. You're not just a businessperson, you're a *successful* businessperson! Well done, you! Choose \$1,000,000 worth of property and gear and stuff. It's yours. You earned it.

NEW TRAITS

Really, you don't need a list of traits from us. It's kinda audacious of us to try to sell you one. You can just make traits up. But here's a list of new traits just in case you don't want to.

Awkward	Childlike	Dedicated	Eccentric
Rebellious	Sassy	Shy	Sultry

YOU SHALL NOT PASS!

Stop now. Seriously, if you're a player in *Strange Science* it's probably best if you stop reading now. There's nothing for you here. It's all just nonsense, you're not missing anything, honest.

Have they gone?

Excellent. The rest of the book is really just for the Director. While there are handy maps of the town, we'll also detail the secrets of these locations for those nosey kids to stumble upon. Best if you keep all this to yourself until they actually find it during the game.



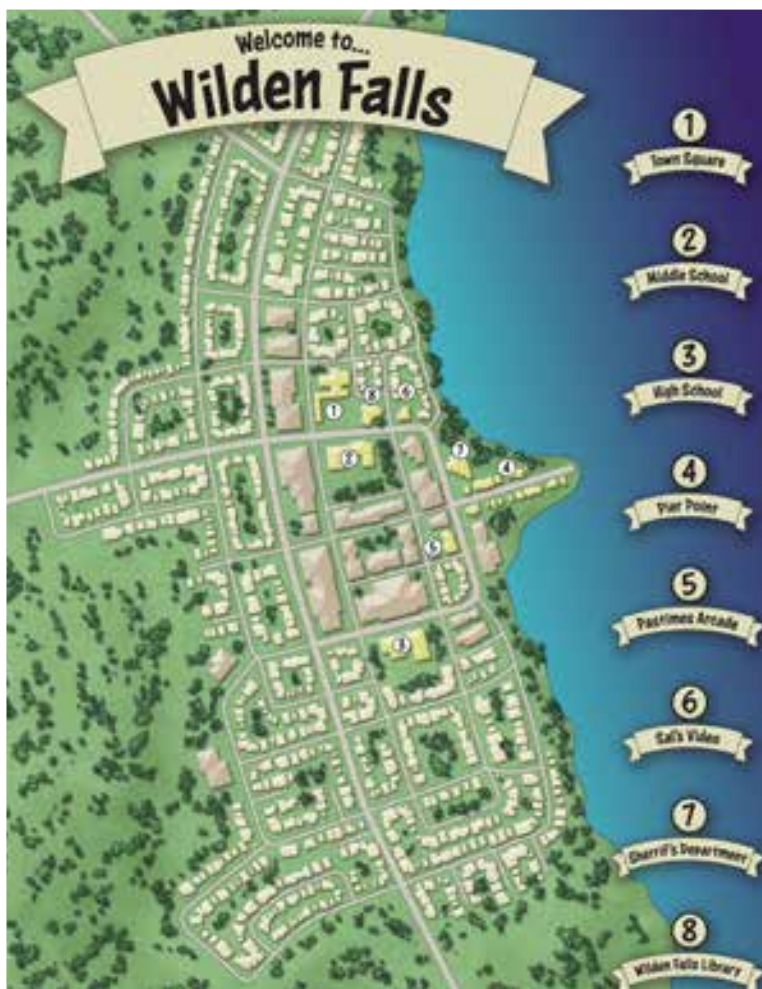
WILDEN FALLS

Now you have a group of meddling kids to run around and discover the weird stuff going on in the town, let's take a look at the town of Wilden Falls itself, and its surrounding area. While the default setting for Wilden Falls is in the Pacific North West of the United States - where so many great genre TV shows and movies are set - with a few tweaks you can set the town anywhere. You could even use your own home town as inspiration for your game, and add a few extra features. Maybe some of your own town's residents can inspire some of Wilden Falls' population - nothing like adding a little local color.

If you relocate the adventures to somewhere different, just make sure the key locations are covered in some way. The town is going to need that research lab and lake nearby!

CARTOGRAPHIA FANTASTICA!

Assuming you're going to run *Strange Science* in the town of Wilden Falls, you'll find in the pages of this book a pair of maps of the area. One of the surrounding area, outside of the main town showing the location of the falls themselves, the radio station, the Lookout Hotel, Wilden Falls Power, and the Osterman Research Laboratory, along with a few other cool locations that can open up a host of new adventures. The other map zooms in to the town itself, revealing the streets, houses and town center locations that will feature heavily during the game, and detail Wildenville, Wilden Falls' predecessor.



The major locations are listed below, along with some of the secrets you could uncover.

WILDEN FALLS MIDDLE SCHOOL

In the center of Wilden Falls is the relatively small Middle School where most of our Heroes could attend. That is, if they're actually kids and of the right age. Gonna be weird otherwise, unless they've been kept back for failing their exams due to constantly being absent and running off investigating weird and wacky goings on.

The Middle School has plenty of relatively modern facilities including a gym, meeting hall, a small swimming pool, canteen, and plenty of classrooms. Everything you'd expect. It's not huge, and has a capacity for about 500 students.

WILDEN FALLS HIGH SCHOOL

On the other side of the town is the High School, the option if your players have gone for older teenagers as characters. As always, better facilities and a capacity of nearly a thousand teens eager to learn and get the qualifications needed to better themselves and go off to college, and get away from this strange little town. Within the High School you'll find the latest high-tech computer labs (with those new cool computers with little green screens) and the latest science equipment. There's a larger gym, sports field, canteen, drama studio, and a lecture hall.

TOWN SQUARE

In the very center of the town is the Town Square, home to the Town Hall with its impressive clocktower, the disused cinema, a host of shops and small cafes. In the center of the square is a community area, with grassy bits for families to sit in the sun, and a fountain with a statue of a grizzly bear holding an axe. The Town Hall is home to the town government, the mayor's office, and a meeting hall for the regular town meetings where they discuss the vital and important issues the town faces - the plans for a new dam for a hydro-electric power station, the harvest festival, and the outrageous suggestion for that second ice-cream parlor on the main street.

THE MINES & MINING MUSEUM

Beyond the southern most part of the town, following 767 down towards the southern most point of the lake, you'll find the Wilden Falls Mines and Mining Museum. The old silver mines have long been disused and abandoned after a tragic cave in, but a small tourist center has sprung into life with exhibits displaying the old mining life in the town, a gift shop, and regular tours of the accessible parts of the mines (not going in too far - there are rumours of strange subterranean dwellers that lurk underground).

KWF RADIO AND THE RADIO TOWER

Sitting on the top of the glorious peak to the east of the Wilden Lake is the great eye-sore of the radio tower. Installed by the government in the 60s to increase the communication facilities for the military during the Cold War. In the early 70's, piggybacking off of the increased range of this tower, a local radio station launched (KWF) playing all the latest hits, and plenty of middle of the road tunes later during the day. In the evening, the station goes over to a great DJ, Cherry Kilbourne, playing late night tunes and bringing all the local news to the town with her dulcet tones.

CHERRY KILBOURNE, DJ

SULTRY RADIO PRESENTER

SMARTS 3 (Computers)	MOVES 3 (Driving)
STYLE 4 (Music)	BRAWN 2 (Climbing)

Health 2 Defence 9

Using her captivating voice, Cherry can make a Style check vs. Smarts to mesmerize somebody for one minute. If it doesn't work, though, they find her really annoying.

LOOKOUT HOTEL

Overlooking (see what we did there?) the legendary Wilden Falls itself is the Lookout Hotel. A stunning hotel with a quirky lumber theme. Home to an annual clown convention, the hotel is one of the big tourist attraction bringing people from miles around to take in the dramatic views of the stunning falls. Owned by business tycoon Ian Peterson, who is desperate to take over the other big money makers in the area such as the Power & Utility company and acquiring the land to the north of the hotel to make as much money as possible from the Power company's plans to build a hydro-electric power station and dam.

IAN PETERSON, Hotel Manager

GREEDY TYCOON

SMARTS 4 (Accounting)	MOVES 3 (Stealth)
STYLE 3 (Persuasion)	BRAWN 2 (Intimidating)

Health 2 Defence 9

Ian has any property or equipment he needs.

AMANDA LEE, Hotel Security

HONEST PROTECTOR

SMARTS 3 (Perception)	MOVES 4 (Shooting)
STYLE 2 (Animals)	BRAWN 3 (Brawling)

Health 3 Defence 12

If Ian Peterson takes damage, Amanda can choose to take it instead.

WILDEN FALLS POWER & UTILITY

The old Wilden Falls Power station is a relatively small facility dominated by a pair of cooling towers. It produces enough power to keep the town and the rest of the county in electricity. There have been talks with a major developer to upgrade the Power & Utility company, shutting down the fossil fuel side of the station and building a hydro-electric power station by damming the river upstream from the falls. The local council are mostly against this, fearing that the dam will impact the falls themselves and any tourism.

OSTERMAN LABS RESEARCH FACILITY

Hidden within the woods of Wilden National Park, behind a high security fence, is the Osterman Laboratories. Supposedly dedicated to bettering humanity with their research, little is known by the public about what they actually do there. Many of the researchers and scientists have residences in the new housing development (PineView Estate) to the north of Wilden Falls itself. They are quite insular, and are often regarded with a level of curiosity by the townsfolk.

PINEVIEW ESTATE

Built to accommodate the influx of new workers at the Osterman Labs in the 1970s, this housing estate to the north of Wilden Falls is almost an entire community of its own. The labs, however, didn't bring as many families as expected, and after building a small shopping mall and their own facilities, almost half of PineView Estate remains unoccupied. The houses are weird and empty, as is the shopping mall (closed in 1982 by the Wilden Falls town council, to keep the local businesses active), and wandering around now feels like exploring one of those fake towns built for atomic bomb testing.

The Mall has only two shops open, in between the shuttered shop fronts. A single convenience store, where most of the laboratory workers used to do their grocery shopping, and a new fitness foods shop that sprung up almost overnight.

THE LOGGING CAMP

To the south of Wilden Falls is the Logging Camp, run by Edith Patrick. She inherited the logging business from her husband, Charles, who vanished three years ago. He simply got up in the middle of the night and walked into the woods - and was never seen again. Edith has an eye on the land to the north of Wilden, hoping to increase productivity in these

STRANGE THINGS

AFOOT

Most of the regular scientists and researchers at the lab have vanished, along with their families, to be replaced by 'pod-people'. It started when they were investigating a weird growth that had manifested in the labs' basement, a plant from deep beneath the town and lake...



difficult times, but may have competition from Ian Peterson, owner of the Lookout Hotel.

WILDEN LAKE

Dominating the area is Wilden Lake, a massive freshwater body that is filled with more secrets than Vanessa Hardcastle's diary. To the east of the lake there's the old summer camp, Camp Whispering Pines, and in the center is Cygnit Island. However, beneath the surface, hidden from all, is the original settlement of Wildenville. Completely submerged, on rare occasions when the water levels have

dropped, the strange cross on the top of the old town spire is visible, just above the surface of the lake. It has only happened maybe once every hundred years, and the old town is lost to memory, but the myth of the strange cross has led the townsfolk to believe there is a sunken ship in the middle of the lake.

In reality, the old town was a place of weirdness and strange folk. Even stranger than we see today. To one end of the old sunken town lay the remains of a stone circle that surrounds a hole that seems to descend into the very depths of hell itself. Maybe the old town was drowned for a reason?

CAMP WHISPERING PINES

Summer camp. You remember summer camps? The canoeing on the lake. The songs around the campfire, roasting marshmallows? Those were the days. And Camp Whispering Pines was one of the most popular until a horrible incident five years ago. The townsfolk don't like to talk about it, but it was a miracle no kids were there when it happened. The camp counsellors were setting up for another summer, doing what counsellors always do at these places - drink too much, smoke too much, and have pre-marital sex. Outrageous. A horrible fate befell them all, one-by-one. Only Cindy Maddison survived, and she hasn't spoken since.

CYGNET ISLAND

In the middle of the lake is a picturesque island, home to many swans that give the island its name. But they are not alone. A single, small house has been built that has fallen into disrepair. There have been many stories of a strange and disfigured creature that lives in the house, but in actuality it is home to Dr. Erik Dunwood, former research director of the Osterman Laboratories. After a falling out with the powers-that-be at the labs, Erik quit and relocated to the middle of the lake where he could work on his experiments in peace without any interruptions from meddling townsfolk. He uses a small boat to go the the town once a week for supplies. He's been busy, building a rather extensive laboratory in the basement of the house, extending tunnels that delve further underground.

PIER POINT

Where the town of Wilden Falls meets the glistening and foreboding waters of Wilden Lake, there's a picturesque waterfront with a range of shops and facilities, most of it aimed at the tourists who come for a relaxing break from the busy city. There's a jutting piece of land that has made a natural jetty out into the lake that has been built upon to act as a pier, harbouring a handful of boats.

PASTIMES

AMUSEMENT

ARCADE

One of the most popular features on that waterfront is Pastimes Amusement Arcade, owned by Douglas and Valorie Williams. The arcade features all the latest games (well, latest to Wilden Falls) including *Spy Car*, *Demogorgon's Lair*, and popular vector graphics game *Space Wars*. The Williams' sassy daughter, Stephanie, can usually be found in the change booth.

DR ERIK DUNWOOD

ECCENTRIC SCIENTIST

SMARTS 5 (Physics, Electronics, Quantum Theory)

STYLE 1 (Science)

Health 2 **Defence** 12

MOVES 4 (Spot Welding)
BRAWN 2 (Carrying)

If a monster has a weakness, Dr Dunwood knows it automatically. It's just a question of physics.

SAL'S VIDEO

While Wilden Falls' film fans have to travel to the nearby city to go to the cinema, Sal's Video has cashed in on the lack of a proper town cinema, bringing all of the latest movie releases on VHS for rental. Sal has one of the best video libraries in the state, and can order films in if he doesn't currently have them in stock. Just don't ask for something that's only just out in the cinema, like *Spirits of Manhattan*. Especially not *Raiders of the Cutty Sark*!

WILDEN FALLS SHERIFF'S DEPARTMENT

Not that there's a great deal of crime in Wilden Falls, it has a dedicated sheriff's department. Lead by Sheriff Harry Slater, his handful of deputies have little to do other than patrol during tourist season, and answering those calls from old Mrs. Ida Winters who claims the owls keep attacking her when she's putting out the laundry. They have two Chevy K5 Blazers and an old Ford Fairmont to drive around. Rose Hollis usually maintains the reception desk, fielding calls and sending the Sheriff where he's needed.

SHERIFF HARRY SLATER

DEDICATED COP

SMARTS 3 (Investigation)	MOVES 4 (Driving)
STYLE 2 (Persuasion)	BRAWN 3 (Brawling)
Health 3	Defence 12



LIBRARY

The town library isn't huge, just a couple of floors of books and town records, but it's the best place to look into the town's past - it's just finding your way through all those index cards and microfiche films. With a bit of effort you should find some dusty records of the old Wildenville town, and maybe the planning documents for the building of Wilden Falls itself. The town is full of secrets, and this is a great place to start your investigation. You just need to get on the right side of head librarian, Joyce Garner.



STRANGE SCIENCE

Something is strange in the neighbourhood, and you can't call the Ghostbreakers for this one. In this adventure you'll take on the role of those meddling kids you expect to find in *Scooby-Doo*, *Stranger Things*, *The Goonies*, or even *It*. There are weird things going on, but the adults don't believe you. It's up to you to investigate, nose about, and possibly save the town - if not the world - from a threat from beyond comprehension.

Strange Science is an epic adventure in three acts, and it starts at school. The Heroes discover a strange kid (Steve Twentyseven) who is actually a weird artificial kid sent by the even weirder scientists at Osterman Labs. They realize one of their favorite teachers, Mr Goodall, has gone missing - just walked off into the woods one day. And are offered some really suspicious health shakes that taste disgusting. A marketing idea from that new health food shop that's opened in the abandoned mall over in PineView Estate.

The shop, the kid, and the scientists at Osterman Labs, have all been taken over. It's a real Stepford situation where the scientists who worked there have gone missing and have been replaced over the spring break by these weird, perfect, creepazoids. They all have perfect hair, perfect teeth, wear the same clothes, and go out jogging first thing every morning. They all are called Steve. All of them. Men. Women. The dog. All called Steve. Steve something-weird, like Bumpersticker, Pumpkinpie, Cordlessphone, Sixpack, Cowbell... See what we mean? Weird.

As the Heroes investigate they discover the replaced scientists are a weird alien cult. Not from outer-space, but from an alternate dimension. A cult that existed back when Wildenville existed, worshipping their alien gods that would melt the brains of any normal person who looked upon them. A gate exists to let these gods into our world, deep under the lake, and the new scientists at Osterman Labs are working to reopen this gate and let their terrible gods through to destroy, dominate, and control.

A group of people realized this was happening to the old Wildenville population and set-to diverting the river, over the cliffs to create Wilden Falls themselves, and flooding the area where Wildenville resides. With the gateway hole submerged, and the village destroyed, the world was safe again. Who these mysterious people were, no one knows. Records have been lost or destroyed, to hide the existence of the original village from the new townsfolk of Wilden Falls that grew to replace it - on the shore of the new lake. Our Heroes will discover who they were when they team up with ostracized scientist, Dr. Erik Dunwood, and send their consciousnesses back in time to defeat the cult.

ACT ONE:

LET'S GET PHYSICAL

Wilden Falls is small enough that almost all of the kids in the town can walk to school, but a handful of pupils come in from some of the outlying communities by school bus. It's the start of summer term, April 24th 1984, and the kids are returning to school after spring break.

Directors can run this however they like - the first day back at school after a short break is a time of catching up, discussing any cool TV or movies you've seen, getting used to being back in school, and that all important gossip. Here are a few events for that fateful first day to hook those kids into the various strange mysteries that are rising in the town.

PARTY TIME! EXCELLENT!

The group all know each other from school, but how they know each other is up to you. They could just be in the same class, or socialize outside school - play *Orcs & Oubliettes* or something. It could be that they are the outsiders of the school who have banded together for support, or they're all neighbours in one of the streets who grew up together.

A NEW KID IN TOWN

First lesson, whatever you decide that could be - probably something really boring like History - there's a new kid who walks into the class. Arms full of books, beaming smile on his face. Plaid shirt, brown tie, beige pants. His perfect blonde hair neatly parted to one side. His perfect little freckles, and perfect teeth. It's all kinda sickening really.

"Ah, you must be the new student. Class, say hello to..."

"Steve," the new kid says.

"Class, say hello to Steven. Why don't you say hello to the class and tell us a little about yourself?"

"I'm Steve..."

He stands there in silence for a bit, smiling. The teacher looks a little confused and awkward as the silence continues. Eventually, Steve heads over to a vacant desk and sits down. Attentive, waiting to learn, like a sickeningly good kid.

STEVE TWENTYSEVEN

CHILDLIKE POD-PERSON

SMARTS 3 (Occultism)

MOVES 3 (Stealth)

STYLE 1 (Disguise)

BRAWN 2 (Tough)

Health 4 **Defence** 9

He's okay. Very quiet. Says his name - Steve Twentyseven. Yes, that's his name. All one word. He doesn't really answer questions, and always smiles. He's going to get bullied if he doesn't stop smiling. The Heroes can (hopefully) try to stop any bullying, but getting any information out of Steve is tricky. We said he's really quiet, didn't we? They could try to make friends, but basically Steve is just going to sit in class, absorb the information, go to the next class, soak it all in, sit by himself at lunch, go to the next class, and eventually get picked up at the end of school by his perfect looking parents.

In actuality, Steve Twentyseven isn't real. He's a podperson. A biological clone created by the scientists at Osterman Labs, who are biological clones themselves. If he does get injured at school, he'll bleed just like a human (except the blood is a strange, greenish goo). He doesn't talk much, but will gradually become more talkative as he learns from those around him. But Steve Twentyseven is here to learn, to observe, and start to infiltrate the town of Wilden Falls.

In order to infiltrate and control the town, the population will need to be docile, compliant, and sleepy. That's where health food comes in...

I'LL BE YOUR SUBSTITUTE

The second strange change at school on that first day comes with science class. The pupils arrive, the bell goes, and there's no sign of the teacher. Mr. Goodall has failed to show. After a few minutes, a stranger walks in carrying a folder full of notes.

'Good morning, class. I'm Miss Wilson, I'll be taking over Mr. Goodall's science class today.' She puts the notes on the table, and writes her name on the board.

Miss Wilson will answer questions, but she doesn't know what happened. She only knows that Mr. Goodall has vanished, and he's been missing for about a week.

The Heroes can investigate, ask around, but news articles only say that he supposedly walked into the woods over on the east side of the lake and hasn't been seen since. The sheriff's department has mounted a number of searches in the woods, but they've been called off. Sheriff Slater said that Mr. Goodall has probably just left town. He was last seen seven days ago, walking in the early evening towards the east side of the lake near the old, empty summer camp.

In actuality, Mr. Goodall did wander off into the woods - a bit like Charles Patrick, but this is unrelated and a bit of a red herring. Charles Patrick did wander off into the woods, but in his case it was following the mysterious squirrels, who were communicating to him somehow. Mr. Goodall,

however, was approached during spring break by some of the scientists from Osterman Labs. He quickly dismissed them, but their weird behaviour sparked some paranoid interest by Mr. Goodall. He started digging into the goings on with the squeaky clean scientists and their creepy housing estate. He even uncovered the subliminal radio signal being broadcast unwittingly by KWF in the commercials for the health food shop that updates and commands the pod-people in the town, and controls any kids under the influence of the mind-weakening drugs in the health shakes (see below). Determined to put a stop to it, he walked off into the woods, and met with Dr. Erik Dunwood on his island retreat. Mr. Goodall was the first of Dunwood's willing experiments to put a stop to the alien invasion. Not wanting to reveal this, Dunwood kept quiet when the sheriff asked about Goodall's disappearance.

Don't worry, this will all become clear when our Heroes head over to the island in Act Two.

BREAK IT DOWN!

Break time comes, and a lime-green van pulls up outside the front of the school. Promoting itself like a twisted ice-cream van, the side opens, the doors at the back dispatches a couple of over-smiling girls dressed a similar green who jump about and look horribly energetic and enthusiastic. Their green running gear and matching headbands are covered in the logos of the super-nutritious fruit shakes they are giving away as part of the launch - Super Energy Fruit Fit Juice Shake!



Free! Come and get your Super Energy Fruit Fit Juice Shake! It makes you fit! Healthy! Smart! Cool! Attractive to others! Try it now! Your first shake is free!

The girls in the fitness gear look like twins, and the guy in the back of the van handing out the

shakes looks strangely familiar. Perfect teeth, freckles fading a little, perfect hair. He could be Steve Twentyseven's dad.

It's great! Only, it's not. It's a horrible green sludge. The worst of those protein shakes that you could possibly imagine. It's like someone has put peas and sprouts into a blender with a heavy dose of cayenne pepper and ox snot. Gross.

Loads of the kids run out to see what's going on and claim their free shake. Heck, who doesn't like free stuff? Of course, the excitement soon turns sour, and kids start spitting the vile juice out and dropping the cups onto the floor. The only kid who doesn't think it's disgusting is, you guessed it, Steve Twentyseven. In fact, if anyone's really checking, the green juice drink is the only thing Steve Twentyseven will consume all day at school.

Anyone (normal) drinking the shake finds it more than slightly disgusting - any ingested infects the kids with a mild mind-control drug that means they will start to hear the subliminal messages in the health club radio commercials. The more shake they consume, the stronger these messages become until they are unable to control their actions. Luckily, the shakes are so disgusting, maybe only one of two of the kids at the school actually drank any of it before throwing the rest away.

Disappointed by the results, the shake van quickly packs up and drives off, leaving a load of flyers on the floor advertising the health food shop - Nutrition - in the PineView Mall.

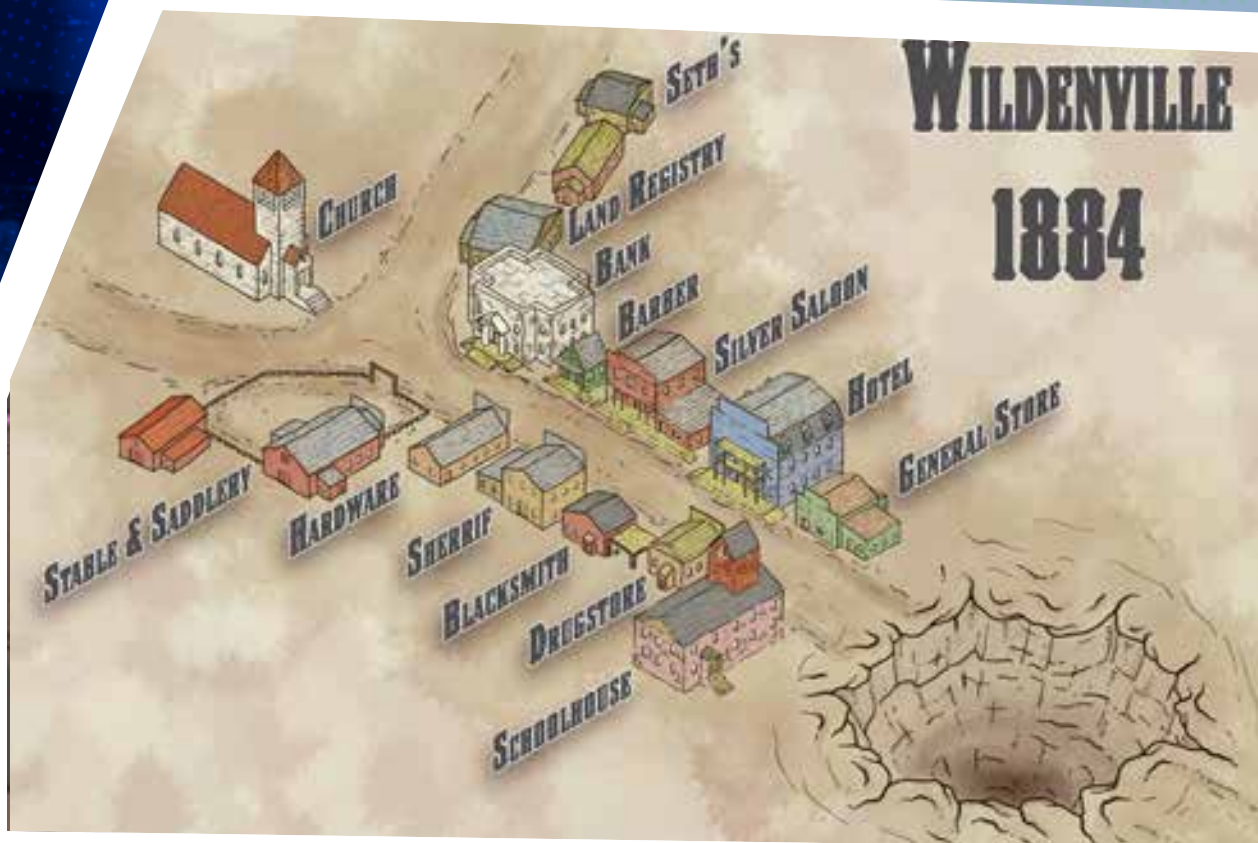
SCHOOL'S OUT!

The end of the day comes with the bell echoing around the classrooms and corridors, and everyone heads out and begins their journeys home. Waiting at the school gates are Steve Twentyseven's parents. At least, it's what you'd assume were Steve Twentyseven's parents.

At the gates you can see a young couple waiting for their child to emerge. The 'dad' looks a lot like the guy who was in the van giving away those awful juice drinks. At least, it looks like him. Probably not the same person though. 'Mom' looks like one of the fitness models, only she's wearing a dress straight out of Good Housemaking or something. They look young, healthy, horribly fit, and have perfect hair. They wave when they see the new kid, Steve. Typical that they're his parents.

TAKE IT EASY

Just because these events are defined for the first day of school, it doesn't mean you can't play out the rest of the day. Directors can feel free to add weird events, clues to other strangeness in the town that we've hinted at already in the guide to Wilden Falls. Or you could just have fun with playing the kids in class and at lunch break. Whatever your group seems to enjoy the most.



IGNORING THE EVIDENCE

If the kids don't go and have a look at the strange goings on at PineView Estate, the following day at school goes the same as before. School, class, break - only this time the van shows up again with a healthy, pink, yogurt-y drink. This one tastes much better (if you like yogurt - ew!) and the kids at school start falling under the influence of the subliminal signals in the radio commercials.

The Heroes can go over and talk to them if they like. They're not very talkative either, just the most stereotypical conversation like 'How was your first day, Steve?', 'Did you make any new friends, Steve?' and 'Time to go home for dinner, Steve.' If asked, or if someone calls them Mr. & Mrs. Twentyseven, they seem confused. 'Dad' is Steve Radioshow, and 'Mom' is Steve Bakingsoda. Yeah, something's not right there. It should be enough to inspire the kids (and their players) to check out Steve's house, look into the strange PineView Estate, and that health food shop in the mall.

ACT TWO:

VALLEY OF THE MALLS

With the seeds of a mystery planted, the kids head off to the PineView Estate to see what's going on with Steve, Steve, and Steve. And the other Steves. The estate is easy to get to, about thirty minutes walking, or ten on cool 80's BMX bikes.

A WOLF IN STEVE'S CLOTHING

PineView Estate was a new development built north of Wilden Falls to accommodate the expected influx of new workers at the Osterman Labs and the power plant, and it all just fell through. The estate houses the workers from the labs, but less than half of the homes are occupied, the rest of the place looking like a deserted set from a movie where all of the houses are the same.

Since the interdimensional invasion started, and the real scientists from Osterman Labs have been replaced by the pod-person clones, the houses have become as identical as their weird clone occupants. Every occupied house is the same, with the same car in the drive, the same color-scheme, the same pristinely mowed lawn. The mailboxes all have 'Steve' written on them.

Finding Steve Twentyseven's house is a little tricky, and can involve a lot of knocking on people's doors where our Heroes will be greeted by a Steve who looks a lot like Steve Twentyseven's clone-mom or clone-dad. They're not great at being helpful, pointing the kids to one house after another. After a couple of houses, they find Steve Twentyseven's home.

Of course, the kids could just sneak about and peer in through the windows until they find the right house. In most of the houses, the Steves in there are going through the actions of a stereotypical family like one of those ideal home films of the 50s. 'How was your day at work, dear?' 'Ooh, yummy, meatloaf for tea!' - not that they actually eat anything at the dinner table. They just consume the weird green juice they were trying to peddle to the school kids during the day.

As the kids look in, the family sits down to dinner.

The perfect family meal, only nothing is on the plates. The 'dad' says, "Time to get dinner! I'll be right back, honey." He gets up, puts on his jacket and heads out of the house. As you watch you realize all of the occupied houses are doing the same thing, and the 'dads' are all leaving at the same time, wearing the same jackets, and all heading off in the same direction.



The kids will probably follow, keeping a distance, as the various Steve-dads from around the estate all head to the mostly abandoned PineView Mall.

The mall was once a great mid-sized mall. Maybe twenty-or-so shops, a veritable hub of family activity. Now, it is barely lit. The shops are all boarded up, the remains of the

'Closing Down Sale' signs still plastered to the boards and doors. Within the mall, only two shops remain open. A small convenience store called Robertsons General Stores, which is mostly empty except for a very bored shop clerk. And the shiny, new fitness and healthfood shop advertised on the flyers left at the school - New-trition.

The Steve-dads almost line up as they march in unison into the mall. Keith, the shop clerk in Robertsons General Stores looks up from the magazine he's reading, watches them march by, then goes back to reading. The Steve-dads head straight to New-trition, form an orderly queue, and collect a selection of Tupperware style drinks containers each. Each container, about the size of a super-glug thirsty cup from a city cinema, looks to be filled with that disgusting green juice.

The Steve-dads collect their juice, and then head back to their respective homes, in a trance-like manner. Once they are gone, the guy at the juice and fitness shop - Steve Feelgood - sits on the chair behind the counter and just stares into space.

The Heroes can go in and look around, the shop is open. It's filled with fitness equipment, neon lycra outfits, plenty of headbands and leg-warmers, and a dispensing station to get your health juice. Steve Feelgood (no relation to Dr. Feelgood) will greet them as they come in, and mostly ignore the kids. Again, he is another one of those perfect pod-people. He doesn't usually have customers - just the Steve-dads that come in every meal-time. The kids can wander around and have a good nose, but they can't access behind the scenes.

If the kids hang around until 7pm, the shop closes, and Steve Feelgood heads home. A perfect opportunity for the kids to have a snoop about and try to get into the back office.

Behind the scenes in the shop is a storeroom with more stock, and a small office area. It doesn't look like there's much of interest here, but the desk has some notes and a handful of photos of people. One is Mr. Goodall, the science teacher who has gone missing. Written in red on the bottom of his photograph is 'Find Him'. The other is a staff photo of a man in a lab coat with the name Dr. Erik Dunwood written on the back of it. Under his name it has the words 'Find and Replace'. The characters' next port of call. Literally, as he lives on an island!

If the kids hang around in the mall too long, or they get stuck, the evening talk radio starts broadcasting. Any of the kids who have ingested any of the juice will hear odd sounds in their heads, and all of the Steves on the estate leave their homes in fitness gear. They start jogging around the estate and into the town of Wilden Falls itself, some even jogging into the woods. But there is something strange about the way they're running. Their eyes are constantly on the lookout - like those robots in that sci-fi series with the red eye that goes back and forth. Searching the area for something, or someone. Notably, Mr. Goodall, and Dr. Dunwood.

AIN'T NO CURE FOR THE SUMMER CAMP BLUES

Where do the kids go next? Their best lead is find Mr. Goodall or Dr. Dunwood. They could hang around at the mall, watch the

CAUGHT BY THE FUZZ

The kids have taken too long, broken into a shop, and they're not going anywhere you want them to. Well, you can always have them get caught! Maybe one of the Steves spots them leaving the Mall and decides to put a stop to their snooping. The kids can get caught, fight their way free even. If they fail to escape, they will be taken to Osterman Labs.

Inside the labs they will discover most of the lab has been converted to a processing plant - quite literally. A weird plant has taken over most of the lab and the Steves are harvesting small pods from it, crushing them into the juice they've been giving to the local kids, and consuming themselves. Larger pods grow to human size, where they eventually birth the weird Steves that have started populating PineView Estate.

The juice is packaged up and shipped by truck down to New-trition. The kids would need to break free, escape, and try to sneak into one of these trucks to get past the gate security guards.

TYPICAL STEVE

CHEERFUL CULTIST POD-PERSON

SMARTS 3 (Occultism)	MOVES 3 (Running)
STYLE 3 (Disguise)	BRAWN 3 (Tough)
Health 5	Defence 9



delivery from Osterman Labs to find out where the green juice is coming from - though after the failure of the first van at the school the green juice will be reprocessed in the future to a more appealing pink shake. However, there is little at the labs to help, except for witnessing the weird plant they are harvesting pods from, or where the pod-people are being grown. The source of this plant is deep within the ground, deeper than kids can dig. Deeper than an excavation crew with blasting dynamite can uncover.

Mr. Goodall is missing, and no one knows where he is - though he was last seen heading towards the old summer camp. The kids can skip school (after all, there's nothing great happening there except for the breaktime van of the new pink shake), or wait until the end of the day, and head over to Camp Whispering Pines. It's about twenty minutes on bikes or skateboards, or an hour's walk. On the way, they'll pass a couple of jogging 'Steves', searching the road towards the summer camp for the scientists who could be a threat to them. If you want to add a bit more action, you could have the kids need to hide from the Steve-joggers, or maybe incapacitate them so they're not a threat. You don't have to feel bad about killing Steve-joggers, they're just creepy plants. Not actual people.

The summer camp is mostly deserted, after that incident five years ago where all but one of the camp counsellors were horribly murdered. However, if the kids get there during the day, a couple of enthusiastic teenagers are cleaning the place up, applying paint and wood-seal to the cabins, ready to reopen this summer.

The teenagers are twins, Fiona and Phillip Bradshaw. For a change, they are not pod-people, just keen and perky camp counsellors-to-be hoping to get Camp Whispering Pines up and running again in the summer, and trying to get the long-dried bloodstains off of the walls.

If asked, they haven't seen Mr. Goodall, but they checked the inventory yesterday and one of the camp's boats has been stolen.

'Why would anyone steal a boat? The only thing in the lake is the island, and no one goes there. It's only got one house on it, and that's where that creepy scientist lives. What's his name? Dunston, Duncan, something like that.'

The kids can volunteer to go over to Cygnet Island to get their boat back, and Fiona and Phil will cautiously agree. They were going to go over themselves, but they're waiting for the delivery of the wet-bikes - any excuse to use them!

NO DOCTOR IS AN ISLAND

Rowing over to the island isn't too hard. There's a small jetty with a single motor-boat moored (this is Dr. Dunwood's - Mr. Goodall's boat has been hidden to avoid any unnecessary investigation by the sheriff's department), and after a few attempts at getting close enough to disembark, the kids make it to Cygnet Island. Remember to tie up the boat!

The island is pretty small. You could walk around the shoreline in about ten minutes, but hidden in the middle of the trees is a small house. The curtains and blinds are all drawn, and the front door has a sign that says 'Go Away - No Trespassing' painted on it. It is locked, but the kids can knock. After all, they are here to warn the doctor about being replaced by pod-people.

'The door flings open and you're greeted by a crazed looking scientist, complete with mad-hair, safety goggles, and a white lab coat. I say greeted, if you call it that. He points a hand-pump spray of weedkiller at you, and shouts, 'What do you want? Go away!'

Dr. Erik Dunwood is everything you'd expect from a mad scientist. He's distracted, brilliant, and thinks so far outside of the box that it's in another universe. He was worried that the pod-people had come for him, but when he sees it's actual-people, not mobile plants, he lets the kids in before anyone can see them. Not that anyone can. He's in the middle of some trees. On an island.

Dunwood knows about the pod-people, and knows what's going on. Hang on to your britches, it's going to get exposition-y.

'Of course I know about the pod-people. Those "Steves" everywhere. They took over all of the scientists at the lab. Osterman Labs. I used to work there, but they didn't like my ideas. Said I was crazy. Ha! Now who's crazy?' He goes over to a white-board and gets out a marker.

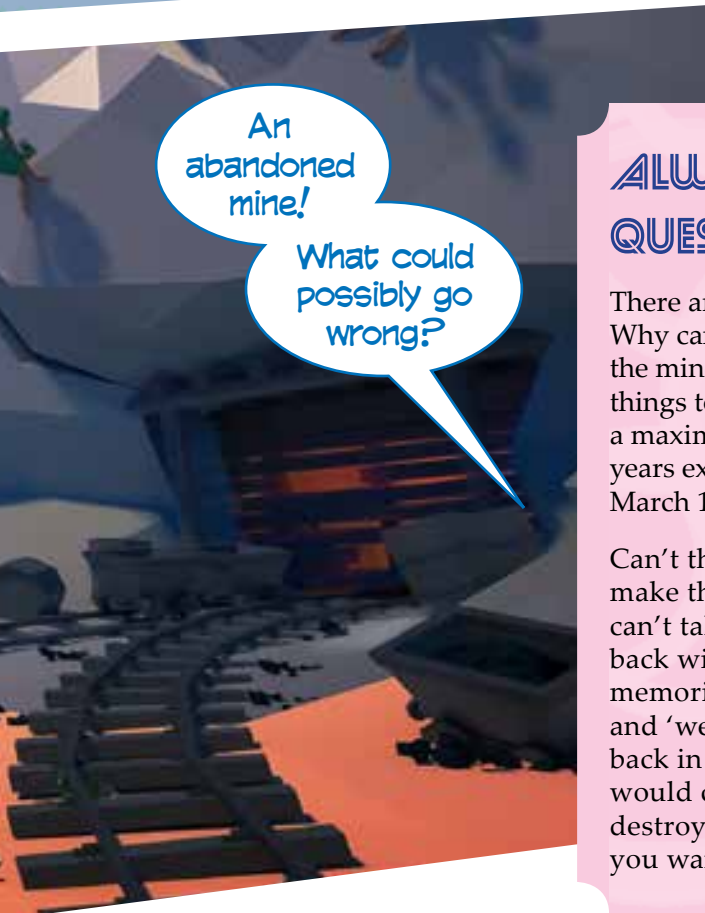
'The pod-people come from this plant. But it's no ordinary plant. It's from another dimension. A dimension of creatures that would drive you insane if you saw them. Your brains would literally run out of your ears, which would be impressive as your ear canals do not normally carry such fluid, and your brains probably wouldn't actually liquidize. That's just an analogy. Look, they're scary. Okay? I've been doing some research into the town, and I've discovered where this all came from. I hope you're ready for a history lesson.'

'Before Wilden Falls, there was a town called Wildenville.' He draws a quick map on the whiteboard. It's a mass of scribbly black lines, but you can see the lake, Wilden Falls, the labs, and the island. 'Wildenville was right in the middle of what is now the lake. Back then, they were a mining town. You know the silver mines down here?' He points at the old mine at the south of the map.

They got greedy. They dug too deep. The middle of the village collapsed into a pit so deep... well, it unleashed all of these horrors. The mine collapsed, thankfully, cutting the back of the mine off from this pit, but it was too late. The villagers started acting weird, worshipping this pit that had opened up in the middle of their homes. They built a stone circle around it, started sacrificing cattle. At least, that's what I managed to uncover. It got a bit fuzzy around the cattle sacrifices. A handful of villagers were unaffected and realised something terrible was happening. They left the village, went up to the river with some of the dynamite from the silver mine. They blew up one of the cliffs upstream, diverted the river, and flooded the village. The massive pit was swallowed by all this water, and the village was destroyed.'

'But it's not enough. Those scientists, up at the labs. They've disturbed it again. That's what the plant is. It's part of one of those... things. You go to the school don't you? You know Mr. Goodall? He knew something was up too. Came to me. Luckily, I was working on this great device. You can help. You can be just what we need to stop them once and for all. Follow me...'

He leads our Heroes down into his basement laboratory. Twice the size of the house above-ground, Dunwood's lab is huge and crammed floor-to-ceiling with inventions, devices, and strange technological creations.



An
abandoned
mine!

What could
possibly go
wrong?

ALWAYS ASKING QUESTIONS

There are bound to be some questions. Why can't they go further back and stop the mine cave-in that unleashed all these things to begin with? Well, the device has a maximum range of 876,000 hours (or 100 years exactly) and the mine collapsed in March 1884. A month out of range.

Can't they go back and tell Dunwood to make the time machine earlier? Well, you can't take any plans or anything physical back with you in time, so you'd have to memorize all of the Doc's calculations and 'weird science' formulas, and then go back in time to recite it to the Doc, which would cause a paradox and possibly destroy the space-time continuum. Do you want to risk that?

He leads you through the corridors made by piles of stuff ('Don't touch ANYTHING!') to a brightly lit corner of the lab where a large, dentist-style chair holds Mr. Goodall. He's wearing a strange device on his head with a mass of wires leading to a dozen computers and boxes with blinking lights. The hum of electricity echoes around the lab.

'Don't worry, he's fine. This device - I haven't thought of a good name for it yet - has sent his consciousness back in time... BACK... to 1884. One hundred years ago, to when the miners have just caused the collapse, opening the pit in the middle of Wildenville. I had this letter delivered that Albert, Mr. Goodall, wrote in 1884. You can save your jokes about the postal service. Look, it says "Deliver on the 24th April 1984". The letter says his consciousness is in the body of the town preacher, Rev. Angus Tweed. He says he thinks he can stop them, but he needs help to do it. I didn't dare go myself - who would monitor the equipment? Now you're here, you can go. It's perfectly safe. See?' He waves the letter at you, as proof that you can time travel...

ACT THREE:

BACK... TO THE PAST!

The kids are hooked up to a collection of makeshift headsets, similar to the one Mr. Goodall is wearing. There are no more fancy chairs in the basement, so the kids will have to sit on chairs brought down from the Doc's dining room.

'I hope you're all ready? It's perfectly safe. You'll be leaping into the bodies of villagers in Wildenville, maintaining some sort of shared quantum state - whatever you'd like to call that. Of course, if you do change the past, it'll mean that this present may not exist. But we'll cross that Einstein-Rosen Bridge when we come to it. Okay, time to send you BACK... to the PAST!'

With that, Dr. Dunwood flips some switches and there is a bright blue flash and then darkness...

OH, MAN!

THE OL' WEST

Wildenville in 1884 is a very basic town. One main street that ends in a gigantic pit in the ground. If you need to picture what the town is like, remember *Back to the Future III* is set in 1885. Think that, with more trees. There is no technology short of telegraph, the telephone is only just starting to come into use. Horses, carriages, mud and dirt. The Director doesn't have to keep it historically accurate - after all, how many Westerns of the 80s were?

The Heroes wake in various locations around the town. Only they're not who they were - they're not kids. They're regular townsfolk. When they look in a mirror, they see someone completely different. Here are a few of the townspeople they could have leapt into. Have the players pick them out at random (write the names on bits of paper and have them draw them out of a hat) or make up some new characters themselves. The only characters they cannot be are the town preacher (as Mr. Goodall has leapt into him), and Felicity McCallum, owner of the Silver Saloon and the first person in the town to succumb to the influence of the ancient interdimensional gods.

Sheriff Whitney Star - the town sheriff and goody-goody. He's wholesome, polite, and keeps the justice in the town.

Alma Summers - teacher. The very proper school ma'am, mostly teaches English, Math and bible studies.

Seth Stubbs - town drink profiteer, and resident manufacturer of moonshine. It's not pleasant, it's not legal, but it could be the explosive catalyst to stop the plant from resurfacing.

Tess Stapleton - Saddlery and Stables owner, general carer of horses for the town. Cowgirl who can handle herself in a fight.

Timothy Lucas - lumberjack. He's okay.

Burt Major - miner from the silver mines. Managed to get out when the mine collapsed. Convinced he saw weird subterranean creatures in the mines before the fateful collapse last month.

The players don't need to generate new stats or anything - while they are inhabiting the bodies of these townsfolk they have the same attributes as they did as kids in the 1980s. They can spend some time getting used to being new people, and trying to fit in, and not draw too much attention to themselves. And, of course, they'll have to find each other in a town full of people.

The easiest way for them to find each other is to find the one person in the town they know is someone else - Rev. Angus Tweed.

LIKE A PRAYER

The church is where you'd probably expect to find Reverend Tweed, but quite the opposite. The church is at the far end of the main street to the pit, and has become some strange and unholy sanctum of worshipping the new gods that threaten the town. The cross on the top of the spire has been inverted, and the townsfolk are already under the control of Felicity McCallum. If the players head to the church to find Reverend Tweed, they'll find him standing in the street grabbing random people, shaking them by the shoulders, shouting at them to wake up.

The townsfolk are in a trance, wandering aimlessly up and down the street. Our heroes can go and introduce themselves to Tweed, who will be very happy to see relatively sane people.



'The Doctor, he sent you? Thank god for geniuses like him. You're from Wilden Falls? From 1984?'

The kids can introduce themselves - after all, they may have all found the 'reverend' at the same time and may only just have discovered the bodies their companions have leapt into. They can take refuge in one of the characters' familiar places: the sheriff's office, the schoolhouse, the moonshine still, or the stable yard. There they can catch up, and find out what's going on in 1884.

'You came just in time. It seems the big ritual is tonight. Felicity McCallum seems to be the ringleader - she used to run the saloon, but now she holes' up in the church. Covered it with weird writing to worship their new gods. Some strange interdimensional being called Yogurt-Sothoth. Seems they were right when they called yogurt the "food of the gods", it's just they were wrong which god it belonged to.'

We need to disrupt the ritual, destroy what's down that pit, flood it, and ensure nothing ever emerges from there again.'

ONE THING LEADS TO ANOTHER

In order to complete the plan, the kids will have to split up. If the Sheriff, or Burt, are in the group, they have access to dynamite. One group will have to trek up into the woods with dynamite and blow up a section of cliff that Mr. Goodall has marked on a map. This will bring down the cliff, diverting the river over the falls and flooding the area. Creating the lake that the kids know and love. If they're worried that the townsfolk will all drown, the flood should wake them from their trance-like state, and they'll recover, rebuild, and start the town again in a new location - Wilden Falls. They'll be okay. We promise.

At the blasting location, they may encounter some of the pod-people that are starting to emerge in the woods. Use the Steves stats from earlier if a fight starts out. Any Steves that remain when the flooding occurs will soon lose functionality and become fertilizer to the forest.

The rest of the group will need to try and delay the ritual in the town, and burn whatever's in the pit. This is probably the most difficult task to accomplish without injuring the confused and controlled townsfolk. As the sun begins to set (probably just as the other group are reaching the blasting position) the townsfolk bring a herd of cows down the main street of the town. Oh god, you may think! They're going to sacrifice the cows, just like Dr. Dunwood mentioned. Don't worry. It was a bit fuzzy on the details, and the actual ritual

involves the cows being lined up around the edge of the pit while the townsfolk milk them - squirting the fresh dairy goodness into the pit to summon Yogurt-Sothoth himself.

AVERAGE POSSESSED TOWNSPERSON

MINDLESS DRONE

SMARTS 2 (Occultism)

STYLE 2 (Ritual Dance)

Health 4 **Defence** 12

MOVES 4 (Riding)

BRAWN 4 (Brawling)

While they do this, Felicity McCallum will recite a strange incantation. She will need to be stopped. The townsfolk will try to protect her, while she recites the words in an ancient tongue.

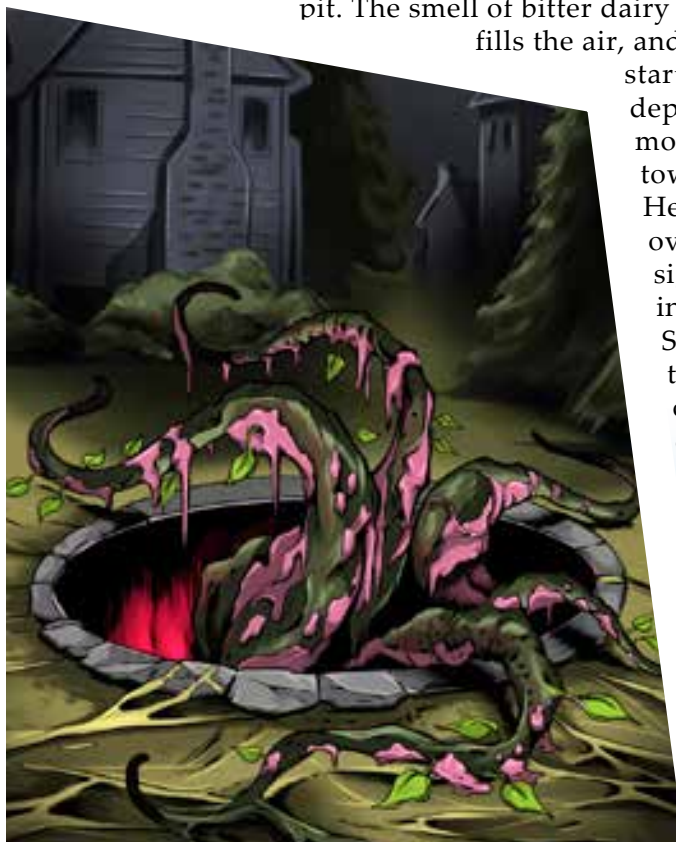
'Y'hoo, n'gool, lawn'fah phragg'n shy'yaya grogu Yogurt-Sothoth, moo huppdah vulca'mcclagg'n Cth-moo-hlu, rise oh ancient one!'

To stop the plant from resurfacing in the future, it'll need to be destroyed. The best way to do this is a combination of Seth's moonshine still and the huge tanks of highly explosive alcohol, which can be transported to the edge of the pit by Tess' carts and horses. Some of the characters can go off and do this while the others stop the villagers from interfering. The tanks can be poured into the pit, or dropped complete as barrel-sized molotov cocktails.

The struggle can continue as long as you need to. If the Heroes manage to halt the ritual, they can blow up whatever's down the pit before the flood engulfs the town. If they don't, strange tentacles rise from the pit. The smell of bitter dairy with a hint of strawberry fills the air, and a pink viscous fluid

starts to ooze from the depths. Burn it! Burn it with moonshine napalm! If the townsfolk overpower the Heroes, they can be carried over to this terrifying sight, about to be hurled in as a sacrifice to Yogurt-Sothoth, when (hopefully) the floodwaters hurtle down into the valley and destroy the town.

If the intrepid demolition party fail, and the flooding doesn't happen, Yogurt-Sothoth rises (maybe)... that's up to the Director.



No matter whether the moonshine explodes, the flooding happens, or the ancient dairy gods rise, the kids (and Mr. Goodall) wake in the basement of Dr. Dunwood.

BACK... IN THE PRESENT?

Depending upon what the players did in the past, there are a number of outcomes for your adventure.

If they sent flaming moonshine to destroy the plant, flooded the town, stopped the ritual to summon Yogurt-Sothoth, it could be that when they emerge everything is perfect. The scientists are all alive and well at the labs. There are no pod-people, no health food store, and no horrible interdimensional threats. Like nothing happened. Of course, emerging in a different branch of the timeline could mean all sorts of things are different now...

Maybe they did exactly what happened in the history books? They destroyed the town and stopped Yogurt-Sothoth rising in 1884, but the plant survived and nothing has changed. The kids will have to get to the root (literally) of the plant-people problem before they take over the town. Before the Steves can get the planning permission for that dam that will expose the pit, and unleash the terror. Maybe Yogurt-Sothoth is rising as they return, the lake turning into a massive lake of strawberry yogurt. Luckily, those wet-bikes have arrived at the summer camp. I think there's only one group of people who could get the kids out of that situation - *The Ghostbreakers!* (Cue epic crossover!)

Maybe, if they failed in the past, they return to a future where Yogurt-Sothoth rose and destroyed the town. They wake in the Doctor's bunker in a post-apocalyptic world, where he greets the characters:

"It didn't work! But you were there? You saw it all? If I can just get more power to the machine I can send you back further. Earlier. Where you can stop this from ever happening. I need to send you BACK to BACK to the PAST!"

SUPERNATURAL KIDS

While the adventure is pretty nuts, and all sorts of weird things happen, most of the kids you'll have as Heroes will be normal, regular, everyday kids. But if you want to shake things up a bit, you could add a Supernatural character in there. In this case, don't reduce their Stats as above, or increase their Karma. Stick a couple of the Stat Points into Power to reflect some cool psychic ability like Telekinesis, Telepathy, or Pyrokinesis.

If you're wanting to start straight away, here are a handful of Heroes so you can start sneaking around and rolling those dice before you can say 'does your brother have an Atari?'





ACE!
Issue 5

BEAM ME UP

MARC LANGWORTHY

BRAZENLY GOING WHERE OTHERS HAVE GONE BEFORE



INTRODUCTION

Space, a vast frontier. These are the voyages of the starship *FSS Brazen*. Its continuing mission: to recklessly go where plenty of people have probably been before... and hope a major interstellar incident isn't sparked in the process.

A long time from now, in a galaxy... uhhh... somewhere... an eclectic starship crew is undertaking a bold mission to explore uncharted regions. The Federated League of Planets (FLoP) has recently commissioned their Spacefleet to undertake several extended missions that will take a number of starships and their crews into the far reaches of space. Although there is no pay—let's face it, everything is free anyway thanks to the use of facsimilators—bed and board are guaranteed, occasional danger is assured, and they even list fun as optional.

FLoP isn't the only interstellar power in existence, however, which means that an unwary starship crew might also run afoul of the might and martial prowess of spacecraft from the Kulkan Empire, or the deviousness of infiltrators from the sinister Boredian Dominion. Hoping to beat FLoP at its own game, both of these powerful stellar entities are pushing to expand their own borders. It's not likely they'll be setting their blazers to stun, that's for sure!

Captain Wayjane and his diverse crew have been sent into the great beyond on the first of these exploratory missions. With a cutting edge starship and an allegedly competent cadre of officers and crewmembers at his command, he is confident that this noble enterprise



will succeed. Strange worlds, bizarre new species and tense space drama mean it's time to beam yourself straight into the action!

OVERVIEW

This book is divided into two sections:

Setting the Stage: The first part of the book introduces the setting and some of the groundwork you'll need to consider when running the game. You'll need to assemble a crew of course—starships don't fly themselves. Ok, ok. Technically they can, but that would make for a boring game for the players. Anyway, this section provides some new Hero options plus offers a little advice on running epic space llamas. Dramas. Not llamas.

The Adventure: We've called it an adventure, but it's more a series of major incidents that the crew encounter during their journey. All rounded out with a little advice on continuing the FSS *Brazen's* mission beyond this book if you'd like to.

TONE

Similar to our other *ACE!* instalments, the adventure in this book doesn't involve strolling from room to room fighting nasties and stealing their loot. Actually, you could technically go dungeon delving in the *Brazen's* holo-suite but we'll leave that to you to organize.

Beam Me Up is designed to be light, fun, and engaging, not dark and serious. There will be fist fights, shootouts with blazers, interstellar chases, and tense diplomatic meetings. The Heroes can be staring down angry Kulkans one minute and relaxing in a holo-suite environment the next. The galaxy is at their fingertips!

SYNOPSIS

The ongoing mission of the FSS *Brazen* begins with the starship and its crew leaving the docking bay of *Near Space 9*. The crew have been briefed and seen off by Admiral Harrison, who is looking forward to hearing their wonderful stories when they return in five years' time. Both FLoP and the ship are buzzing with excitement, the engines are primed and all that's needed to launch the grand adventure is for Wayjane to enthusiastically state: 'Make it so!'



Where's the
gas pedal on
this thing?

As this is an ongoing mission, the first two acts of *Beam Me Up* take place in any order you choose. For ease, they are described here in the sequence they are presented in this book.

In the first encounter, the crew have been tasked to investigate a seemingly spurious distress call from the *FSS Independent*, which

is a research vessel attached to operating in the Alpha Ceti IV system just beyond the limits of FLoP's border. After a brief space battle and some boarding action, the crew are introduced to Duchess Ali Cann, a super soldier with claws that is seeking revenge against FLoP for abandoning both her and her crew when they signed the truce with the Kulkan Empire.

The crew also encounter R, a strange and powerful entity that seems determined to place the team on trial for the very right to exist in the same universe as itself. The outcome of a tense encounter with the Kulkan Empire and the discovery of a strange secret may just decide the fate of every system and species that comprises FLoP.

With the first two scenarios out of the way, it's time to deal with the fallout of Cann's wrath. The players are enjoying some much-needed downtime in the Brazen's holo-suite when a destructive virus implanted by Cann activates and overwhelms the ship's computer. The team are transported to the set of a spaghetti western, where they'll need to keep their wits about them, their steeliest stare constantly active, and one finger on the trigger of their blazer in order to survive.

As mentioned earlier, however, these three short episodes are only a snapshot in the continuing adventures of the *FSS Brazen*. There is not the end! There will be plenty of stories to tell during the five-year mission, so feel free to continue with them right up until the crew return to *Near Space 9* and the rather surprised looking Admiral Harrison, as she really did not expect them to return!

CREATING YOUR OWN STARSHIP CREW

If you would like to get playing without delay, you can use the free pdf containing character sheets for Captain Wayjane and his crew. If you do decide to create your own characters, any one of the Roles from the core rules can be used — the universe is full of all sorts of non-human life after all. If you'd like some classic crew Roles that fit a starship perfectly, the Astronaut, Chef, Doctor, Engineer, Pilot, Professor (also known as Civilian Specialist) and Soldier fit the bill perfectly.

You can also use the new Roles presented here. Just be prepared to practice some iconic catchphrases, such as 'Highly illogical' or 'Make it so!'

TAKING COMMAND

Yep, one of you gets to play the Captain. While that does mean giving orders, we assume everybody else will ignore them. It also means looking out for the welfare of those under your command, so play nice! The other Heroes are also officers who will have crew under their command, so this advice goes for them too. State your orders with authority but don't make them a demand. "Open a channel to the Kulkan ship" is much less confrontational than "Hail the Kulkan's, NOW!".

It should go without saying, but also don't make orders that are just outright ridiculous. No Captain trained in a FLoP academy would expect to order a crewmember to leap from a cliff and expect it to be obeyed. You're out there in the vastness of space trying to save lives and bring folks together, not make ridiculous demands and incite wars. Leave those sorts of shenanigans to the Kulkans and Boredian Dominion, damn you!

TOP OF THEIR GAME

You should go ahead and assume that each Hero is the lead officer in their chosen Role. If they're the Chef, they're the Head Chef. If they're a Boxer or Soldier, they're Chief of Security. We also recommend that each Hero selects a different Role that would fill each of the branches you might find on a starship, such as engineering, medical, science, security, wellbeing, that kind of thing. You could run a game for a bunch of red-shirted security officers if you like, but their survival rate would be pretty low to non-existent and the game might get stale due to overlapping skill sets. When different branches are chosen, each Hero gets to shine in their particular area of expertise.

NEW ROLES

Captain. You command a starship. Yes, you! You are so goddamn inspiring that you have 10 Karma instead of 6. That's how goddamn inspiring you are! You can also spend your Karma on another Hero's behalf, granting them one of the benefits from p. 15 of the core rules, although you can't do this if they've spent their own Karma in the same round.

Chief Engineer. To you, starships are a living, breathing thing to need just as much tender loving care as any other species. Once per day if you are in the engineering section, you can spend a Karma point to cause a starship to regain 1 Health or 1 Shield without a roll, or to make your ship go one warp speed factor faster than the *Owner's Manual* says you should be able to. The warranty is voided if you do this, but when did that ever stop you?

Comms Officer. Communication is key when you're out travelling the galaxy meeting any number of new species. Especially when there won't always be a universal translator to hand. You can understand and speak any language you encounter.

Hologram. You are a hologram that manifests an advanced artificial intelligence to fulfil a specific role within the ship. You don't have a Health score and can't go unconscious or die, although destroying the synthesizer that lets you join away crews or the destruction of your starship will be pretty bad for you. Oh, and you can't physically interact with anything. But you can, like, talk and stuff.

Gunner. Security might get to blase hostile aliens but you get to go *pew! pew!* with a starship! If you're on the bridge and in control of the ship's weapons, increase any damage the weapons cause by 1.



Is there something behind me?

Ship Counsellor. You're not only a great listener but also know how to bring people around to a more positive outlook on things. People talk to you. A lot. Once per day per Hero, you can spend a minute listening to their problems and help them regain 1 Health. Also, you always know when somebody is lying.

Pilot. Yes, you know how to fly starships. But you can also get them to do cool stuff! You can spend a Karma point to increase a starship's Defence by 2 for one round.

ALTERNATE TIMELINES

The universe is a strange place featuring all sorts of unexplainable anomalies. Couple that with advancements in technology and suddenly all sorts of potential misadventures with timelines and alternate realities are possible.

The adventure as written assumes that you are using the pregenerated Heroes Captain Wayjane, Chief Science Officer Spoke, Chief Medical Officer Crunch and Chief Engineer Mackem La Kiln. These are available as a free download from www.awfullycheerfulengine.com. Don't worry if you aren't, *Beam Me Up* runs just as well without them! We can't recommend enough that at least one Hero take up the role of ship's Captain, however.

GEAR & TECHNOLOGY

Beam Me Up is set waaaaay into the future. Or the past. No, the future. Oh, we don't know. How far? That's up to you. Regardless, technology has advanced to the point that interstellar travel is possible using advanced concepts such as warp drives that allow fast-than-light travel. Poverty is also a thing of the past—for the citizens of the Federated League of Planets at least—due to facsimulators that can recreate most types of matter, including food stuffs and small-scale equipment.

Starship crews also enjoy access to portable death rays known as blazers, although these are firmly kept out of the hands of Joe Public (and who can blame them? The last time Joe Public got his hands on a blazer he tried to use it to microwave some Voldavian Ale, and atomized half a city block in the process).

All this means that the crew of the *FSS Brazen* won't need to purchase anything, so there is no need to worry about money. Anything

unusual will probably need to be run by the Captain, while anything dangerous—such as rocket launchers or tactical nukes—will likely be restricted by the computer’s programming unless overridden somehow, but other than that, replicate away!

Oh, and this is *Beam Me Up*, remember, so Heroes can definitely teleport between locations using their ship’s translocators! Unless that location is protected by something such as a starship’s shields or some other nifty type of technology.

NEW WEAPON

Blazer

A blazer inflicts 4 damage. It’s hot, hot hot! If a target is reduced to zero Health, it disintegrates and disappears from existence forever. Heroes can avoid this fate by spending a Karma point and turning it into a glancing blow, although they are still Knocked Out. Lucky them!

Blazers also have a stun setting, which instead renders the target Knocked Out when they reach zero health, but who wants to use that?



STARSHIPS AND COMBAT

Sooner or later, it’s likely that the Heroes will end up in the midst of a battle between starships. It’s probable that the Heroes are acting as officers for the crew and deciding on what actions the ship takes. Although the Captain can give the orders, each crew member should roll for their particular area of expertise Gunner to shoot at enemy ships, Chief Engineer to fix systems, that kind of thing. In this case, the narrative guidelines presented here offer a framework for the combat between the fighting spacecraft. Otherwise, if the Heroes aren’t part of the command structure, you should focus on what they are doing as individuals in the fight rather than what the ships themselves are up to.

Warning: We’ve tried to make these rules a little less dry than a desert planet with twin moons in a galaxy far, far away but it’s likely you will need some guidance for big starships taking chunks out of each other. Bear with us, you get to blow things up in space! Well, big imaginary things. But still.

Ships have four main attributes:

Science. This is all the nifty electronics on the ship. Scanners and transporters and medbays and science labs and stuff.

Shields. Shields are what make sure you don't blow up.

Size. Some ships are small, and other ships are big. It's kinda self-explanatory really. Size 1 is the size of a shuttle and size 5 is a massive battleship. Size 10 isn't a moon it's a space station. Wait, wrong franchise.

Warp. Zooooooom! This is how fast the ship can go.

Like Heroes, starships also have a Defence rating (four times their Warp, minus their Size.) and a Health score (twice their Size) plus different damage ratings depending on their weapons.

FSS BRAZEN	
SCIENCE 3	SHIELDS 3
SIZE 4	WARP 2
Health 8	Defence 8
Blazer (2 damage)	
Boson Torpedo (4 damage)	

WHO SHOTS FIRST?

We knew you'd ask that one again! A bit like combat between Heroes, the ship with the captain with the highest Style acts first. If it's a tie, compare the Smarts of the pilot for each ship. If it's still a tie, compare the Moves of each pilot. If there's *still* a tie, flip a coin. If you don't know a pilot's score for a particular stat—either because we didn't provide it or you forgot to note it—or a computer is operating in those roles, assume it's a 2.

JUST SHOOT IT ALREADY!

Pilots fly starships, Gunners shoot at things. On smaller ships, like shuttles and runabouts, a pilot might do both but for the bigger vessels you'll definitely need a different crewmember at each station. The gunner on the starship chooses which weapon they are using and makes a Moves roll, adding dice for a Shooting Focus if they're able to. And if they're a gunner and haven't got Shooting as a Focus, they're really in the wrong line of work.

Each point of damage from the chosen weapon blasts the target ship's Shields by 1 point. Once a ship's Shields are gone, you then start reducing Health. Health can't generally be repaired in combat, but a technician or engineer can attempt to repair 1 point of Shields each round with a Smarts 10 roll.

If a ship has no Health or Shields left, it's a sitting duck. Dead in the water. Err. Space. It shouldn't be in the water. Each successful attack it suffers means critical damage. That's each attack, *not* each point of damage. When critical damage occurs, roll a die and check it against the following table. If the result doesn't apply, roll again.

A starship that suffers a number of critical hits equal to its Size is destroyed; small ships are blown into pieces while larger ones may become drifting wrecks.

As a sidenote, starship weapons and Health are definitely *not* on the same scale factor as mundane weapons and humanoid creatures. A starship weapon that deals 1 damage can level a building. Starship weapons that inflict 3 damage can obliterate settlements.

Starship Hull Critical Damage Table

1d6	Result
1	Precise Hit. One weapon is destroyed.
2	Shields Down! Shields are knocked out until repaired out of combat. I mean, the shields were down anyway, but now they're <i>permanently</i> down.
3	Hull Pressure Lost. Lots of crew are killed. Probably not the Heroes, eh? Anyway, without a crew, the ship can't do much.
4	Bridge Strike. Reduce all checks and attacks by 1d6 until repaired.
5	System Overload. Reduce Comms by 1. Translocators are out of action until repaired.
6	Engine Damaged. Reduce Warp by 1.

STARSHIP OPERATIONS

Usually you use a Hero's score to perform an action. When the ship opens fire with its blazers, use the gunner's Moves. When the pilot attempts a maneuver, use *their* Moves. When the science officer tries to scan a nearby planet, use Smarts. It's all just common sense, really. But starships in the far future are really cool, and sometimes your job is to just tell the ship what to do. If the ship's Science score is higher than your Smarts, you can always use that instead. And then pretend it was you all along.

TRAVEL TIMES

In general, you shouldn't really worry about how long it takes to get anywhere in space. Everything moves at the speed of plot, with each journey taking as long as you feel it needs to. Having said that, a few benchmarks are useful for setting the scene and expectations. While it



might not matter how long it takes to get somewhere in general terms, it will definitely make a difference when a chasing other starships or racing against the clock.

Generally, moving between a planet and its moon or orbiting space station takes anywhere up to an hour. Moving between planets within a system can take several hours to a day. Moving between star systems takes a little longer, though can be counted in days or weeks thanks to warp drives. It's just a shame they aren't already a thing!

If you need to organize a chase, decide how far ahead the pursued vessel is by giving it a number that relates to the number of successes the pursuer needs to catch it. Also assign the pursued vessel the number of successes it will need to make its escape. Then use the Opposed Action rules on p. 19 of the core rules to see who wins a round and gains a success, using Warp instead of Moves. If the pursuer reaches the first number, they catch the pursued. If the pursued reaches the second number before that, they escape. Maybe they make it into that asteroid belt and hide or slip into a nebula and are lost to sensors. Just watch out for giant space worms if you do go checking those asteroids!

BEAM ME UP



Set your blazer to stun and prepare to engage the warp drive; the main show is about to begin! Like most adventures, *Beam Me Up* is broken down into a number of acts and scenes.

If you're planning on playing in this sci-fi space drama, stop reading now! You get to be the actor in the scenes and the Director will guide you through them. Unlike acting in pre-scripted movies, the dialogue in this one is ad-libbed, and the scenes are revealed as you go. Don't risk spoiling the plot beforehand.



ACT ONE

SHOTGUN ALI

Large sweeping vistas of strange new worlds, sleek starships and enormous space stations dominate the opening credits, all accompanied by an uplifting orchestral tune. The future is a bright and hopeful place that offers the thrill of exploration and discovery for the starfaring species that are part of the Federated League of Planets.

Admiral Harrison fills the vidscreen as the FSS Brazen gently maneuvers from the Mars shipyards under the expert guidance of your pilot. The whole crew have been buzzing for weeks, with briefing after debriefing and exercise after training drill finally leading to this one moment as the Brazen slips from her moorings. Viewports show figures waving you off from inside the space station, while an honour guard of space tugs and patrol vessels has also formed up to watch you all depart on the Brazen's maiden voyage. Having finally reversed the mighty starship clear of the shipyard's sheltering arms, the pilot spins the vessel on its axis and points it towards the FLoP's distant frontier. "Good luck!" states the Admiral. "May you brazenly go where no-one has gone before. I look forward to seeing you all in five years' time!"

Captain's Log, Stellar Date 10666.13

Today is the day. Today we set sail on solar winds to explore the frontier. It's hard to believe that this day has arrived but the crew and myself are ready and eager to depart. I don't know what awaits us but I do know that I couldn't face any of what's to come with a more braver and competent crew than the one I have now. Except for Acting Ensign Masher, that is. That boy seems to have an unhealthy fascination with made up games that keeps him constantly distracted. Less Occulations & Oubliettes and more academy training for that one!

If you haven't played an ACE! game before, you can use this opportunity to get used to the system. You can have a Hero try a Moves roll to pilot the starship out of the shipyard, or perhaps chart a course for their first scheduled stop at Starbase 42 at the edge of the FLoP's territory. Have one of the bridge crew — that's the Captain, Comms

Officer, Gunner or Pilot—roll a Moves check to leave the docks or a Smarts check to chart a course. If it beats a Target Number of 10, they manage to pilot starship out safely or plot the course to Starbase 42 correctly. If they don't succeed, the ship's computer will take over and finish the maneuver or make the calculation for them but the rest of the crew will certainly raise an eyebrow or two -- particularly when the collision warning sounds when the starship swings perilously close to the immovable shipyard.

The *Brazen* arrives at Starbase 42 without incident. There's no scheduled stop to be made here but the crew will need to drop from warp speed and check in with the Starbase's commander, Captain Douglas Dent, before continuing past the frontier's border. The perpetually befuddled Captain Dent requests that the FSS *Brazen* check in on the FSS *Independent*, a deep space research vessel operating in the nearby Klaatu Barada system that recently sent a distress signal but then followed up with an all-clear. Despite repeated requests, the *Independent* has yet to supply a report of the incident. Strange indeed!

The Klaatu Barada system is listed as an uninhabited system with several planets of specific geographical interest, although only one has any potential for habitation. The FSS Independent is listed in FLoP archives as an armed research vessel designed to operate close to the League's frontier. Currently under the command of Captain Kirstie Ketch, the Independent was deployed to Klaatu Barada to investigate the possibility of establishing mining facilities there.

YOUR OWN PATH

It was mentioned right at the start but bears repeating again here. The first two acts are completely interchangeable. This first act opens the action with a bang but if you'd like something a little more low key (although still potentially galaxy ending), you might want to opt for the second act first. At least then it's the Heroes' choice as to whether they start shooting first or not.

If you're playing through this act second, the *Brazen* can receive the distress call directly from the *Independent* rather than it going through Starbase 42. Read on, you'll see what we mean.

You can introduce the Heroes to the system again here if you like, having them make a Smarts 10 check to look up the Klaatu Barada system and gather the information presented above. If they succeed, all well and good. If they fail, they misinterpret Klaatu Barada as Gladys Ferrara and instead pull up images of an elderly lady with her hair in rollers whose flower print overcoat, broomstick and thick stockings only serve

SEEING IT IN THE STARS

If you're a fan of *Star Trek* or any of its parodies and the title didn't tip you off, you'll definitely recognise the utopian sci-fi genre as inspiration for *Beam Me Up*. You should draw on the sweeping scope of the different series and films as encouragement for the descriptions and scale of this particular *ACE!* game. As a sci-fi extravaganza that's more than a little tongue-in-cheek, there are also nods to *Star Wars*, *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* and some others. Yeah, we know. Don't question it, just run with it! The galaxy is vast and unknown space that can harbour all sorts of strange oddities. Even two-headed, three-armed humanoids who only seem interested in themselves.

underwent was highly wanted to forget they ever existed and assumed they would all perish in Alpha Ceti's harsh environment.

Cann now has command of the *Independent* thanks to her mind control of Captain Ketch and her First Officer through the use of some nasty parasites she placed into their ears. Let's call them Alpha Eels. Cann now has the ship sitting in orbit, waiting for another FLoP vessel to arrive so that she can ambush and capture, which will signal the beginning of her very own fleet that can be turned against the League. The whole grand plan can be accomplished with a liberal sprinkling of Alpha Eels to ensure her orders are followed. Who needs doomsday devices when you have those?

Captain Ketch answers any hail quickly

to add to her menacing image. Cue more raised eyebrows at the very least!

IT'S A TRAP!

The *Independent* was last logged as orbiting the planet Alpha Ceti VI, where it was conducting surface investigations of the planet to determine locations for potential mining facilities. Unfortunately, Alpha Ceti VI was already home to Duchess Ali Cann, a super soldier from a secret program who had been banished here when the truce with the Kulkans had been signed. Why didn't previous records show her existence? It's simple, silly. The genetic modification that Cann and her crew illegal and clandestine. FLoP



enough and asks for assistance in recovering an away crew that's currently trapped on the planet's surface. An intense magnetic storm is making translocation difficult and the only shuttle they have is grounded with the away crew and badly in need of repair. It's a Smarts 20 roll to figure out that something is up with her story—sweat is beading on her brow and she seems a little nervous—but don't ask for the check unless the players call for it. She is, after all, a Spacefleet officer. If the Heroes do cotton on to something, Ketch seems to crumble and tearfully ask for help onboard her ship. The shuttle is still on the planet (sensors reveal this to be true) but some of her crew have come down with a strange malady that she didn't want to admit to. It's a strange old tale but all she's really doing is enticing the *Brazen* into range with their shields down. Once that happens, all hell breaks loose.

As you coast into orbit and translocator range of the Independent, the translocator room on your own ships signals the bridge. Just as they're relaying a message that they have an incoming translocation from your sister ship, the red alert siren kicks in and the computer wails that all weapon systems are locked on to the Brazen. Then the Independent opens fire and everything goes dark.

What's that? Your suspicious Heroes connive to send their own away crew to the planet and deftly avoid the trap? Ali Cann has prepared for that eventuality and left some of her super soldiers down there to subdue new arrivals and implant some worms. Let's hope it's not the command team that head down there. That could get nasty!

FSS INDEPENDENT	
SCIENCE 6	SHIELDS 2
SIZE 3	WARP 3
Health 6	Defence 9
Blazer (2 damage)	
Boson Torpedo 2 (4 damage)	

CANNNNNN!

The main power is only down for a moment before the computer brings emergency systems online. Seems like the Brazen took a hefty blow to the engines. There was also that message from the translocator room to consider but they aren't responding and the computer is now screaming that intruders are spreading out through the ship.

Duchess Ali Cann and three of her super soldiers are carving their way through the ship. Cann is heading for the bridge with one of her crew while the other two head for engineering (with a little diversion along the way). Meanwhile, the *Independent* is continuing to fire at the *Brazen*. The Heroes will need to think about their positioning and how to deal with the two separate teams. If you have officers in different areas, try to

swap the action between the two at opportune moments without breaking the momentum of each combat too much. Although the *Brazen* can't move (making its Defence zero), it can raise Shields and return fire on the *Independent*. There's nothing like starting the show with a bang!

Cann and her super soldiers are tough but they aren't immortal. You can describe the rest of the crew putting up a good fight using their training, although it seems to little avail as Cann and her team mercilessly move towards their targets. She wants to capture the bridge and engineering so that she can threaten one with the other if either resists. With the blows from the *Brazen*'s crew hardly slowing them down, it's left to the command team to take the super soldiers on.

The super soldier team fighting their way to engineering will also attempt to access a control panel, seemingly to hack into the ship's computer. While they do try to accomplish that, it's really a cover for them leaving a nanotech virus that slowly slithers its way into the computer's systems. This is another one of Cann's backup plans to gain control of the ship, although the Heroes hopefully send her packing so it won't come back to haunt the *Brazen* until Act 3.

Captain Ketch is under orders to translocate Cann back to the *Independent* when commanded, which Cann will order as soon as the engineering team falls or she is herself reduced to 1 Health. At either of these points, Cann disappears in the familiar white glow of the translocation pads.

You begin to fully take in the damage to the Brazen and her crew after Cann's disappearance through the blinding glow of a translocator. Not ten minutes outside of FLoP's boundary and already your ship is badly banged up with a quarter of the crew dead or in med bay. As the damage and casualty reports continue to filter in, the shrill voice of the ship's computer once again shrieks over the noise: "The Independent's shields are down. Recommend sending a boarding party now."



DUCHESS ALI CANN

SMARTS 5 MOVES 6 (Dodging)
STYLE 5 BRAWN 6 (Brawling)

Health 6 Defence 18
Brawling 8 (2 damage)
Blazer Rifle 6 (4 damage)

Cann has 3 Karma points. She can spend 1 Karma point to have a blow reduce her to 1 Health instead of Knocked Out.

SUPER SOLDIER

SMARTS 4 MOVES 4 (Shooting)
STYLE 4 BRAWN 4 (Brawling)

Health 4 Defence 12
Brawling 6 (2 damage)
Blazer Rifle 6 (4 damage)

RETURNING THE FAVOUR

Spacefleet protocol recommends that the Heroes at least attempt to board the *Independent* and capture it. Plus with the *Brazen* currently dead in the water, they'll only have a short window to try and strike back at the vessel before it moves out of range and disappears. Or just takes its sweet time continuing to trade blows. Either way, it seems a great opportunity to take advantage of this stroke of good luck. Some sort of scrambling seems to be stopping the translocators being able to put an away crew on the bridge but anywhere within one-hundred metres of there should be fine. Getting a lock on a specific location for translocation is a Smarts 20 roll.

The first thing you notice when you rematerialize is that none of the Independent's Spacefleet crew seem to want to put up a fight. The few that you can see around you shove their hands in their air and look rather sheepish shortly before swivelling their fingers to point at the bridge. Whatever's going on with this research vessel, it doesn't seem like the crew have any inclination to put up a fight. In fact, they seemed pretty relieved that you're here.

Most of the crew are being held in the small brig or inside their rooms, with only a select few being forced to operate the ship's main systems. Any one of the *Independent's* crew that the Heroes encounter will relate the tale of Cann's mental control over Ketch and First Officer Anton, which placed themselves in a difficult spot. The away crew on the surface are also being held hostage, which put further pressure on the main crew to cooperate. They don't know how Cann has a hold over the Captain but they do know it's painful if Ketch tries to fight it.

The computer cheerily informs everyone that the self-destruct sequence has been initiated not long after the Heroes arrival. All overrides except one have been locked. That single remaining override? It's with Ketch on the bridge. The crew won't raise a hand against their Captain but they implore the Heroes to set blazers to stun for her.



As soon as the self-destruct sequence kicks in, gather up a dice pool of 10 dice and keep it separate. Roll it each time the Heroes stop to speak or do something, including moving to the bridge. Don't be too harsh but do use the pool to make it clear that time is ticking. Each time you roll a 5 or 6 with the dice, take it out of the pool and use the remainder for future rolls. If the pool reaches zero dice, the ship goes boom.

Cann is on the ship's bridge with two super soldiers plus Ketch and First Officer Anton. Cue some dastardly monologuing about the deviousness of FLoP and being cast aside as an unwanted relic of war. Cann and her crew then fight to the death. Hopefully, Ketch and Anton fight until the Heroes get them to Knocked Out—go ahead and use the Cop stats from the core rules to represent these two. Assuming this all happens, it's then a Smarts 20 roll to stop the self-destruct sequence.

There's also the small matter of the Alpha Worms wrapped around Ketch and Anton's cerebral cortex, which requires a Smarts 10 roll to detect with a medical scanner. Removing them is a Smarts 20 roll with the correct medical equipment. Otherwise they'll need to be put on ice until they can be taken somewhere that has the capability and expertise to remove the worms. Oh, and there's the small matter of the *Independent's* away crew trapped on the surface of Alpha Ceti VI, although rescuing them should be a pinch after dealing with Cann. In fact, it's probably something that can be left in the capable hands of more junior officers. (Which means it takes place off screen and save you the drama.)

ACT TWO

INCIDENT AT BOREDIA I

If you've run Act I first, the Heroes will need to spend a little time repairing the *FSS Brazen* and escorting the *Independent* back to FLoP space, which will likely mean a trip back to Starbase 42 as it's the closest port of call. If they like, the Heroes can also spend a little time there carrying out further repairs and replenishing their crew. Ketch and her First Officer are taken into custody, with the rest of the *Independent's* crew placed under house arrest on the Starbase, all of them pending further investigation. None of that's a matter for the *Brazen* and her crew, however. Those continuing journeys await!

If you're playing through this act first, Captain Dent welcomes the *Brazen's* Captain and crew as they pay Starbase 42 a visit before carrying on into the frontier. Although there are no specific orders to follow currently, Captain Dent recommends that they pay a visit to Boredia I in the Boredia Corlion system. He's heard it's a beautiful world inhabited by welcoming people and it can't hurt to start an exploratory mission on a positive note.

Captain's Log, Stellar Date 11111.14

We have been travelling beyond FLoP's borders for a few weeks now and I have to say that I'm impressed with this ship and her crew. So far, we've helped rescue a giant space whale that had somehow gotten caught in the pull of a star and gathered a new species of fruit that looks like an eye but tastes like rhubarb and custard. Walking through a forest of eyes was a weird experience and I'm still not sure who decided to try eating one first. Oh, and Acting Ensign Masher talked the command team into trying Occulations & Oubliettes before we put a veto on it. I'm glad we did. We all seem to be working together more closely now and each one of us looks forward to game night.

FLoP's MIGHTIEST HEROES

Heading to Boredia I is one of those journeys that takes as long as you decide it takes. While they're en route to the Boredia Corlion system, or wherever else the crew have decided to travel if they opt for a different destination, a strange being materializes in the briefing room dressed resplendently in the ceremonial robes worn by Judges of ancient Earth—well, ancient for this time period at least.

It's weekly report time, which means you're all gathered in the briefing room providing reports on crew rotations, illness, maintenance schedules, holo-suite usage and other important facts that keep the Brazen ticking like a well-oiled machine. Suddenly, there's a bright flash of light and a tall male dressed in ceremonial robes and wig appears before you. "Oh, don't stand for me," he sneers. "I'm just here to put FLoP on trial because I'm pretty sure the entire mish-mash of species is unworthy of continued existence."

The entity introduces himself as Arr, an omnipotent being with powers far beyond that of mortal ken. Although he doesn't perform tricks at request, Arr will spend a little time proving how all powerful he is in a number of ways, such as transporting the Heroes to a medieval court and pronouncing their quest, dropping them into a forest of carnivorous plants and only whisking them out as they are about to be eaten and freezing anyone in place that tries to attack him. He grandly informs the Heroes that their quest to save FLoP from annihilation begins at Boredia I. If the Heroes opted to head somewhere other than Boredia I or protest that they aren't heading there, Arr waves his hand and disappears. The *Brazen* is then struck by a massive impact and sent spinning across the cosmos, slowly coming to a stand at... Boredia I.

Boredia I is a lush planet overflowing with abundance. It's inhabited by humanoids—the Boredians—who haven't yet mastered interstellar travel but are fairly technologically advanced. Except for the faint ridges on their foreheads and pointed earlobes, the Boredians look just like humans. Their technology has progressed far enough for them to understand their planet's ecosystem and coexist in bountiful harmony with it.



Everything seems peaceful and nothing is out of place. The Boredians even hail the *Brazen* and welcome them to their system, where they then spend a little time arranging a diplomatic visit to the planet. Or they offer to visit the ship, whichever is preferred. Talk doesn't continue for long, however, before sensors pick up another ship entering the system at roughly the same speed that the *Brazen* was flicked across the galaxy. A quick scan confirms that the new ship is a fearsome Kulkan Raptor.

ENTER THE KULKANS

The Kulkan Raptor spins to a stop and hangs motionless for long minutes, almost as if the crew are recovering from disorientation in exactly the same manner as your own after being flung light years across the galaxy. You eventually see the Kulkan ship come about and point itself in the Brazen's direction, then the familiar shriek of the computer screeching "Red Alert!" blasts through the ship as the helm confirms that the Kulkan's have locked their weapons on.

KULKAN RAPTOR

SCIENCE 8
SIZE 3

SHIELDS 2
WARP 3

Health 6 Defence 8
Blazer 2 (2 damage)
Boson Torpedo 2 (4 damage)

The Kulkan Raptor can spend a round turning invisible. It can't fire its weapons when in this state but can move undetected and ambush its target in subsequent rounds. It needs to become visible to attack.

The Kulkan ship doesn't immediately attack, which might give the Heroes the opportunity to hail it before combat ensues. The fanged and grizzly visage of a Kulkan Commander, Vetlok, will angrily request what sort of weapon the FLoP used to drag his own ship here. It's a Style 20 roll to convince him it wasn't anything to do with FLoP, the *Brazen*, or the Boredians. He doesn't believe a word about any being called Arr. In fact, he suspects the Heroes are ridiculing his strangely piratical accent. It's another Style 20 roll to convince him that they aren't. Failing any of these means that the Kulkans attack.

Vetlok's interest piques at the mention of the Boredians, who he invites into a confusing three-way conference call on the vidscreen. The Boredians offer to host a diplomatic party from both ships on their planet and the Kulkans readily agree. The onus is on the players and it's at this point that Arr freezes time and reappears to scornfully remind the Heroes that the entirety of FLoP is on trial here.

The Kulkans arrive on the planet with enough force to overwhelm the Boredian governing body and claim command of the planet, which is what they immediately set about doing. They're banking on the FLoP

representatives not being able to intervene, which is exactly what the League's standing orders mandate. Cue maniacal laughter and preening from Vetlok. In your face, FLoP!

The Heroes have a couple of options here, some of which include:

- ☀ Breaking with protocol and fighting on the Boredians behalf.
- ☀ Arming the Boredians so that they can fight back themselves.
- ☀ Following protocol and walking away.
- ☀ Reminding the Kulkans that neutral territory means the Boredians rule themselves.

The first two options will lead to a direct confrontation with the Kulkans one way or the other. The third option definitely feels like a huge slap in the face. And the fourth option seems impossible to achieve—it's a Style 30 roll at the least.

Praying to Arr won't help, as this is part of the test that he has placed the Heroes under. In fact, praying to any god won't really help. Luckily, the Heroes do have one option. They can pit their best fighter against the Kulkan's in a hand-to-hand honour duel. If they win, it'll impress the Kulkan's enough to reduce the Target Number of that fourth option to 20. Any volunteers?

The last laugh seems to be on the Kulkans, however. It becomes painfully apparent that they have been stricken by a virus when they return to the ship. A smiling Vetlok, who seems to be desperately trying to hold in laughter, hails the *Brazen* asking for help. It seems his entire crew are rolling with crippling laughter. If they don't get help, he fears they'll laugh themselves to death. Formulating and administering a vaccine involves getting one of the Kulkans into the medical bay, succeeding at a Smarts 20 roll, and then taking the vaccine back to distribute among the Raptor's crew. If they manage this, the Heroes will have made Kulkan friends for life.

KULKAN CHAMPION	
SMARTS 2 STYLE 1	MOVES 3 (Dodging) BRAWN 7 (Brawling)
Health 7	Defence 9
Brawling 9 (2 damage)	



JUDGE AND JURY

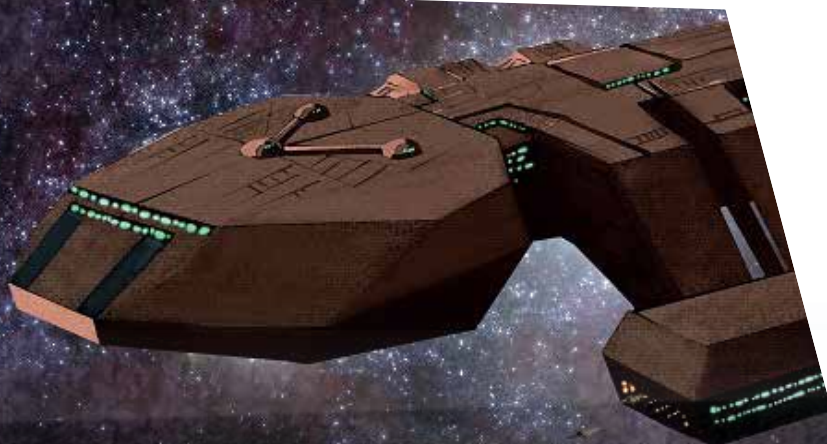
Arr reappears once the dust has settled and the Heroes have made their way back to the *Brazen*. No matter the outcome of each situation, he seems less than impressed with their actions and antics. But then, he definitely comes across as a smarmy and snarky being who derives great pleasure from his superiority. Smug isn't the word for it.

He soon whisks the Heroes back to court to place them back on trial and receive their verdict. If they managed to convince the Kulkans to walk a non-violent path at even one point during their previous meetings, Arr grudgingly concedes that FLoP might just be worth saving. The Heroes have to have tried doing the right thing at least one time, right?

After all this, there's still the virus to consider. It could certainly help in any future conflict against the Kulkans. Although FLoP wouldn't release it as is, they might want to reduce its effect to only incapacitate Kulkans, rather than kill them. Could that be why Arr brought the *Brazen* and her crew to Boredian I? Does he know something of the future that they don't?

HIGHER STAKES

Arr was never really going to destroy an entire interstellar organisation and the planets and species that it consists of, was he? A post-apocalyptic and dystopian galaxy in the wake of such devastation is beyond the scope of this book. Plus *ACE!* is meant to be light and fun remember. That said, if you'd like to take your game in a different direction, go right ahead. It's not like Arr will turn up to set you back on the right path. He doesn't even exist except as mere words on a page inside a silly tabletop roleplaying game. Unless he is really out there. Watching and judging...



ACT THREE

GUNFIGHT AT BRAZEN CORRAL

They've survived the murderous Cann and met the enigmatic but arrogant Arr, but can the Heroes survive the dangers of their own holo-suite?

Towering ice-capped mountains, a serene undisturbed lake, a picturesque forest and a cosy campfire all provide a stunning backdrop to some much-needed downtime. Captain's orders meant that you none of you could refuse this trip to the holo-suite and you're certainly glad of the choice of location. Laying back and watching the sunset, it's easy to forget that you're on a huge starship millions of miles from home. Then the sky ripples and the earth shakes, creating a dust storm that momentarily blinds you. Spitting mud as your eyes clear, you hastily roll out of the way of the horse hooves thundering towards you.

Unfortunately for the Heroes, the *Brazen* recently skirted close to a flair from a nearby nebula, which had the ill-timed effect of activating Cann's nanotech virus that had dug its way towards the computer's core. Waking up and overwhelming the ship's AI, it rapidly determines that the command staff are all in the holo-suite together and institutes a new holo-program to take them all out. Not for this virus a quick clean kill that would leave little room for the Heroes to escape their predicament. Oh no. This super intelligent artificial entity wants to have some fun with them instead. Danger inhibitors are off, revolvers and rifles are loaded and the scene is set.



IS IT O.K.?

Why, yes, it is! The O.K. Corral that is. The nanotech virus has taken over the ship and gained a new identity, now calling itself Demeter. It has warped the command crew's holo-suite experience into a replica of the town of Tombstone on Wednesday, October 26th, 1881. Almost exactly one hour before the infamous shootout at the O.K. Corral.

The Heroes have been whisked from their previous reverie and dumped in the middle of Tombstone, Arizona, in the southern United States. Their clothing has been changed for dusty suits and Stetsons and six-shooters hang from gun belts on their hips. Asking around town or looking for information, including newspapers, soon reveals their location, either of which can prompt a Smarts 10 Smarts roll to recall some facts about the gunfight at the O.K. Corral. Top of the list is the fact that Morgan, Virgil and Wyatt Earp and their friend Doc Holliday gunned down Clanton-McLaury gang at around 3 pm on this very day. Doc Holliday himself is sitting at the Oriental Saloon if the Heroes head there for information. He doesn't know anything about the shooting yet but he can confirm one fact: the Heroes have taken the roles of the Clanton-McLaury gang. With the clock ticking, it seems like their time is running out!

Now, this part of the adventure is meant to contain a little bit of silliness mixed with an overriding sense of urgency and danger. Tombstone appears as the wild west awash with a whole load of stereotypes. If they aren't wearing snugly fitting tailored suits replete with chains and pocket watches, the men sport jeans, waistcoats, neck scarves and huge Stetson. Plus everyone has a cigar, including the most elegant ladies of the town. And that's not to mention the troop of dancers dancing the Can-can at the Bird Cage Theatre. Demeter is still figuratively finding its feet and coming to terms with its new existence, plus the ship's AI is attempting to fight back. It hasn't quite got to grips with itself and the data at its fingertips yet. Events and people around town should feel odd and campy to the Heroes, and the more they interact with the oddness, the worse it gets.

THE SOUND OF INEVITABILITY

Ultimately, Demeter aims to force the Heroes into the shootout at the O.K. Corral no matter what. He contrives and reorders everything to make it happen. Each time the Heroes change something or try to alter the event, Demeter resets Tombstone to one hour before the gunfight and starts the ball rolling all over again. The Heroes needing to dodge from the path of thundering horses after a reset seem as inevitable as the shootout itself. This happens every time the Heroes try to dodge their fate. If they gun down Doc Holliday or Wyatt Earp before 3 pm? Reset. If they leave Tombstone and flee for the hills. Reset. If they hire some additional help and place snipers on the rooves. Reset. If they hide in the rear of the theatre and wait out the allotted time. Reset. Worse yet, if they get close to the allotted time, there's another glitch and it soon becomes clear that their ammunition is fake. Although you can bet the Earps' and Holliday's isn't.



There is one saving grace after each rest, however. A subtle glitch in the program after the reboot that becomes a little easier to detect each time. After the first reset, everyone is smoking cigarettes through a cigarette holder instead of chomping on cigars. After that, cowboys are wearing ten-gallon hats instead of Stetsons. Something different each and every time. Spotting these subtle clues starts as a Smarts 30 roll, then drops by 5 after each reset. Ultimately, the Heroes can deduce that whatever is controlling the program doesn't seem to have as firm a grip as it might like. Reducing the Smarts roll to 10 through resets is enough to cause the program to collapse in places, leaving the metal walls of the holo-suite visible in places. After that, it's a Smarts 20 roll to open a panel and shutdown the holo-suite entirely. Just so long as they avoid the stroke of 3 pm, everything will be fine. Promise.

REBIRTH

With the holo-suite shutdown, the Heroes can make a Smarts 10 roll to deduce that the ship's computer is in dire straits. With most of its systems locked out or under Demeter's control, they'll need to hightail it to the computer's core at the *Brazen's* heart and manually help it fight off the nanotech virus. Some of the crew could head to engineering and force a drop in temperature, which would slow Demeter and make him less responsive but they'd need to get eyes on the tight grip his nanotech form has around the computer's core to reach this conclusion.

Making their way to the ship's core isn't a walk in the park, however, as Demeter will engage as many defences as he can to stop them. Doors slamming shut on Heroes requires a Moves 20 roll to avoid 2 damage. Electricity crackling from panels or cables needs a Smarts 20 roll to spot the discharge and ground it in time to avoid the same damage. Demeter has any number of tricks up his sleeve to stall his progress. You can even start the same countdown using dice that you used in Act I, only this time remove a die on a 4, 5, or 6. If that dice pool hits zero, Demeter totally consumes the ship's computer and jettisons the Heroes into space. Hopefully they made it into a zero-g suit or shuttle in time. They didn't? Well, they do say that no one can hear you scream in space. At least it's a quiet death.

Hopefully, the Heroes make it to the ship's core in time to help it fight Demeter. This needs a Smarts 30 roll to succeed. If they bring the cold to bear from engineering somehow, such as rerouting a cryogenic gas into the chamber from somewhere (making sure to avoid anyone living, of course), then the Target Number is instead reduced to 20.

Demeter doesn't die, however, but is instead absorbed into and conjoined with the ship's computer. At least now there won't be a horrible shrieking wail each time a red alert is announced. That's a win-win, right?

FURTHER SEQUELS

The galaxy is huge place to explore. Unless you run up against the boundaries of the Kulkan Empire or Regular Dominion, of course. With so many television series and movies set within this genre to draw upon, it will be a small and easy step to seek out your favourite episodes or feature films and draw upon them to create notes for further adventures for the crew of the *FSS Brazen*. Just remember to give them a light-hearted twist in keeping with the spirit of *ACE*! Or is that Manhattan? Either way, this does not need to be the end. After all, these are the voyages of the starship *FSS Brazen*. Its continuing mission: to recklessly go where plenty of people have probably been before... and hope a major interstellar incident isn't sparked in the process.

Captain's Log, Stellar Date 120705.77

It's hard to believe that we've been beyond the League's borders for such a long time. Long enough, in fact, for our crew to begin thinking of returning home. I've said it before but I'm exceedingly proud of their performance throughout. Sadly, I've had to indefinitely postpone our regular game of *Orcs & Oubliettes*. Our whole team were assimilated because we couldn't agree on how to tackle a space cube operated by a hive mind, with everyone blaming each other. Personally, I'm back to watching Acting Ensign Masher closely for now...





ACE!
Issue 6

Orcs & Oubliettes

MARC LANGWORTHY



In a Spin

Welcome to the amazing planet of Webworld, a disc-shaped world spinning through the cosmos, tethered to the web of the great spider, An'Ansee. A mystical place steeped in magic, myth, and mischief, Webworld is home to all manner of civilisations, creatures, and characters. From tunnels that house trolls to dungeons that host dragons, and from lords with powerful rings to realms that have somehow been forgotten, the ever-spinning disc is home to a complete medley of fantastical people, places, and personalities. Tour guides aren't joking when they welcome interplanar visitors with the line: "Welcome to Webworld, the place that has it all!"

Of course, any visit to Webworld should always begin at the heart of the realm, the not-so-shining jewel hanging at the centre of the web that An'Ansee continually weaves: Heq Moreveg. Lurking at the core of the everchanging mesh like a bloated fly which willingly flew into the jaws of death only to find it was attempting to sacrifice itself to a fruitarian, the city serves as a melting pot of different species and societies, all been drawn together in distinct disharmony. With the city dangling like it does at the centre of a spider's web, Heq Morevegians have the dubious honour of being able to look up at the rest of Webworld's inhabitants who reside on the rim around them. Or of being looked down upon by the rimward people, depending on your perspective.

Raucous hub of perpetually shadowed commotion that it is, the metropolis of Heq Moreveg requires a unique constabulary to ensure that the city's status quo doesn't boil over into rioting between the various sects—nobody wants a repeat of the Great Blaze of 666 that nearly burned through the strands holding the city to the web. Enter the Dusk Watch, a specially appointed task force who have been given the duty of keeping the peace in the city. Trouble is, they largely achieve this through incompetence, feigned ignorance, or outright dishonesty.

Our story starts with Captain Phanta, a rare silver beacon in the Dusk Watch who is hoping to turn the constabulary into something a little more than the largely derided outfit that it currently is. Hot on the trail of the kidnapped emissary, Unipollen, Phanta is hoping to avoid a diplomatic incident that could easily spill over onto the streets. Can she enter the famed catacombs beneath the Perturbed Dragon Tavern and find the envoy before it's too late? And will her investigations uncover the true mastermind behind a nefarious plot to place a new king on Heq Moreveg's throne? Just how deep does the Underweb go and where does it end? (Trust us when we say you don't want to know the answer to that last one!)

Overview

This book is divided into three sections. Honestly, we wanted more but 2nd Century Fox, the production company behind this grand fantasy adventure, kept quoting budget restraints. So here they are:

INTRODUCTION: The bit you're reading now. As this entire manuscript is an adaption of a novel, we (read: 2nd Century Fox) wanted to spend a little time introducing you to what you can expect and the types of Heroes you can play.

THE SETTING: If you've read the 'In a Spin' introductory text, you'll have picked up on the fact that Webworld is a magical place full of dungeons, dragons, faeries, enchanted items, and all manner of peoples and places. Oh, and orcs and oubliettes. Forget about the rest of Webworld for now (pesky budget constraints again) and let's stay focussed on the city at the centre of

Tone

Unlike like our other *ACE!* instalments, this adventure might involve strolling from room to room fighting nasties and stealing their loot. This is *Orcs & Oubliettes* after all, so there'll definitely be a bit of dungeon delving and equipment upgrading. Plus we'll leave it up to you to decide whether you want to let the Heroes steal any loot. Just gently remind them that it might be prudent to declare it with the numerous thieves' guilds if so. They tend to get a bit upset at unsolicited thievery.

Orcs & Oubliettes is designed to be light, fun, and exciting, not dark and serious. There will be fist fights, shoot outs, chases, and strange occurrences. The Heroes can be exploring dungeons one moment and fighting dragons the next. Oh, and try not to fall from the web. Nasty business that.

the web: Heq Moreveg. This part gives an overview of the metropolis and introduces some of the characters and factions the Heroes might run into as they bounce from dungeon to dragon.

THE ADVENTURE: This is the complete adventure, *Orcs & Oubliettes*. You can jump straight into the action with Phanta and her friends or create your own crew. Your band of Heroes will get to explore the famous dungeon beneath The Perturbed Dragon Tavern, drink with orcs in the infamous orphic oubliette beneath Castle Moreveg, and tangle with a dragon as it tries to burn the city from the web in a temper tantrum.

Original Cast of Characters

The characters presented here are the original cast as presented in the 1990 novelisation that first introduced the Dusk Watch and their misadventures in Heq Moreveg. They offer a quick option to delve straight into *Orcs & Oubliettes*, but you are of course free to create your own. Maybe you'd like a child prince who wields a sword drawn from a stone or a halfling who stumbled across a mysterious magical ring instead. Don't let us stop you, go right ahead!

Each character here is already provided with a trait and Role. Just like designing new characters, however, feel free to swap these out if you'd like to tweak them a little.



Captain Phanta

Intense Watch Captain

A magical construct with a heart, Captain Phanta was purchased by the Dusk Watch from Al & Dean's Artefact Shop to take over the job of cleaning out the ablutions of the various Watch Stations. This silver-plated mechanoid rose above the detritus of her intended fate and passed her entrance exams to join the Dusk Watch as an officer. It was only after she began rattling the cages of the various thieves' guilds and *actually* arresting people that the Dusk Watch began to realise the size of the problem they had created for themselves.

Grom Silverwing

Larcenous Sprite

A light-fingered faerie with hands that are often too small for the items that find their way into them, Grom has been an invaluable companion to Phanta ever since she tried to steal one of her shin guards. With one ear always tuned to



the pulse of the street and one hand in the Dusk Watch's coffers, there isn't much in the way of information that Grom can't find out given a little time. Although she's sworn to Phanta that her pickpocketing days are behind her, what the Captain can't see hasn't really happened, right?

Garry Swotter

Teenage Wizard

As the seventh son of a seventh son, it was hoped that Garry would be somewhat of a prodigy when it came to the magical arts. Flying through his studies at the Watchful Order of Witches and Warloques, Garry hit a bit of a brick wall during his third year when he was seconded to the Dusk Watch as part of his final assessment to enter his fourth. Patrolling the streets, dirtying the hem of his robe, and investigating the odd grisly murder just isn't for him.

Up till now he hasn't been able to pass the assessment, so he's stuck at the Watch until someone takes pity on him or he pulls his stockings up and gets on with the job.

As sulky as he is about the whole affair, it's looking more and more likely that the former will happen first.



Soggoth

Inattentive Troll

Although the Dusk Watch are largely derided and ignored, they do sometimes need to make sure that the law is enforced or peace is maintained. Which is how certain characters like Soggoth make their way into the ranks. Sometimes the Watch need to at least pretend to investigate, other times they need to bring along the muscle and make sure folks are listening. For his part, Soggoth generally enjoys looming over people and offering his toothy grin. It seems to make his friends on the watch happy and means he ends up with a larger portion at mealtime. Speaking of food, is that the smell of roast hog coming from just over there...

Creating Your Own Dungeon Delvers

If you do decide to create your own characters, many of the Roles from the *ACE!* core rules will work for this adventure. You can also use the Roles presented here. As you'll be working as part of the city watch, you also may want to practice important interview questions such as 'Alright, what's all this then?'.

New Roles:

Watch Captain

You've worked your way through the ranks and now look after your own merry band of constables and special investigators. That generally means you get to tell people what to do while picking and choosing which cases you get personally involved with. Although you'll have several members of staff and a Watch Station to administer, don't worry about them too much as you can just crack on with solving the latest major crime and leave things to run themselves. Your badge gets you entrance into everywhere but the thieves' guilds—those are by appointment only—plus you can spend a Karma point once per scene to ask the Director for an important clue. Just the one mind. And if there aren't any clues, you don't spend the Karma point.

Sprite

Thanks to faerie dust and a set of glimmering wings, you can fly for a number of rounds equal to three times your Moves. After that, you need to rest for the same number of rounds that you spent flying before being able to fly again. Or you can spend 1 Karma to refresh your flying to zero rounds. You can't ever have a Brawn higher than 2 but you do start the game with 2 extra Karma. You also never take falling damage but gently drift to the ground like a feather. Oh, and you don't disappear just because people tell you they don't believe in faeries. That's just laughable. Of course they exist, you're living proof!

Troll

You're a troll. That doesn't mean that you heckle people from sewer grates. You also don't have a carrot for a nose or turn to stone if the sunlight catches you, but it does mean you're massive, strong and generally only attractive to other members of your species. Which is fine, because you're afraid to even give the little folks a hug as they're so soft and squishy. You gain the Tough Focus for free, in addition to whatever other Focus you choose for your Brawn Stat and you deal 1 extra damage with your fists or weapons in melee. You also eat a lot and you're not too fussy about flavour.

Gear, Magic Items & Technology

As a member of the Dusk Watch, you'll have everything that's required to fulfil your role, which includes a tabard, a weapon, a leather jerkin, a whistle, a truncheon, and a waterproof poncho.

Webworld is a fantastical place which has magic soaked into every fibre of its disc. Many of the civilisations that inhabit the planet have also advanced their technology through the use of either magic or science. This means that

there's a little bit of steampunk-type tech available—flying galleons, magical picture boxes, steam-powered engines of destruction, that kind of thing.

Cost

Everyone uses gold as the standard coin on Webworld. Some folks trade in gems and other precious ore but then these are always given an equivalent gold value too. So gold it is..

Listed by difficulty to obtain, here's a breakdown of some of the standard gear and services available to your Heroes.

Amount	Difficulty	Example
Up to 10	-	Send a carrier pigeon, buy a dagger, rent a room at an inn
Up to 1,000	10	Purchase chain mail, buy a bow, snag a healing potion
Up to 10,000	20	Buy a small boat or a horse, purchase a magic sword
Up to 100,000	30	Buy a griffon or similar flying beast, purchase a ship
Up to 1,000,000	40	Buy your own ship or airplane

Magic Items

There are a handful of magic items on p. 16 and 17 of the *ACE!* core rules but we've included a few extra here that might find their way into your hands. Each item is listed under the difficulty to purchase it. As this is *Orcs & Oubliettes*, it's also entirely possible that you come across one or two items while exploring a dungeon or looting a corpse.

NORMAL (10)

- **Climbing Potion.** Like some sort of spider or creepy possessed person, you can climb as fast as you can walk for one scene.
- **Dark Vision Potion.** Lets you see in the dark for one scene.
- **Riveted Rod.** A metal rod that stays in place when a button is pushed, even if it's just hanging in the air all on its lonesome.
- **Snore Powder.** Fling it in someone's face and watch them fall asleep! Unless they pass a hard Brawn 20 roll that is, which means they'll probably just sneeze instead.



HARD (20)

- **Amulet of Fiery Death.** This amulet has three quick release hoops attached, each of which has a small ruby inset into it. When thrown, each hoop does 2 damage to everyone within 30 feet. So make sure you throw them at least 30 feet away!
- **Bag of Storing.** A sack, satchel, rucksack or some type of... bag that can hold an awful lot of stuff inside the pocket dimension that nests within its innocent looking opening. Who knows what might be lurking inside the nooks and crannies of its interdimensional space? (The Director, that's who!)
- **Lidded Eye.** A lantern with a mechanism that can change it from hooded (30 foot radius of light) to bullseye (5 foot wide 60 foot line of light). Anything invisible that is caught by the lantern's light is now visible.
- **Winged Boots.** Leather boots with itty bitty wings on each ankle. You can click your heels together and teleport to anywhere you like... no, wait... and fly for an hour. Yes, that's it. Once they've been used to fly, they need an hour's rest before they can be used again.

HERCULEAN (30)

- **Absorbing Gloves.** A pair of black gloves that absorb a Power that specifically targets you. The Power can't be affecting an area, as that's indiscriminately rolling over lots of folks, not just targeting you. If the gloves absorb a Power, they convert it into 1 Karma and store it. The gloves can hold up to 10 Karma. Power targeting you once the gloves are full has its normal effect. If you have a Power stat, you can use the stored Karma to fuel your Powers.
- **Bracers of Giant Strength.** Putting these on makes you amazingly strong. You don't gain any muscle or mass, though, which can make it look a little odd if you're a faerie holding a horse aloft in one hand. Multiply your Brawn Stat by 4 for anything related to feats of strength, including unarmed damage, and add your unarmed damage as a bonus to damage when attacking with melee weapons. Don't adjust your Health, this only affects your strength. And yes, Sprites can have a Brawn higher than 2 if they have a pair of these.
- **Symbol of Speed.** Shaped like a lightning bolt, this symbol needs to be worn prominently on the centre of your chest to be effective. You need to shout the magic words 'fastest person alive' to activate it. When you do, you gain two actions instead of one each turn for the rest of the scene. The symbol needs 24 hours to recharge once used.

IMPOSSIBLE (40)

- **Lamp of Three Wishes.** Go on. Give it a polish. Then say hi to the djinni inside and seriously ponder your heart's desires. Or maybe do some good with them instead. And no, like the blue person says, you can't wish for more wishes. What *can* you wish for? Director, this one's on you!

- **Vorpal Blade.** A sword that goes snicker-snack! You get 1 extra die when attacking with this weapon and it does +2 damage. If you three 6s when you attack then you chop off the creature's head. Unless it has more than one head, there's no coming back from that!



Heq Moreveg

Nestled at the core of not just the web that supports it but also the entirety of Webworld, the bustling metropolis of Heq Moreveg has the distinct honour of being in the middle of everything, which is exactly how most Heq Morevegians like to conduct their affairs, by walking right into the midst of something and attempting to put their own stamp on proceedings, whether its wanted or not. 'You must be from Heq Moreveg!' is a popular retort when receiving an unwanted opinion, as is 'Keep the Heq to yourself' when someone tries to undercut a business deal between two other parties. Anyway, the point is, that for better or worse, Heq Moreveg is right at the centre of the different elements that make up Webworld—on the vertical plane, it's even at the mid-point between the great spider, An'Ansee, her ever-shifting web, and the ring it all dangles from—and the different folks that live there seem to take that to and if you made sense of all that, you're a lot clever than we are.



From Small Strands

Nobody really remembers the exact date that led to the foundations of the city's existence. In fact, the actual date changes from year to year depending on the results of a peoples' poll. Trust us when we say there have been plenty of violent clashes over some of those results, and copious amounts of money will often change hands to influence the outcome.

Although few folks remember the exact day and year it happened, everyone knows the story behind it. Or some variation of it at least. Only Heqqle, the unfortunate Silk Dwarf who dug too far, ever knew for sure as she was the only one there. Sadly, she's joined the great silk ancestors in the Underweb so she won't be telling the true version any time

soon. Regardless, the day she tumbled from the caverns and tunnels inside the Lower Rim to land in the detritus at the centre of the web below has become a feat of legend. Clearing out some of the rubbish and making a home for herself amongst the discarded refuse, much to the initial ire of An'Ansee as most of the garbage went in her direction, led others to investigate the trembling of the web and eventually settle in themselves. There are some other pertinent points to the tale, such as the odd battle with rimward folks who took offense to their spider goddess getting continuously sprinkled with trash, and a heroic effort to save the web from disappearing in a blaze after a mishap with a grease-spreading automaton built to help shift the larger items of rubbish, but the rest, as they say, is history.

Life Below the Rim

Aside from the fact that everyone seems to want to get involved in everyone else's business, life in Heq Moreveg isn't too different from that of those who live on Webworld's ring.

Musical Chairs

The city is ruled by a monarch, although by law this isn't a hereditary title. In keeping with the ever-shifting pathways of the web, the ruler of the city

changes from generation to generation. Oh, the odd king or queen has tried to pass power on to their children of course, but this has never ended well. The riots and Great Blaze of 666 are testament to this. Instead, the Brazen Yeopersons of the Elective Council of Keepers (BY'ECK for short) that advise the monarch convene to choose a new ruler from amongst their membership following the death of the previous one. BY'ECK also largely sets policy and makes decisions on behalf of the city through a complex system of voting, although the king or queen has the power to veto the outcome. Most monarchs avoid flexing their authority too often, however, as this has sometimes been known to lead to a short reign.

BY'ECK

The members of BY'ECK are all elected representatives of particular trades and cross-sections of the city's diverse composition. A spokesperson for each species sits on the council, as do the prominent heads of the various esteemed professions, which includes establishments such as the Guild of Accountants, the Watchful Order of Witches and Warloques, and the League for Rehab of Fantasy Villains to name a few. Even the various thieves' guilds have a delegate at the table, which is how there is an unspoken agreement with the Dusk Watch that the raiding of a guild house is only to be undertaken by prior appointment and with at least forty-seven hours and fifty-six minutes notice. (The thieves' guilds wanted two full days but the Dusk Watch countered with the fact that four minutes is the average length of time it would take them to hide any signs of their illicit activities, so they let the matter drop.)

A People and Place

The people of Heq Moreveg are an eclectic collection of every species that exists on Webworld, with the odd addition of folks from other worlds or dimensions—demons summoned to perform some nefarious bidding, spirits lingering to complete an unfinished task, and aliens who seem to appear from nowhere, that kind of thing. With daily routines in the city determined by its strange day and night cycles, and the populace itself a raucous and glorious coming together of Webworlders from all walks of life and all its lineages, settling down in Heq Moreveg is something that only usually happens to someone who is born there or someone who is seeking escape from the strictures and prejudices of the nations that vie for space on the world above. In Heq Moreveg, orcs share tankards with dwarves, trolls play medleys with elves, and everyone makes allowances for the delightful odour that follows the troglodytes around.

As noted earlier, Heq Morevegians have a penchant for sticking their nose in, even if their opinion isn't wanted. Visitors and outsiders consider this rude, but in a city that hosts every intelligent species on Webworld,

each of them normally used to speaking their own language and hailing from lineages with their own unique idiosyncrasies, a certain amount of brashness has come to be expected as a means for getting anything done. In the city's early days, meetings between peoples could take hours or even days to conclude so as to avoid diplomatic incidents. The citizens eventually learned to get over themselves and accept that everyone is different. They also acknowledged that a particular way of doing something because 'that's how it's always been done' might not always be the best method in the long run, so giving and accepting constructive criticism became more socially acceptable between the various folks. Far from being rude, most Heq Morevegians sincerely believe they are trying to help when sticking their oar in and often fail to understand why a non-resident gets upset over their input when all they're trying to do is improve the situation.

Strange Cycles

One facet of life for Heq Morevegian's that differs greatly from those who live on the rim is their relationship with the solar and lunar cycles. While the tiny sun that orbits Webworld rises and sets in a regular twenty-four-hour cycle, peeking over the edge of the rim and passing over the doughnut of Webworld to provide approximately sixteen hours of daylight before disappearing over the opposite side and plunging those who live on the rim into another night. The sun then loops around both the web and An'Ansee in its orbit, warming the great arachnid's face, thorax and other over-sized spidery bits before making its way towards Webworld's horizon once more. The moon depicts a similar orbit, although as it circles at a different pace to the sun on a different elliptical orbit, it also passes through a lunar cycle ranging from absence to full presence, waxing and waning on a weekly cycle (which, quite literally, drives the werewolves nuts).

As it sits below the horizon at the centre of the huge hole that forms the inner circumference of Webworld, Heq Moreveg experiences a different cycle to the rimworlders above. According to Heq Moreveg's daily cycle, the first part of the day begins when the edge of the sun lifts above An'Ansee enough to be seen by the city's residents. Heq Moreveg then enjoys roughly two hours of daylight before the sun passes over the disc's rim to light the world above and slowly eclipses the city at the heart of the web, keeping it mostly dark for another few hours until it then clears the inner edge of Webworld's ring. This happens once more as the sun passes over the opposite side of the disc and begins its descent towards An'Ansee. These three phases of daylight are called first light, second dawning, and lowering, while the periods of darkness are known as the first eclipse, second eclipse, and dusk. Again, the moon depicts a similar cycle although the light it provides is of course dependant on its current phase (absent, crescent, half, gibbous, or full).

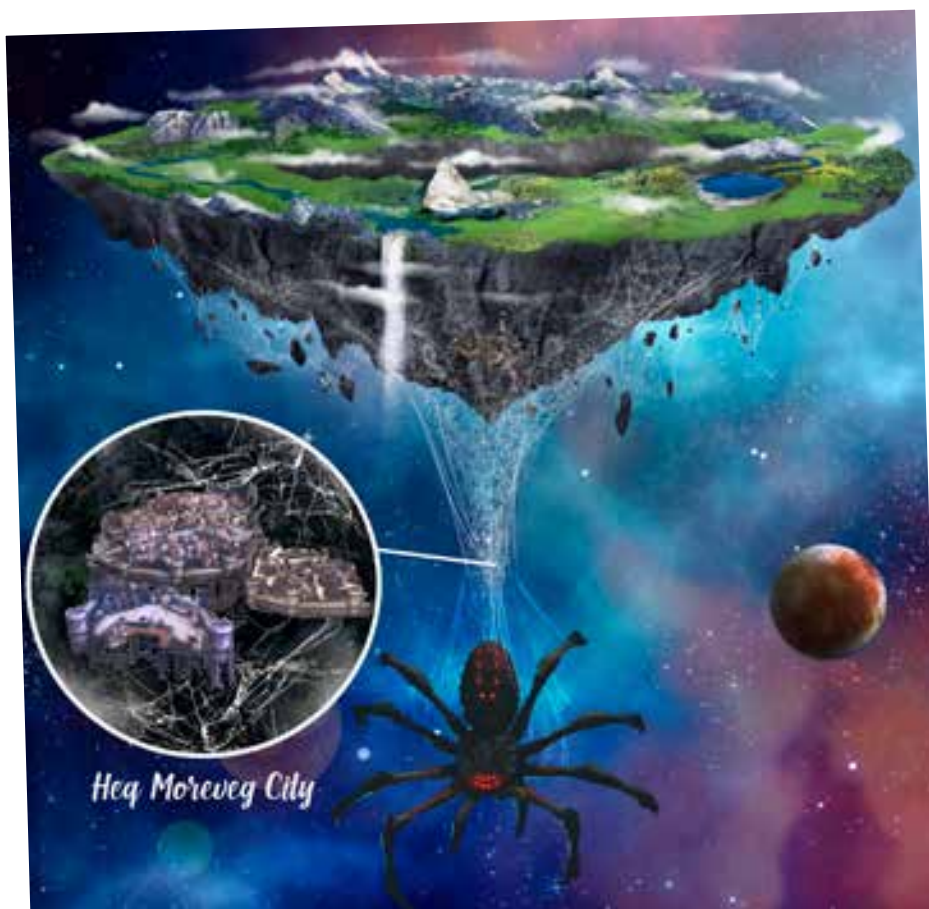
The City at a Glance

Built on huge stone slabs bridging the gap between the strands of the web below them, the city rests on a strong foundation of rock and springy cables that are tougher than steel. Constructed on a web as it is, Heq Morevegians refer to the districts and neighbourhoods of the city as spirals and threads. There are three distinct spirals to the city, each containing a number of threads. Oh, and there's the Underweb, which definitely *isn't* part of the city but does need to be talked about—and not just because it's dark and scary.

Monarch's Spiral

As the name implies, the Monarch's Spiral is home to the sprawling manse that houses each sovereign when they come into power: Heqqle's Redoubt. Less practical fortification and more rambling villa from the flighty imaginings of a splatter artist employed as an architect, Heqqle's Redoubt is an expansive collection of architectural styles that should never exist together in close proximity. Each ruler that takes over adds their own unique touch, of course, making the grounds an ever-changing jumble of extravagances. The place is a city planner's nightmare, but luckily the monarch has a veto over that particular office.

The Monarch's Spiral is also home to the various administrations that support the monarch or oversee the day-to-day running of the city, such as Heq Moreveg's Ledger of Guilds (HM's LoG for short) that serves as an authority over all the



various guilds. LoGs authority gets a little convoluted, as the monarch is officially their head but the guilds and other BYECK reps effectively serve as a power check to sovereign's rule, although it generally works overall. You can normally tell if things are going to turn nasty between a ruler and the BYECK by any new policies being set through LoG that have a design on curtailing guild activities. Many of the affluent guilds and their senior management, such as the Guild of Accountants and Bankers Guild, are housed here, as is the headquarters of the Dusk Watch constabulary (affectionately known as Half Yard, as the architect of the building only designed the original entrance to accommodate the halflings that made up most of the watch at the time).

Residents' Spiral

Almost all of the residents of Heq Moreveg have a home in this quarter, regardless of whether that consists of an apartment shared with several other citizens or one of the large mansions that house the wealthier families of the city. Without any seeming rhyme or reason, ramshackle dwellings of wood and stone butt up against the enclosed manors of the rich and famous. Not that the residents of this spiral really care who their neighbours are. On the whole, the poorer folk look on their richer neighbours as inspiration to improve their own lot, while the wealthier folk tend to use their position to provide opportunities for those less fortunate than themselves.

While there are a few convenience stores, inns, and taverns dotted throughout this spiral, most other businesses are housed in the Trader's Spiral. Notable enterprises and locations include Hasten, a messenger service employing pixies and watercolours, Orange Pinafore, a meal delivery service, the Heavenly Academy of Martial Arts, *not* to be confused with marital arts, and the Town Squarespace, where all gatherings and meetings are held.

The various thieves' guilds tend to focus their operations elsewhere also, unless a particularly wealthy individual has chosen to use their affluence as a means disadvantage those around them. Whenever this happens, the thieves' guilds will collaborate to 'redistribute' the wealth of the guilty party, which continues until they either make reparations or their assets have been completely divested — whether coin, jewellery, or shares, the criminal organisations have ways of stripping the lot. There are more than a few cautionary tales of stubborn nobles being left as paupers, their holdings having been picked clean like a carcass being nibbled at by rats.

Traders' Spiral

As its name suggests, the Trader's Spiral houses the majority of Heq Moreveg's businesses. A lively set of docks and jetties provide mooring for the balloons and skyships that bring goods and trade from the nations and city states up on the rim. There is also a terminus here for the various



companies that use the thicker strands of the web as highways to provide transport to jumping off points in the caverns and tunnels of the Lower Rim (the layer of rock and earth that the topsoil of the rim sits upon), while plenty of inns and taverns provide food and accommodation for new arrivals.

With businesses operating throughout each of the daily cycles, the Traders' Spiral is even more of a raucous hive of activity than the Residents' Spiral. Although almost any enterprise imaginable can be found in this area, notable premises include Al and Dean's Artefact Shop, Mrs Cockle's Codpiece Emporium, Quickshot's Crossbow Delicatessen, Boarfindle's Dwarf Spirits, and Grimlick's Animal Avatars and Familiars for Persons of a Magical or Sorcerous Persuasion.

Orcs & Oubliettes

Hail constables! And welcome to your first night on the Watch. Grab your tabard... not that one, that's the chef's apron. Yes, we do feed you but not until later, so stay focussed... Soggoth, is it? Now where was I? Ah yes, uniform. Hmm, thinking about it, we might need to find a bigger leather shirt, and maybe a fencepost in place of a truncheon for you, big fella. Everyone suited and booted? Good, good. Just enough time for a guided tour of the Watch Station before your rounds start. Follow me...

Orcs & Oubliettes is an epic adventure spread across three entertaining acts. If you intend to be a Hero in this tale, stop now before reading any further! This introduction and the rest of the chapter provide all of the details your Director needs to run the adventure. No need to spoil the fun for yourself, just enjoy the ride as it unfolds.

The story opens as so many of the routine shifts for the Dusk Watch do: clocking into the Watch Station, donning uniform, listening to the daily brief, and prepping for routine patrols. It isn't long, however, before this particular shift takes a dramatic turn. Three loud, repeating whistle blasts echo through the streets, signifying a Watch member in trouble. The shrill notes lead the Heroes to the Perturbed Dragon Tavern, a popular alehouse famed for the access it provides to part of the Underweb. Investigations reveal that Unipollen, an emissary from the Twoeys, a warlike plant species from the rim, has been kidnapped and dragged into the dungeon below the tavern. With the emissary's Dusk Watch escort worse for wear and the Heroes first on scene, it's up to them to enter the Underweb, rescue Unipollen, and prevent a diplomatic incident with a bunch of carnivorous plants.



Unfortunately, it seems Unipollen has become somewhat maddened by their kidnapping. In a confused melee, Unipollen turns on both their abductors and the Heroes. Another Dusk Watch patrol arrives shortly after the fray and the Heroes are asked to remain on site until a city Arbitrator can attend. They may be able to gather some of their own clues but Arbitrator Tarterci doesn't take too long looking around before declaring that the Heroes murdered Unipollen. Without much ado, they are whisked off to the Monarch's Spiral, given a hasty trial by Duchess Mattia, the royal counsellor to Revenger, and thrown into the Orphic Oubliette—the strange interdimensional pocket where the city's worst criminals and vilest secrets are thrown. An encounter with some friendly orcs and the real Unipollen eventually leads to them claiming the fabled Dragonseur and their freedom. Time to take their clues to the one person who can clear their name: Heq Moreveg's sorcerous monarch, Revenger.



The Heroes will need to use a combination of stealth, cunning, and brute force to gain an audience with Revenger. After listening to their evidence, the cunning monarch admits that events were planned to spark a war between Heq Moreveg and the Twoeys. Once the conflict ensued, the monarch's top advisor would have stepped in to scour the plants from Webworld. How? Mattia the Gatekeeper is really a dragon, and she wants nothing more than to take control of Heq Moreveg so that she can return the whole planet to earlier times when dragons ruled the land. Revenger is banking on the Heroes using the Dragonseur to rid him of his dragon problem so that he can get back to ruling the city on his own. Once she's outed, however, Mattia throws a huge temper tantrum and tries to burn the city from the web. It's up to the Heroes to organise the residents against the blaze. Then all they need to do is tackle a dragon. Luckily for them, they have the perfect weapon for the job!

Act One: The Portal Yawns

Heq Moreveg, a vibrant metropolis at the centre of a web filled with all manner of species. One the Heroes are tasked with patrolling as part of the thin brown silver strand tasked with keeping law and order in the bustling city.

Although Directors can run this adventure with the Heroes as raw recruits to the Dusk Watch if they prefer, it's assumed that they've been on the beat for a little while now. They have regular patrol routes, know all the usual

suspects, are regularly gifted sweets as a thanks for their service by Mrs Cockle of Mrs Cockle's Codpiece Emporium, and always get side-eyed by the staff at Chiselwick's Poisoners' Guild. They also know all of the back alleys of their particular neighbourhood and have a fair appreciation of the streets patrolled by neighbouring Watch Stations.

Expanding the Patrol

This chapter provides the main events for *Orcs & Oubliettes* in a fairly linear fashion, which can happen at a pretty breakneck pace if you hop straight from scene to scene. If you'd like to build on the main storyline or even expand sideways to allow the Heroes a chance to ground themselves beforehand, however, feel free to do so! Running a few shifts for the Heroes with some fun incidents that introduce them to one or two of the more colourful characters of the Veils is one option. A couple of run-ins with the thieves' guilds, a friendly rivalry with another Watch Station over a particular case, and a visit to Half Yard for some hands-on training are also fine choices to indirectly expand the plot, ground the Heroes in the daily workings of Heq Moreveg, and establish some Extras that might be able to have an input later in the story.

Watch Station 12-and-1-Half

As members of the Dusk Watch, the Heroes are all part of the constabulary designated to Watch Station 12-and-1-Half. It used to be designated as Watch Station 13, but after the first and second Watch Stations of that name collapsed into a sinkhole of the Underweb, and the third fell over and collapsed into a fresh sinkhole after catching fire in the Great Blaze of 666, the Dusk Watch decided that the station's label might be unlucky and opted to rename it.

A three-storey, detached affair that stands on a plot of land at the centre of a terminus of three streets in the Veils neighbourhood of the Resident's Spiral, Watch Station 12-and-1-Half follows a layout similar to most other stations. The ground floor has a barred reception window for residents wishing to speak to a constable, desks and an office for administrators, constables, and the Duty Watch Officer, plus a small armoury of various weapons and armour. Much to the chagrin of the administrators thanks to the dust that continually sifts down when combat drills are taking place, the



first floor is home to training and briefings. The second floor incorporates a laboratory for forensics, although, due to the facts that the discipline is still considered to be the realm of pseudo-technobabble and most laboratories are often claimed by spellcasters seconded from the Watchful Order of Witches and Warloques, little scientific investigation actually takes place in them. Finally, the basement level contains several cells.

FLI on the Wall

Being shunted out of their workspace has led forensic location investigators (FLIs) into quietly clubbing together and taking up residence in a building wholly dedicated to their art. Situated right next to Half Yard and somewhat unironically named Full Disclosure, the building is a hive of activity dedicated to producing anonymous tip-offs that nudge constables towards solving complex cases. The FLIs liken themselves to their namesake, delicately flitting the city's web and gathering clues about the environment without getting stuck in its strands. Weirdly, a FLI always seems to be on hand on the rare occasions that one is called for, almost as if they know when they're needed.

A Night Unlike Any Other

After clocking on for the night and donning the trappings of their chosen profession, the Heroes settle in for their shift briefing. If the player of Captain Phanta feels comfortable enough doing so, they are more than welcome to deliver it. If not, the eternally jovial goblin, Sergeant Virgule, delivers it in his characteristic gravelly baritone.

Ok. Ok. Settle down! Seems like nothing new to report today. We still have a backlog of paperwork thanks to the Twocanmoons and their impromptu displays. Old Mr Jones has filed a noise complaint against the squirrels in Viscid Park. Again. We are still on the lookout for the Blusher Thief. Even the guilds are getting antsy about this one, as the rouge operator appears to be operating without any of their approval. Finally, Commander Liana has confirmed that our whistles will be getting supplemented with bells at some time in the future, so expect some training plans to cover that soon. Right. That's it for tonight. Have a good one!

It seems like it'll be a night just like any other. Just as the Heroes are prepping for the first patrol of the night, however, the shrill blast of a Watch whistle pierces the relative calm of the night. Three sharp notes with a pause, repeating over and over. Someone from the Dusk Watch is under attack and in need of assistance!



Somewhat Perturbed

As it's the very start of the adventure and we don't want the Heroes to miss getting drawn in, following the whistle blasts to the Perturbed Dragon Inn should be fairly easy. If this the very first game of *ACE!* that your group has played, feel free to call for a Smarts 10 roll so folks can get used to both the dice pool system and recommending which skill and/or special ability they might like to employ for the roll.

As the Veils neighbourhood forms part of the Resident Spiral's border with the Trader's Spiral and the Perturbed Dragon Inn sits just inside the perimeter of the latter, it's only a short hop and skip for the Heroes to reach the distinguished tavern. So short,

in fact, that they're the first responders on the scene by a country mile. Lucky them!

There are a fair few patrons milling around the square outside the two-storey inn when the Heroes arrive. All of them are very helpful and immediately point the constables to Perturbed Dragon's interior. Many of them are confused as to the actual events and excitedly babble amongst each other. There are plenty of comments such as 'Did you see what happened? Folks just started screaming so we ran!' and 'It was all over so fast! That Twoey was enjoying a glass of honey one minute and then gone the next'.

If any of the Heroes ask who or what a Twoey is at this point, you can ask for a Smarts 20 roll. If they succeed, they know that Twoeys are a species of carnivorous plant that live on the rim. Known to feast on flesh and thirst for blood, drinking honey seems a little odd for one of their genus (although technically it could be considered cannibalism to some degree).

Constable Down!

The inside of the inn is a shambles of overturned furniture and broken crockery. The Perturbed Dragon's proprietor, a gnome called Faddy Grouse, is bemoaning the state of her furnishings and tending to a human Dusk Watch sergeant who is unconscious on the floor. A discarded Watch whistle lays on the floor beside

the pair, and Faddy hastily explains that Sergeant Thoros asked her to sound the alarm after being laid low by a group of cloaked and hooded hoodlums. Although she can't be sure, Faddy thinks the thugs sprang from the inn's old cesspit that provides access to the Underweb, which is exactly where they returned to after subduing Thoros and the Twoey he had been escorting. A trail of leaves, sap, and the odd blood splatter that leads to the widened entrance in one of the former downstairs latrines seems to corroborate her story, and also intimates that the prickly plant gave as good as it got.

Bringing Thoros around or checking his credentials uncovers the fact that he is part of a Half Yard security team that provide escort to visiting dignitaries. The fact that he was tasked with providing protection to Unipollen can be gleaned from either himself (if brought round) or a scroll containing his orders found inside his jerkin. If he's awake, Thoros can relate that the seriousness of the kidnapping will lead to a diplomatic incident with the Twoeys at the very least or even all-out war. Alternatively, if the Heroes don't revive Thoros, Faddy can be used to relay any number of rumours and tidbits she's heard concerning Unipollen's visit. Faddy did note that Unipollen was extremely polite and only seemed interested in hearing some songs and drinking some honey, which struck her as odd for someone from a species always portrayed as cruel and bloodthirsty.



Into the Depths

If Thoros is unable to coax the Heroes into jumping on the trail of the kidnappers as he's too worse for wear—he will impress on them that they are first on the scene and now responsible for his mission—Faddy will certainly recommend they do so. She assures the Heroes that she'll stay with Thoros until more members of the Watch arrive.

Although the latrine hasn't been used as such for years, the smells coming from the cesspit indicate that something of its former occupation is perhaps stained into the very stones. The hollow to the pit has been widened to provide better access for would-be dungeon delvers, although the Heroes will still need to use a rope or some other method to make the descent. A Smarts 10 roll allows them to spot a barbed iron bolt lodged in the mortar between two stones on the roof of the latrine. The frayed ends of a hemp rope dangling from it indicate it might have been used by the kidnappers, but either way, the Heroes can use it to secure their own rope—if they have one, if not they can always tie some of the inn's bedsheets together, though Faddy won't take this too well.

There are three exits leading into the translucent, steely round tubes of the Underweb from the old cesspit. Picking up the trail of the abductors and choosing the right exit is a Smarts 10 roll but following the tracks after leaving the rather conspicuous mud is a Smarts 20 roll. The Heroes will need 3 successful rolls to catch up to the kidnappers, although they don't need to be consecutive. The strange twists and turns of the Underweb plus a little backtracking will always provide the Heroes with the opportunity to pick up the trail. Each time they fail a roll, feel free to use the following table to introduce a random encounter. It wouldn't be a dungeon without a random encounter table, right?

1d6 Roll	Random Encounter
1	It's a Trap! Arrows shoot from the walls, spikes spring from the floor and ceiling or something. It's a Hard 20 Moves roll to avoid 2 damage.
2	Webbed! The Heroes run straight into the webs of 2 giant spiders (<i>ACE!</i> p. 26).
3	Lost and Found. The Heroes come across the skeleton of a previous explorer. Beyond some mouldy old clothes, there is also a magic item—choose one item that normally needs a Style roll of 20 or less to acquire.
4	Spider Shrine. Quite appropriately, someone has set up a shrine to An'Ansee in this part of the Underweb. Stopping to honour the spider mother here grants a Hero 1 temporary Karma until the end of the scene. (This can take them above their normal maximum.)
5	Fresh Meat. The Heroes bump into a necromancer who is scouring the surrounds for fresh minions. They seem happy to set their 2 zombies on the Heroes in the hopes of creating more. (<i>ACE!</i> p. 27 and 28).
6	How? An underground casino run by goblins. They won't be interested in a fight but will definitely offer bribes for the Heroes to look the other way and forget they ever saw the place.

Sapped!

The Heroes catch up with the kidnappers at a Y-junction of the Underweb. A Smarts 10 roll will pick up on the clashes and screams of battle as they approach. Although the combat would normally keep the abductors distracted and provide the Heroes with an opportunity to approach stealthily, the thugs are well aware that their pursuers will arrive imminently. Because of this, trying to sneak up on them is a Moves 20 roll—it might be best use the troll as a lumbering shield on this occasion.

There is one Mook per Hero, plus a Carnivorous Plant (*ACE!* p. 24 and 25 respectively). Oddly, all of the combatants including the plant turn to fight the Heroes as soon as they arrive, and every last one of them fights to the death. As mentioned earlier, this a fake Unipollen who is actually a doppelganger disguised as the Twoey emissary. The real Unipollen has been passed to another group of kidnappers who are well on their way to the Orphic Oubliette with their charge. Revenger doesn't want the diplomat disposed of just yet as he wants some insurance against Mattia's plan going wrong. Nothing like a bit of forward thinking to help close loose threads later in the plot!

The Heroes may be puzzled as to why the Twoey has turned on them. The plant attacks them in a frenzy, almost as if it's caught in a bloodlust. Even so, they may still try talking it down. You can have them make a Style 40 roll if they attempt this but even if they succeed, the Twoey will only stop long enough to guzzle a liquid that has the consistency of honey. The vicious shrub then wilts and dies a few short rounds after this.

More members of the Dusk Watch arrive on the scene a few minutes after the combat ends. Likely just as confused as the Heroes over the scene before them, the patrol's leader, a stickler named Captain Narbuckle, asks for the Heroes to remain on site until an Arbitrator can be summoned to examine the scene. Evidently, the violent and bloody death of a visiting dignitary warrants a little more serious attention than your average duo of serial exhibitionists.

Act Two: Betrayed!

On site at the scene of a slaughter of their own making, the Heroes will have a little bit of time to gather some clues before the arrival of a city Arbitrator.

Strange Signs

Although he's a by-the-book dwarf who won't allow the Heroes to wander away from the scene until the Arbitrator clears their departure, Captain Narbuckle will allow the Heroes to search the area for any clues that might help their cause when it comes to explaining events. He only agrees to this, however, if they allow him to carefully shadow their investigation. After a five-minute search and a successful Smarts 20 roll, the main clues to be found are:

- ⊙ Depending on the number of Mooks involved, the kidnappers include an elf, a gnome, a human, and an orc. They all wear brown leather jerkins and long, hooded cloaks. Each thug wears a pendant that looks like a dragon claw covered in flame.

- ③ Unipollen seems to be bleeding green blood, rather than sap. Captain Narbuckle will posit that this is because the plant feasts on flesh, but astute Heroes may recall the trail of sap leading from the Perturbed Dragon.
- ③ Although the kidnappers have the odd scratch and minor nibble mark from the Twoey's vicious maws, Unipollen's only wounds are the result of the Heroes' attacks.

There will be much tutting, muttering and raising of bushy eyebrows from Captain Narbuckle during the whole time the Heroes are investigating.

The Distinct Order of the Gatekeeper's Wrath

The kidnappers are all members of a secret cult called the Distinct Order of the Gatekeeper's Wrath, a bunch of dragon worshippers in awe of Mattia's majesty who are wholly dedicated to seeing her once again take her place at the top of the food chain. The abductors are all rank-and-file members drawn from the streets of Heq Moreveg but the cult itself boasts disciples at every level of society, including the current monarch, Revenger. Although it only has a fixed role for the purpose of this tale, the cult would make an excellent faceless antagonist for further adventures in Heq Moreveg.

The Killer Catcher

Arbitrator Tarterci arrives either towards the end or shortly after the Heroes finish their own investigation, bringing several other Watch patrols with him. Assuming the Heroes take the time to do so of course. They might just prefer to sit around and swap crime stories for all we know. Everyone falls silent and shivers without really knowing why when the Arbitrator slips into the scene. A short human dressed in a black morning suit with lank hair trapped under a battered top hat, Arbitrator Tarterci's sallow features, bulbous nose, and red-rimmed eyes only add to his decidedly villainous appearance. Slinking around the scene and seeming to sniff the air, Tarterci soon states: 'There are murderers here somewhere. I can smell them'.

The Arbitrator waves a hand towards the Heroes, which prompts half of the new Watch arrivals to sheepishly herd them into a group and stand guard over them. He then studiously ignores anything they say as he quietly slinks around the



scene taking in the clues. Seeming to find all the evidence he needs, he spins on the Heroes and states: 'Guilty! Revenger will have your teeth for a necklace and your eyeballs for earrings. Take them away'.

Even more of the Dusk Watch gather around the Heroes at that statement, while a somewhat sullen-looking Captain Narbuckle holds out several pairs of manacles for them to put on. Narbuckle tries to reassure them that a fair trial is in order. He's seen enough here to understand that things aren't as clear cut as Tarterci is making them out to be but warns that the courtroom is the place to argue out the facts. The Arbitrator simply gives them all an evil smile at that. Cure more shivers.

Whether at this point or sometime during or after the trial with Mattia, it's entirely possible that the Heroes try to make a break for it in the hopes of clearing their name later. Although it should very much seem like impossible odds for them, try to roll with it if they do choose this option. A dramatic escape might seem like it'll derail the story but a few tweaks here and there can keep the core plot intact. Instead of being *thrown* into the Orphic Oublette, for instance, the Heroes might sneak around investigating the Distinct Order of the Gatekeeper's Wrath and decide they need to explore there thanks to clues they find along the way. The benefits of maintaining the Heroes' sense of agency will far outweigh the little extra work needed to accommodate any necessary changes because of it. Be like a spider and prepare to spin new threads!

Guilty as Charged

Rather than being remanded in custody as protocol would require, the Heroes are brought straight to Heqqle's Redoubt and hustled into the offices of Revenger's royal counsellor, Duchess Mattia. Resplendent in a royal purple dress that contrasts her flaming red hair, the bored looking noblewoman spends most of her time staring thoughtfully out of her window as the facts of the case are described to her by Tarterci. He posits that Unipollen had already overcome their captures and was making good their escape when the Heroes arrived on the scene and set about butchering them. The Heroes will have a chance to argue their case but to no avail, as a clearly disinterested Mattia orders them thrown into the Orphic Oublette for their crimes. She does, however, take the time to



impress on them the serious repercussion of their murderous deed: a devastating war with the Twoeys.

The Orphic Oubliette should prompt another shudder from the Heroes, for it is commonly known to be a terrible punishment reserved for the city's worst criminals. A place of no return that nobody has ever escaped from. Well, except for the few times that the celebrated escape artist Barry Pucini managed his much publicised and very spectacular breakouts. Much to the embarrassment of the judiciary, who have since provided assurances that his feats would be impossible to repeat.

Once More Into the Depths

Marched to the mouth of the Orphic Oubliette, which is a pitch-black, vine-entangled maw hidden in a cramped courtyard amongst the labyrinthine passageways, gardens, and enclosures of Heqqle's Redoubt, the Heroes are forced into the pit one by one at the tip of several polearms.

It seems like you plummet for an eternity, with no end in sight to the lightless void around you. In fact, you have no sight at all. Everything is just black. Only the whistling in your ears and wind-induced tears streaming across your cheeks remind you of the fact that you are falling. Just as you begin resigning yourself to the fact that you'll be falling forevermore, you start to feel something brushing against your limbs. Or somethings, more like. Whatever it is that you are hurtling past slowly begins to apply more pressure against your fall, until you finally feel strong arms take hold of your arms and legs, bringing you to a stop. The hands that are holding you suddenly pass you onto new sets of hands, which continues until you are being whisked along sideways by a seemingly endless sea of arms. A faint yellow light begins to glow in the distance, slowly glowing brighter as you approach and bringing the multitude of grey limbs into focus as they speed you forward. Eventually, you shoot from a tunnel in the side of a cavern and enjoy a gentle landing on a cushion of yet more strong grey hands. It's hard to determine where the yellow glow is coming from but as you look around to take in your surroundings, several pairs of hands rise from the sea of fists around you on elongated limbs and come together to shape themselves into a pair of eyes, a nose, and a mouth. A gravelly voice echoes around the chamber: 'Welcome to the Orphic Oubliette. We are the Obliging Arms. How can we help?'.

The Obliging Arms will answer as many of the Heroes' questions as they can. Which is really just limited to the fact that they are now trapped in an interdimensional pocket. The Arms don't know exactly how to escape the Oubliette but they *can* offer to lift the Heroes to one of the three other tunnels that lead out of the chamber they're in. Going back the way they came isn't

possible, as the arms are unable to reach up past the limit at which they caught the Heroes. They want to know what is down the other passages? Good question! The arms will answer with these three cryptic clues.

- ☉ One leads to a mighty weapon from an age long ago. Treasure seekers beware, however, as none have yet bested the mighty beast that guards it.
- ☉ Another leads to salvation, though not necessarily the kind the Heroes may be thinking of.
- ☉ The final path leads to home, though only for the wielders of the ancient weapon. Even then, departure is not guaranteed, as a final challenge still awaits.

Although Oubliettes are meant to be inescapable, deadly, and frustrating, this is a fantasy game in which the players are Heroes. You can make their escape as convoluted or as simple as you like. Sending them to the exit for them to double back and attempt to retrieve the dragonsque only to discover that the orcs at Salvation have it could wear a little thin.

The arms have no knowledge of which tunnel relates to which cautionary clue, they only know the passageways as upper, middle, and lower. You—yes you, the Director—can determine which tunnel leads where before the Heroes choose, or you can let some of the weirdness of the Oubliette creep into play by rolling a die whenever they make a choice: 1-2 Ancient Weapon, 3-4 Salvation, 5-6, Home. Each time a result is used, ignore that result and reroll if comes up when you next make a roll.



Ancient Weapon

The Heroes make their way along a dimly lit tunnel, which slowly begins to get hotter and glow with an increasingly vibrant red glow the further they travel. They eventually arrive in a chamber which is wide island of stone ringed by a thin strip of lava. The tunnel the Heroes exit from forms a bridge over the lava, providing access to the island. Resting on a plain rack that appears purpose-built for the weapon it is holding is a ranseur seemingly made from platinum and carved with intricate

runes. A Smarts 20 roll will indicate that this could be the mighty dragonseur of legend, an ancient artefact forged during the Age of Flame to combat the dragons who seemed intent on razing Webworld to ash with their internecine wars.

Reaching the dragonseur won't be easy, however, for the demon bound to guard the weapon appears as soon as the Heroes set foot on the island. The lava flares and heat intensifies, with flames roaring to block the exit as it says: 'Ah, how wonderful. Fresh meat for the barbecue'.

The Heroes might rush to attack, which means a straight up combat, or they could stop and have a conversation. With a creature from the Abyss. The demon is happy with either but would prefer to coax them into conversation and offer them a bargain. It explains that the dragonseur they can see is a carefully constructed illusion. The pesky orcs of Salvation stole the real one a little while ago. With nothing to guard and fresh meals few and far between, the demon is more than a little bored and simply wants to go home. If they help it, it can give them the answer to one of the two puzzles they'll need to complete to leave the Oubliette. It doesn't need anything too troubling. Just a little trifle really. Maybe just a tiny slither of each of their souls.

In mechanical terms, this equates to the Heroes giving up 1 point of Karma each. In story terms, if you plan on coming back to Webworld and Heq Moreveg in future games, this tiny morsel of spiritual fuel can certainly lead to all sorts of repercussions in future games...

If they agree and give up the Karma, the demon gives the Heroes the answer to the first puzzle they need to complete to leave the Oubliette, then disappears in a blaze of smouldering cinders with a sinister laugh. The lava and flames blocking the exit die down shortly after. If they don't agree, they'll either need to fight and defeat the demon to free up the exit or leap through the flames to escape and suffer 6 points of damage.

Salvation

Salvation is probably far from anything the Heroes had in mind, for it's actually the name of the section of the oubliette that a group of displaced orcs have claimed for themselves—a small collection of stone huts nestled beside a lake in a wide cavern. As an interdimensional pocket, the entrance from Webworld isn't



GUARDIAN DEMON**SMARTS** 5**STYLE** 5 (Persuasion)**POWER** 5 (Fire 7)**MOVES** 3**BRAWN** 8 (Brawling)**Health** 8 **Defence** 9**Firebolt** 7 (2 damage, 30' range)**Fiery Sword** 10 (3 damage plus a Moves 10 roll to avoid catching fire)

the only one that deposits people in the Orphic Oubliette. Persecuted by bands of adventurers on their homeworld for nothing more than history and fiction books labelling them as evil and everyone assuming it to be true, the well-natured orcs of Salvation were travelling ancient tunnels and ended up in the oubliette.

Nestled at the edge of the water with their roots thrust deep into the lake is a very familiar looking Twoey. This, however, is the *real* Unipollen, a mild-mannered Twoey who prefers to feast on the fruits of nature rather than flesh. Unipollen doesn't understand in the slightest why they were kidnapped and dumped here, but they are keen to escape with the Heroes, avert a war, and help the orcs find a new home.

The chief and spiritual leader of Salvation, a male orc named Gortack, welcomes the Heroes to Salvation and explains his tribe's plight over some blood fire ale. Although the cavern they live in provides food, water, and shelter, the small tribe is slowly stagnating and dying off. Gortack is unable to make any difference as travelling here has cut him off from the elemental energies that fuelled his shamanistic powers. If the Heroes describe their own predicament, he will give a deep-throated, toothy laugh and tell them not to worry. He already has the old spear they're looking for in his hut. He managed to overpower the guardian demon and claim it before his powers faded completely. He's happy to hand it over in exchange for the Heroes bringing his handful of tribe members and himself along when they leave the oubliette. Cue some backslapping and more toothy grins!

Home

The final tunnel the Heroes will need to traverse, although it could be one they are revisiting if they've been particularly unlucky, leads to a wide, pillared room which seems so vast as to not have a ceiling. The Heroes will need to face two challenges in this chamber, with the first only able to be overcome if they have the dragonseur in hand.

The first puzzle to overcome is a riddle involving an earth elemental, an air elemental, and the dragonseur. The Heroes find a bridge arching across a chasm of deep lava with the two types of huge elemental patrolling the side they are currently on. Both elementals are largely passive, although they change their state based on certain conditions. A web of force that requires both raw earth and lightning energy in its vicinity to untangle the threads and allow progress is strung between the pillars on the far side of the bridge. Sticky business indeed. The air elemental is becalmed by the dragonseur and won't cross until it's on the far side of the bridge but the earth elemental won't cross until the air elemental is recharged by removing the spear. Figuring out that the dragonseur needs to cross to coax the air elemental across, then the dragonseur needs to return to the original side to coax the earth elemental towards the air on the far side is a Smarts 20 roll. Or you can just roleplay it through trial and error. Either way is cool and is really down to your group's preferences.

When the two elementals are on the far side of the bridge, the web strands strung between the pillars part to reveal a courtyard with more pillars and a single arch in the centre. One short pillar at the start of the courtyard beyond the strands contains the phrase 'water is key', while each of the other pillars contain rotating blocks that show the basic elements of earth, air, fire, and water. Bear with us, it's *Orcs & Oubliettes* for pity's sake, not Mastermind! Spinning each block to show water is the first step but won't open the portal beneath the arch. The Heroes will need to cover up every word except water in the inscription for that to happen. Once they do, hey presto! A portal to the Orphic Oubliette courtyard in Heqqle's Redoubt opens. Time to go home and save the day!

Act Three: Dealing with Dragons

With Unipollen safely in their custody, the Heroes will likely want to clear their names. Oh, and help prevent a rampaging horde of intelligent carnivorous plants from eventually attacking the city, of course. Revenger will help them with their problems, right? What's in a name anyway?

In Search of Revenge(r)

The Heroes step from the portal and straight into the courtyard that holds the entrance to the Orphic Oubliette. As a place that is feared and associated with the worst of punishments, the courtyard is always empty and never guarded. Nobody ever goes out of their way to visit here and nothing that has gone into the yawning portal that leads to the oubliette has ever returned... until now, of course.

Exiting the oubliette and leaving the courtyard is the easy part for the Heroes. Sneaking around with a tribe of orcs at their backs, not so much. For his part, Gortack is happy to undertake any one of several suggestions that may be discussed by the Heroes in relation to the orcs. Probably at length. Might be worth putting the kettle on while they do so. Some of the possible options are covered here:

- ☉ **Incognito:** The Salvation orcs have never been seen in Heq Moreveg before. Nobody knows who they are. The city already has an orc community that has been welcomed in and is wholly part of the population's vibrant culture. Nobody would bat an eyelid at a few more orcs moving around. Well, they might ask why they're wandering around Heqqle's Redoubt, but once clear of there, the Salvation orcs are home free.
- ☉ **Extra Muscle:** Finally free from the oubliette and eternally thankful to the Heroes for releasing them, the Salvation orcs will be more than happy to accompany them as backup while they search for Revenger. Simply use the Stats for orcs on p. 27 of the *ACE!* rulebook. Trouble is, upwards of twenty orcs are far from quiet and their presence imposes a -1d6 to any attempts at stealth.
- ☉ **The Distraction:** Having been couped up for so long, the Salvation orcs will be equally happy to charge around Heqqle's Redoubt making some noise. They aren't out for blood but they do have a lot of energy to burn. Plus what's a few more days in a cell at the end of it after spending so long locked away in a dimensional prison. And the Heroes will come to free them once they clear their names anyway, right? If this last option is chosen, the Heroes gain +1d6 to stealth rolls as the guards are heavily distracted by the orcs.

1d6 Roll	Random Encounter
1	Gatekeeping. Several nobles who are members of the Distinct Order of the Gatekeeper's Wrath are having a meeting in a garden of the Redoubt. If overheard, they are plotting to infiltrate the Guild of Accountants.
2	BYECK! The Heroes chance across an unofficial meeting of BYECK leaders and their guards. If overheard, they appear to be discussing how they can reign in the head of FLI.
3	Family Honour. The Heroes encounter an open crypt in the Redoubt's cemetery. The ghost of Contessa Velna Sams the Third is restless due to the presence of an ancient and powerful entity in the city (Mattia). She can reward the Heroes with a magical item to combat the terrible foe.
4	Guards! Guards! The Heroes encounter 1d6 Redoubtable Guards who are out on patrol (use Soldier or Cop stats in <i>ACE!</i> , replacing pistol with bow for Cop).
5	Phantom Cries. The Heroes bump wander into a haunted part of the Redoubt (noticeable by its lack of cleaning or presence of living persons). The Ghostly Shrieker doesn't appreciate visitors.
6	Charmed, I'm Sure. The Heroes stumble across a group of masked nobles who seem to be enjoying a private party, except they're actually under the influence of a vampire in their midst!

Whichever option they choose in relation to the orcs, the Heroes will need to make their way towards the throne room at the centre of Heqqle's Redoubt. We're writing an exciting pulp adventure here remember, not an expansive novel with world-building that takes place over fourteen volumes so let's keep this simple. The Heroes can sneak their way, try to use brute force, use a little bit of sorcery and charm to smooth talk their way in, or employ a combination of all three. Rather than detail every encounter and minute that passes, we'll let you decide how easy or hard it is for the Heroes to gain an audience with Revenger. We will say, however, that this part of the adventure should be fast-paced, fun and thrilling for the Heroes, with plenty of opportunities to sneak by the guards and nobles or stumble into trouble. As Heqqle's Redoubt is a jumble of architectural projects from multiple previous rulers, the exact path taken is also left to interpretation. Feel free to use this random encounter table to generate some quirky encounters along the way.

The Heroes can leap in through stained glass windows, burst through the huge oak doors, or rappel in from the roof beams. Make sure to reward their progress so far with as grand an entrance as possible to the throne room. The important part is that they actually end up there.

An Audience with the King

When the Heroes arrive, Revenger is deep in conversation with Duchess Mattia. Curiously, he is not sat on his throne but is actually stood a step below the Duchess, looking up to where she is on the platform that the throne sits on. Just an oddity of the moment, surely.

Revenger's royal guard close in to protect his royal personage after the Heroes' grand arrival but he soon waves them away and bids the Heroes to approach. It can be easily noted that he has an arrogant cast to his features and a mischievous gleam in his eyes. Revenger bids the Heroes to speak and allows them to continue uninterrupted as they state their case. For her part, Duchess Mattia continues to look disinterested and bored by the interruption. With their dialogue out of the way, Revenger begins to clap slowly and then states the following:

"Bravo! Who knew that a handful of the Watch might actually be competent at their jobs. Yes, you have uncovered a grand conspiracy that leads all the way to the heart of this very throne room. I put the plans into motion that led to the Twoey being kidnapped and yourselves being thrown into the Orphic Oubliette but it wasn't me that plotted these events. There is a greater power behind the throne, you see. One that even I, the great Revenger, is beholden to. And now you have the means in your grasp to release us all from its malevolent grasp before she returns us to the terrifying days when giant wyrms ruled the web. Mattia the Gatekeeper is actually a dragon. Slay her!"



At Revenger's word, Mattia's disinterested look rapidly shifts into one of rage and fury. Shockingly, her form and clothes shift almost as rapidly as her features into the form of an enormous red dragon. Bellowing in fury, Mattia releases a blast of flame at the throne room's roof that blasts an enormous hole into the structure. Have the Heroes make a Smarts or Style 20 roll at this point, with anyone who fails paralysed by fear and awe for 1d6 rounds. Enraged, Mattia bellows the following as she snatches up the sorcerous king and soars through the hole in the roof:

"You fool, Revenger! What you don't understand is that I don't need this city to rule Webworld. Now watch as I burn it from the web entirely!"

Caught in the downdraft of Mattia's wings as she shoots away with dust and chaos swirling around them, the Heroes will undoubtedly be in shock. Thankfully, the screams from the city that reach their ears soon after will snap them out of their shock.

For Whom the Bell Tolls

Mattia wastes no time in strafing the city with her flames. Completely surprised by the attack and in no way prepared for an assault by an ancient and powerful dragon, nobody in Heq Moreveg can mount any kind of defence against her attacks. As the city and webs burn, most citizens either begin huddling in rubble and smoke strewn alleyways or else charging around in panic looking for loved ones. This includes common and noble folk alike. Someone in Watch Station 14 seems to remember their training and begins tolling the fire warning bell but it isn't long before the dolorous donging draws Mattias's ire and the Watch Station is burnt to the ground. In the months after the battle, the Dusk Watch put together a play to remember the heroics of the Watch Station members and prisoners that faced down the dragon's fury. Named Assault on Watch Station 14, it becomes surprisingly popular and features regularly at a day of remembrance held each year.

But we digress. Mattia is angry. Really angry. And she wants to burn the city from the web. In between strafing the city with her flames, she begins to attack the strands that holds the slab which the city is built upon. These breaks in her destructive passes across the city will allow the Heroes an opportunity to begin organising its residents and either getting them to safety or rallying them to tackle the flames. The citizens becoming more orderly and less panicked will further stoke Mattia's ire and force her to seek out the organisers—namely, the Heroes! Time for them to put their best dragon-slaying trousers on!

There are several actions the Heroes will need to take before Mattia comes looking for them. If they end up scratching their heads and wondering what to do in the throne room, the head of Dusk Watch, a gnome named Commander Tauria Prendebower, can arrive at the throne room to investigate what has happened. She can then be used to offer guidance on next steps and even take some action herself.



- ☉ **Keen Eyes:** The burglars and footpads of the various thieves' guilds are good at spotting their next opportunity. They will make excellent eyes and ears in the search and rescue of refugees. The Heroes can head to the see the leader of the guild that operates in their own quarter of the Residents' Spiral, the Benevolent Brokers, to get the ball rolling. Fronted by a pawn shop, the Brokers will need to be convinced with some sort of tax incentive or other arrangement around their activities. You can boil this down to a Style 20 roll if you like but it would act as a tense social encounter. Who doesn't like dealing with thieves!
- ☉ **Powerful Magic:** As it's called the Watchful Order of Wizards and Warloques, it's a given that the order has plenty of magic users amongst its membership. With their laboratories and magical creations at risk, you'd think it would be fairly easy to convince them to help raise magical shields or summon deluges of water against the dragon fire. Trouble is, they're a fractious lot who like keeping their own secrets. The heads of the various factions in the order can be summoned together at their headquarters, Hugwurts School of Magic and Mystery. Convincing them to work together is a tall order that but offering them something like ownership of the Dragonseur once the crisis is over may just sway them.
- ☉ **Steady Hands:** The Heroes already have access to the best form of defence against a deadly blaze... the Dusk Watch! Not just trained to uphold the law, they also serve as an impromptu fire brigade (sidenote: BYECK did try to establish an independent fire brigade after a disastrous ritual involving a large number of the Watchful Order of Witches and Warloques but the motion wasn't successful).

Commander Predebower won't need any convincing to begin organising the watch, she just needs to be tracked down. Luckily, she might already be with the Heroes if they needed a prompt to get moving and organising.

- Wicked Minds:** The League for Rehab of Fantasy Villains has a roster that's chock full of former criminals with certain skill sets. It also boasts a number of masterminds who once had their own plans for Webworld domination. One of those villains, Geronimous Blofelden, built an airship empire transporting goods between Heq Moreveg and the rim after retiring from his super-villainous activities. He can be convinced to send his fleet of airships aloft to battle Mattia with their catapults. All that's required is arranging a seat on BY'ECK for him...

The actual order that the Heroes use to tackle these objectives isn't important. A sense of urgency around their completion can be added through narrative. There is a blooming great big dragon rampaging across the city after all. Tremors wracking the city from the strands supporting it beginning to fray, buildings collapsing as the flames consume them, and a mounting death toll are just some of the descriptions that can be used to usher the Heroes along towards the final climactic battle.

Mattia comes looking for the Heroes once they have completed their final task. How does she know these are the Heroes she's looking for? Well, she has an entire cult at her disposal still, some of whom will be hidden in the ranks of the places the Heroes are visiting. Once word reaches the upper echelons of the Distinct Order of the Gatekeeper's Wrath, the leaders of the order will use a telepathic link to inform Mattia of the Heroes' antics and position. Time for one final battle!

Mattia breathes a blast of flame and she swoops in to land, then goes straight on the attack. Hopefully, the Heroes bring

Shell Shocked

It's entirely possible that the Heroes are at a loss over what to do about the enormous dragon tearing the city apart. Or, equally, their negotiations with the various parties that can help to save the city might not come to fruition. While Commander Predebower can help with both issues, poor outcomes could still spell disaster for everyone in Heq Moreveg, the Heroes included! Using a little Director fiat here, you can have An'Ansee step in to help at this point. She certainly won't be too impressed at the rubble and detritus of an entire city falling onto her abdomen, after all. If things do go badly, the whole web shudders as An'Ansee shoots a thread of webbing from her spinneret towards Mattia. Although the dragon deftly dodges, strands become entangled in her wings and force her to the ground. Now all that's needed is some brave Heroes in possession of a dragon-slaying ranseur to tackle her. Seen any of those around anywhere?

the Dragonseur to bear against her, which halves her Defence against attacks made with it and inflicts double damage on a successful attack (4 instead of the normal 2).



Aftermath

Hopefully the city isn't a smoking ruin that is slowly sliding along An'Ansee's enormous abdomen. It isn't right? With Mattia slain and the city not just saved but also united—for now at least—the Heroes can rightly bask in their status as the saviours of Heq Moreveg. Although the city mourns and rebuilding needs to get underway, there will certainly be a celebration, promotions, and medals to take care of. The day itself becomes entrenched as another day of remembrance for the city. Rather than name it after a destructive force, BY'ECK unanimously agree to name the holiday Unity Day.

With the party and medals out of the way, the Heroes are soon back on the beat of their familiar watch. Trouble is, they truly are Heroes now, and their celebrity status brings all sorts of additional boons and problems...





ACE!
Issue 7

DOMES OF THUNDER

WALT CIECHANOWSKI

We May Need Another Hero...



It's the year 2020, give or take. Or maybe 2030. Who knows? Well, not *our* 2020, as apocalyptic as it seemed. In this world, our whole civilization, with its skyscrapers, nightclubs, and being stuck in the rat race, destroyed and replaced by bleak wastes, water hoarders, and, well, betting on rat races. In essence, the world was flushed in the toilet and what little order remains in the waste is under constant threat from marauding gangs looking for gas.

But this waste is home. Or at least that's what you keep telling yourself as you drive over the old roads protected only by your vehicle and what weapons you've scrounged. The world outside your reinforced windows is a perpetual Burning Man festival, all leathers and fetish gear kissed by desert sand. Everyone is a threat; even friends

can flip for the promise of clean water or a gallon of gas. That's why you don't have any friends.

No, if there's one thing you've kept from the world before is that you just look out for Number One and you are willing to step on anyone who gets in your way. Or at least that's what you keep telling yourself. The truth is, you can't just walk away when you see people in trouble or some punk who thinks they can take what they want because they have the means. No, you'll rise to the occasion because, deep down, you still have a heart.

You'll just be damned if you let anyone see it.

Waste Warriors

While types of postapocalyptic fiction vary greatly, *Domes of Thunder* concentrates on a specific type of postapocalyptic tale, the wasteland road trip. The heroes undertake a dangerous mission across a blasted landscape. There is plenty of action as they confront challenges and enemies along the way, guarding a precious cargo until they can deliver it to their destination. This is the setting in which the Heroes find themselves.

For you, the Boom happened a few decades ago. Bombs fell, plagues ran rampant, civilization collapsed, and the surviving humans now share the world with cyborgs and mutants. You remember little of the world before, having been too young or perhaps not even born until after the collapse. You have been forged in the fire of ruin, learning skills and honing instincts that enable you to survive in a lawless land. You are a waste warrior.

Overview

This book is divided into two sections:

SETTING THE STAGE: The first part of this book, the part that you're already reading, introduces the setting and the tools you'll need to bring *Domes of Thunder* to life. This includes some Hero options to help you create a team of waste warriors and a new rule or two to reinforce the genre. It also provides an adventure synopsis.

DOMES OF THUNDER: This is the actual adventure that the synopsis laid out. We wouldn't be surprised if you stray a bit from what the synopsis expects, but unless your players are really looking for something different then they're probably going to follow the three acts. We round out this book with suggestions for further adventures.

Synopsis

Domes of Thunder is about, well, domes of thunder. But it's quite a bit more than that. The entire adventure revolves around domes of thun- okay, more like electrified cages that fighters do battle in. A local warlord known as the Saint is hosting a big tournament, known as the Lectric Buggalu, to dispense gifts. Fighters come from many isolated communities to participate.

Paradise City, however, is not a participant, nor are they beholden to the Saint. What they are beholden to, however, is a plague known as the Bleeding Fever. There is a cure, but Paradisians can't manufacture it. Instead, they sent word to the laboratories at Heartbeat City. Heartbeat's Scientific Council sent the cure, but the truck was captured by the Saint.

Paradise City has no choice but to send a fighter and pray that he can convince the Saint to part with the drug. The fighter's manager isn't so certain of the plan and decides to hire mercenaries – the heroes – to use the tournament to steal back the truck. Unfortunately, the fighter runs afoul of a mutant and gets killed, leaving the heroes to try and fulfil the plan on their own.

After dealing with a mutant biker gang along the way, the heroes make it to the Saint's compound, which is the ruin of an old regional mall. The truck is parked inside the outer walls, but the Heroes gain access through a night-time ball that takes place within the gate. With a little luck, they should secure the truck and drive it out of the compound.

Unfortunately, the Saint is not about to let the insult go unanswered. She sends her ORCS, along with her fearsome 'Dragon,' to kill the Heroes and return the truck and its contents to her. Only by destroying this gang of maulers can the Heroes complete their mission and bring the life-saving drug to Paradise City!

Creating Your Own Waste Warriors

The 'lone gunslinger' archetype might be great for film, but you've got a table full of waste warriors that don't want to be clones (that's a different genre)! Your Heroes can take either a species or an occupation as a Role.

Waste-Born

The Boom created, mutated, or shaped entirely new types of humans. We've listed some recommended Roles from *ACE* #1 below. You can also pick a talking animal; it's up to you whether it is a normal looking but intelligent animal or a humanoid variation. Kangaroos are an excellent choice!

Recommended Roles

Barbarian, Outlaw, Bounty Hunter, Cowboy, Doctor, Engineer, Gambler, Hermit, Soldier.

New Roles

CYBORG. Part of your body is replaced with machinery, making you a tough opponent. You may spend a Karma point to make a Brawling attack and do double damage.

DRIVER. You are a wizard of the road, able to push vehicles long after their expiration date across the Waste. You gain the Driving focus for free, in addition to whatever other Focus you choose for your Moves stat.

ENTERTAINER. In a world without smartphones, game consoles, and streaming services, entertainment is in short supply. All eyes are on you when you perform, granting the other Heroes a bonus circumstance die on their non-combat actions while you are performing.

GLADIATOR. You've toughened yourself up for blood sports. Basically, you're an Ogre. You get an extra +1 to your Brawn Stat, and an extra +2 Health.

MECHANIC. You keep the machines running, even when they are falling apart around you. For every Karma point you spend, you can scrounge up enough material to repair 1 point of Health to a vehicle. This takes you a round, but you can spend as much Karma as you like.

MUTANT. The Boom has granted you special abilities. You have a Power stat, although you don't get extra points to distribute.

SURVIVALIST. You know your way through the wastes. You never get lost and you can always secure enough food and adequate shelter for you and your friends.

WARRIOR. Anyone that sees you knows that you are a true Wasteland Warrior. You gain the Armor focus for free, in addition to whatever other Focus you choose for your Moves stat.



Rules of the Wasteland

You didn't think that a few new Roles were the only thing needed to enforce the genre? We didn't think so! The following are new rules to help you and your fellow Heroes navigate the Waste in *Domes of Thunder*!

The postapocalyptic world follows the Rule of Cool. Heroes on motorcycles look awesome in driving leathers with various metal bits attached; wasteland raiders look fearsome in spiky pads, belts, and not much else. Guardians of communities might dress like medieval knights; while astronauts recently returned to Earth might find their spacesuits still offer some protection.

Gun Control

Guns are difficult to maintain, and ammunition is scarce in the Waste. Thus, Heroes and Extras alike are limited to weapons that add 2 damage, with an exception for the occasional sword or chainsaw that does 3. More lethal weaponry such as guns only enters the adventure if your Director places them there.

Your Director does have the option of granting you a gun with a few bullets to start the adventure. In this case, you must spend a Karma point to use a bullet. You'd better make those shots count!



Vehicles

Domes of Thunder is a road trip, not a nature hike! You're going to need cars, motorcycles, trucks, and armored RVs! Fortunately, this is the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* and not *Mechanics and Machines*, so we only need to go into enough detail to keep things moving (groanworthy pun intended!)

Vehicles in *Domes of Thunder* are rarely pristine examples of their original design. Instead, they are patched and modified to operate in the dangerous Waste, most of them barely held together with ill-fitting parts and duct tape. Thus, Heroes shouldn't be too worried about losing a vehicle, as chances are that they will find a reasonable replacement somewhere along the way. Let's just hope that there aren't any used car salesmen around!

Acquiring and Filling a Vehicle

Domes of Thunder is a setting where life is hard, and vehicles are scavenged. Heroes aren't assumed to start an adventure with a vehicle unless they can pay the cost (i.e., roll the difficulty) listed on the Vehicles table. Also, at the start of each act, a hero must make a Style 15 roll to have enough gas to run their vehicle for the remainder of the Act.

These limitations don't apply to the adventure itself. Vehicles found or captured are presumed to have enough gas in them to run for the remainder of a scene and a Hero may siphon gasoline from one vehicle into another (unless your Director wants to have fun with gasoline vs diesel!).

Vehicle Stats

Vehicles have stats just like Heroes, but they're a little different. Every vehicle has the following stats:

BASH. Vehicles can usually take and dish out a lot of punishment. Thus, a driver uses the Vehicle's Bash stat when ramming a car or running over a pedestrian. Bash is also used to determine the vehicle's Health.

STEERING. Some vehicles are more maneuverable than others. A vehicle's steering rating is the bonus die or penalty die applied to a Driving roll.

PLATING. Vehicles can take more punishment than a Hero; some weapons don't do any damage at all. Whenever a vehicle takes damage, its Plating stat is subtracted from the damage. If the new total is 0 or less, then the vehicle takes no damage. That's not to say that a pistol or a rifle can't make the side of a car look like Swiss cheese, only that, as far as the car is concerned, such damage is only cosmetic.

TYPICAL WASTELAND VEHICLES

Type	Cost	Health	Bash	Steering	Plating	Notes
Dune Buggy	20	5	3	+1	2	Or any largely open air vehicle, including sedans with missing roofs or doors
Cycle	25	2	3	+2	2	Also works for trikes and ATVs
Sedan	30	15	4	0	3	Really any car
Truck	35	25	5	0	3	Also works for vans
Bus	50	25	6	-2	3	Also works for RVs
Semi	50	30	6	-2	3	Without a trailer, the Semi only has -1 Steering

Targeting Passengers

As stated above, Heroes in vehicles usually must rely on their Driving focuses when being attacked, but sometimes a vehicle provides protection to those aboard. If your Hero is completely covered (i.e. in a car, but not on a bike), then they receive the benefit of Plating should they be hit. If the Extra is trying to shoot around the plating, then the Director may impose an appropriate circumstance penalty.

Who Maintains the Roads?

One fun criticism of zombie apocalypses (or indeed, apocalypses in general!) is that the lawns of abandoned houses always seem to be maintained, despite needing at least biweekly mowing in the real world! This is, of course, due to filming limitations, and a similar pattern is seen in wasteland road trips. The paved roads always seem reasonably well-maintained for lack of maintenance crews.

Domes of Thunder runs with this trope. Paved roads may be cracked and potholed, but vehicles can easily navigate them, and the many dirt roads are packed enough to

What about Speed?

ACE! is a cinematic game of fast and furious action; Directors aren't required to break out battle mats when Heroes get into trouble. Vehicle duels are no different; we don't expect you to break out the minis and measure hexes or squares. Also note that, in the post-Boom, there are rarely long stretches of unbroken road that allow vehicles to travel at full speed. You think you have trouble getting potholes filled in the present, who's filling them and removing road debris in the Waste?

With all these factors, catching up to a vehicle or leaving one in the dust is more a question of maneuverability than speed. Thus, Driving rolls are still modified by Steering stats rather than using a Speed stat.

enable vehicles to drive over them as well. This accounts for why a vehicle's speed doesn't overly matter; everyone is slowing and maneuvering around the obstacles littering the road.

We leave it up to you to decide how barren your Wasteland is. If you want to set your adventure in the desert or plains, then roads are almost meaningless – vehicles simply travel in the direction they want to go until a natural landform gets in the way. If you set your adventure in a more temperate region, then shrubs and trees keep vehicles on roads and trails. Hills and mountains limit land travel to valleys. Whatever you decide, keep in mind that you'll want to assign circumstance penalties of varying intensity depending on how hard it is to travel "off-road."

Driving Duels

While different vehicles have different accelerations and top speeds, we don't worry about that in *Domes of Thunder*. It just wouldn't make for a thrilling chase if one car simply outruns its pursuers! Instead, whether a vehicle catches up to another or can pull away is resolved as an opposed Moves action (and, obviously, someone in a vehicle can either get away from or approach a pedestrian without the need for a roll!).

When making the roll, each participant announces what they are trying to accomplish. You may wish to get alongside the bus, while the bus driver simply wants to stay ahead of you. Action rolls are made, and the winner gets to accomplish what they wanted. Simple, huh? What were you expecting, math?

Spectacular Destruction!

When a vehicle is reduced to 0 Health, it isn't very *Domes of Thunder* if it just stops working. It should crash and burn in spectacular fashion! Make sure to narrate what happens to a vehicle as it gets destroyed – motorcycles slide down the road and get run over, dune buggies flip and roll, sedans are launched into the air or knocked off the side of the road into convenient ditches! Make sure that every vehicle 'death' is unique and memorable!

Don't worry so much about the occupants. Motorcycle riders may be thrown from their bike, but they just dust themselves off and keep going. Sedan drivers slowly and painfully crawl out of the wreckage of an overturned vehicle. The passenger on the bed of a truck leaps to safety. Of course, if you are feeling a little bloodthirsty, that motorcycle rider can get run over, the sedan may explode before the driver clears it, and the truck passenger may leap out only to be impaled on an old signpost. It's your Wasteland!

Disabling Vehicles

Heroes rarely have the means to destroy vehicles (at least not without playing Chicken!) What they do have is the ability to disable them. Puncturing a tire, releasing fuel, and pulling battery cables are all ways to disable a vehicle without destroying it. The intent is simply to take the vehicle and its occupants out of commission.

Whenever you wish to disable a vehicle, you should describe how you wish to accomplish it. Your Director assigns a Difficulty and the appropriate Stat. If you make the task roll, then the vehicle is disabled!

Note that disabling a vehicle doesn't normally affect its occupants. You might blow out a tire, but the Extra affected still may shoot at you! Also, disabling a vehicle doesn't necessarily mean that it stops. Instead, it may continue rolling forward, especially if it is attached to another vehicle!

A disabled vehicle may be repaired with a Smarts check, with the time required and a Difficulty set by the Director. Sometimes it's as easy as pulling a bolt free or reattaching cables. Other times you might have to salvage two or three vehicles and spend a day or two rebuilding an engine!

Domes of Thunder

Okay, enough with the rules, now it's time for the Heroes to put on their chainmail and hockey masks! This adventure follows three main acts, each of which are further divided into scenes.

If you are playing a Hero, then you should stop reading now (well, you should've stopped before the Synopsis, but here we are!) The rest of this book is for the Director's eyes only! And if you do peek, be forewarned that your Director has the authority to change things up and take the adventure in a direction that these acts don't anticipate! Oh, and shame on you for still reading!

Dome Fighting

Dome fighting is a popular sport in the Waste, especially with the Saint's encouragement. Fighters are placed inside a metal cage roughly in the shape of a dome and fight until one submits, is killed, or can otherwise no longer engage. As with an old-school duel, the fighters agree on the weapons, if any, allowed in the fight. The Llectric Buggalu bashes are unarmed, as the Saint doesn't want the winners permanently damaged.

As an extra bonus, many cages are rigged with a battery-powered electrical charge that can shock or kill an opponent. Depending on the level of current, brushing or touching the side of the cage can cause 1-4 points of damage. In some bouts, the level of current randomly changes each round. A fighter that wishes to push another against the cage takes a 2 dice penalty on their Brawn roll. If they succeed, then the damage of the cage is used rather than their usual damage.



Act One: **A City in Need**

Our story opens on a long, cracked interstate before panning to an old rest stop, now known in waste-speak as a 'restie,' where a walled compound now serves a similar purpose. Jin's Restie is a place for travelers to stop, rest, and get a filling – if not particularly tasty – meal on their journey through the wasteland. The restie is protected by a gate and wall manned by at least a dozen crossbow-wielding "guardians" at all times. The gate not only ensures protection, but also keeps those inside from stealing each other's vehicles!

This adventure assumes that the Heroes are just waiting around for a mission (after all, it is your job to give them one!), but if any of them are fighters then it is possible that they are already on their way to the Lectric Buggalu tournament. If so, then you can switch things up. Tucker Welch picks a fight with them first. Hercules and Shelby arrive in their bus as spectators and make the offer after the fight. Just remember if you do this then Hercules must still find some way to offend Tucker!

Welcome to Jin's Restie, an oasis along a crumbling road through the wasteland. Secure as can be from roving gangs behind its makeshift wall of old concrete and steel, you are spending the night enjoying Jin's homemade swill and gruel in the cafeteria. Your server Su offers you a smile and asks a few questions about the world outside the complex as you notice two travelers, both well-muscled beneath their travelling clothes, enter the room. You immediately recognize the male as a fighter, while the woman, no less buff, walks with a slight limp. She scans the room and settles on you as she gestures for the fighter to follow her.

The male is Hercules Ferris, a fighter from Paradise City, and his manager, Shelby Hudson. Shelby was a fighter herself before losing a leg. She replaced it with a prosthetic, but that made her ineligible to fight (only 'unblemished humans' are allowed to participate). Now she is Hercules' manager and trainer.

Shelby asks Sue to get the Heroes another round of drinks before asking to join them. If the Heroes agree, Shelby makes her offer.

"Hercules and I are from Paradise City, which is currently in the grip of the Bleeding Fever. Don't worry. If either of us had it we'd have died long before getting here. The City's only hope is a cure from Heartbeat City that was on its way to us when the Saint hijacked it. She's keeping it in her compound, and we pray that, if Hercules wins the tournament, then he can request it as a gift. I don't put that much faith in her and people's lives are more important than winning some bouts.

Unfortunately, we lost our protectors to the waste gangs getting here. I'd like to hire you to accompany us and ensure that the cure gets to Paradise City.

At this point, the two biggest questions are "What is the Bleeding Fever?" and "Who is the Saint?" For the former, use your imagination! No one is in danger of getting it in this adventure, so we'll let the players conjure horrors in their minds. The only matter of import is that the Science Council of Heartbeat City provided the cure, so the delivery vehicle has their colors. For the latter, it's common knowledge that the Saint is a petty warlord about a day's full ride west of here (or north, east, southwest, or north-northeast – it's your choice!). You can simply tell your players the information in the next two paragraphs, but it's more satisfying to work it into a natural conversation with the travelers and Su.

The Saint's power and prestige is wrapped in fantasy tropes (not exactly, but don't spoil the surprise!). She is said to have an army of orcs to keep order and elf spies that act as her eyes and ears. She also has a fearsome dragon that she unleashes when necessary. Fortunately, the Saint's reach isn't this far (well, as far as anyone knows!), although many communities still send fighters to her tournaments.

The Saint enjoys watching bouts and holds periodic 'Lectric Buggalus.' These fighting tournaments are designed to bring the best fighters from all around and acts as a subtle recruitment tactic. The Saint's army ensures that she has the best of everything, and she only bestows gifts on the home communities of proven fighters, usually in return for their service in her army.

If the players are interested, then Shelby plans for them to travel as part of her entourage protecting Hercules. Once they secure the drug and get it to Paradise City, then Shelby can offer them any reasonable reward (all the gas they can carry, a home, repairs for their vehicles, etc.). Su is also listening to this conversation. While seemingly friendly, she is an elf, and she plans to thwart the travelers on the road.

Chest Beating

Hercules isn't the only fighter with something to prove. Tucker Welch, an obnoxious oaf of a fighter surrounded by his friends (Mooks; one for each Hero). Tucker wears a spiked leather cap, leather pants, and little else. He's looking to inflict himself on any fighters he deems worthy. He marches right up to Hercules, his breath reeking of swill, and challenges him to a fight!

Shelby objects, fearing an injury before the tournament, and Jin, a fearsome-looking woman herself, despite her short stature and needing a stool to stand on, with powerful arms stirring the cauldron of gruel, shouts at them to take the fight outside. Hercules is only too happy to oblige, reassuring Shelby that he needs to stay in shape and a sparring match would help.

Obviously, the Heroes want to get involved in the conversation and if things go poorly then they may find themselves fighting Tucker and his mooks. If this is the case, then Hercules pulls off Tucker's cap during the fight and discovers Tucker's secret. Otherwise, everyone eventually gets outside to fight as part of the 'parking lot,' a patch of dirt with spectators forming a circle (there's about three dozen people between Jin's staff and travelers at the restie) for the fight.

If a Hero isn't involved, then you don't need to play out the fight. Just mention that Hercules and Tucker take turns kicking, pummeling, and wrestling with each other until Hercules finally puts Tucker in a headlock and, as Tucker gestures his submission, Hercules pulls Tucker's cap off. This reveals that Tucker has a third eye in his forehead. While it isn't functional, it does mark Tucker as a mutant and therefore ineligible for the Lectric Buggalu and any other bout.

Injecting Personality

While you don't need life stories for each NPC, it helps if they have a roleplaying hook. Sue is friendly and curious about the world. Hercules is overconfident and a bit full of himself (obviously unlike today's celebrity athletes!), Shelby bears the weight of responsibility and regret that she can no longer compete. And Tucker is a bully, but sympathetic (which goes right out the window when he kills Hercules!).

An embarrassed Tucker takes his knife from a mook and briefly brandishes it, but he thinks better of it when Jin, the old proprietor, steps between them.

"You know the restie's code of conduct!" Jin shouts. "Using weapons here is forbidden! Put that away or this restie is closed to you forever!"

Tucker growls, but after spotting the wall guardians fingering their crossbows, he reluctantly puts his knife away and storms off.

At this point, Shelby suggests that everyone get some sleep (Jin's has a crude motel as part of the compound, but many, including Hercules and Shelby, sleep in their vehicles) as she wants to be on the road first thing in the morning.

A Spanner in the Works

Unfortunately, the Heroes awaken to a new complication. At some point during the night, Tucker kills Hercules. Despite his trainer's suggestion, Hercules went out for some more swill and excitement and bumped into Tucker. Hercules couldn't resist throwing a few barbs Tucker's way and Tucker responded by sinking his knife into Hercules' chest.

If any of the Heroes are awake then they can witness this; otherwise, Shelby, who went looking for Hercules when she stirred and realized that he wasn't in the bus. She arrives just in time to see the light fade from Hercules' dead eyes. Her scream is enough to awaken the entire compound (except for Su, who's already slipped out. If the Heroes think to ask the wall guardians, then a couple of them mention that Su went out, ostensibly for supplies. It is sometimes safer under cover of night).

"Murderer!"

How this plays out is largely up to you. Tucker is emboldened; he knows that he is no longer welcome in the restie, so pulling out his knife is no big deal. The same goes for his mooks, as they are effectively banned by association, but the mooks only pull weapons if the Heroes do the same. Shelby angrily charges Tucker weapon-less and,



if the Heroes don't intervene, Tucker and his mooks beat her into submission before tying her to a motorcycle and dragging her around the compound (she isn't killed, but she could get seriously injured before Jin intervenes and puts a stop to everything).

Oddly, the wall guardians only get involved if someone brandishes a ranged weapon. Otherwise, they stand and watch until Jin arrives, with an armed escort, after 3 rounds and tosses out Tucker and his mooks. As Tucker started the fight, the Heroes are exempt from Jin's rule. Her words carry weight, so the wall guardians do shoot anyone who doesn't comply.

When the fight is over, Shelby is devastated. With Hercules dead, she has no chance to win the supplies in the Lectric Buggalu tournament. Of course, that isn't going to stop the Heroes (if it does, then this was a fun, short adventure)! There are several ways they can convince Shelby to complete the mission:

- ⊗ One of the Heroes can fight in the tournament (if the Hero is a cyborg or mutant, then they need to disguise that fact).
- ⊗ They can go as spectators or otherwise sneak into the compound to steal the drugs.
- ⊗ They can find someone else to fight (making Tucker do it could be fun, but you could also create any on-the-spot Extra with sufficient, and perhaps conflicting, motives to help).

In any event, as dawn breaks the Heroes should board or otherwise accompany Shelby's bus and hit the road!

The Bus

Shelby's bus is an old school bus, but little of its original paint remains. Most of the seats have also been torn out, making the interior look more like an RV than a bus. The bus is protected by armor plating and wiring over the remaining windows (the side windows are mostly covered over) and there is a turret atop the bus accessible from the inside. Shelby has an old pump action shotgun for anyone using the turret, but she's down to her last 6 shells.

Shelby drives unless a Hero offers to take the wheel. She uses an old atlas to navigate, with many of the old places and roads crossed out and new ones marked inside. Because she had a full complement before drafting the Heroes, she has enough canned food, water, and gas for everyone to make it to the Saint's Compound and back.

The Howlers

Unfortunately, the Heroes' mission could be over just as it gets underway. Su, making her way to the Saint's Compound ahead of the Heroes, was captured by the Howlers, a waste gang. She's bargained for her life and freedom by tempting the Howlers with an "easy score," the Heroes' bus!

You are cruising along the broken highway when you suddenly hear something – or someone – howl, followed by several more. A pack of motorcycles pull out on the road behind you, followed by a pickup truck. Judging by their outfits, their howls, and exaggerated gestures, you swear that you are being pursued by werewolves!

The Howlers are a gang of mutants that resemble classic werewolves – humans with canine features. They aren't magical creatures and regular weapons are just as effective as silver ones, nor is their bite contagious. The Howlers do, however, understand their condition and emphasize it; most Howlers go shirtless or wear open vests so that their hairy bodies intimidate their prey.

The Howlers want the bus's gas and anything else valuable that it holds. They feel no need to negotiate, as they have the upper hand. They do, however, respect their Alpha, a large wolf-man with a jagged scar down one side of his face. The Alpha calls off the attack if the Howlers lose half their members.

There are a dozen Howlers on motorcycles. Most are doubled up, either with side cars or together on a single cycle. They try to close the distance so the non-driving Howler can hop aboard and take the bus.

The Alpha drives in a pickup truck with two Howlers and Su, who is bound to the back of the roll cage. The Alpha occasionally growls questions at Su about the bus, but it's obvious that she is his prisoner. Su's only goal is to escape; the moment that she is free she tries to make a run for it.

Should the Heroes manage to capture or corner Su, then she pretends that she was gathering herbs when the Howlers caught her. This is a lie, as an opposed Smarts task roll would attest. If found out, then Su admits that she is an elf for the Saint, having been taken under her protection as a child. She may be coerced into helping them, but only begrudgingly, as her loyalty to the Saint is strong.

HERCULES FERRIS

SMARTS 2	MOVES 5 (Dodging)
STYLE 3	BRAWN 6 (Brawling)
Health 6 Defence 21	
Unarmed 8 (2 damage)	

SHELBY HUDSON

SMARTS 3	MOVES 4
STYLE 3	BRAWN 6 (Tough)
Health 8 Defence 12	
Unarmed 6 (2 damage)	

TUCKER WELCH

SMARTS 2	MOVES 2 (Armor)
STYLE 4	BRAWN 5 (Brawling)
Health 5 Defence 12	
Unarmed 7 (2 damage)	



"SU" SUSSUDIO

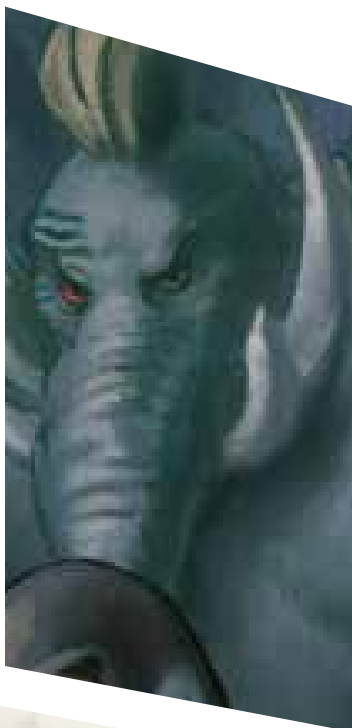
SMARTS 3	MOVES 4 (Stealth)
STYLE 2 (Empathy and Perception)	BRAWN 2
Health 2 Defence 12	
Knife 2 (2 damage)	

HOWLERS

SMARTS 2	MOVES 3
STYLE 2	BRAWN 2
Health 1 Defence 9	
Clawed Hands 3 (1 damage)	

ALPHA

SMARTS 3	MOVES 3 (Dodging)
STYLE 2	BRAWN 3 (Tough)
Health 5 Defence 15	
Clawed Hands 3 (1 damage)	
Machete 3 (2 damage)	





Act Two: **The Heist**

In this Act, the Heroes must infiltrate the Saint's compound and acquire the medicine that Paradise City desperately needs. Fortunately, with the Lectric Buggalu happening there are plenty of distractions and the Heroes have no problem hiding in plain sight. They simply need to find the location of the medicine and get it out of the Saint's Compound.

The Saint's Compound was known as the Odessa Retail Center before the Boom and reorganized as a fortress by the first 'Saint,' Nicholas Last. A mall Santa, Nick discovered that his profession carried some weight and he twisted holiday and fantasy mythology to his advantage. Nicola Last continues his legacy.

The ORCs are derived from mall security and the elves, patterned after Santa's Little Helpers, maintain control through infiltration. In addition to his army, the Saint has two other weapons at her disposal. The first is the movable minigun (4 Damage) that currently sits above the gate and the second is her 'Dragon,' a helicopter that boasts a flamethrower.

A Small Matter of Elves

If Sussudio slipped away from the Heroes in **Act One**, then she makes her way to the compound and tries to warn the Saint about the Heroes. If she is with the Heroes, then she slips away at the earliest opportunity. In either case, it takes an Opposed Smarts vs Su's Stealth to catch her before she can inform Mr. Frost of their presence.

If Su was killed or otherwise out of the picture, you can still have a little fun by introducing Mickey, a young boy who is also an elf. He tries to hire himself out to the arriving Heroes as a guide, offering to help them navigate the festivities. Mickey does help, but he also shares any useful intelligence that he gathers with Mr. Frost. As a bonus, you can use the same Extra stats as Sussudio!

The Lay of the Land

Shelby visibly relaxes and tenses as the Heroes crest the final gentle hill into the valley of the Saint. No one is foolish enough to attack them here, at least not without the Saint's sanction.

Just ahead of you, the land opens into a wide valley with a three-sided two-story building at its center. The building was obviously important before the Boom, as it is surrounded by a large sea of asphalt currently rimmed with a high wall made from the ruins of cars and trucks that were parked on that sea when the Boom came. There are still a few well-maintained cars and trucks behind the wall, likely the Saint's army, as well as a giant fighting dome sitting between two "legs" of the building just behind the massive gate. The building and walls fly the white-trimmed red flag of the Saint.

Surrounding the compound is a large tent city flying several flags from different communities. There are also several domes out here as well, proving grounds for those fighters hoping to make their mark in the tournament. All are a testament to the power that the Saint wields over this part of the land.

Shelby asks a Hero to unfurl the Paradise City flag and mount it on the turret. Once the bus gets to the perimeter of the tent city, it is met by four ORCs on horseback. The ORCs wear normal leathers, but each has a badge with a stylized ORC on a shield (the mall's own symbol). Once Shelby explains herself, the ORCs direct her to an area where she can park the bus and set up a training area for her fighter.



Compound Layout

The Odessa Retail Center is roughly laid out in a triad design. The center also serves as the entrance, from which two long halls radiate, with a shorter hall directly behind the center. Each hall originally ended in an anchor store. Today, the left anchor store is the Workshop, the right is the Eagle's Nest, and the back is the Dragon's Lair.

The halls always have at least a half-dozen ORCs on patrol and two ORCs guard each entrance to the anchor stores. Doors are usually locked and require Smarts (20) rolls to open.

Currently, a large dome is constructed in front of the entrance; this is where the fights take place, and the surrounding area is for both the audience and the Jingle Ball. The dome is laced with lights that glow with a winter wonderland theme while the fighters are fighting.

The Rabbit and the Snowman

As the Heroes settle into their space and Shelby starts marking the practice area, this is a good time to introduce Mickey if desired. The Heroes also become aware of a traveling entertainer working her way through the various encampments.

You are unloading the bus and helping Shelby set up when you notice a crowd gathering around someone not too far away. The person responsible for the crowd is a woman wearing a Wasteland-chic version of a magician's outfit, complete with a maroon leather dress coat and black top hat. She waves a heavy wand as she produces magic for the crowd, bowing as they roar in approval.

The magician is Rosanna, or 'Rosie the Riveting.' Rosie is a traveling mutant with hair-like features; she has large ears that she hides under her hat, wide eyes, and a spring in her step that makes her seem to 'hop.' She is a master illusionist, her 'magic' is simply illusions and parlor tricks, and she is an accomplished thief, using her powers to help her survive.

Despite her criminality, however, Rosie has a kind heart and treats any Heroes that speak to her kindly. If Mickey or Su is not with the Heroes then she may also provide valuable information and, if Mickey is leading the Heroes into a trap, then Rosie's curiosity puts her in a position to aid them.

Rosie, however, does tend to attract unwanted attention and, whether the Heroes approach her or not, she is soon confronted by a few Mooks that accuse her of stealing from them. This may or may not lead to an altercation with the Heroes, as Rosie rushes through their encampment to get away from the angry Mooks!

Whether or not the Heroes get involved, Mr. Frost soon arrives to sort things, along with at least four ORCS. Wading through the crowd to assess the competition, Mr. Frost is a massive shirtless man wearing a black wool hat. His body is covered in white powder except for dark circles around his eyes, orange on his nose, and three small black circles lined up down the center of his chest. He is also the Saint's reigning champion, although he fears that his age is catching up with him and someone may steal his title.

The sight of Mr. Frost and the ORCS is enough to scare off the Mooks, but it also brings the Heroes to Mr. Frost's attention. He isn't above trading barbs with any perceived competition, so if you want to establish a rivalry with Mr. Frost and a Hero, now is a good time! Fortunately, he'll be called away for the speech before a Hero can get into too much trouble.

The Starter Speech

All good villains must have a proper introduction and the Saint is no different. Not long after the Heroes meet Roxy, the crowd is silenced by the firing of the minigun and an announcement over the speakers.

As the gun stops shooting, a man dressed in a long brown coat, an antler cap, and sporting a red clown nose addresses the crowd through a microphone.

"Patrons of the Wasteland! You have travelled far and wide through dangerous territory for a chance to bring glory to your homes here at the Lectric Buggalu! And now, I bring to you for the opening address, the Jolly Saint of the Wasteland, Checker of Lists, and General Manager for Life, Saint Nic Last!"

The crowd erupts as a woman steps forward and takes the microphone. Over more standard wasteland attire she wears a red cloak with white trim and a similar white band around her head. She waves to the crowd with a red-gloved hand.

"Thank you, Rudy. I'd like to welcome you all to our latest Lectric Buggalu, where we will find out which communities are deserving of gifts and which need to try a little harder next time. Over the coming days, there will be many opportunities for prizes that my ORCs have gathered from all over the waste. Starting today, Mr. Frost will select the worthy for tomorrow's games and invite them inside the walls tonight for our Jingle Ball! Now, without further ado, Mr. Frost?"

The hulking powdered brute steps in front of her and bellows into the microphone.

"Let the Games Begin!"



With that, the Saint retreats into the compound. The ORCS move into the crowd and begin organizing bouts to see who is worthy. This is an opportunity for you to create some fun fights between the designated Hero and other community fighters (just remember that these fights aren't exactly "fun" for the other Heroes, so keep this to one or two fights). Make sure that Mr. Frost is positioned to see the Hero win and invite them into the tournament and extend an invitation to all Heroes and Shelby to tonight's Jingle Ball.

Looking for Answers

Once the Heroes have settled into a spot, they have some time to do a little reconnaissance. Here are a few of the things that the Heroes might discover by poking around. If they ask about something not offered here, just roll with it and make up something!

Note that Mickey is a big help here; he knows just about everything regarding the compound, and he isn't too shy about sharing that information. He wants to gain the Heroes' trust, after all!

Where is the medicine? Almost no one on the outside except for the earliest arrivals knows anything about the medicine trucks but asking around and making a Style (10) roll reveals that all 'gifts' are inside the 'Eagle's Nest,' which is the former anchor store to the right when you enter the compound by the gate. A Style (15) roll enables a Hero to find someone who's been here long enough to see a truck with Heartbeat City's logo (which looks like an electrocardiogram) being taken into the compound.

How can we get into the compound? The compound wall is topped with ORCS wielding shotguns, an ostentatious display in a world where guns are rare. In addition, there is a movable minigun above the gate to further dissuade intruders. The best time to infiltrate would be at night, which makes stealth moot since the gates will be opened for the Jingle Ball anyway.



A Hero looking for another way in can make a Smarts (10) roll to discover that the Saint holds court in the compound during the day, so any Hero or Extra that is arrested will immediately be brought into the compound to receive the Saint's judgment.

There are no secret tunnels in or out of the compound. Pipelines and such were cut and filled long ago and if the Saint must beat a hasty retreat, then she will simply ride her dragon.

How can we get the medicine out of the compound? This is a question that can't be answered until the Heroes inspect the truck. The Saint hasn't moved the medicine from the truck because it is being kept cold by the dry ice in the truck and the driver, before dying, mentioned that the medicine was rendered useless if warmed.

It is possible for the Heroes to pack the medicine in containers of dry ice (there's about four coolers' worth) and take it to their bus, but it is much easier to simply drive the truck out of the compound while the gate is open. A Hero making a Smarts (20) roll hypothesizes that the truck would be safe from the minigun, as the Saint is obviously being careful with the cargo.

The Saint's Justice

Heroes being heroes (or is that players being players?), it's possible that they find themselves dragged to the Saint's court for some offence or another. They may have been led into a trap by Mickey, they may have offended Mr. Frost, or they may have been caught being somewhere they shouldn't have gone. In all cases, they are brought to the Saint's court, which is, of course, the spot the mall Santa had pre-Boom.



The Saint sits atop a golden throne with red cushions and white trim behind two staircases that lead up to the second floor. She sits with a grim expression as two ORCS drag a struggling fighter in chains who clearly can't stand on one of his legs. One of the ORCS holds a small piece of metal still dripping with blood.

"Oh, Jolly One, this fighter is part machine."

"I-it's just a pin," the fighter spits, "from an old injury. It doesn't help me fight."

"It helps you stand," the Saint says as she stands and gestures at her legs to make a point, "and that helps you fight. Where are you from, fighter?"

"R-Rio."

"Indeed." The Saint sits. "Well, in my court, the rules are the rules. I hereby judge you "naughty."

"But--"

"Silence!" One of the ORCS kicks him.

"Gift wrap his head and take it to Rio," the Saint orders. "And after they unwrap their gift, my ORCS, make sure that you spread some holiday cheer!"

"As you command, Jolly One," the ORCS bow as they drag the pleading fighter away. Something tells you that the holiday cheer won't be a celebration.

This is a fun opportunity for the Heroes to plead their case to a ruthless but intrigued "mall Santa." The Saint listens until she's heard enough and then passes judgment. Fortunately, the Heroes avoid execution (which would be amusing considering the ACE! rules!); they are more likely sent to "the Workshop" to be evaluated by Rudy for assignment to the games, the Workshop, the Eagle's Nest, or manual labor.

The Workshop

The Workshop is a former two-story department store that houses the labor camp and training grounds for ORCS on the lower floor ("tribute" to the Saint from surrounding communities) and spills out into the parking lot, and an upper floor that houses weapons and sensitive equipment for the compound. This is Rudy's domain, and his technicians keep the machines of the compound operating from here. Heroes that meet Rudy find that he embraces the 'mad, giggling henchman' trope.

If the Heroes are judged, then they are imprisoned upstairs near the Workshop, where several of the old mall businesses been repurposed into prison cells for those awaiting judgment or assignment. It takes a Smarts (20) roll to pick the cage and escape from one of these rooms (escape is always into the mall, as external exits have been bricked over). Imprisoned Heroes may receive help from Rosie if needed.

The Eagle's Nest

Named for the old department store mascot statue, the Eagle's Nest is where the gifts are housed. A half-dozen ORCS patrol the two floors, which are primarily filled with bits and pieces of old junk from the Pre-Boom, but there is also a large, refrigerated truck parked inside that has Heartbeat City markings! This is the truck that houses the medicine, and it is currently being evaluated by a couple of technicians as to whether the medicine inside can be safely off-loaded and preserved.

Any reasonable plan should get the Heroes inside the truck. A Smarts (10) roll enables them to determine that the medicine is best kept inside the trailer and the truck can be driven through the loading door (although a Hero may wish to open it first with a Brawn (10) roll).

The Dragon's Lair

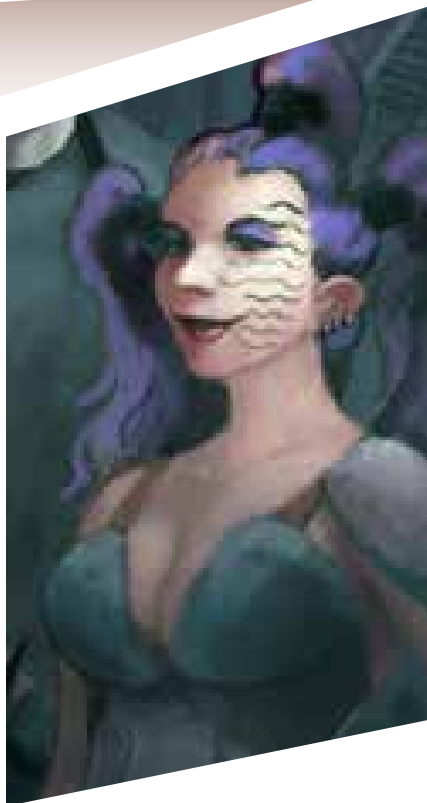
The Dragon's Lair is the most heavily guarded area of the compound; it houses both the Saint's living quarters and the Dragon, her personal helicopter. It's important that the Heroes don't get their hands on the helicopter – if they prove too fixated, then the Saint may send her Dragon on another mission to quell a wayward community so that the Heroes don't have access to it (although it returns in time for the climax!).

Outside the Dragon's Lair is where the land vehicles are stored. A Hero can access these if they can get past the ORCS – all vehicles are wired to bypass the need for keys.

The Jingle Ball

While the name is a bit silly (the whole point, really), the Jingle Ball does provide the Heroes with an opportunity. It is the only time that the massive gate is open, allowing the Heroes to drive the medicine truck right through it.

The Jingle Ball is dressed up in the usual winter wonderland theme, all around a band playing inside the dome. The band is appropriately playing versions of 1980s hits, all channeled through loudspeakers around the ball area. The Saint joins the party, wearing a blue and white gown and well-protected by ORCs. A Hero that has impressed the Saint (no mean feat!) may be escorted by an insistent Mr. Frosty for a dance!



ROSIE

SMARTS 3	MOVES 5 (Acrobatics)
STYLE 4 (Stagecraft)	BRAWN 2 (Brawling)
POWER 3 (Conjuration)	
Health 4	Defence 21
Baton 4 (2 damage)	

ORCS

SMARTS 2	MOVES 3 (Armor)
STYLE 2	BRAWN 3
Health 1	Defence 15
Sword 3 (3 damage)	
Hand Crossbow 3 (2 damage)	
Shotgun 3 (3 damage)	

FIGHTERS

SMARTS 2	MOVES 3 (Dodging)
STYLE 2	BRAWN 4 (Tough)
Health 6	Defence 15
Unarmed 6 (2 damage)	

THE SAINT (NICOLE LAST)

SMARTS 3 (Empathy)	MOVES 4 (Shooting)
STYLE 5 (Leadership)	BRAWN 3
Health 3	Defence 12
Pistol 6 (3 damage)	

MR. FROST

SMARTS 2 (Perception)	MOVES 4 (Dodging)
STYLE 2	BRAWN 5 (Intimidating)
Health 5	Defence 18
Unarmed 5 (2 damage)	
Spiked Baseball Bat 5 (3 damage)	



RUDY

SMARTS 2	MOVES 5 (Acrobatics)
STYLE 4 (Public Speaking)	BRAWN 2
Health 2	Defence 21
Knife 2 (2 damage)	
Thrown Knife 5 (2 damage)	



Act Three: **To Outrun a Dragon**

In the final act, the Heroes drive the medicine truck out of the Saint's compound and onto the open road towards Paradise City. Unfortunately, the Saint cannot let this insult go unpunished, so she sends her best ORCS, as well as herself, after the Heroes to destroy them and retrieve "her" property.

All the Heroes need to do is outrun the Saint while whittling away enough of her forces that she calls off the hunt. This isn't easy, however, as the Heroes must contend with both a minigun and the Dragon in addition to her overwhelming army of ORCS. Fortunately, they receive a little assistance from a timely sandstorm, but whether that ultimately helps or hinders depends on the Heroes' skills!

Breakout!

Thanks to the Saint's mystique, the ORCS aren't ready for someone brazen enough to sneak in, jump into a truck, and simply drive out with it. Thus, the Heroes have the element of surprise and a great chance of success if they come up with any half-decent plan to get inside the garage and drive out inside the vehicle.

At this stage, there are only three things that the Heroes must contend with, a closing gate, a minigun, and nearby ORCS. The gate is the easiest; as soon as the medicine truck bursts out of the compound, Mr. Frost orders the gate to be closed. Fortunately, this is a slow process and, presuming the Hero driving the truck keeps a steady pace, it only requires a Moves (15) roll to squeeze through the gate. If the Hero pauses for any reason, then the TN raises to 20.

Unfortunately, the truck may not get there if the cabin is sprayed by a minigun (sure, the Saint may be worried, but a panicked gunner may get trigger-happy!). To deal with the minigun, a Hero can scale the crushed-car wall by making a Brawn (15) roll and do it without being seen by making a Moves (20) roll (sorry; there are a lot of people here!). The Moves TN may be reduced if everyone's attention is drawn to the medicine truck crashing through the ball!

A Hero that reaches the top must contend with an ORC or two before getting to the gunner. A Hero that was spotted, or makes too much noise, may also discover the minigun being trained on them! The Hero may leap onto the truck as it passes with a Brawn (10) roll, although they lose a die if they bring the minigun with them.

But, oops, did they remember the ammunition? Assuming they did, then the minigun still has 3 attacks' worth of ammo (minus any that was used during the breakout). If the Hero remembers to grab ammunition, then the minigun may be used 10 times before it runs out of ammunition.

As for the ORCS, the Heroes need only contend with one or two leaping and climbing onto the truck as they flee. These ORCS are more disciplined and concerned with recapture, so they limit themselves to melee attacks unless shooting at a Hero atop the truck.

Once the Heroes pass through the gates, they tear through the crowds outside and head for the open road. Unfortunately for them, the Saint doesn't take this insult sitting down. The chase is on!

The Chase

The Saint is the most powerful warlord in the region, and it is in her best interest to let the Heroes go. After all, no one really knows what's in the truck and the Lectric Buggalu is the largest things on their minds. Unfortunately for the Saint, her ego can't let this go. She's willing to make the Heroes pay for stealing from her, no matter what the cost.

Portable Miniguns

While miniguns typically require an external power source, it just feels ACE! to let the Heroes tear into their enemies like a mercenary ripping into an alien in a rainforest! For *Domes of Thunder*, a Hero can use a minigun if holding it with two hands, but they take a die deduction on any Moves actions.

(And for you purists out there worried about a handheld minigun in a setting of mutants and cyborgs, there actually was a gas-powered prototype produced that was fully portable, to say nothing of microguns, so there!).

As the Heroes clear the camps, the Saint orders Mr. Frost and Rudy to follow them as she gets the Dragon ready. Rudy rides in an old police cruiser with flashing red lights; Mr. Frost stands on the back of a truck that has a harpoon gun (with rope attached) mounted on it. They are accompanied by a dozen or so ORCS traveling in various vehicles – feel free to use any combination of motorcycles, dune buggies, and sedans – and more may join as the chase continues.

The Dragon

Once the Heroes have whittled down the ORCS, they soon face a new problem, the fearsome Dragon! Without needing to follow the road, it makes up for lost time and swoops down on them just in time for the final conflict!

Thus far you've managed to stave off the ORCS and protect yourselves and your cargo. The seemingly unsurmountable army that pursued you is now just a handful of vehicles, and you are feeling confident in your chances of defeating them and finishing the run to Paradise City.

And then those hopes are dashed by a mighty roar. The Dragon is here!

Flying just behind the medicine truck is a metallic beast, or what was once called a 'helicopter' in ancient times. The red machine bears down on you, and you are certain that, deep inside its belly, the angry motions of the Saint demand that the pilot get closer to finish you once and for all!

The Dragon is a helicopter that, before the Boom, was used to fight forest fires by burning fire lines with its bottom-mounted flamethrower. In the post-Boom, this has given it the reputation of being a 'dragon.' The Dragon has a pilot and a co-pilot. The co-pilot operates the flamethrower. Inside, the Dragon can comfortably hold another 4-6 people and, if the Heroes didn't take the minigun or disable it, then it is mounted on the left side of the helicopter and manned by a gunner.

The Dragon's main occupant, of course, is the Saint herself, bearing down on the Heroes in a moment of pure hubris. It's likely to get her killed, but she intends to take the Heroes down with her. She angrily points at them while directing the co-pilot or minigunner to destroy the truck – she's no longer interested in saving it!

Fighting a helicopter is difficult, but fortunately the flamethrower is a relatively short-ranged weapon, and a Hero may be able to leap from the truck to the helicopter, disable it from afar, or shoot the pilot through the relatively exposed window.



THE DRAGON

BASH 4 **STEERING +1 PLATING 3**

Health 4 **Defence 15**

Flamethrower 4 (4 damage)

Epilogue

Once the Heroes have slain the Dragon, er, downed the helicopter, they are free and clear. Regardless of whether the Saint survived the crash, her mystique as an untouchable leader is destroyed and any ORCS still chasing the Heroes break it off and return to the compound. The Heroes are free!

Whether the rest of their journey is uneventful is, of course, up to you! Paradise City can be as near or far away as you need, and other adventures may await as the Heroes protect this precious cargo. Alternatively, the Heroes may arrive at the city as, well, Heroes, and due to their hard-won reputations, they may be hired for other missions across the Wasteland!



ACE!
Issue 8

Bite Tale!

BEN ROGERS



Introduction

In a world very similar to ours, people still watch popular shows that feature high school monster hunters and talking animal companions. But in the world of *Bite Me!* Sinister creatures actually *do* lurk in the darkness, and those shows featuring vampire slayers and mystery machines serve as uncanny documentaries, even if the general populace doesn't know it. Some nefarious creatures plot humanity's enslavement, some feed on them, others have goals and drives that are unknowable to simple human minds, but almost every one of them is evil. Meanwhile, the majority of humankind labours away in ignorance, blissfully unaware of the shadowy creatures who lurk just on the edges of their perception. The majority, but not all.

A (mostly) brave few either suspect or know from blood-curdling experience that monsters are real. They have chosen to use that knowledge to uncover and oppose these creatures. These monster hunters come from all walks of life and backgrounds; often they are teenagers with curiosity and time on their hands, scholars whose studies have taken them on paths that the establishment decries or even officers of the law with a "crackpot" reputation. Some may even be considered supernatural themselves. Regardless of their background, the inevitable lack of resources of even a small organisation or authority is made up for through tenacity, creativity and sometimes just plain luck. Their adversaries may be evil incarnate but—in the world of *Bite me!*—good always overcomes. And you can be sure there will be some madcap antics and crazy chases along the way!

There are many creatures of the night, from beasts of folklore and legend to man-made creations of perverted science. No matter the form they take, the *Monster Hunters* are ready to confront them. A stalwart line of defence against the encroachment of evil. Now where did we put those poochy snacks...

Overview

This book is broken up into two broad sections:

The Critters and Crew: The first part includes options for creating monster hunting characters, useful gear and technology that they may need on their adventures and a menagerie of adversaries that Directors can pepper into their own games.

The Adventure: This pulsating heart of the book, this section consists of a full-length adventure that pits the Heroes against a variety of creatures of the night whose nefarious plot schemes revolve around a seemingly harmless, abandoned amusement park...

Original Cast of Characters

The Heroes presented here are the original cast as presented in several popular television serials from the '90s that involved paranormal investigations and monster hunting. They offer a quick option to delve straight into *Bite Me!* but you are of course free to create your own. Maybe you'd like a reluctant werewolf trying to do some good with their curse or an immortal warrior who is simply trying to keep their head on their shoulders. Don't let us stop you, go right ahead!

Each character here is already provided with a Trait and Role. Just like designing new characters, however, feel free to swap these out if you'd like to tweak them a little.

It's Comedy horror, not Horror horror...

Getting the tone right in any roleplaying game can be tricky but it can be particularly hard when trying to cross two seemingly opposed genres such as comedy and horror.

Advice on achieving the right tone can also vary based on your group; what works well for one may not sit well for others. Bearing this in mind, here are a few points to consider.

Talk to the group and set expectations. If everyone knows the tone you are trying to strike, then most people will guide their choices accordingly. When players know they have a licence to be a bit less earnest and crack a few jokes at the table, it will happen.

Watch some source material first, either as a group or individually. Nothing helps set the tone or get the mindset right more than a few back-to-back episodes of *Scooby-Doo*, *Buffy*, or *Goober and the Ghost Chasers*.

While you can make an R-rated comedy, use graphic violence sparingly and preferably only in an exaggerated manner. Violent deaths and gore are horrific but over the top violence and deaths or wounding in mundane or unexpected ways can be darkly comedic. This can be a really tough one to balance, though, so if in doubt, play it safe and let the players imaginations fill in the details.

Fluffy Winters

RELUCTANT VAMPIRE SLAYER

All you ever wanted in life is the chance to ruffle some pom poms for the cheerleading team. But destiny wasn't going to let you have that one simple pleasure. You switched off during the lecture from that creaky librarian. Something about a prophecy and 'the Chosen One'. Some ancient order of slayers and vampires everywhere... whatevs. You know the pointy end of a stake and picked up the crossbow really easily. And at least you can still wear pink, as vampires tend to dust rather than spray blood everywhere. Red stains on pink would be a *nightmare*.

Lillo Thornberg

WITTY FORTUNE TELLER

You've never quite fitted in, which is cool with you. You've always been happy with who you are. It's not like you can talk to animals or anything, more like you've always been able to see the signs their presence or actions mean. You have some pretty weird dreams too, which leads to a lot of *déjà vu*. Then you hit high school and found the library that just happened to be filled with books on all sorts of occult histories and practices. That's where you met Fluffy. You make an odd duo but your knack for seeing snippets of the future has helped keep her out of too much trouble so far. You just wish she'd stop trying to get you to wear something other than black.

Rooby Roo

FAITHFUL DOG

You grew up alongside Ted and had the perfect life filled with snax, naps, and lots of play. What made it even better was the fact that you could understand everything Ted ever spoke to you. So you started talking back once day. After everyone's shock wore off, life became... different. But that was ok. Making your own food and being independent meant you could finally make a



hamburger stack to the size *you* wanted. Then Ted started high school and your life was turned upside down. Ted likes to help everyone and that led to him getting involved with really weird adventures. You're there for him of course, but you really wish he would stop chasing ghosts and other scary things.

Ted Bones

CHEERY PARANORMAL INVESTIGATOR

Not that you know it, you're pretty humble after all, but you've always been the cool kid. Good grades, good at sport, good with people. You're just so damn... good at everything in life. When you found out there were some pretty bad monsters out there that actually enjoyed scaring folks, you decided to make it your mission to protect people from them. And you know what, you're good at that too. With your faithful friend, Rooby, at your side, there isn't any paranormal investigation you aren't willing to tackle.

Creating Your Own Monster Hunters

People who become Monster Hunters are often either those who suspect that such creatures exist and want to prove this fact, or those who have had a personal encounter with such monsters and feel driven to stop them or protect people from them. There are even those who make it their mission in life to disprove the existence of such creatures. For science. In either case such individuals can potentially come from all walks of life, so many of the Occupation roles outlined in the core *ACE!* Book could be used to create such Heroes. Depending on the Director's vision for the tone and style of the game, players may also have access to a number of supernatural or strange roles reflecting the quirkiest characters you might have seen in monster hunting tales. Some new Occupations are presented here, while other suitable roles from the main *ACE!* rules that might be particularly suitable for *Bite Me!* are also suggested.

Suggested Roles

(Refer to *ACE* #1 for more information on these Roles)

ANIMALS. You are the faithful animal companion of one or more members of the group. Although you look more or less like a regular creature of your species, you can also talk in some fashion. Well, your human friends claim to understand your communication at least. It's a little strange when you think about it but everyone just accepts it as normal. Pick an ability from one of the Talking Animal roles in the *ACE!* Book to reflect your particular species. You also start the game with 2 extra Karma and can share your Karma points with your friends.

CLERIC – Priests have Power in the Bite me! world and having someone along who can handle the (real) undead can be handy. Even though they may keep singing “Onward Christian Soldiers” at top volume at inconvenient times.

DRUID – While priests may be able to wield Power in the Bite me! World, so can some ancient and primal faiths. The Druid role can serve for a number of characters of pagan or New Age backgrounds

SLAYER - While most monster hunters might be considered investigators first some are just out to destroy the creatures they hunt. You are one of them. You probably have a collection of sharp, pointy objects and most people avoid you at parties.

VAMPIRE – Yeah, you may have an insatiable lust for blood, but you are one of the good guys. Maybe you just borrow from blood banks or like particularly rare steaks.

WEREWOLF – Much like the Vampire above you are a good monster. A very good monster, yes you are, what a good monster...do you want me to throw the stick? Do you? What a good monster....and yes, you are house trained. Mostly.

New Roles

Here are some additional new roles that might be particularly fitting for *Bite me!* Games. But you never know, if you speak nicely to your Director, they might let you use them in other ACE! Games too...

FORTUNE TELLER. You might call yourself a white witch or Wiccan, or perhaps you twitch your nose to cast spells, regardless of the specifics you are a well-intentioned practitioner of the occult who has a knack with portents of the future. You gain the Power stat but no additional points to add to it. You also gain a bonus 1d6 when using a tarot deck and instinctively know if a spirit conversing via a Ouija board is a harmful one.

PARANORMAL INVESTIGATOR. Creatures of Darkness are out there, you know it. Now you just need to find one to prove their existence. Oh, you’ve been on many investigations into the supernatural but they’ve always proven to be elaborate hoaxes by disgruntled or unpleasant humans. At least your help has ingratiated you with the cops. You gain a bonus 1d6 when searching for clues and interacting with any local authorities. You also begin the game with a brightly coloured, mid-sized van called the Mystery Wagon.

Gear & Technology

As the world of *Bite Me!* is essentially a caricature of our own, you can refer to the *ACE!* rulebook for details of costs and difficulties for acquiring many useful items. The following list provides specific gear which may aid monster hunters in their investigations, organised by cost.

NORMAL (10)

FLASHLIGHT. Provides illumination up to 30' away.

GARLIC. Inflicts 4 damage against certain supernatural creatures such as vampires. Unless the Director says otherwise, this will usually involve infusing water with garlic in a water pistol or some other method. Careful. Carry too much people will start giving you a wide berth.

HOLY SYMBOL. Adds 1d6 to a Cleric's Power roll to affect undead with their Power. May also ward off other creatures depending on their own beliefs or vulnerabilities.

OUIJA BOARD. Allows Heroes to communicate with ghosts and spirits. Kind of like using the keyboard on a mobile phone to contact someone in the afterlife. Users should beware, not every spirit is friendly or truthful.

TAROT DECK. Allows a Hero to perform a reading for another character. With a successful Style or Power 20 roll, the Hero may ask the character they are reading for one yes or no question about themselves, which must be answered truthfully. Alternatively, the Hero performing the reading may ask the Director one question about the character's future, which must be answered as cryptically as possible. While a deck may be used multiple times, a reading may only be performed on a specific target once per day.

WOODEN STAKES. Pointy sticks are sharp. Be careful you might get a splinter. Can be used as a weapon that inflicts 1 damage. A successful attack against a vampire that beats their Defence by 5 or more will render them Prone.

HARD (20)

EMF METER. An electronic device that measures electromagnetic fluctuations, making it easier to detect the presence of spirits. Adds 1d6 to Smarts rolls made to sense the location of nearby spirits.

HOLY WATER. Blessed by a priest or other holy individual, holy water can harm some evil monsters such as demons or vampires. Thrown like a grenade, the vial explodes on impact to inflict 5 damage on any supernatural creature it can affect. A vial contains up to three uses (less if you use it on a particularly big creature).

PURE SALT. Sprinkled in circles or lines, pure salt can ward off certain creatures such as zombies or devils. Creatures warded by salt need to make a Style 30 roll to cross an unbroken line. Sufficient salt for one use. Also handy for fish and chips.

SILVER AMMUNITION. Although expensive projectiles for a ranged weapon, if you have money to burn, why not shoot it at your enemies? Doubles the weapon's damage when used against a monster that is vulnerable to silver, such as a werewolf. Roll a calamity while using the weapon and you've run out of silver ammo... that werewolf has stopped moving, right?

UV FLASHLIGHT. Like a regular flashlight (above) but inflicts 2 damage against creatures that are affected by sunlight who are caught in its beam.

Crooked Property Developer

SMARTS 4 MOVES 2
STYLE 3 (Disguise) BRAWN 2
Health 2 Defence 6
Fisticuffs 4 (1 damage)

Devil

SMARTS 6 MOVES 4 (Flying)
STYLE 6 BRAWN 8 (Brawling)
Health 8 Defence 12
Flaming Trident 10 (3 damage)
Fire blast 6 (3 damage, 30' range)
Takes double damage from silver weapons. Smells of sulphur.

Mummy

SMARTS 6 MOVES 2
STYLE 4 BRAWN 6 (Brawling)
Health 8 Defence 6
Throttling grasp 8 (3 damage)
A mummy takes double damage from fire-based weapons.

Cultist

SMARTS 2 (Occultism) MOVES 2
STYLE 1 BRAWN 3
Health 3 Defence 6
Sacrificial Dagger 5 (2 damage)

Ghost

SMARTS 3 MOVES 3 (Flying)
STYLE 3 BRAWN -
Health 3 Defence 9
Ghostly Chill 5 (2 damage)
When first seen a Ghost causes characters to be *Spooked!* (see p. 13) unless they succeed on a Smarts 20 or Style 20 roll. Spirits can't pick things up and are only harmed by holy, magical, or sci-fi ecto-gadgetry damage.

Hex Master

SMARTS 6 **MOVES** 3 (Rituals)

STYLE 5 **BRAWN** 3

POWER 5 (Necromancy)

Health 3 **Defence** 9

Hex Doll 7 (4 damage. Target has to be able to see the doll and the Voodoo Master needs to be able to see the target and have an appropriate doll prepared)

Pirate Ghost

SMARTS 2 **MOVES** 4 (Climbing)

STYLE 3 **BRAWN** -

Health 3 **Defence** 12

Spectral Cutlass 6 (3 damage)

When first seen, a ghost causes characters to be *Spooked!* (see below) unless they succeed on a Smarts 10 or Style 10 roll. Spirits can't pick things up and are only harmed by holy, magical, or sci-fi ecto-gadgetry damage.

Poltergeist

SMARTS 1 **MOVES** 5 (Flying)

STYLE 1 **BRAWN** -

POWER 5 (Telekinesis)

Health 3 **Defence** 15

Ghostly Fling 7 (2 damage to all within 10')

Spirits can't pick things up and are only harmed by holy, magical, or sci-fi ecto-gadgetry damage.

Wolfman

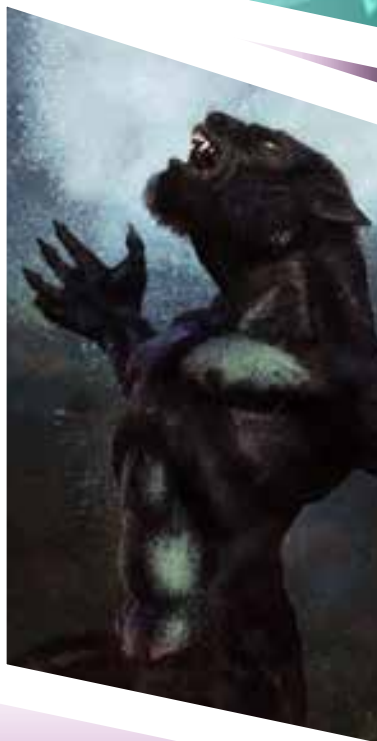
SMARTS 3 (Tracking) **MOVES** 4

STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 6 (Brawling)

Health 6 **Defence** 12

Claws and bite 8 (2 damage)

Takes double damage from silver weapons.
Regenerates 1 Health per round unless at zero Health.



Darkness, BITES!

Synopsis

This *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* adventure is designed for 4-6 Heroes. While imagined as taking place near a major conurbation or city in modern day United States, it could easily be transplanted to another location by an enterprising Director.

Our adventure begins with our heroes investigating a local amusement park that has been abandoned for some years. Recently, however, strange lights, woeful noises, and weird occurrences have been documented at the site. An initial investigation leads our intrepid gang to the discovery of a poltergeist that appears to be haunting the site, but tracking the creature down reveals it to be none other than Mister Scribbens, a local property developer. But the mystery deepens. The monster hunters soon discover that while the poltergeist was a fake, Mister Scribbens is a cultist in thrall of a supernatural being known only as the Dark Master.

Now on the trail of the Dark Master, our investigative Heroes search for further clues, potentially leading them to consult Madame Rosmerta, an expert with tarot. She in turn leads the Heroes to a local goth club that is thought to be a meeting place for the Dark Master's cult. Things soon take a lively turn when the Dark Master sends the monster Adam to stop them by abducting the contact they were due to meet.

We then have the staple of all good monster hunts: a chase scene. Adam will have likely either captured the contact the Heroes were due to meet or else been beaten and fled. This leads to a hectic race across the city and into the sewers after the beast. The creature leads the do-gooders straight into the lair of its mistress, the open-minded Eve. An epic fight ensues with mummy and daddy monster and all their little creations.

Having learnt that the monsters are merely pawns of the Dark Master, the Heroes' search continues until a seller of antiquarian books offers a clue which leads them to a money trail of property investments. All the while, however, the Dark Master's scheme is growing towards fruition inside a dreadfully spooky upstate mansion; a stately home that just happens to be guarded by hellhounds!!!

Having overcome, or been overcome by, the Dark Master's guardian hounds, the heroes must deal with the evil overlord's coven of vampires. Finding themselves in the midst of an ancient and very evil ritual, it's soon apparent that arrival of the master of disaster is imminent. The Dark Master is none other than Dracula, the most vicious and stylish of all vampires. An epic finale ensues, one you can be sure involves copious amounts of holy water and a fair amount of sunlight. (You did remember to order those tanning lamps, right?)



Act One:

Talk Around Town

Somewhere on the outskirts of town sits a dilapidated old amusement park called Rosco's Fun Land. It has been years since the sounds of joyful screams and the scent of hot dogs and cotton candy permeated the air around the once-gaudy rides and brightly lit arcades. Paint peels from the signage and the once bright and gay colours are now muted. Many of the light bulbs that once illuminated almost every surface are cracked or broken and the metal work of the rides are tinged with rust and corrosion.

Depending on where you have decided to set the story and the Heroes involved, one or more of them may have visited the amusement park as a child or heard stories of it from family members or friends. It was genuinely once a fun place to visit. Full of laughter and merriment, the place would be heaving with families at weekends and was a common haunt for teenagers and college kids during any evening. If a Hero opts to have a connection to the place, feel free to have them elaborate by creating or filling in details. For particularly detailed, entertaining or creative tales, you can award the Hero with one or more Karma at the start of the game.

But, you might ask, what has summoned our heroes to the amusement park? Why here, and why now?

The “incidents” began about a month ago. First of all, a group of high school kids who were trespassing on the site as a dare—a common rite of passage for the local youth since the closure of the park—came away saying that they had seen a terrifying spectre that had driven them from the site. Their parents and the local police dismissed the stories as a hoax. A fresh variation on an age-old hazing ritual. But less than a week later, the watchman from the security company employed to watch the park was scared senseless after seeing a similar ghostly vision while carrying out one of his rare site visits. Since then, the “incidents” have only increased in frequency, possibly as rumour of them seems to attract an increasing number of voyeuristic visitors and optimistic debunkers.

The “incidents” seem to only occur at night and all follow a similar pattern: previously dead lights start to glow or flash and a nearby ride will suddenly creak into life (with the accompanying perky musical accompaniment). Depending on the location in the park where this occurs a second or third ride also starts up soon after, building the noise, light and music into a chaotic crescendo. Then, all will suddenly fall silent. After what seems like an age, the silence is broken by a dread mournful moan. It starts quietly, almost imperceptibly. Like a suggestion on the breeze. Building and swelling, the noise seems to sweep up loose items and fairground debris, whirling them around to strike at anyone nearby. Just as the sounds and swirling rubbish reach a crescendo, a spectral vision appears; a skull-faced apparition glowing green with ghostly energy. Never uttering anything intelligible, the skull only ever issues forth a dreadful moaning wail. Not one person has yet been brave enough to hang around and see what might happen next.

Getting Involved

Wondering how you can get the Heroes involved? Fear not, we have you covered!

- ◎ If a Hero has a history with the amusement park or the local area, then an old school friend or family member may be, or know of, one of the early witnesses to an incident.
- ◎ If the Heroes are professional monster hunters or paranormal investigators, then they may have spotted news of the “ghost sightings” in the local press or even a national tabloid.
- ◎ Wandering or transient Heroes may just have arrived in town at the exact time the events are unfolding. Serendipitous, right? Unfortunately, as the new faces in town, they are either accused of being involved or looked to as unbiased investigators.
- ◎ Heroes with a supernatural connection may be drawn by visions, dreams, magical senses, or prophecies of significant events to come. Spooky!

Once they have been brought into the story, our Heroes may well want to start asking questions and learning more about the park and the previous victims. There are a number of ways to go about this, all described in detail below or summarised in the Town Rumours Table.

Heading to City Hall or the Town Records Office and succeeding on a Smarts 20 roll (or a Style 30 roll if they try to charm a local civil servant into doing research for them) will reveal that the land and park is owned by Dilapidate Industries, a holding company that has administered the assets of the Rosco Entertainments and Amusements Company since the death of its founder, Archibald “Rosco the Clown” Artichoke. A real estate developer by the name of Stephen Scribbens has been attempting to purchase the land but every attempt so far has been rejected due to Mr Scribbens’s failing due diligence and affordability checks. Not at all dodgy, right?

The Heroes may also look to question previous victims or other townsfolk. Asking around town is a Style 10 roll, although this may be skipped altogether if one or more of the Heroes was brought up in the town or currently lives locally. A successful roll provides the any rumours and personal pet theories you might like to throw into the mix as misdirection. If the Heroes ask about the history of Rosco’s Fun Land itself, then a Style 20 roll will reveal that the amusement park was always really popular and would probably still be going today had the owner, Archibald Artichoke, not died in a freak cream pie accident. After his death, the company remained intestate and things just fell apart. At least one person that the Heroes speak to will claim that the visions are caused by the unsettled spirit of Archibald, overwhelmed with sorrow to see the happy world he had created fallen into such disrepair.

Speaking with one of the previous incident victims will require a Style 20 roll as they are obviously still shaken and unwilling to share their experiences. Upon a success they will outline the pattern of events as laid out above and will warn the Heroes to not to go to the amusement park at night for fear of disturbing whatever evil haunts the place.

Town Rumours Table		
Location/NPC	Target Number	Rumour
Asking Around Town	10	Full backstory about how and when the incidents started, plus misdirections.
Asking Around Town	20	The amusement park was a popular place until the death of its owner, Archibald Artichoke.
City Hall/Town Records	20	Land and park is owned by Dilapidate Industries. Stephen Scribbens is attempting to purchase.
Witness of Incident	20	First-hand account of the poltergeist-type activity described.

The Abandoned Amusement Park

Finally, the Heroes might decide to investigate the amusement park in daylight before carrying out a nocturnal visit. Whether they head there in the day and lie in wait or arrive after dark they will need to make a Move 10 roll to clamber over the fence and into the park or a Brawn 20 roll to break in.

Gathering clues here requires one or more Smarts rolls. The following clues can be found with successful rolls at the listed difficulty:

Difficulty	Clue
Normal 10	There are traces of a strange, sticky, fluorescent, substance. Is it ectoplasm?
Hard 20	No... it's not ectoplasm. It's fluorescent paint!
Hard 20	There is still a live power supply at the park, so there is nothing to say the rides couldn't be switched on.
Herculean 30	What's this? It appears to be some sort of radio control device wired up to the rides....
Herculean 30	Odd. There are sets of spring-loaded platforms and panels which could be used to launch loose items. They seem to be triggered by radio control...

The Heroes may decide to deactivate the power supply or any of the radio control devices they find. Doing so requires a Smarts 20 roll and will prevent the related step from being triggered as and when they witness an incident (see p. 14, **Poltergeist Party**).

Spooked!

Events in *Bite Me!* games can rattle even the most stalwart and bravest of Heroes at times... and their talking animal companions even more so! To model this, a Heroes may gain a condition called *Spooked!* This is usually due to a failed Smarts or Style roll caused by a potentially concerning situation or spooky extra. A *Spooked!* Hero suffers -1d6 to all rolls until they can recover their composure. They can do this by either spending a point of Karma, succeeding in a Style 20 roll or receiving help from another Hero in the form or some sort of healing action or encouragement. If all else fails, Heroes always recover from being *Spooked!* at the end of the current scene they are in.

A *Spooked!* Hero cannot be *Spooked!* any worse than they already are, but if they encounter new sources of the *Spooked!* condition they should roll to resist (with the -1d6 for already being *Spooked!*). On a successful roll, they recover their senses and are no longer be affected by their original *Spooked!* state. Maybe they pulled their socks up or had a shot of whiskey!

If the Heroes fail all their rolls to uncover clues at the amusement park, or the Director just feels that it might be time to move on, two Cops arrive (see *ACE!*, p. 25) to investigate the trespassers. The Heroes will only get arrested if they resort to violence. Otherwise, the officers will look to escort them off the site with a warning. They are getting very used to having to keep “well-meaning enthusiasts and trouble-shooters”. Unless convinced differently, they will put the Heroes into this category. Don’t mess with the fuzz!

Poltergeist Party

In order to get to the bottom of things, our plucky monster hunters will eventually need to head to the amusement park at night. They did remember to pack their flashlights and EMF Meters, right?

As long as they are not trying to remain hidden, it will not be long before they become a target of an incident once in the park. These occurrences escalate in a series of stages:

- ⊙ Previously dead lights begin to flash. The Heroes need to make a Style 10 or Smarts 10 roll to avoid being *Spooked!* If the PCs found the clue about the power supply to the park, then they gain an extra die for the roll.
- ⊙ Next, one of the fairground attractions will suddenly burst into life. This just happens to be the one the Heroes are investigating if they have chosen to do so. They’ll need to make a Style 20 or Smarts 20 roll to avoid being *Spooked!*. If they found the clue about the remote controls, they gain an extra die for the roll. Actually being on the ride when it starts requires a Move 20 roll to avoid falling prone and suffering 1 damage.
- ⊙ A second and then third ride also comes to life, building the noise, light and music. The Heroes will need to make further rolls as per the step above.
- ⊙ Then, suddenly, everything goes quiet and the lights go out. The Heroes will need to make a Style 20 roll to avoid being *Spooked!*.

As the Heroes might expect if they spoke with some of the previous victims, the silence is broken by a dreadful moan. No, not someone complaining about the general state of the world and the youth of today. A real, blood-curdling keening. The Heroes need to make a Style 20 or Smarts 20 roll to





The Park Poltergeist

SMARTS 3

MOVES 3

STYLE 3 (Intimidate)

BRAWN 2

Health 2 Defence 9

Fling Debris 5 (2 damage to all within 10')

avoid being *Spooked!*, gaining a bonus die if they successfully spoke with the previous victims and were thus expecting this to happen.

At this point, loose items and parts of the fairground will be flung at the heroes. This is a 3 dice attack against each character, with a successful hit doing 2 damage.

Finally, a skull-faced spectral apparition will appear, glowing green with ghostly energy. The Heroes need to make a Style 30 or Smarts 30 roll to avoid being *Spooked!*, gaining a bonus die to the roll if they discovered the fluorescent paint clue.

At this point the Park Poltergeist has arrived and the scene will probably descend into some sort of fight.

Ghost Traps

In the hopes of getting the upper hand on their spooky adversaries with ingenuity and forethought, monster hunters will often attempt to set a trap or ambush for their supernatural foes. Invariably, this rarely goes as planned...

Encourage the Heroes to come up with such schemes and ploys, and don't be afraid to reward creative ideas with 2-3 points of Karma. The detail of such plans will vary by Hero and situation but ideally should involve a sequence of stages and associated rolls. For example:

Someone needs to set up the trap, possibly a physical snare, cage, or something more mystical such as rings of salt, occult inscriptions or fragrance diffusers filled with garlic essence. Depending on the nature of the trap, this could be a Smarts or Brawn roll.

One or more of the Heroes don a disguise to attempt to lure the monster towards the ambush or use some form of fast talking or bluffing. This requires Style vs the target's Smarts.

The Heroes will then need to get the creature into exactly the right location. Probably through their Style or Moves versus the target’s Smarts or Moves.

Then, spring the trap! This could vary depending on the nature of the trap but is likely to require the target to make a Smarts, Moves or Brawn roll to avoid some sort of condition (such as prone or entangled) or damage.

At first glance, this might seem like an easier way to deal with a threat, and to be fair that is why protagonists do it, however, there are two limitations. Firstly, the Heroes need to have at least some time to prepare. Traps don’t just happen on the fly! Secondly, as mentioned above, things often don’t go smoothly in these situations. When using a trap or ambush in this way, if a Hero rolls a Calamity on any of the related rolls, you can determine what happens. Cue nefarious laughter!

Mister Scribbens All Along?

Once the Heroes have defeated the Park Poltergeist, they will see the spectral figure fall to the ground with a very physical thud. Upon closer investigation, it becomes immediately apparent that this ghostly fiend is a very real and very mundane threat. In true spook-hunting fashion the players should get a “mask pull” moment and discover that the Poltergeist is, in fact, a scrawny middle-aged man with dark, thinning, greasy hair, a pencil moustache, and a sharp hooked nose. In the light of day—or suitable artificial illumination—the Poltergeist costume is clearly a mix of old Halloween costume pieces and luminous paint.

Read aloud the following once he is captured:

Mr Stephen Scribbens
Crooked Real Estate Developer

SMARTS 3 (Accounting)	MOVES 2
STYLE 2	BRAWN 1
Health 1	Defence 6

“Heh, you caught me. I would’ve gotten away scott free if it hadn’t been for you meddling...whatever-you-ares!”

He wriggles in a way that makes you think he might be about to try to escape but it seems like he is just shifting uncomfortably where he sits.

“You think you know it all, don’t you? You think this is just some get rich scheme for me? Me, poor ol’ Albert Scribbens. Has-been. Down on his luck. Real estate developer who never caught a break? Hah! What, scare people off to drive the price of the property down so that I can sell it and make a ridiculous profit on the development of the land? Well you’d be mostly right!”

He draws in a deep raspy breath as he continues to shift around, twitching a lot now and seeming almost incapable of remaining still.

"You see I am just the agent...." His previously nasal and whiny voice seems to break and deepen. "The one you should TRULY FEAR IS MY CLIENT..." the voice seems to grow and swell now, like somebody has opened a radio channel to hell. "HE IS THE ONE WHO COMES. HE IS THE DARK MASTER. HE IS THE DOOM. ALL WILL KNEEL BEFORE HIM!"



At this point, Scribbens starts to look very flushed and begins to shake uncontrollably. The Heroes should make a Smarts or Moves 20 roll. Failure means they get caught in the blast as the corrupt developer explodes! Anyone caught by the gore suffers 1 damage and becomes *Spooked!* due to the hideous nature of being covered in bits of estate agent.

Act Two

The Dark Master's Trail

Our Heroes may need to tidy up some loose ends and deal with the authorities after the events at the amusement park. But that's all pretty dull stuff so we'll take it as read that it happens and get on with the fun bit!

In summary:

- ⊙ The authorities will confirm that Mister Scribbens remains are his. There may be some awkward questions down at the station but ultimately they are convinced that the real estate developer staged events to try to lower the sale value of the property.
- ⊙ Any attempt by the Heroes to argue a different take on events will be put down to stress after witnessing Scribbens's horrible demise. Police and emergency services dismiss any suggestion of actual supernatural elements to the story and declare the death as "death by misadventure".

If the Dark Master that Scribbens mentioned is going to be stopped, the Heroes will need to do it themselves. The question is, how?

It's likely that the monster hunters will look to establish further clues. There are a variety of ways that they can do this:

SCRIBBENS' REAL ESTATE: As Mister Scribbens had mentioned working for a client, the Heroes might decide to follow this up via his office. Scribbens' Real Estate is a single room office in a shared building in a downtrodden downtown block. Everything about it has seen better days. There is only one employee, a hassled young secretary and "junior developer" named Quentin Braddock. Hamster-like in both features and demeanour, the young man is desperately trying to satisfy creditors and interpret and understand the records of his deceased boss whilst remaining sane in the process.

The Heroes can try to sweet talk, deceive, or threaten Quentin into sharing information with an appropriate opposed roll but the simple fact is he is completely in the dark and out of his depth. If the Heroes can convince him to allow them free reign to look through the business records, they might be able to glean some information. Alternatively, they may attempt to break into the office after dark (which requires a series of Moves 10 and 20 rolls depending on methods used). If successful in gaining access to the business records, the Heroes can attempt to

decipher the ancient, cryptic tongue that Scribbens used to record his personal diary entries with a Smart 20 roll. This reveals that he frequently met his biggest client at *Gotham Gothic Goth Club for Goths*.

Quentin Braddock

SMARTS 2 (office work)	MOVES 2
STYLE 2	BRAWN 2
Health 2	Defence 6

ARCHIBALD ARTICHOKE: If they did not do so in the previous act, the Heroes may conduct some research into Rosco's Fun Land, including its original and current, owners. If that is the case refer to the previous relevant section for what they may learn.

City Hall: The Heroes may search legal record to try to identify any other properties that the Scribbens may have been involved in on behalf of the Dark Master. Doing so requires either a Smarts 20 or a Style 30 roll. This takes time, however. If successful, they are informed that the information will be provided when available (see Act Three, p. 26).

MADAME ROSMERTA: Heroes with a supernatural bent or knowledge of the local occult scene will be aware of a nearby tarot reader and fortune teller by the name of Madame Rosmerta. Hoping that her gifts of prophecy can aid them, they may decide to consult her. You can always make her arrival in the adventure a bit more ominous by having a Hero receive a call from an unrecognised number. If answered, Madame Rosmerta introduces herself and informs the Hero that the spirits are howling that her assistance is needed. To refuse will bring doom upon them all!

Madame Rosmerta has a small New Age bookshop just off the main high street. Eagerly welcoming visitors, she dresses for the part in embroidered scarves, a long shawl and lots of costume jewellery. She already knows the purpose the Heroes' visit and who they are, of course. She wouldn't be much of a fortune teller otherwise! Offering herbal tea and freshly baked cookies, she closes the shop and leads them to her back room where she conducts all her readings and seances. Once there, she will explain that the spirits have told her of their search to stop the Dark Master and that their next steps lie in finding "the woman with the rainbow hair" in the Gotham Gothic Goth Club for Goths. She herself knows nothing of the Dark Master other than it is a powerful and evil presence who well-protected from any attempt she has made to learn more of it.

If the Heroes are unconvinced of her abilities, or simply wish to take advantage of the opportunity, she will happily perform tarot readings for them. As with the Tarot Deck on p. 6, you can make a Style 20 roll for Rosmerta. If successful, you can allow the Hero ask a single yes or no question. No fibbing now! Although you can be as cryptic as possible, of course.



Madame Rosmerta

SMARTS 4 (Occultism)

STYLE 5 (Fortune Telling)

POWER 3 (Fortune Telling and Séance)

MOVES 2

BRAWN 2

Health 2 **Defence** 6

The Monster Mash!

Whether from information gleaned at Mister Scribbens’s office or Madame Rosmerta, the next logical step appears to be a visit to Gotham Gothic Goth Club for Goths.

Housed in the basement of an old industrial warehouse that is now a bridal wholesale outlet, the club is only open after dark, usually from midnight until an hour before dawn. The interior sports a delicately nuanced black-on-very-dark-black decor. All the lighting appears to be strobe or black light (or strobing black lights) and the clientele are, unsurprisingly, all goths in various types of goth attire.

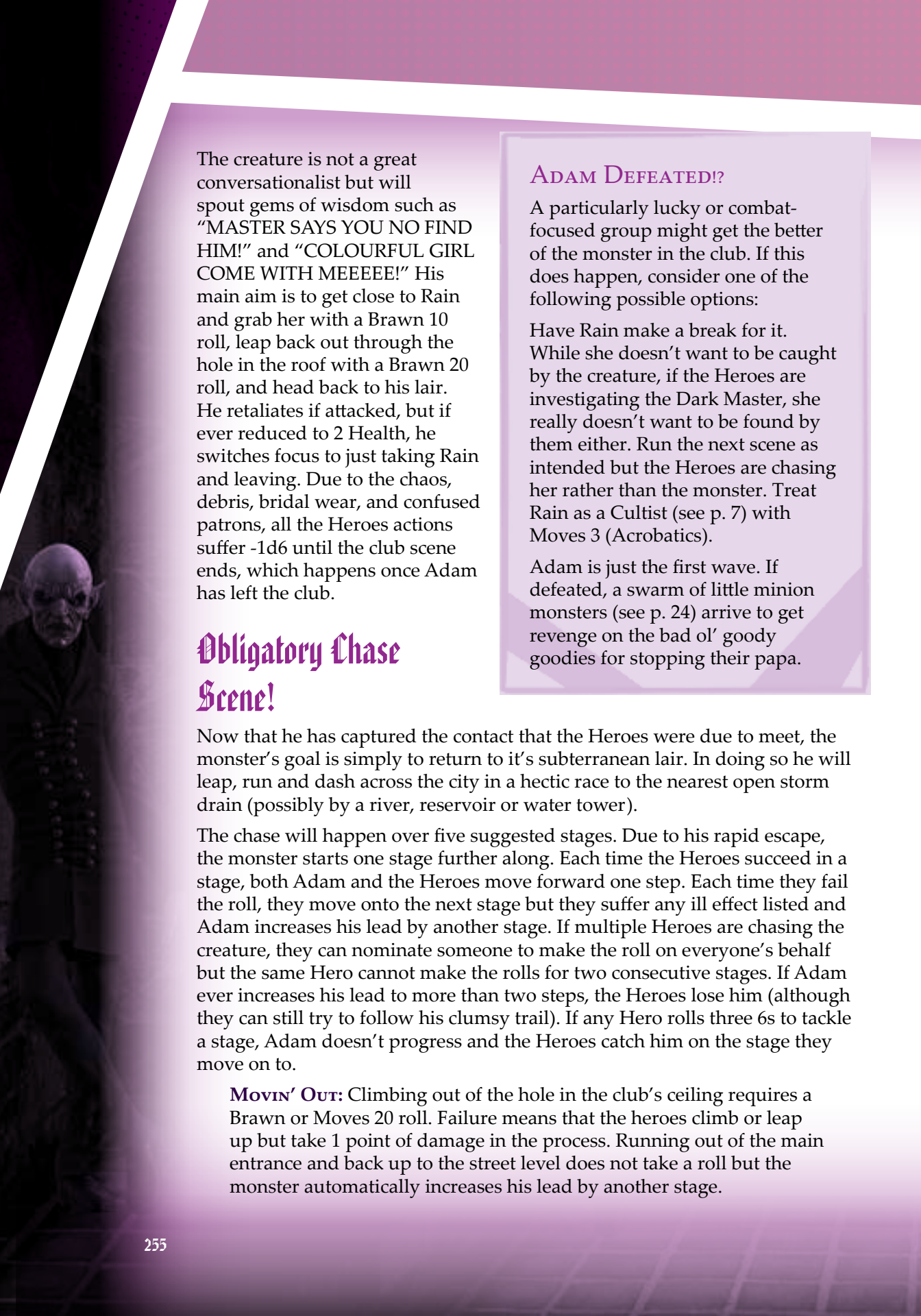
The Heroes may be looking specifically for “the woman with the rainbow hair”. If they are, then her shock of colour is relatively easily spotted with a Smarts 10 roll in the otherwise monochrome club. Failing that, a successful Style 20 roll allows the Heroes to ask around (grant a bonus die if the Hero has made any effort to blend in with the club scene). Asking around and name-dropping Scribbens reveals that he used to regularly attend the club. Folks remember him as he stood out like a sore thumb. The Heroes will be pointed to “Rain”, the colourful haired young woman mentioned by Madame Rosmerta, and informed that she was the only other patron that Scribbens ever seemed to talk to.

A huge crashing sound is heard just before the Heroes reach Rain. They need to make a Moves 20 rolls to avoid being hit by falling masonry and debris as a section of the roof over the dance floor collapses, with failure meaning 1 point of damage. Crashing through the ceiling in a hailstorm of bridal gowns, veils, and assorted accessories is a huge flesh golem; a creature built from the parts of other human beings. The Dark Master has sent Adam to stop the Heroes in their tracks. Things are about to get ugly. And not just because the creature isn’t pretty to look at either.

ADAM

SMARTS 1	MOVES 3 (Jumping)
STYLE 2	BRAWN 5 (Brawling, Tough)
Health 7 Defence 9	
Brawling 7 (2 damage)	
Regenerates 1 Health each round. Cannot regenerate once reduced to zero Health.	





The creature is not a great conversationalist but will spout gems of wisdom such as “MASTER SAYS YOU NO FIND HIM!” and “COLOURFUL GIRL COME WITH MEEEEEE!” His main aim is to get close to Rain and grab her with a Brawn 10 roll, leap back out through the hole in the roof with a Brawn 20 roll, and head back to his lair. He retaliates if attacked, but if ever reduced to 2 Health, he switches focus to just taking Rain and leaving. Due to the chaos, debris, bridal wear, and confused patrons, all the Heroes actions suffer -1d6 until the club scene ends, which happens once Adam has left the club.

Obligatory Chase Scene!

Now that he has captured the contact that the Heroes were due to meet, the monster’s goal is simply to return to it’s subterranean lair. In doing so he will leap, run and dash across the city in a hectic race to the nearest open storm drain (possibly by a river, reservoir or water tower).

The chase will happen over five suggested stages. Due to his rapid escape, the monster starts one stage further along. Each time the Heroes succeed in a stage, both Adam and the Heroes move forward one step. Each time they fail the roll, they move onto the next stage but they suffer any ill effect listed and Adam increases his lead by another stage. If multiple Heroes are chasing the creature, they can nominate someone to make the roll on everyone’s behalf but the same Hero cannot make the rolls for two consecutive stages. If Adam ever increases his lead to more than two steps, the Heroes lose him (although they can still try to follow his clumsy trail). If any Hero rolls three 6s to tackle a stage, Adam doesn’t progress and the Heroes catch him on the stage they move on to.

MOVIN’ OUT: Climbing out of the hole in the club’s ceiling requires a Brawn or Moves 20 roll. Failure means that the heroes climb or leap up but take 1 point of damage in the process. Running out of the main entrance and back up to the street level does not take a roll but the monster automatically increases his lead by another stage.

ADAM DEFEATED!?

A particularly lucky or combat-focused group might get the better of the monster in the club. If this does happen, consider one of the following possible options:

Have Rain make a break for it. While she doesn’t want to be caught by the creature, if the Heroes are investigating the Dark Master, she really doesn’t want to be found by them either. Run the next scene as intended but the Heroes are chasing her rather than the monster. Treat Rain as a Cultist (see p. 7) with Moves 3 (Acrobatics).

Adam is just the first wave. If defeated, a swarm of little minion monsters (see p. 24) arrive to get revenge on the bad ol’ goody goodies for stopping their papa.



CROSTOWN TRAFFIC: While it is late at night, the city never sleeps and the creature's path is taking it across multiple lanes of traffic. The Heroes must make a Moves or Smarts 30 roll. Failure means the Heroes cause a fender bender and leave behind some angry motorists that will need to be placated later.

BACKYARD BRAWL. The monster vaults a chain link fence and heads through a series of yards and backlots, climbing over walls and fences as he does so. The Heroes will need to make a successful Moves or Style 20 roll to follow him. If they fail, they're tackled by an angry hound. Is it a hellhound? That's up to you!

ROLLING ON THE RIVER. Reaching the nearby river, the creature moves against the tidal flow to get to a storm drain. The Heroes need to make a Brawn or Moves 10 roll to avoid being slowed by the current. If they fail, someone loses a random piece of equipment.

DOWN, DOWN, DEEPER AND DOWN: Once through the storm drain, Adam is almost at his lair. The Heroes will find it hard to follow him in the dark and echoey passages and chambers, needing a Moves or Smarts 20 roll with a -2d6 penalty if they have no light source or other means of seeing in the dark. If they fail, they bump into a carnivorous plant that has taken root down here (see *ACE!* p. 25)

If the Heroes are left unconscious or completely lose Adam in some way, they can try to track using a combination of Smarts (looking for clues as to his route) or Style (questioning witnesses along his escape route) 10 rolls. Either way, the Heroes enter the next scene with the monster being fully prepared for their arrival.

Likewise, run a new combat scene if they manage to catch up with the creature. However, the monster will simply try to escape and begin the chase again. If the Heroes do manage to defeat Adam before he reaches his lair, refer to Adam Defeated!/? textbox.

The stages presented are just one suggestion as to how the chase might go. The Heroes may well come up with dozens of potential ways to follow or catch the monster. You should encourage any creative solution they suggest, using the suggestion in the Ghost Trap sidebar and the stages here as guidance on how to adjudicate any madcap plans they come up with. Those pesky Heroes *never* stick to the plan!



Subterranean Sewer Setup

Following the monster will have led the do-gooders straight into its sewer-based lair. The creature dwells in a large chamber formed by the junction of four large storm drains. The east and west pipes exit at the floor level while the north and south pipes exit at about 5ft from the ground. A ledge that extends 2ft from the walls surrounds the chamber at the same height as the north and south pipes. The pipes themselves are about 5ft in diameter and the chamber is approximately 20ft on each side. While there is a constant, slow flow of sewage water running along the ground between the pipes, the edges of the chamber are relatively dry and filled with a variety of salvaged furniture and ramshackle belongings. The place is damp, smelly and dimly lit from a selection of stubby candles, lanterns and flashlights suspended from above.

If the Adam gained more than a single stage lead on the Heroes, then the denizens of the lair are ready for them. Adam, Open-Minded Eve and as many Little Minion Monsters as there are Heroes will ambush the Heroes as they enter. If the creature gained at least a three-stage lead, the Heroes arrive to find that the monsters have torn Rain to pieces. Alternatively, if the creature could only lead by a single stage, he has not been able to summon the whole family to defend the lair and the Little Minion Monsters will not be present.

The lair itself is home to Adam, his shrewd and cunning partner, Open-Minded Eve, and the family of infant Adams that the Dark Master has made for them. A fight with the creatures is inevitable. (Why is she open-minded by they way? The top of her skull is missing, leaving her brain on view. It's pretty gruesome. What else would it be!?!)

Open-Minded Eve

SMARTS 3	MOVES 4
STYLE 3 (Hideous Allure)	BRAWN 5
POWER 5 (Lightning)	
Health 5	Defence 12
Brawling 5 (2 damage)	
Shocking Blast 7 (2 damage, 20ft range)	

Little Minion Monsters

SMARTS 1	MOVES 3
STYLE 1	BRAWN 1 (Brawling)
Health 1	Defence 9
Brawling 3 (1 damage)	

If she still lives, the Heroes can speak to Rain once the monsters are defeated. The treatment she has received at their hands has caused her to reassess her loyalties to the Dark Master. She will maintain that she was only ever an intermediary, passing communications between Scribbens and the cult proper. She offers the Heroes information in exchange for her freedom.



Rain can confirm that the family of monsters are creations of the Dark Master and that his immense power has not yet come to full fruition. She knows that Scribbens was involved in the acquisition and turnaround sale of a number of properties but she has no idea why. She does know that there is an old antiquarian bookshop owner in the metropolitan part of the city who has previously been the only one to get close to discovering the Dark Master's plans. She suggests that the Heroes might wish to learn more from him.

Should the Heroes be defeated by the monsters, all is not yet lost. They are handed over to the cult as prisoners and regain consciousness just in time for **Things Get Most Serious** in Act Three, p. 26.

TURNCOAT RAIN

If the Heroes are having trouble in the sewer fight, Rain may pitch in to help. In that case, as mentioned above, treat her as a Cultist (see p. 7) with Moves 3 (Acrobatics). If she joins the fight, the monsters focus on her rather than the Heroes (with accompanying cries of "KILL THE TRAITOR!"), potentially buying the Heroes time to rally.

Act Three

Things Get Serious(ish)

In order to continue their investigation, the Heroes need to speak with Golden Joe, a seller of antiquarian books in the city's Chinatown district. There are a number of threads that could lead them to him:

- ◎ They could be given his name and location by Rain after the fight in the sewer.
- ◎ If the Heroes triggered some enquiries into the properties that Mister Scribbens had been involved in purchasing (see *The Dark Master's Trail*, p. 18), those investigations finally pay off. A bicycle messenger will hand deliver a message to whichever Hero led the query. Written on fine, handmade paper and sealed with a wax raven, the letter's ornate calligraphy offers a simple invitation: *"My sources have made me aware of your recent research and I believe that we have a similar line of enquiry. I would wish to share information with you which could be to your advantage. Please call upon me at your earliest convenience, Joe."*
- ◎ Heroes of a mystical persuasion or those with focuses in Parapsychology, Occultism, or similar may know Joe by reputation and think to consult him.
- ◎ Heroes might use abilities or gear, such as magical scrying (with a Power roll) or the use of a tarot deck to get a hint as to where to turn next.
- ◎ If all else fails, you can fall back to an earlier *deus ex machina* and have Madame Rosmetra contact the Heroes with a new message from the spirits. She is personally aware of Joe but is openly unsettled by his techniques, stating that her own methods are far superior. She would rather trust in the spirits than... invasive scientific investigation. But if the spirits say that he can help, who is she to argue?

Joe's store is tucked away between a grocery store and a fishmonger. From the outside, it looks like any other used bookshop dotted around the country. Once the Heroes enter, they find themselves in an Aladdin's cave of books, pamphlets, and papers that are, quite literally, stacked from floor to ceiling. Any Hero with a passing interest in the printed word will be overawed and impressed with the rarity, variety, and quality of the collection within the shop. Although everything seems randomly placed in a haphazard stack, every visitor stumbles across something that they've long been searching for.

The proprietor emerges soon after the Heroes enter. He presents a distracted young man who seems overly intent on the tomes around him. He asks the Heroes of their interests and walks between the volumes as he does so, rarely making eye contact. He will initially make a big thing of not being able to hear or understand the visitors (a contrivance on his part to try to dissuade time wasters) until such time as they have introduced themselves

and mention the Dark Master. At the mention of that name, the wiry young man will seem to stiffen, like a new steel has entered the core of his being. A metallic infusion that causes his eyes to shine with an inner fire.

"We share a common foe, this Dark Master. I know not yet who or what he is but his hands creep throughout this city and insinuate themselves into many lives. I would oppose him directly my skills are best served in tracking his followers and gathering information. Thanks to the nuances of social media and modern investigative techniques, I have put some pieces of the puzzle together. If you can share what you have witnessed so far, I will offer my own insights in return."

If the characters agree and tell Joe their story, he will listen intently while taking copious notes in his beautiful, flowing handwriting on a seemingly endless leatherbound tome. He will let the Heroes lead, only asking an occasional question. Once they have concluded their tale, he will stand and head across the room to the largest stack of papers. He nimbly takes a large hardback bookkeeping ledger from the middle of the pile, causing the rest of the stack of books to fill the gap with a resounding thud, not one of them spilling. The book contains records, photographs, and—oddly—social media accounts of all the interactions that Joe can verifiably trace back to the Dark Master. It appears that there have been an increasing series of property purchases and resales, flipping the developments for increasing margins over the last few years.

Reviewing the bookseller’s forensic analysis of financials and social media activity allows a Hero to attempt a Smarts roll, which reveals the following clues if the listed difficulty is met:

Difficulty	Clue
No Test	There are notes instructing Scribbens not to pursue the purchase of the amusement park as it was no longer necessary. “The work is reaching its conclusion.”
Normal 10	The Dark Master and his cult have made a tidy sum, which they seem to be immediately reinvesting. If this continues, they could soon rival larger science-based cults.
Hard 20	The location of the properties is very interesting. Plotted on a map sequentially, they form a Satanic pentagram! Could the purchases actually be part of something more sinister?
Herculean 30	The final purchase is right in the middle of the others and was only finalised in the last fortnight. It is an old mansion house north of the city.

Armed with this knowledge, the next logical step would be for the Heroes to head to the mansion house mentioned as the most recent purchase. If the players do not suggest this, Joe suggests that this is what he would do if he were in their shoes.

Before they leave, Joe apologises for not being able to accompany them. He has some book restoration to take care of in his basement. Opening up his old investigator's gear, he provides each Hero with an item of their choice from the Gear and Technology section, p. 6.

Things Get More Serious

Locating the Dark Master's mansion is a relatively easy proposition. It's a fair drive out of the city to get there but it isn't difficult to find. Questioning local residents reveals that some "outsiders" have been seen around the place but they keep to themselves and haven't caused any trouble. Further enquiries and a successful Style 20 roll divulges that the new residents are only seen between sunset and dawn and that they all look somewhat pale. The locals explain these points away with comments such as "they must commute to jobs in the city during the day" and "professional career people rarely take good care of themselves, but the country air will soon see them right." If nobody suggests it, a Smarts 10 roll indicates that the group could be dealing with a cult of blood-sucking vampires! With this knowledge in hand, the Heroes may decide to only approach the mansion during daylight. If this isn't the case, circumstances conspire to have the group arrive at the mansion around sunset.

The mansion itself is a large building dating from colonial times. It sits alone on a hill and can be plainly seen for miles around. The base of the hill is surrounded on all sides by a gnarled old forest of dead trees. Bordering the forest and marking the perimeter of the mansion's property is a tall wrought iron fence, painted in a gloss black and topped with vicious looking spearhead points.

There is no answer at the mansion's gatehouse as the residents are in the full swing of preparations for the culmination of their ritual. Entering the



Hell Hound

SMARTS 2 **MOVES 3** (Shooting)
STYLE 1 **BRAWN 5** (Brawling)

Health 7 **Defence 9**

Bite 7 (1 damage)

Fiery Breath 5 (2 damage, 15' range)

Takes double damage from silver weapons

grounds will require either a Move 10 roll to clamber over the fence (Heroes who fail suffer 1 damage from the sharpened points on the top of the fence), a Brawn 20 roll to break in or a Moves 20 roll to pick the lock on the gate.

Sneaking through the woods and up the hill requires a Move 10 roll.

This will not dissuade or fool the supernatural guardians of the grounds (see below) but failure will convince a Hero that the forest itself is alive and malevolent. They will think that they hear the whisper of the trees themselves and that the twisted old branches are not just blowing in the breeze but are reaching out for them. Such Heroes are *Spooked!*.

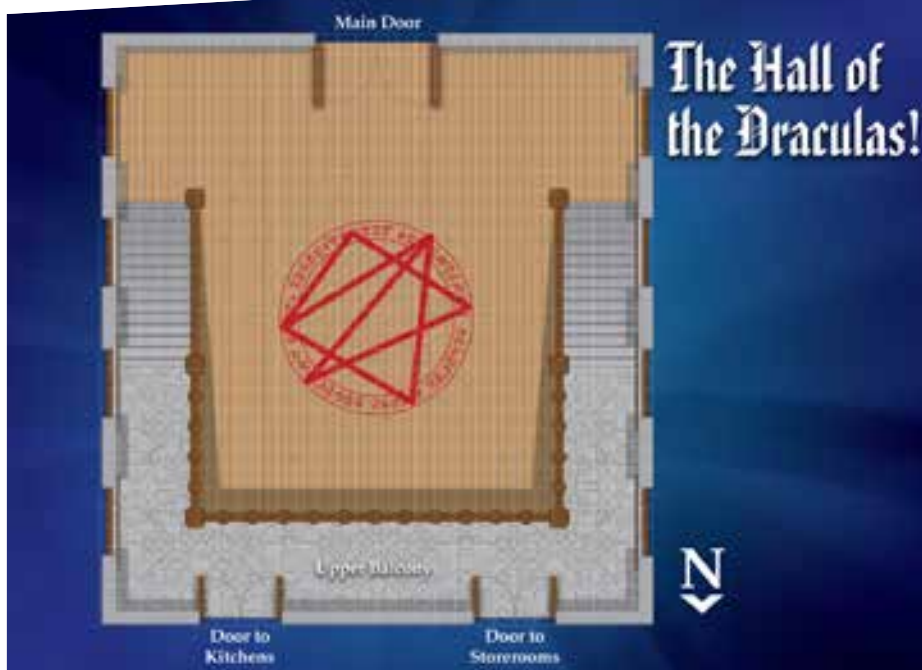
The Dark Master does not wish his work interrupted and has set a pack of hellhounds to guard his land. Due to their supernatural senses, they cannot be avoided and will charge at the Heroes before they reach the mansion. There are two hellhounds in total.

Things Get Most Serious

Regardless of the time of day the Heroes arrive at the mansion a Smarts 20 roll will hear the sounds of eerie chanting building to a crescendo. This close to the building, it's immediately apparent that all the windows have been boarded up. Removing the boards takes a Brawn 20 roll or an attack causing at least 2 damage.

To gain access to the building, the Heroes will need to either get in through a window after removing the boards, pick a lock with a Moves 20 roll, or break in through a door with a Brawn 20 roll. The Heroes may try to enter quietly without alerting the coven of cultists using an opposed Moves vs Smarts roll. If they manage to sneak up on the cult mid-ritual, then they will each get a free turn before their enemies can respond.

The cult itself consists of a group of lesser vamps, debonair crea who have gathered to summon their Dark Master back to Earth. As the Heroes enter the scene, they see the ornately dressed vamps gathered in a circle chanting in an ancient, lost language. On the floor is inscribed a pentagrammic sigil and around and about are black candles, skulls and other tokens of death. Floating in the centre of the circle is a misty red visage...the Dark Master himself!



Currently, the Dark Master is only semi-corporeal but he is aware of what is happening and the Heroes will be able to hear him goading on his supplicant devotees. As soon as the Heroes are spotted, though, he will shout to his minions to “Stop the meddling kids!” and half the vamps will break away from the ritual to engage them. In total there, are two more vamps than there are Heroes. If one is destroyed, then another will be commanded to break off from the ritual to fight the Heroes. As long as at least one vamp remains then, after four turns, the ritual will be complete and the Dark Master will appear...

PRISONERS OF THE CULT

If the Heroes are defeated by any of their previous monstrous opponents (i.e. Adam or the hellhounds) then they will be captured and will eventually awaken to find themselves bound to stone biers as part of the summoning ritual. A sacrificial part, to be precise.

Escaping their bonds will require a successful Moves 20 roll to slip the ropes, a Brawn 20 roll (to break their bonds, or some way of causing at least 1 point of damage). Players should be encouraged to come up with other unique and creative means of escape too. Once at least one Hero is free, the scene proceeds much as outlined above.

It's Really, Really Serious Now!

If and when the summoning is successful, the Dark Master fully reveals himself. All Heroes are *Spooked!* unless they succeed on a Smarts 20 or Style 20 roll.

The Dark Master is that most deadly (and gorgeous) of vampires... a true prince of darkness. As soon as he is fully corporeal, he will sneer at the assembled Heroes

"Fools! You think you can defy me? I may have been banished before by greater than you but now I return, stronger than ever, my new form strengthened by the unholy magicks of this unsanctified place... my minions worked tirelessly to ensure the perfect location, the very sequence of purchases combined with the labyrinthine nature of real estate law coupled with sharp financial practice became an intrinsic component in the occult ritual! My flesh golems, created by my sorcerous workings served as my perpetual servants, acting as the brutal fist of my will, but all this has culminated in this moment...now I am once again flesh, and now I shall personally slay those who dare to oppose my will!!!"

Final battle will be joined between the Heroes, the Dark Master and any remaining Vamp Cultists. No mask pulls here. This a fight to the last drop of blood!



Dark Master

SMARTS 7

MOVES 7

STYLE 6 (Seduction)

BRAWN 8 (Brawling)

POWER 6

Health 8 Defence 21

Bite 10 (2 damage, Dark Master recovers 1 Health)

Killed by sunlight, vulnerable to Holy Water and Garlic, can turn into a hellhound (p. 29) or a ghost (p. 7).

Further Capers

When defeated, the Dark Master dissolves into a pile of ash from which a red mist dissipates with a blood-curdling shriek. Any remaining vampires will flee or simply immolate, unable to sustain themselves without the core connection to their Dark Master.

But is that the end? For **Darkness Bites!** Certainly. The ancient evil of an elder vampire has been vanquished. Our Heroes should feel very pleased with themselves for all they have accomplished. However, the stories don't have to stop there.

Both Madame Rosmerta and Joe may have tasks that require the Heroes' assistance in the future. Likewise, there is the question of the family of monsters in the sewers... did the Heroes manage to stop them all or are there some members of the clan, maybe a host of little minions, looking to get revenge on the Heroes?

Lastly, there is the Dark Master and his cult. When summoned, he alluded to having been banished before, but could he return for a sequel adventure? And what of any surviving cultists? Are they out there somewhere, plotting revenge on our brave group of stalwart adventurers? Only you can answer that for sure...



ACE!

Issue 9

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eroes!**

RUSSE MORRISSEY

Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Heroes!

When crime stalks the streets, the city turns to a ragtag band of plucky vigilantes to keep them safe. These Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Heroes (or AAAH! for short) will fight the fights that we cannot, and keep us safe from those who would do us harm.



It's the year Twenty Something and Something, and MOON LABS, New Bristol's foremost scientific research facility, has accidentally created a team of anthropomorphic animals, who promptly escaped and disappeared into the city. From time to time, these animal heroes pop up to save the day, much to the chagrin of the overworked and underpaid New Bristol Police Department who have yet to catch these menacing vigilantes!

But our Heroes are not the only creatures to have gained human-like sentience. Led by the archvillain Whistler, gangs of talking animals wielding tommy guns and ninja weapons terrorize the streets. His lieutenants include Banjo the rhino, Jerry the frog, and Sliver the rat, and now he has a new nefarious plan to control the whole world using his fearsome psionic powers.

Enter the Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Heroes!

This book takes its inspiration from all the animal crimefighters you remember from Saturday morning cartoons. In *AAAH!* you play an heroic talking animal. You might be a ninja turtle or a mouse detective, or even a kung-fu dog. With even the police against you, your job is to see the streets safe from villains and criminals, and foil the schemes of the Whistler and his evil allies. Good luck: you're going to need it.

Overview

This book contains three sections.

AAAH! The first part of the book, which you'll find in the first part of the book, just before the second part of the book, tells you how to create your Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Hero. You and your fellow Heroes will form a team of fearless defenders and cunning investigators to root out the rot in your city.

NEW BRISTOL. This section of the book describes New Bristol, its important locations, and notable individuals. Of course, you might choose to set your game somewhere else, and we think that's an excellent idea—perhaps your home town might make for a fun adventure location? This section also includes a quick random crime generator and rules for getting about town.

REVENGE OF THE WHISTLER. What's a Whistler? Why is he whistling? Who knows! But a dastardly villain called the Whistler is terrorizing the streets of New Bristol, and only you can stop him! This adventure pits you against a despicable evildoer and his gang of animal goons.

Creating Your Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Hero

You create your Hero the same way as always, but this time you need to be an animal. Obviously. It's right there in the title.

However, there's a twist! Normally in *ACE!* you have a Trait and a Role. But in *AAAH!* (we'll never get tired of saying *AAAH!*) you have *two* Roles. Yep, you heard us. *Two* Roles! Plus an Origin! Wow, this is getting complicated. Sit down if you need to.

One of your two Roles is an animal. Your other Role is an occupation. That means instead of just being a ninja or a turtle, you can now be a ninja turtle! You get the benefits of both Roles. You can arrange them whichever way round you like — cat doctor, doctor cat, whichever you think sounds best.

You can find a big list of occupations on pages 7-9 of *ACE! #1*, including detectives, doctors, reporters, spies, students, and more. We highly recommend the ninja role from the list of fantasy occupations, because ninjas are awesome. At least we think so. We've never seen one.

Here's the Roles we think are particularly appropriate: Boxer, Burglar, Cowboy, Detective, Doctor, Engineer, Inventor, Ninja, Samurai, Scientist, Spy. You might also have fun with Alien or Vampire. But really, it's up to you—if you want to be an Astronaut crimefighter, don't let us stop you. We're sure you'll figure out how to fit in!

New Animal Roles

In addition to the animal Roles in *ACE! #1* we have a whole bunch of fun new animal Roles for you to choose from. *ACE! #1* includes the Ape, Cat, Crow, Dog, Kangaroo, and Turtle. We looked up cartoon animals for ideas, and there are a LOT of dogs and bears. Surprisingly few octopuses. Or is it octopi? Does it even matter?

Of course, this game is about ACCIDENTALLY anthropomorphic animal heroes, with an emphasis on the 'accidentally'. That's right, you don't get to simply choose which animal you are. You have to roll for it!

Now, check the list below. No cheating! (By which we mean 'no getting caught' —look, we're not going to come round your house to check or anything, so we can't really tell you what to do.)

11. **Ape.** You're a walking, talking ape! You can jump 30 feet in the air with no effort. Also, when you throw things, you do an extra point of damage!
12. **Badger.** Badgers are fierce! I know because one used to chase my dog. They're super angry. You regain +1 Karma every time you do melee damage in a fight.
13. **Bat.** You're a bat, and if you dressed like a man, you'd be some kind of Bat-man. You can fly, and you can use your echolocation to see in the dark. And you're pretty good at hiding, getting +1 die when you try to be stealthy.
14. **Bear.** You're big and tough and kinda cuddly. You get +3 Health.
15. **Cat.** Agile and sneaky though you are, your main power is your nine lives! Roll a die; that's how many lives you have left. When you would normally be Knocked Out, instead you remain at 1 Health.
16. **Crocodile.** Those big snapping teeth do 3 damage. Ouchy!
21. **Crow.** You can fly. That's good, isn't it? You don't have to be a crow; you can pick a different bird if you want.
22. **Dog.** A loyal companion, if there's something to smell you can always smell it. Also, sometimes you smell, and you like fetching things. Good dog!



23. **Donkey.** You've heard the phrase stubborn as a mule? Well, a mule is a bit like a donkey. You cannot be mind controlled or mentally influenced in any way.
24. **Duck.** Ducks can swim and fly and quack. Some of these things are more useful than others.
25. **Elephant.** Elephants never forget. You can produce random useful pieces of knowledge from the recesses of your mind. Simply ask the Director, spend 1 Karma, and they'll tell you something super useful. Oh, also you get +1 Brawn.
26. **Fox.** You are oh so cunning! You'd make a great detective... or a great criminal! You get +2 Karma and your Smarts score increases by 1.
31. **Frog.** Bouncing and jumping all over the place with ease! You can scale great heights with your prodigious leap - heights and distances of up to 60 feet. You also have a sticky tongue which lets you grab things from about 15 feet away.
32. **Hamster.** Hamsters store stuff in their cheeks. You won't believe the stuff they store! You can spend 1 Karma and automatically pull out an item with a target number of 10 or less.
33. **Hippo.** Did you know the hippos are the most dangerous animal in the world? And they're closely related to whales. True fact. They're also super territorial. If anybody comes within 10 feet of you, you have to make a Smarts 10 check to avoid bopping them (by which we mean making a melee attack). Rude, if you ask me.
34. **Jackal.** What's like a dog, but a lot less friendly? OK, a wolf. But also a jackal! Jackals are wily scavengers., which makes you really good at finding things. If you're looking for something and it's within 10 feet of you, you find it.
35. **Kangaroo.** Kangaroos pack one heck of a punch! Your punch does an extra point of damage. Most people try to ignore the boxing gloves.
36. **Lion.** You can roar really loudly. Make a Style check vs. the Style of anybody (except your friends) within sight who can hear you. Anybody you beat becomes afraid and cannot approach you for one minute.
41. **Lizard.** You can change color. That makes it easy to hide, giving you a +1 die when you do, but it also makes you very stylish, giving you +1 Style.



42. **Mole.** You are very shortsighted and take a penalty of -1 die to ranged attacks, but don't let that get you down—because you can dig! Yep, you heard us. You can dig underground and move through the earth, under walls, and emerge wherever you wish.

43. **Monkey.** You can climb, you can swing. It's almost like you're flying! As long as you are in an area with enough things to grab on, you are effectively able to fly. Plus, you get +2 Defence.

44. **Mouse.** Wait, what? Cat? Where? You are a master of stealth. You'd make a great secret agent! Anyway, when you sneak you get an extra two dice to roll.

45. **Ostrich.** Ostriches are known for burying their heads in the sand. Well, that's a metaphor. At least we think it is. I guess if you want to actually bury your head in the sand, we can't stop you. But more importantly, you can ignore things, and when you ignore things they don't exist for you. Yes, we know that makes no sense. Anyway, you can designate a creature or object and choose to ignore it.

That creator or object is unable to affect you, but you are unable to affect it. It's like it simply isn't there.

46. **Owl.** Owls are wise and perceptive. In your case, you're definitely the latter! You can see in the dark, and also you can fly. That's a lot like the bat, you say? Well the bat can't swivel its head round like you can, can it?

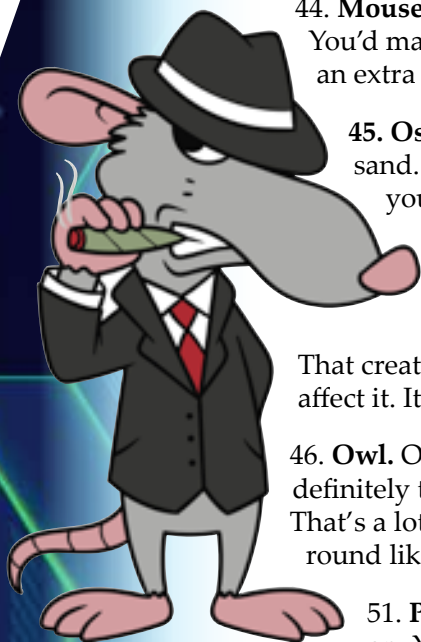
51. **Pig.** Pigs can eat anything. Even pizza with pineapple on. You gain 1 Health by spending a minute eating. Doesn't matter what.

52. **Platypus.** You're such a ridiculous animal that everybody does a double take when they see you. You can make a Style vs. Smarts roll against a target nearby, and if you win they spend the next round gawping in bewilderment.

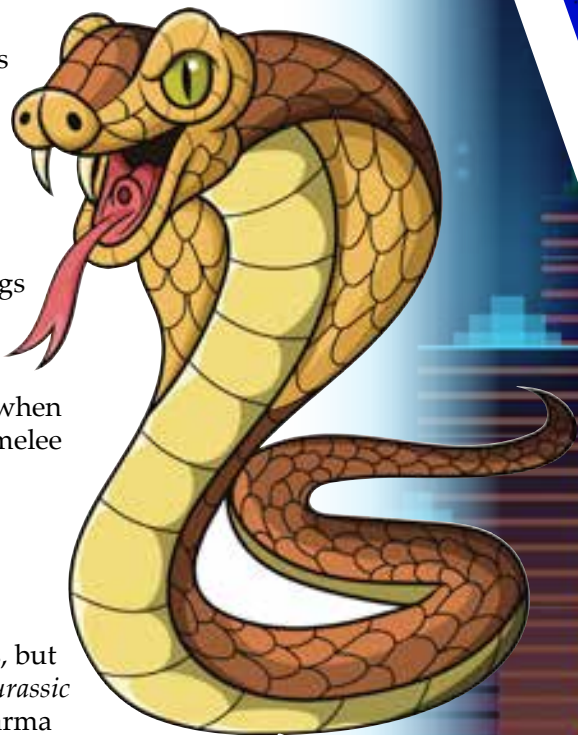
53. **Porcupine.** You're covered in spiky quills. Whenever somebody makes a melee attack against you they automatically take 1 damage.

54. **Rabbit.** I mean, we all know the saying about rabbits. We don't need to go there. That aside, you are great at running away. In any situation, as long as you're not trapped or restrained, you can run away easily.

55. **Rat.** Rats can chew through anything. Seriously, anything. It takes you a minute, but you can bite through any restraints, and in an hour you can chew through a door.



56. **Rhino.** Rhinos are shy, timid little creatures ... nope, scratch that. When you charge at somebody within 30 feet, you deal double damage with any melee attack. If they're your size or smaller, you also knock them down.
61. **Skunk.** Yep, you know where we're going with this one. You can emit a horrible smell. Anybody nearby (yes, that includes your friends!) must make a Brawn 15 roll or spend the next turn doubled over in disgust.
62. **Snake.** You can sway back and forth and hypnotize your prey. Make a Style vs. Smarts roll. If you win, your target will do one thing you say, but they won't harm themselves. Then you can't hypnotize that target again.
63. **Squirrel.** With your big bushy tail, you're so cute! You can run up trees to escape from dogs and supervillains alike. Also, you like nuts.
64. **Tiger.** You're big and fierce, and everybody knows not to mess with you. You get +1 die when you attack and you do +1 damage with any melee attack. Rawwr!
65. **Turtle.** A hero in a half shell, you reduce all damage done to you by 1 point.
66. **Velociraptor.** We all know that velociraptors were really small feathered murder-chickens, but this is *ACE!* so you're a velociraptor like in *Jurassic Park*. You live to hunt your prey - spend a Karma point to designate a prey that you can see. You get an extra die with any rolls against that target, but you cannot switch to a new prey until that target is reduced to 0 Health or a day has passed.



Traits

You have a trait, too, just like always. The Traits list is found in *ACE!* #1, but for convenience we'll list them below. You might be a Lazy Crow Engineer, or a Brave Detective Frog. Or a Teenage Ninja Turtle. Wait, that sounds familiar? Next you'll be saying they're mutants or something. Wait...

Traits list: Abrasive, Affable, Angry, Apologetic, Brave, Beautiful, Cautious, Cheerful, Clumsy, Cocky, Cowardly, Cynical, Elderly, Evil, Greedy, Gullible, Forgetful, Hardy, Heroic, Honest, Impulsive, Inattentive, Kindly, Larcenous, Lazy, Logical, Lustful, Naive, Obsessive, Optimistic, Paranoid, Phobic, Punk Rock, Quiet, Sentimental, Smelly, Squeamish, Teenage, Tiny, Unlucky, Vain.

Your Origin

Why are you all walking, talking animals? MOON LABS, a hi-tech research facility in New Bristol is usually the source of Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Heroes.

Roll d66 again. Don't get too excited — this doesn't give you any special abilities or anything, but it sounds cool. All the Heroes should have the same Origin — this is why they're together!

11. Atomic	31. Genetic	51. Supernatural
12. Augmented	32. Futuristic	52. Electronic
13. Chemical	33. Cosmic	53. Foretold
14. Cybernetic	34. Reincarnated	54. Psychic
15. Magical	35. Elemental	55. Billionaire
16. Mutant	36. Evolved	56. Enchanted
21. Nuclear	41. Clone	61. Symbiotic
22. Radioactive	42. Divine	62. Narcotic
23. Robotic	43. Infinite	63. Cursed
24. Experimental	44. Astronomical	64. Mythological
25. Alien	45. Electronic	65. Immortal
26. Accidental	46. Bionic	66. Demonic



Putting It All Together

Form your descriptor as normal. It will have a couple of extra elements—rather than a Trait and a Role as in other *ACE!* adventures, you have an **Origin**, a **Trait**, and two **Roles**. You can arrange the Roles in any way you wish; whatever sounds best. It should look something like this:

- ⊙ Angry Chemical Frog Detective
- ⊙ Lazy Nuclear Ninja Hippo
- ⊙ Punk Rock Robotic Hamster Engineer
- ⊙ Teenage Psychic Cowboy Dog

If you can't make your mind up, grab a couple of dice and roll your Trait and Occupation randomly too. There's a d66 table on the next page where we've compiled it all for you.

Other Adventures

While we assume in this book that you're going to play vigilante crimefighters wanted by the law, you can use these rules to play any type of anthropomorphic animal adventurers. A gang of ape gangsters in pin-striped suits and tommy guns? Sure! Deputized detectives working for the mayor? Go for it! Heck, combine this with other *ACE!* books and crew a starship with dogs and lizards, or populate the post-apocalyptic landscape with talking kangaroos and velociraptors!

The world, as they say, is your oyster.



D66 ROLL	TRAIT	ORIGIN
11	ABRASIVE	ACCIDENTAL
12	ANGRY	ALIEN
13	APOLOGETIC	ASTRONOMICAL
14	BEAUTIFUL	ATOMIC
15	BRAVE	AUGMENTED
16	CHEERFUL	BILLIONAIRE
21	CLUMSY	BIONIC
22	COCKY	CHEMICAL
23	COWARDLY	CLONE
24	CYNICAL	COSMIC
25	ELDERLY	CURSED
26	FORGETFUL	CYBERNETIC
31	GREEDY	DEMONIC
32	GULLIBLE	DIVINE
33	HEROIC	ELECTRONIC
34	HONEST	ELECTRONIC
35	IMPULSIVE	ELEMENTAL
36	INATTENTIVE	ENCHANTED
41	KINDLY	EVOLVED
42	LARCENOUS	EXPERIMENTAL
43	LAZY	FORETOLD
44	LOGICAL	FUTURISTIC
45	LUSTFUL	GENETIC
46	NAIVE	IMMORTAL
51	OBSESSIVE	INFINITE
52	OPTIMISTIC	MAGICAL
53	PARANOID	MUTANT
54	PHOBIC	MYTHOLOGICAL
55	PUNK ROCK	NARCOTIC
56	SENTIMENTAL	NUCLEAR
61	SMELLY	PSYCHIC
62	SQUEAMISH	RADIOACTIVE
63	TEENAGE	REINCARNATED
64	TINY	ROBOTIC
65	UNLUCKY	SUPERNATURAL
66	VAIN	SYMBIOTIC

OCCUPATION	ANIMAL	D66 ROLL
ACTOR	APE	11
ARCHAEOLOGIST	BADGER	12
ASTRONAUT	BAT	13
ATHLETE	BEAR	14
BOUNTY HUNTER	CAT	15
BOXER	CROCODILE	16
BURGLAR	CROW	21
CHEF	DOG	22
CON ARTIST	DONKEY	23
COWBOY	DUCK	24
DETECTIVE	ELEPHANT	25
DOCTOR	FOX	26
ENGINEER	FROG	31
GAMBLER	HAMSTER	32
GANGSTER	HIPPO	33
GHOST	JACKAL	34
HACKER	KANGAROO	35
HERMIT	LION	36
INVENTOR	LIZARD	41
MUSICIAN	MOLE	42
NINJA	MONKEY	43
OUTLAW	MOUSE	44
PILOT	OSTRICH	45
PIRATE	OWL	46
PRIEST	PIG	51
PROFESSOR	PLATYPUS	52
REPORTER	PORCUPINE	53
ROBOT	RABBIT	54
SAMURAI	RAT	55
SCIENTIST	RHINO	56
SMUGGLER	SKUNK	61
SOLDIER	SNAKE	62
SPY	SQUIRREL	63
STUDENT	TIGER	64
STUNTMAN	TURTLE	65
VAMPIRE	VELOCIRAPTOR	66



Your Base

Every Hero gang needs a base of operations, and you're no exception! Roll on the list below to find out where your headquarters is. You only get one base between all of you, so pick one Hero to make the roll. If you don't like the result, at least you have somebody to blame.

1. You live under the streets, in the sewers, able to pop out through convenient manhole covers across the city.
2. You lair in a cave under City Hall, unbeknownst to the local government.
3. You're exhibits at the zoo, sneaking out at night to solve crimes!
4. You've got a big mansion. No, we don't know how you got it, either.
5. You live in an amusement park, possibly in an underground lair, or working as attendants.
6. You are sent on missions from a top-secret military experimental base.

Legal Status

Roll a die on the list below to determine what the Heroes' relationship with the authorities is.

1. Vigilantes are not welcome. Wanted!
2. Believed to be guilty of a crime they didn't commit. Wanted!
3. Government needs to study them for science. Wanted!

4. Police department is corrupt. Wanted!
5. They messed up a previous case. Wanted!
6. They actually committed a crime. Wanted!

OK, so whatever happens, you don't have a great relationship with the cops. That sucks, because it means you need to stay clear of 'legal' entanglements. Y'know, like cops. Or traffic wardens.

Gathering Info

From time to time, the Heroes will need to obtain some important information in order to continue their mission. Often that will be the location of a particular individual. To do that, they're going to need a contact!

Yep, you know it. You get to roll a die again! This will tell you who the contact is. Don't worry, the contact will never rat on the Heroes.

1. An ace reporter.
2. A cop. Roll again; if you roll a 6 it's the Commissioner!
3. Somebody at the mayor's office.
4. A hacker who is able to get any info in a matter of minutes.
5. A shadowy figure who meets the Heroes in dark alleyways and never shows their face.
6. A network of spies on the city streets.

When the Heroes need a vital piece of information to continue their mission, they can spend 1 Karma to ask their contact. We'll let them decide which of them has to spend the Karma.

Equipment

Crimefighting vigilantes need gear! Of course, you can use anything out of *ACE #1*, but these new gadgets may help you in your battle against lawbreakers.

Normal (10)

Beachball. It's a beachball. What?

Earplugs. Useful if you don't want to hear somebody whistling.

Handcuffs. Snap these on somebody, and they won't be able to break free unless they make a Moves or Brawn 20 roll.

Parachute. Ensures you take no damage when you fall, as long as you fall 10 stories or more.

Pizza. Mmmm. Delicious pizza. Pizza restores 1 Health. And they deliver it. Can you believe that?

Medium (15)

Caltrops. If you need to slow somebody down, throw some of these spiky bad boys down! They'll have to spend a turn making their way over them or take a point of damage.

Ninja sword. Or any kind of sword, really. Does 3 damage. Also other ninja weapons of your choice. We heard once about some turtles who used staves, sai, and nunchaku. Let's just say ninja weapons do 3 damage and leave it at that.

Hard (20)

Jetpack. No wings? No problem! Spend 1 Karma to fly for a turn.

Radar. If your opponents are flying, use this radar to give yourself and all your allies +1 die to shoot them.

Rocket skates. This footwear adds +1 to your Moves score. And it looks really rad. Rad is still a cool word to say, right?

Skeleton key. This thing will open any lock. But each time you use it, roll a die. If you roll a 1, it breaks.

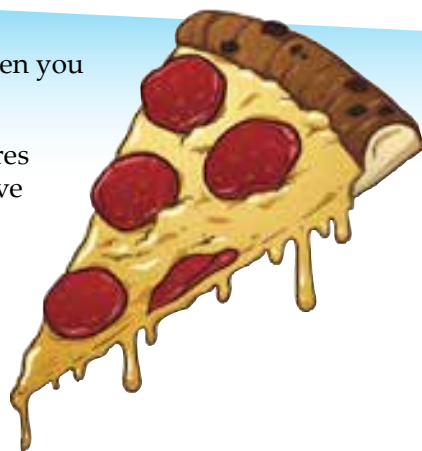
Umbrella shield. When open, this umbrella acts like a shield. Attackers suffer a -1 die penalty when trying to hit you.

Uzi. A submachine gun always comes in handy, and you can pretend you're The Terminator. This Uzi 9mm does 4 damage.

X-ray Specs. These glasses let you see through walls and stuff. Also comes as an eyepatch.

Let's Go!

So you've got an Origin, a Trait, an Occupation Role, and an Animal Role. And you have a base! Now you know whether you're a Cocky Cybernetic Cowboy Kangaroo, a Nuclear Punk Rock Rhino Chef, or a Heroic Mutant Bear Detective. Whoever you are, you're ready to rumble!





New Bristol

The action takes place in New Bristol, a city not unlike New York or London, but with notably more talking animals. Life in New Bristol is much like that in any large city — there are museums and bars and parks and all that good stuff. We're sure you know what a city is like. If you don't, imagine a town, but bigger.

Notable locations in New Bristol include City Hall, the Oliver Peabeard Library, the many museums, including the Museum of Natural Art, and numerous banks just waiting to be robbed. It's a modern city, with all the latest amenities and conveniences, sited on the shores of a large lake.

AVOCADO, Inc.

Avocado is the world's most prolific supplier of hi-tech mobile devices.

Bingo Pizzas

Bingo Pizzas has numerous branches throughout the city. They promise to deliver within 15 minutes or your money back.

Central Botanic Gardens

This mile square area of natural beauty contains a boating lake, a small zoo, picnic areas, an outdoor stage, and plenty of open space for walking, running, playing games, and other healthy outdoor activities. During the day it is usually crowded with thousands of people, but at night it can be quite dangerous.

First Bristol Bank

The biggest bank in New Bristol. It's a bank. What more do you want to know?

MOON LABS

MOON LABS is a privately owned, but government funded (sweet gig if you can get it) state-of-the-art research facility. Here, research is conducted into a wide range of scientifically implausible, cutting-edge, highly experimental projects.

Museum of Natural Art

This is the biggest museum in New Bristol, and is always filled with tourists and students. Different floors of the museum contain dinosaur skeletons, ancient artifacts, and scientific curiosities. The museum is open from 8am until 8pm every day, and it costs \$10 for the day.

NBTV Studios

New Bristol Television Studios creates a broad range of televisual and radio entertainment, from reality shows to ... OK, they mainly make reality shows. They're cheap to make, and they draw in the crowds.

New Bristol University

The university includes a world-renowned archeology department, and the famed explorer Dr. Indiana Bones. It's a mid-sized university with about 5,000 students, studying a diverse array of topics.

Oliver Peabeard Library

This library contains many thousands of catalogued items, from books to books, to... well, books. I think they have magazines and old newspapers and stuff too. Anyway, if you need to do research, the library is a great place, as long as you keep your voice down. No, we don't know who Oliver Peabeard is, either.



The World State Tower

The tallest building in New Bristol, with 100 floors, the World State Tower is an art-deco architectural marvel. It features an observation platform, along with retail and dining facilities.

Random Crime Generator!

Need to quickly generate a crime alert? Look no further than this handy-dandy random crime generator! The crime is perpetrated by a group of **mooks** (one for each Hero).

Roll 2 dice	Crime is taking place...	... at Location
2	Hostages	Avocado, Inc.
3	Arson	Bingo Pizzas
4	Brawling	NBTV Studios
5	Mugging	First Bristol Bank
6	Shoplifting	Central Botanic Gardens
7	Robbery	City Streets*
8	Vandalism	New Bristol University
9	Speeding/Dangerous Driving	World State Tower
10	Drunk & Disorderly	Oliver Peabear Library
11	Murder	MOON LABS
12	Kidnap	Museum of Natural Art

*If you roll City Streets roll one die again: (1) highway (2) alleyway (3) plaza (4) shopping mall (5) bar (6) residential area.

Getting About Town

Do the Heroes have a vehicle? If not, it's probably time for a flashback to when somebody bought one. Spend a Karma and make a Style roll. A cheap car needs a roll of 10, while a luxury car needs a 20. Heck, if they make a roll of 40 they can have a helicopter! Otherwise, it looks like they're on foot.

Difficulty	Vehicle
5	Bicycle, skateboard, roller skates
10	Cheap car or van which may or may not fall apart
20	Decent car, bike, or van like <i>The A-Team</i>
30	Luxury vehicle like James Bond has; might have a trick or two
40	Some kind of supercar or something like out of <i>Knight Rider</i> or <i>Dangermouse</i>

Run Some Red Lights!

There will be multiple times in the game when you're traveling from one part of the city to another, usually on an urgent call by some poor citizen who needs saving from something terrible. You put your foot down, hit the sirens (if you have sirens) and weave through the traffic.

However, you could throw some extra elements into the mix. Roll a single die!

1. **Roadworks.** You know where you're going but you know that city works have dug up one of the main streets that you need to use. Traffic's going to be backed up on the surrounding ones, so getting there is going to be a real pain in the ass. Have the driver make a Smarts 10 roll to calculate a better route.
2. **Flatbed.** A flatbed truck has broken down in the street ahead, strangely stacked high with wooden crates full of chickens. What it's doing in the middle of New Bristol I don't know, but it's there, and it's in the way. You're going to have to swerve around it, mounting the sidewalk and hoping the pedestrians dive out of the way. Make a Moves 10 roll to swerve clear.
3. **Glass.** A couple of guys are carrying a huge sheet of glass across the street ready to fit it into a store front. They're using those little sucker handles, and they're right in the road as you turn the corner. You can make a Smarts 10 roll to spot it, but failing will mean you drive straight through and thoroughly cheese-off those workers. They'll claim for damages from the Heroes in a few days.
4. **Fruit Cart.** Time is running out and you've taken a short cut, but the street is narrow and looks like part of it has been closed for some sort of market. There's something blocking the road, like a taco truck or something, and the only way through is going to be mounting the sidewalk and plowing through that fruit cart. Have the driver make a Moves roll - 10 if they want to smash through the cart and have melons explode everywhere (they'll probably have to pay for that later!) or 15 if they want to swerve to the opposite sidewalk where it's clear.
5. **Wetworks.** Like the roadworks above (1) there's a section of street having work done on it, though it was a surprise and wasn't something that could be planned for. The driver can either make the Smarts 10 rolls like before to think of a way around, or keep going. The roadworks are nearly done, and they've already filled in the hole. If you put your foot down and drive over it fast enough, you won't sink. Surely? Make a Moves 15 roll to gun it over the concrete, spraying the workers, and continuing to the call. Fail, and the car will get stuck and you'll have to pay to have it removed, repaired, and reimburse the city for the damage you've caused.
6. **Nuns!** Suddenly a line of nuns, or ducks, or a cat, or a kid with a ball, appears ahead of you in the street. What the hell are they doing there? It's going to take some quick reactions to swerve out of the way, and you'll probably end up on the sidewalk, knocking over a load of garbage bins, newspaper stands or mailboxes. It's a Moves 15 roll!

Feel free to mix it up, create some new ones, go crazy!

When driving about the city, it's time to throw some kind of obstacle into the mix. Y'know, just to keep things exciting! If you remember *ACE #2: Spirits of Manhattan*, you'll recall doing this before. We've repeated it on the previous page for convenience, though.

Of course, the Heroes might not be driving. If they're running through the sewers, you might have to think fast and come up with something different. A big fatberg, perhaps. A cloud of noxious gas. Some kind of icky slime.

Revenge of the Whistler

New Bristol is a busy city and densely populated. And with dense populations comes crime. The notorious Whistler has been terrorizing the streets with his gang of villainous henchmen, and it's time to stop him!

The Villainous Plan

The Whistler has a simple plan! He can control the weak-minded by whistling. He's powerful, although not powerful enough to control the whole world—but with three special items he will be able to focus and broadcast his psychic whistling powers across the whole planet. See, simple, eh?

If only there was somebody to stop him.

This adventure contains three Acts:

Act I: A City Under Siege. In this Act, the Heroes will foil a series of robberies orchestrated by the Whistler's henchmen. These robberies are how the Whistler is gathering the necessary items for his nefarious plan.

Act II: Following the Breadcrumbs. The Heroes gather information about their enigmatic foe, learning of the Whistler's fiendish plan. Knowing which three items the Whistler was trying to gather, they are able to determine that he will need to broadcast from the highest point in the city.

Act III: The World State Tower. The Heroes ascend the World State Tower for a final confrontation with Whistler and (hopefully) save New Bristol!

The Heroes will (hopefully) foil the Whistler's plans to control the world in the first Act by stopping the three robberies, figure out where he is in the second Act by working out what the three items were for, and finally confront him in the third Act as he attempts to dominate the city of New Bristol in a fit of revenge.



Act I:

A City Under Siege

On The Town

We begin the adventure by introducing our Heroes to the mean streets of New Bristol. In this Act, they will foil three robberies. You can introduce these robberies in any order. But first, let's break the ice with a little encounter on the city streets!

The Heroes are on the streets. Perhaps they're collecting a pizza. Maybe they've just taken in a show. On their way back to their base (you did roll for their base, didn't you?) they see a mugging take place. One **mook** for each hero has surrounded an old lady, laughing cruelly and tossing her handbag to each other while she pleads for its return. Enter the Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Heroes!

The mooks are human — only the major players of this adventure are awesome animals — as is the elderly citizen. They are armed with chains, knives, and baseball bats, although they don't feel the need to draw these until the Heroes intervene.

When the fight is over and the mooks are defeated, the old lady thanks the Heroes tearfully. If they're nice enough to escort her home, give each Hero a Karma point.

With that out of the way, it's time to begin the robberies. In each of these robberies, the Heroes will encounter some of the Whistler's goons. The villain needs some Exotic Matter from the Museum of Natural Art, a valuable gemstone locked in a safe deposit back at the First Bristol Bank, and finally a new TV transmitter device from NBTV Studios.

The goons don't know the plan, but when the Heroes learn of the three items the Whistler is trying to gather, they will be able to figure it out.



ROBBERY #1: Museum Of Natural Art

The Whistler needs a sample of Exotic Matter, which can be found in the Museum of Natural Art's exhibit of rare minerals. This matter will power his diabolical device.

The Heroes' contact alerts them to the robbery at the museum. Use the 'Getting Across Town' rules and play out the journey. They arrive while the robbery is still in progress.

Looking across the street at the darkened Museum of Natural Art your eyes are drawn to a lighted window. You can see silhouettes, clearly visible. As you watch, you are shocked to see one figure raise an arm, clearly pointing a gun at another. Something is amiss, and only you are near enough to help!

Something is, indeed, amiss! A gang of the Whistler's **mooks**, under the leadership of **Banjo** the rhino, is holding the museum's night staff at gunpoint while they ransack the building. Right now they're all in the Rare Minerals exhibit on the 2nd floor. They're seeking a special sample of Exotic Matter, but more on that later.

The Heroes can force entry into the museum with a Moves 15 (to pick the lock) or Brawn 15 (to break down the door) roll. If they want to be quiet about it, they will also need to make separate Moves 10 rolls - succeeding on this means they can get the drop on the bad guys and make the first move.

There is 1 **mook** for each Hero (the mooks are warthogs), plus Banjo the rhino.

The exhibit also includes a giant T-Rex skeleton. The first time anybody rolls a 1 on the Calamity Die, the skeleton topples over, crashing to the ground. Everybody must make a Moves 10 roll or take 1 point of damage from being whacked in the head by a 5-foot bone.



BANJO

Tough but dumb rhino henchman

SMARTS 2 **MOVES 2**

STYLE 2 **BRAWN 6 (Lifting)**

Health 6 **Defence 6**

Horn 6 (2 damage; charging does double damage)



ROBBERY #2:

First Bristol Bank

In a lockbox at the First Bristol Bank is a valuable gemstone, the Arkadian Emerald. This artifact can be used to focus the Whistler's powers, and is important to his plan to dominate the world.

Again, the Heroes are alerted by their contact. As before, run through the 'Getting Across Town' sequence and then read the following.



The bank is an imposing building, a hundred years old, with large pillars bracketing an enormous door. The door is closed, and through the glass you can see that furniture has been piled against it to keep it that way. The cops aren't here yet, but from within you hear a scream!

One **mook** for each hero (these guys are wolves with tommy guns) are holding the customers hostage while **Jerry** the frog raids the safety deposit boxes. He gets distracted, however, by the cash in the vault, giving the Heroes time to stop him!

The villains plan to escape through the sewers, leaving any police cooling their heels in the street outside. There are 6 hostages, each of which is tied up. To untie a hostage a Hero needs to make a Moves 10 roll. That hostage can then run out of the bank to freedom.

Jerry will eventually make a run for it into the sewers.

JERRY	
Greedy frog henchman	
SMARTS 3	MOVES 5
STYLE 1	BRAWN 3
Health 3	Defence 15
Leaping kick 3 (1 damage)	
Jerry can leap heights and distances of up to 60 feet. He also has a sticky tongue which lets him grab things from about 15 feet away.	



ROBBERY #3:
NBTV Studios

NBTV, in partnership with Avocado, Inc., has developed a new, briefcase-sized broadcasting studio capable of transmitting the Whistler's influence across the entire world. Of course, in order to do what Whistler needs it to do, its power needs to be amplified, for which he requires the Exotic Matter from the Museum of Natural Art.

Once more, the Heroes are alerted by their contact. As always, run through the 'Getting Across Town' sequence and then read the following.

NBTV Studios, makers of your favorite show, Love Coaster, where couples meet and have their first dates on a roller coaster. It's the top rated show in New Bristol, and has millions of fanatic viewers.

A window on the second floor of the studio is smashed, and ropes dangle down from the roof. This must be how the dastardly villains gained access!

As with the other two robberies, there's one **mook** for each Hero (this time they're turtles—their names are Mikey, Leo, Donny, and Ralph, and they all have ninja weapons); they're led by **Sliver**, a rat. They're all on the main soundstage, has a giant roller coaster set up on it!

Sliver will grab the briefcase and jump onto the roller coaster. What ensues is a *Temple of Doom*-style chase, with the Heroes in one car and the bad guys in another. Each turn, before anybody gets to act, roll a single die on the following list:

1. **Upside down loop!** Make a Moves 10 roll or fall off the roller coaster, taking 1 point of damage in the process.
2. **Tunnel!** The roller coaster dives into a tunnel, plunging everybody into pitch blackness. When using a ranged attack, a 1 on the Calamity Die means you hit an ally instead.
3. **Jump!** The roller coaster needs to leap a gap in the track! Everybody hold on tight! A Moves 10 check is needed to avoid dropping whatever is held in hand.
4. **Corkscrew!** This terrifying experience requires a Style 15 check to avoid losing your lunch and missing the turn!
- 5-6. **Fork!** The carts each take a different fork and run alongside each other. Melee attacks are possible this turn!

Quick-minded Heroes may think to target Sliver's cart instead of the occupants. This has Defence 10 and 5 Health. When reduced to 0 Health, the cart crashes off the roller coaster, leaving the bad guys bruised and dazed with 0 Health.

SLIVER

Clever rat henchman

SMARTS 5 **MOVES** 4
STYLE 4 **BRAWN** 3

Health 3 **Defence** 12

Pistol 4 (2 damage)

Sliver can chew through anything. It takes him a minute to chew through restraints and an hour to chew through a door.



Act II:

Following the Breadcrumbs

In this Act, the Heroes will figure out the Whistler's plan and learn where his secret base is (spoiler: it's at the top of the World State Tower). They have foiled his plans—for now!—but the fiend has vowed revenge. He may not be able to dominate the world without the three items he needs, but he is still powerful enough to control the city of New Bristol using a transmitter on the top of the tower. A radio message is broadcast to the city:

The radio crackles into life, and a hissing, sibilant voice begins to speak.

"You meddlesome fools think you have won! But you are sadly mistaken. All you have done is strengthen my resolve! Listen and learn, for you have not defeated the Whistler! In 24 hours I shall turn New Bristol into my personal domain, and there's nothing you can do to stop me!"

They know that he required the Exotic Matter, the gemstone, and the briefcase broadcaster. However, in order to determine his evil plan, they will need to work out what these components were for.

First they need to locate an expert for each item. Unfortunately these three experts aren't as easy to get hold of as you'd hope. Wouldn't you know it? Each of them has managed to get themselves into a spot of bother, and will need some help from the Heroes!

The Heroes may need a little nudge at this point. Luckily, today's newspaper has just been delivered, and we've provided a handy page from it here. Give that to the Heroes. If they don't figure it out from that, order a pizza or something instead.

The Heroes may need to call upon their contact to find out where Rocky Rocco's apartment building is.

ENTER
TO WIN
Fairy Tale
Wedding
(page 13)

& New Bristol Gazette &

The Weather



Vol. V • Ed. 1074

16th October, Two-thousand-and-something

25 ¢



BREAKTHROUGH AT MOON LABS

MOON LABS, New Bristol's world-famous research facility, held a press conference yesterday to announce groundbreaking research in the application of antigravity. **Dr Rudolphe Van Grekko**, the Nobel Prize-winning Exotic Matter expert, presented the latest findings, which she promises will revolutionize multiple technology sectors.

ANCIENT VIKING SHIP UNCOVERED

A thousand-year-old Viking longship named *Ormurin Langi* ('Long Serpent') has been discovered on the outskirts of New Bristol. Eminent archeologist **Dr. Indiana Bones** (34) of New Bristol University is heading up a deep delve into the wreckage, which is buried over 40 feet below ground. Dr. Bones has spend his career searching for the Arkadian Emerald. The stone, said to have special properties, has been missing for hundreds of years.

AVOCADO INC. UNVEILS LATEST PRODUCTS

As they do every year, the world's leading mobile device manufacturer, Avocado, Inc., which is maintains its headquarters in New Bristol, has unveiled its latest product line. Among the new cellphones, tablets, goggles, and tea-cosies for which Avocado is famous, much buzz arose around the latest Avocado Portable Broadcasting Studio, which reduces the size of a television or radio studio to that of a simple briefcase. Lead technician **Rocky Rocco** (29) spoke to reporters from outside his apartment building.

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Exotic Matter

Dr Rudolphe Van Grekko, a chameleon chemist at MOON LABS, can tell them that the Exotic Matter can be used as a power source. Unfortunately, an experiment at MOON LABS has gone awry and if they Heroes don't save Rudolphe, they'll never get the information they need.

MOON LABS. Home. This is where you first gained sentience. MOON LABS is where all sorts of scientific experiments take place. You know you need to be careful — anything could be happening in there! Standing outside you can hear loud crashes which seem to occur every 60 seconds or so. Some experiment gone awry? There's only one way to find out!

It's easy to get into MOON LABS. The Heroes can simply walk in through the front door. Normally there is security, but now it's all in chaos.

MOON LABS' new antigravity generator has gone wild. Everything that was up is down, and everything that was down is up. Even worse, it switches every minute, so things are constantly crashing upwards, then downwards, then up again.

As you can imagine, it's made quite a mess.

If you can, get a timer and set it to one minute. Every time it runs out, the gravity switches, and everybody plummets to the ceiling, or the floor, and takes 1 damage.

Of course, things are worse than that. Some experimental **velociraptors** are loose, and they're mad. They will attack anybody and everybody, including the Heroes. Rudolphe is holed up in her office, hiding in the closet (it's built-in which means she doesn't fall so far each time the gravity switches).

Velociraptors

SMARTS 1 (Tracking)	MOVES 5
STYLE 2	BRAWN 4
Health 4 Defence 15	
Pistol 4 (1 damage)	
When attacking in a group of 3 or more velociraptors, each gains +1 die to attacks.	

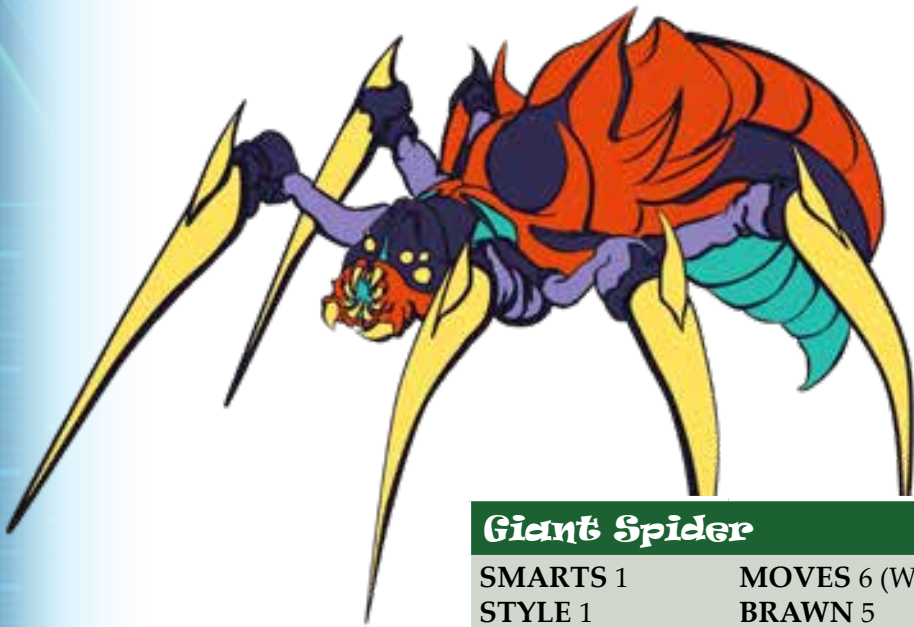
Gemstone

Dr Indiana Bones, a dog archeologist at New Bristol University, can tell them that the gemstone is the Arkadian Emerald, said to be able to focus psychic power. He'd be happy to help, but the Heroes will need to find him—he's currently exploring an ancient tomb on the edge of town. At least he's supposed to be; he's been missing for a couple of days, and Dean Bosco (a bear) is worried for his safety. Perhaps the Heroes can go look for him?

The tomb is rumored to be the final resting place of Erik Eriksson, a Viking from the 10th century. Erik's ship is buried underground, which is kinda odd given that New Bristol is hundreds of miles inland. But who said the *Awfully Cheerful Engine!* made sense? Not us, that's for sure.

The excavation leads to a hole with a wooden ladder extending down into the darkness. You can smell the dank, rotting wood of the ancient ship buried below. Cobwebs are everywhere, on the ladder, on wooden beams and blocking doorways. Tiny spiders crawl across them, and up the walls and ceiling. There are broken tables and rusting metal tools and helmets littering the place. As ships go, this isn't one you're going to be booking a luxury cruise on!

Anyway, Dr. Indiana Bones is deep underground, exploring the *Ormurin Langi* (it means 'Long Serpent') but he's run into a pair of **giant spiders**. They've trussed him up in their sticky webs down in the cargo hold, presumably planning on having him for dinner later, and the Heroes have arrived just in time.



Giant Spider

SMARTS 1

MOVES 6 (Webs)

STYLE 1

BRAWN 5

Health 5 Defence 18

Poison bite 5 (2 damage, makes target Sick)

Sticky Web 8 (0 damage, 30-foot range, restrains target, needs Brawn 10 check to escape)

Broadcaster

An aardvark technician called **Rocky Rocco** at Avocado, Inc. maker of the world’s most popular mobile devices, is able to tell them that a broadcast from a sufficiently high point, such as the World State Tower, would be needed to reach the whole city. Rocco has gambling debts, and right now he’s hiding from the mob — three **crow mobsters** are outside his apartment building.

The building is dark. It’s an older 3-story apartment block, and you can see a rickety fire escape running down the front of the building’s facade. Parked in the road you can see a sedan, and within you can just about make out the silhouette of the driver—it looks like crow wearing a trilby! Looking closer, you can see another crow on the fire escape, clearly holding a baseball bat, and one at the apartment building’s front door. There’s something fishy going on here!

Crow Mobster	
SMARTS 3	MOVES 3
STYLE 3	BRAWN 3
Health 3	Defence 9
Pistol 3 (2 damage)	
Baseball bat 3 (2 damage)	
These crows can fly.	



The crows take to the air and shoot at the Heroes with their pistols. If the Heroes defeat two of them, the third flees. Rocco is extremely grateful, and will gladly share any confidential information from Avocado, Inc. with the Heroes.

Putting It All Together

These three clues should lead the Heroes to the World State Tower and their confrontation with the Whistler!

The Whistler’s original plan was to dominated THE WORLD! Without those vital components, his plan is foiled; but he is still powerful enough to control the whole of New Bristol from a transmitter atop the tower, and this is what he now plans to do.



Act III:

The World State Tower

So now the Heroes know where the Whistler is — at the top of the World State Tower. Look, this is basically the Empire State Building. 100 floors, Art Deco style, the tallest building in New Bristol.

The World State Tower is currently undergoing renovations, and that means the elevators are shut off. Damn inconvenient, if you ask me.

Whistler, who it turns out is a hooded cobra, is indeed, at the top of the tower, along with some of his henchmen.

The Heroes have foiled the Whistler's plans, so he's not very happy. He knows they'll be coming, and now he has vowed revenge. He has placed henchman on important floors to slow the Heroes down, and is waiting at the top with his personal guard of ninjas.

Climbing the Tower

100 floors is a long way and with no elevators the Heroes will have to use the stairs. Have you ever tried to climb 100 flights of stairs? It's not fun. Look, the Heroes will probably have to stop for a picnic or a nap or something partway up. We understand.

On the way up, the Heroes will pass through some notable floors guarded by the Whistler's henchman. Each group of henchmen contains one **mook** for each Hero, plus one of the lieutenants below — **Tango** the tiger, **Jacko** the jackal, and **Burt** the bear. You can roll randomly on the animals table at the beginning of the book to determine what the mooks are. If you want. It's up to you.

1st Floor Foyer

The ground floor of the tower is the lobby. It contains some shops, a reception desk, the (non-working) elevators. This floor is guarded by **Tango** and his **mooks**.

TANGO

Fierce but loyal tiger henchman

SMARTS 3 **MOVES** 4

STYLE 3 **BRAWN** 4

Health 4 **Defence** 12

Claws 4 (2 damage)



35th Floor Maintenance

This floor is not usually accessible to the public, and the elevators usually head right on past. It's the maintenance floor, with crates of supplies, janitorial storage, and random unexplained electrical wiring which is sparking dangerously. The floor is quite the maze. It's guarded by **Burt** and his **mooks**.

BURT

Really a nice bear underneath

SMARTS 2 **MOVES** 2

STYLE 2 **BRAWN** 6

Health 6 **Defence** 6

Bearhug 6 (2 damage)

86th Floor Observatory

This floor is an open-air observatory with 360-degree windows all around, giving a wonderful view of New Bristol. In the center of the room is a 20-ft ape statue, surrounded by detailed 3-ft. long biplanes. It's guarded by **Jacko** and his **mooks**.

JACKO

Sly, mean-spirited jackal henchman

SMARTS 4 **MOVES** 4

STYLE 4 **BRAWN** 2

Health 2 **Defence** 12

Uzi 4 (2 damage)

100th Floor Top Deck

This is the famous top deck of the tower, and where **Whistler** is hiding out along with his most trusted goons. Whistler himself isn't that much of a physical threat, but he does have psychic powers which let him control others. He will try to turn the strongest Hero against their allies.

Whistler isn't alone, of course. He is protected by **ninjas** (one for each Hero).

This floor consists of a central room, surrounded by a wide balcony which encircles the tower. There are numerous protrusions from this balcony, which can be walked on or swung from, but falling from one... well, you did pack that parachute, right? Right?

Also on this floor is a radio transmitter. Destroying this transmitter will prevent Whistler from broadcasting to the city. Anybody can break the transmitter with a Brawn 15 roll.

So, these are the Heroes who have been interfering with my plans? I was expecting you to be more... impressive. No matter! You may have foiled my genius plan to control the world but I shall have my revenge! New Bristol will suffer for your interference! My ninjas..... attack!



WHISTLER

Sinister evil snake genius

SMARTS 6	MOVES 5 (Dodging)
STYLE 6	BRAWN 4
POWER 4	

Health 4 Defence 21

Bite 2 (1 damage and target is poisoned losing 1 more Health on their next turn)

Whistle. The Whistler makes a Power vs Smarts check against a target within sight who can hear him. If he succeeds, that target will do anything he says for 1 minute.

NINJA

SMARTS 2	MOVES 6 (Climbing)
STYLE 2	BRAWN 3 (Brawling)

Health 3 Defence 18

Sword 5 (2 damage)



Conclusion

With the Whistler defeated, the city will finally appreciate the Heroes for the darned heroes that they are, right?

Wrong.

No, somehow the Heroes get the blame. They're still wanted by the law. But they get to fight crime another day, and that's something. New Bristol is never short of lawbreakers and megalomaniac villains, and only a plucky band of Accidentally Anthromorphic Animal Heroes can stop them!

Further Adventures

Crime never sleeps! Here's a few ideas for those who would like to continue with *Accidentally Anthropomorphic Animal Heroes*.

The Rat King. Sliver, one of the Whistler's henchmen, is now hiding out in the sewers. Using a serum stolen from MOON LABS he has begun building a rat army in order to overrun the city. Already civilians are being attacked by rat gangs who climb out through manhole covers to strike fear and discord across New Bristol. Can the Heroes find the Rat King's lair down in the labyrinthine sewers, and what about that giant alligator down there?

Robot City. An experiment crimefighting AI at Police HQ goes rogue and starts to take control of the city streets in a misguided attempt to clean up New Bristol. Robot cops stalk the streets and punish the smallest misdemeanor. The citizens hide in their homes. Only our Heroes can defeat the robot cops and stop the AI!

The Land That Time Forgot. Central Botanic Gardens has been taken over by dinosaurs! They roam the park, turning it into a version of *Jurassic Park*. Nobody knows where they came from, but a mysterious signal emanates from the zoo in the center of the park. Can the Heroes get through the dinosaurs to the zoo and stop whoever is causing them to run amok?

Monkey Business. Gangster apes have taken over the city! Even the cops are afraid to cross them. Dressed like 1920s gangsters, these apes look and sound like something from an Al Capone movie.



ACE!
Extras

Pregenerated Characters

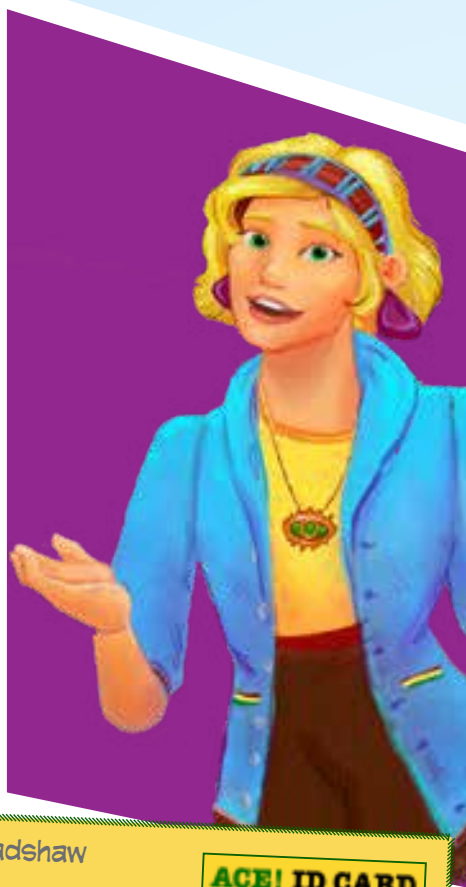
What follows is a collection of pre-generated Heroes you can use if you're short on time. There's a set for each of the adventures in this book, but of course you should feel free to mix and match if you prefer! These Heroes can be used as-is, or customized to your own tastes.

SPIRITS of Manhattan

Dr. Aurora Bradshaw

Daughter of hippy parents, adopted by the Martins after they are killed in a fire. She's a doctor of psychology and parapsychology, determined to document and prove the existence of ghosts after witnessing a paranormal event as a teenager.

Her work and research at the University is often mocked, but thankfully she is left to her own devices in her lab.



Name **Dr. Aurora Bradshaw**

Trait/Role **Obsessive Scientist**

ACE! ID CARD

Health **2** Defence **9**

Stat Dice

Smarts **4** (parapsychology)

Moves **3** (running)

Style **3** (persuasion)

Brawn **2** (carrying)

If a monster has a weakness, you know it automatically. It's just a question of physics.



Carlos Martin

Carlos, with his adoptive sister, witnessed the paranormal as a teenager. Instead of turning to science, he turned to religion joining the church. However, his research into spirits continued, and he was excommunicated for his unfaltering fascination with becoming an exorcist. Before joining the team he was traveling the country, hoping to find his faith once more.

Name Carlos Martin

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role Curious Priest

Health 2 Defence 8

Stat	Dice	
Smarts	3	(theology)
Moves	2	(stealth)
Style	5	(bluffing)
Brawn	2	(sports)

The undead cannot harm you. They're still pretty scary, though.

Dr. Miles Wheeler

The real brains behind the group and creator of most of the super-science technology the team uses to battle the spirits. He's a doctor, in theoretical physics and engineering. He doesn't really talk about his past, and finds talking to people a little unsettling.

Finds science the most fascinating thing and loves the more outlandish multidimensional hypothetical theories around.



Name **Dr. Miles Wheeler**

Trait/Role **Naive Engineer**

ACE! ID CARD

Health **5** Defence **8**

Stat Dice

Smarts **5** (engineering)

Moves **2** (shooting)

Style **2** (animals)

Brawn **3** (tough)

If something is broken, you can fix it within an hour. Well, within reason. Not like the Golden Gate Bridge or something, but a vending machine or a car.



Kymberlyn Gardner

Ex-marine, Kim has been working as a taxi driver for the last two years, hoping to earn enough to set up her own private security or chateur service. She's generally very skeptical, but struck up a friendship with Aurora after chatting in the cab. No nonsense, tough and streetwise, she's picked up lots of information about the streets of Manhattan through her driving.

Name Kymberlyn Gardner

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role Abrasive Driver

Health 4 Defence 12

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (engineering)

Moves 4 (driving)

Style 2 (dancing)

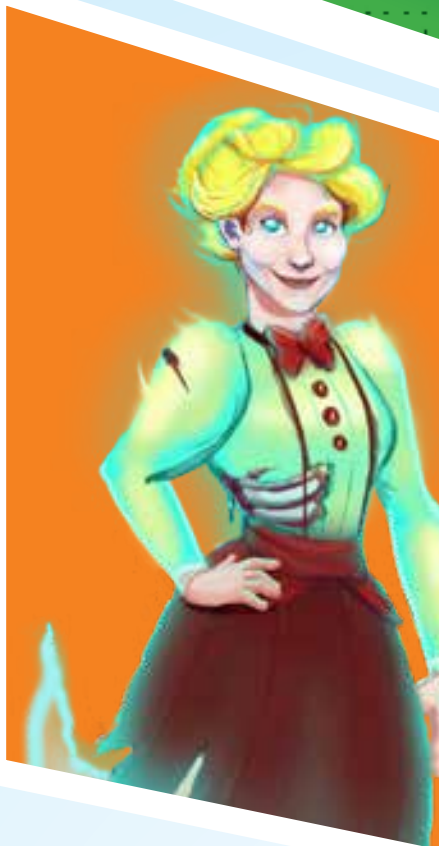
Brawn 4 (brawling)

When you're driving somewhere, you get there in half the time.

Emeline Holt

Emeline was once a school teacher in the quiet rural town of Harper's

Hollow, who enjoyed teaching children of all ages. She fell in love with a local man, Edward Barry, who promised he'd return from his trip to the city to marry her. She waited for his return in a storm and died of exposure. That was 1876. As a ghost, she chose to seek Edward, and came to New York hoping to find her one true love. She was one of the first ghosts that Dr. Wheeler tried the anti-plasm particle accelerators on—though they worked too well and Emeline is completely corporeal now. Not “alive”, but solid and unable to move on. She has difficulty with modern technology, but is learning how to answer the “telephone” and assign the team to their emergency call-outs. Despite being 134 years old, you have the appearance of a young woman in her late twenties.



Name **Emeline Holt**

Trait/Role **Kindly Ghost**

ACE! ID CARD

Health **3** Defence **9**

Stat Dice

Smarts **3** (history)

Moves **3** (cooking)

Style **3** (singing)

Brawn **3** (intangible)

You don't take damage unless its from a holy source or some special sci-fi ecto-gadget. But you also can't pick things up. So there's that.

MONTANA DRONES

AND THE RAIDERS OF THE CUTTY SNAKE



Dr Abigail Elizabeth Joens, aka Montana Drones

Professor of History at Halcyon Hall

Somewhat monotonous lecturer by day, international artefact hunter by night. Dr Abigail takes her role at the all-girl Bennett College very seriously. She also takes great pride and enjoyment in the adventures she undertakes to snatch ancient relics from under the noses of nefarious villains. Unfortunately, she's also come to learn that those artefacts sometimes bite the hand that liberates them. In addition to her historical expertise, Dr Abigail is the College's most prestigious fencing instructor.

Montana Drones uses the Archaeologist or Professor Occupation from the ACE! core rules.

Name Montana Drones		
Trait/Role Cocky Archaeologist		
Health 3	Defence 9	
Stat	Dice	
Smarts	4	(history)
Moves	3	(shooting)
Style	2	(bluffing)
Brawn	3	(brawling)

ACE! ID CARD

Gear: Fencing Foil (5 dice, 2 damage), leather shoulder satchel, fedora hat, .45 revolver (pistol)

Lou Doble

Dean of Art at Halcyon Hall

A student of art from many cultures, Lou has used her studies to learn a great understanding of the motivations and idiosyncrasies of ancient and modern civilisations. Lou's prominence in the art world and connections to many other famous sculptors of her time mean that she can open doors that are often closed to anyone outside of high society. Although great friends, Montana and Lou frequently banter or outright disagree over the traditional perceptions of ancient civilisations and Lou's insightful observations to how those cultures functioned. Lou's position as Assistant Dean is a large part of the reason that Montana and her team are able to lead double lives.

Lou uses either the Socialite Occupation from the *Raiders of the Cutty-sark* adventure, or the Gangster Occupation from the *ACE!* core rules.



ACE! ID CARD

Name Lou Doble

Trait/Role Optimistic Socialite

Health 4 Defence 9

Stat

Dice

Smarts 3 (anthropology)

Moves 3 (acrobatics)

Style 4 (wealth)

Brawn 2 (tough)

Gear: Sculpting tools, veiled Eugénie hat, derringer (pistol)



Jonah Henry Jr

Assistant Librarian at Halcyon Hall

An academic dreamer and master of ancient languages, Jonah claims to prefer the quiet and solitude of the college's library to the exciting world of adventure that Montana frequently drags him into. He puts up a fight against Montana's insistence over joining the team every time she comes calling, to the point that it's now something of a ritual between the two. Once onboard, however, Jonah soon bubbles with excitement, his backpack brimming with books as he races to catch everyone up. Short and stocky, his enthusiasm and dogged willpower mean he is more than capable of keeping up with the team despite often trailing in their wake.

Jonah uses either the Detective or Professor Occupation from the *ACE!* core rules.

Name Jonah Henry Jr

Trait/Role Clumsy Professor

Health 4 Defence 8

Stat Dice

Smarts 4 (history, languages, occultism, theology)

Moves 2 (dodging)

Style 2 (gambling)

Brawn 4 (carrying)

Gear: Backpack of books, umbrella, panama hat

ACE! ID CARD

Johnnie Cobbler

Groundskeeper at Halcyon Hall

A talented landscaper and accomplished botanist, there is little that Johnnie doesn't know about flora and the fauna that can inhabit them. If he does find himself lacking in a particular area, he seeks out his auld friend Jonah and slips him a dram or two to secure use of the college library for a short time. Johnnie's expertise concerning the plant and animal kingdoms has saved the life of his colleague's more than once during their expeditions, although he remains extremely humble about the fact. Just don't trample his shrubbery or leave footprints on his lawn or you will soon find yourself on the wrong side of a scathing Scottish tirade.

Johnnie uses either the Botanist Occupation from the *Raiders of the Cutty-sark* adventure, or Ranger Occupation from the *ACE!* core rules.



Name Johnnie Cobbler

Trait/Role Cynical Botanist

Health 3 Defence 12

Stat Dice

Smarts 3 (botany)

Moves 4 (stealth)

Style 2 (disguise)

Brawn 3 (brawling)

Gear: Gardening tools, Webley revolver (pistol), tartan flat cap

ACE! ID CARD

STRANGE SCIENCE

Name Oma Oates

Trait/Role Awkward Brain

ACE! ID CARD

Health 2 Defence 9

Stat Dice

Smarts 5 (Computers)

Moves 3 (Running)

Style 2 (Bluffing)

Brawn 2 (Parrying)

You're clever and you know stuff. Usually the stuff you know is really nerdy. Sometimes it's actually useful. You can spend a Karma point to ask the Director a single 'yes/no' question which they will answer honestly. Oh, and clever cogs -- the question should be about the game, not the Director's personal life!

Name Xavier Xiong

Trait/Role Cocky Athlete

ACE! ID CARD

Health 4 Defence 9

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (Perception)

Moves 4 (Running)

Style 2 (Persuasion)

Brawn 4 (Sports)

You can move twice as far in your turn. Normally you can move 10 feet per point of Moves, but you're an Athlete - you can move 20 feet per point of Moves!

Name Hollie Hodge

Trait/Role Sassy Cheerleader

Health 1 Defence 9

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (Languages)

Moves 3 (Acrobatics)

Style 5 (Dancing)

Brawn 2 (Intimidating)

Everybody loves you (or at least pretends to). Plus you can do acrobatics and stuff. But mainly, you can cheer people on to be their best selves. You are able to grant your Karma points to your friends.

ACE! ID CARD

Name Nova Norcross

Trait/Role Rebellious Outsider

Health 3 Defence 15

Stat Dice

Smarts 3 (Perception)

Moves 3 (Dodging)

Style 3 (Persuasion)

Brawn 3 (Brawling)

You don't fit in. Always a loner, you have learned to be very observant and you always know when somebody is lying.

ACE! ID CARD

Name Blanch Burdick

Trait/Role Shy Experiment

Health 2 Defence 9

Stat Dice

Smarts 3 (Medicine)

Moves 3 (Stealth)

Style 2 (Disguise)

Brawn 2 (Intimidating)

Power 2 (Telepathy)

You have telepathic powers! You have a Power score which you can use in the ways described in ACE! #1

ACE! ID CARD

BEAM ME UP

CAPTAIN WAYJANE CAPTAIN OF THE FSS BRAZEN



Wayjane is the quintessential embodiment of a starship Captain. Look up Captain in the dictionary and this guy's name is listed at the top of the descriptions. He was literally born to be a starship Captain. Compassionate, stern, tough, expressive, charismatic and heroic are just some of the words his crew use to sum him up. He can also get a little bit angry. Wayjane is confident that each one of his crew would follow him into the jaws of hell if he requested it, even if he asked them all to pull on a red shirt. Oh, and watch out for his iconic chop to the neck. It's a real fight finisher!

Name Captain Heironymus Wayjane

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role Suave Captain

Health 5 Defence 9

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (Perception)

Moves 3 (Acrobatics)

Style 4 (Persuasion)

Brawn 3 (Tough)

Gear: Blazer, Communicator Badge

You command a starship. Yes, you! You are so goddamn inspiring that you have 10 Karma instead of 6. That's how goddamn inspiring you are! You can also spend your Karma on another Hero's behalf, granting them one of the benefits from p. 15 of the core rules, although you can't do this if they've spent their own Karma in the same round.

CHIEF SCIENCE OFFICER SPOKE

CHIEF SCIENCE OFFICER AND SECOND-IN-COMMAND OF THE FSS BRAZEN



Sometimes wrongfully described as cold and unemotional, Spoke is the bridge crew's perfect counterbalance to Wayjane's enthusiasm, which, let's face it, sometimes runs away with him. It isn't that she lacks emotion, just that she sets it aside to better focus on the task at hand, whether that's analysing data from a nebula, organising the starship's crew or rescuing the Captain from the jaws of yet another gribbly alien. All that said, the rare smiles that she graces the crew with are scary enough to send even the toughest of Kulkans running in terror.

Spoke uses the Professor Occupation from the from the *ACE!* core rules. Is she also a robot, or just devoid of emotion? That's up to you!

ACE! ID CARD

Name Spoke

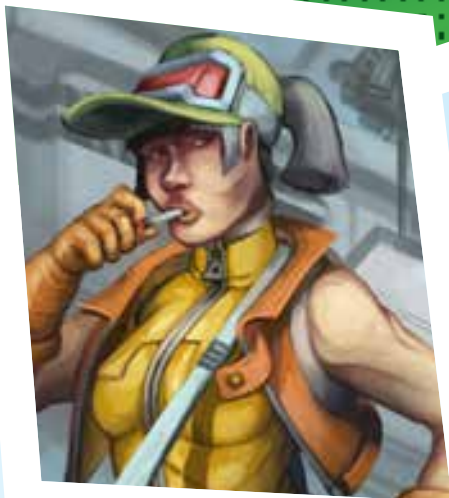
Trait/Role Intellectual professor

Health 3 **Defence** 9

Stat	Dice	
Smarts	4	(History)
Moves	3	(Shooting)
Style	2	(Bluffing)
Brawn	3	(Brawling)

Gear: Blazer, Communicator Badge, Scientific Scanner

You know stuff. You get free Focuses in History, Languages, and Theology.



CHIEF MEDICAL OFFICER MCBOLD

CHIEF DOCTOR OF THE FSS BRAZEN

Being a doctor in the FLoP is pretty cool. There are all sorts of technologies available to help with diagnosis and cure, plus if you don't have exactly the tools or compounds you need, you can almost always turn to the facsimilator and magic them up. It's truly rewarding but never really challenged Leondra, so she signed up for Spacefleet and joined the *Brazen* on its five-year mission. Some say she can be cranky and hot-tempered, but it's only because she wants to make sure every crewmember makes it home, dammit!

Name		Leondra 'Crunch' Mcbold	
Trait/Role		Passionate Doctor	
Health	3	Defence	8
Stat		Dice	
Smarts		4	(Medicine)
Moves		2	(Dodging)
Style		3	(Gambling)
Brawn		3	(Intimidating)
Gear: Blazer, Communicator Badge, Medical Scanner			
Medic! You can heal people. For every Karma point you spend, you heal somebody (or yourself) one point of damage. This takes you a minute, but you can spend as much Karma as you like.			

CHIEF ENGINEER MACKEM LA KILN CHIEF ENGINEER FOR THE FSS BRAZEN



As part of a family that served on other far-reaching missions, Mackem grew up in Spacefleet. It's in his blood. He got to explore starships a lot and learned his way around their insides thanks to their maintenance crawl spaces, or juniper tubes. The ship's computer was his constant companion in those days and he got to see engineering from a whole new perspective. Where most people view a starship as a means of moving from A to B or blowing stuff up, Mackem looks at them as living, breathing entities that need plenty of care and attention. Give Mackem some duct tape, bubble gum and pencil shavings and he'll have your warp drives back online in no time!

Name Mackem La Kiln

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role Excitable Chief Engineer

Health 2 Defence 12

Stat Dice

Smarts 5 (Engineering)

Moves 2 (Stealth)

Style 3 (Disguise)

Brawn 2 (Brawling)

Gear: Blazer, Communicator Badge, Laser Scalpel

To you, starships are a living, breathing thing to need just as much tender loving care as any other species. Once per day if you are in the engineering section, you can spend a Karma point to cause a starship to regain 1 Health or 1 Shield without a roll, or to make your ship go one warp speed factor faster than the Owner's Manual says you should be able to. The warranty is voided if you do this, but when did that ever stop you?

Orcs & Oubliettes

Captain Phanta

Intense Watch Captain

A magical construct with a heart, Captain Phanta was purchased by the Dusk Watch from Al & Dean's Artefact Shop to take over the job of cleaning out the ablutions of the various Watch Stations. This silver-plated mechanoid rose above the detritus of her intended fate and passed her entrance exams to join the Dusk Watch as an officer. It was only after she began rattling the cages of the various thieves' guilds and *actually* arresting people that the Dusk Watch began to realise the size of the problem they had created for themselves.

ACE! ID CARD

Name Captain Phanta

Trait/Role intense Captain

Health 3 Defence 7

Stat Dice

Smarts 4 (Engineering)

Moves 2 (Shooting)

Style 3 (Persuasion)

Brawn 3 (Carrying)

Gear: Sword (3 dice, 3 damage), truncheon (3 dice, 1 damage), Captain's badge, whistle, waterproof poncho, leather armour (+1 Defence)

Your badge gets you entrance into everywhere but the thieves' guilds those are by appointment only plus you can spend a Karma point once per scene to ask the Director for an important clue. Just the one mind. And if there aren't any clues, you don't spend the Karma point.



Grom Silverwing

Larcenous Sprite

A light-fingered faerie with hands that are often too small for the items that find their way into them, Grom has been an invaluable companion to Phanta ever since she tried to steal one of her shin guards. With one ear always tuned to the pulse of the street and one hand in the Dusk Watch's coffers, there isn't much in the way of information that Grom can't find out given a little time. Although she's sworn to Phanta that her pickpocketing days are behind her, what the Captain can't see hasn't really happened, right?



Name **Grom Silverwing**

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role **Larcenous Sprite**

Health 3 Defence 16

Stat Dice

Smarts 3 (Perception)

Moves 5 (Thievery)

Style 3 (Bluffing)

Brawn 1 (Tough)

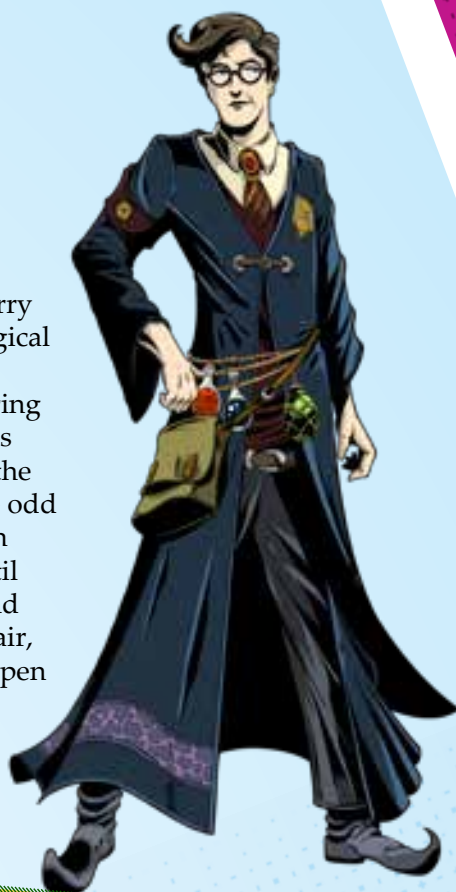
Gear: Small dagger (1 dice, 1 damage), truncheon (1 dice, 1 damage), whistle, waterproof poncho, leather armour (+1 Defence)

You can fly for a number of rounds equal to three times your Brawn. After that, you need to rest for the same number of rounds that you spent flying before being able to fly again. Or you can spend 1 Karma to refresh your flying to zero rounds. You start the game with 2 extra Karma.

Garry Swotter

Teenage Wizard

As the seventh son of a seventh son, it was hoped that Garry would be somewhat of a prodigy when it came to the magical arts. Flying through his studies at the Watchful Order of Witches and Warloques, Garry hit a bit of a brick wall during his third year when he was seconded to the Dusk Watch as part of his final assessment to enter his fourth. Patrolling the streets, dirtying the hem of his robe, and investigating the odd grisly murder just isn't for him. Up till now he hasn't been able to pass the assessment, so he's stuck at the Watch until someone takes pity on him or he pulls his stockings up and gets on with the job. As sulky as he is about the whole affair, it's looking more and more likely that the former will happen first.



Name **GARRY SWOTTER**

Trait/Role **TEENAGE WIZARD**

Health **2** Defence **6**

Stat Dice

Smarts **4** (Occultism)

Moves **2** (Shooting)

Style **2** (Gambling)

Brawn **2** (Sports)

POWER **3** (Fire)

Gear: Dagger (2 dice, 2 damage), truncheon (2 dice, 1 damage), whistle, waterproof poncho, wand (+1 Power)

YOU. HAVE. THE. POWER!

AGE! ID CARD

Soggoth

Inattentive Troll

Although the Dusk Watch are largely derided and ignored, they do sometimes need to make sure that the law is enforced or peace is maintained. Which is how certain characters like Soggoth make their way into the ranks. Sometimes the Watch need to at least pretend to investigate, other times they need to bring along the muscle and make sure folks are listening. For his part, Soggoth generally enjoys looming over people and offering his toothy grin. It seems to make his friends on the watch happy and means he ends up with a larger portion at mealtime. Speaking of food, is that the smell of roast hog coming from just over there...



ACE! ID CARD

Name **SOGGOTH**

Trait/Role **INATTENTIVE TROLL**

Health 7 Defence 10

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (Nature)

Moves 3 (Running)

Style 2 (Persuasion)

Brawn 5 (Brawling, Tough)

Gear: Club (7 dice, 2 damage), truncheon (7 dice, 1 damage), whistle, waterproof poncho, leather armour (+1 Defence), sack of leftover food

You gain the Tough Focus for free, in addition to whatever other Focus you choose for your Brawn Stat, and you deal 1 extra damage with your fists or weapons in melee. You also eat a lot and you're not too fussy about flavour.

DOMES OF THUNDER

DOCTOR PAIN

Doctor Pain is not a doctor. However, he once met a doctor, which is why he has this cyborg arm, and he's not happy about that. Still, the arm packs a heck of a wallop!

Doctor Pain enjoys a fight, and is happy to wade into any barroom brawl. He also enjoys a game of poker, and if he loses.... well, he's not known as Doctor Pain for nothin'!

Name **DOCTOR PAIN**

Trait/Role **ANGRY CYBORG**

ACE! ID CARD

Health **7**

Defence **9**

Stat

Dice

Smarts

2

(Perception)

Moves

3

(Driving)

Style

2

(Poker)

Brawn

5

(Tough)

Gear: Cyborg arm, card deck

Doctor Pain may spend a Karma point to make a Brawling attack and do double damage.

Name **THE WHIZ**

Trait/Role **ELDERLY MECHANIC**

ACE! ID CARD

Health **2**

Defence **12**

Stat

Dice

Smarts

4

(Engineering)

Moves

4

(Driving)

Style

2

(Music)

Brawn

2

(Drinking)

Gear: Heavy wrench 2 (2 damage), toolkit, overalls with many pockets

For every Karma point she spends, The Whiz can scrounge up enough material to repair 1 point of Health to a vehicle.

THE WHIZ

The Whiz has forgotten the name she was born with. She has also forgotten more about mechanics and engineering than most mechanics and engineers ever learn. A hard drinking, fast driving woman in her 80s, The Whiz can fix most things, and can drive anything on wheels.

ACE! ID CARD

Name **ROCKSTEADY**

Trait/Role **APOLOGETIC KANGAROO**

Health 4 Defence 18

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (Cooking)

Moves 4 (Dodging)

Style 2 (Gambling)

Brawn 4 (Brawling)

Gear: Boxing glove 6 (3 damage), cigarettes

Kangaroos pack one heck of a punch! Rocksteady's punch does an extra point of damage. Most people try to ignore the boxing gloves.

ROCKSTEADY

You'd think a kangaroo wearing boxing gloves was joke... until that gloves fist connected squarely with your jaw! Rocksteady is a bad gambler, but a great boxer. He also enjoys cooking. Nobody else enjoys his cooking, but most have the good manners to hide it.

SHOOTIN' BOB

An old-school shooting', tootin' wasteland warrior, in a bygone age Bob would have been a wisecracking cowboy. As it is, he's a leather-clad biker with a pair of six shooters that he knows well how to use. Oddly, he also likes to learn languages using some old cassette tapes he once found.

Name **SHOOTIN' BOB**

Trait/Role **COCKY WARRIOR**

Health 4 Defence 12

Stat Dice

Smarts 3 (Languages)

Moves 4 (Shooting)

Style 3 (Bluffing)

Brawn 2 (Tough)

Gear: Pistol 6 (3 damage), Motorcycle, two shiny six-shooters

Shootin' Bob's armor means he takes 1 less damage whenever he gets hit.

ACE! ID CARD

Bite Me!

A.C.E.!
AWFULLY
CHEERFUL
ENGINE

Name **FLUFFY WINTERS**

Trait/Role **RELUCTANT VAMPIRE SLAYER**

Health 4 Defence 18

Stat Dice

Smarts 2 (Perception)

Moves 4 (Dodging)

Style 4 (Fashion)

Brawn 4 (Brawling)

Gear: Sharpened stake 6 (2 damage), really fancy clothes

Fluffy slays vampires real good. She does double damage whenever she hit a vampire. The vampires don't like this. Ouch!

ACE! ID CARD

Fluffy Winters

All you ever wanted in life is the chance to ruffle some pom poms for the cheerleading team. But destiny wasn't going to let you have that one simple pleasure. You switched off during the lecture from that creaky librarian. Something about a prophecy and 'the Chosen One'. Some ancient order of slayers and vampires everywhere... whatevs. You know the pointy end of a stake and picked up the crossbow really easily. And at least you can still wear pink, as vampires tend to dust rather than spray blood everywhere. Red stains on pink would be a nightmare.

Lillo Thornberg

You've never quite fitted in, which is cool with you. You've always been happy with who you are. It's not like you can talk to animals or anything, more like you've always been able to see the signs their presence or actions mean. You have some pretty weird dreams too, which leads to a lot of déjà vu. Then you hit high school and found the library that just happened to be filled with books on

all sorts of occult histories and practices. That's where you met Fluffy. You make an odd duo but your knack for seeing snippets of the future has helped keep her out of too much trouble so far. You just wish she'd stop trying to get you to wear something other than black.

Name **LILLO THORNBERG**

Trait/Role **WITTY FORTUNE TELLER**

Health 1 Defence 6

Stat Dice

Smarts 3 (History)

Moves 2 (Driving)

Style 1 (Disguise)

Brawn 1 (Swimming)

Power 5 (divination)

Gear: Weak punch 1 (1 damage), Ouija board, Tarot deck

Lily gains a bonus die when using a tarot deck and instinctively know if a spirit conversing via a Ouija board is a harmful one. Also, she can do magic using her Power stat.

*See *Bite Me!* for rules for these items.

ACE! ID CARD

Rooby Roo

You grew up alongside Ted and had the perfect life filled with snax, naps, and lots of play. What made it even better was the fact that you could understand everything Ted ever spoke to you. So you started talking back once day.

After everyone's shock wore off, life became... different. But that was ok. Making your own food and being independent meant you could finally make a hamburger stack to the size you wanted. Then Ted started high school and your life was turned upside down. Ted likes to

help everyone and that led to him getting involved with really weird adventures. You're there for him of course, but you really wish he would stop chasing ghosts and other scary things.

Name **ROOBY ROO**

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role **FAITHFUL DOG**

Health **3** Defence **9**

Stat Dice

Smarts **3** (Cooking)

Moves **3** (Running)

Style **3** (Animals)

Brawn **3** (Eating)

Gear: Bite **3** (1 damage), An old tennis ball

A loyal companion, if there's something to smell you can always smell it. Also, sometimes you smell.

Name **TED BONES**

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role **CHEERY PARANORMAL INVESTIGATOR**

Health **3** Defence **9**

Stat Dice

Smarts **4** (Theology)

Moves **3** (Sports)

Style **2** (Flirting)

Brawn **3** (Stamina)

Gear: Hockey stick **3** (2 damage), Mystery Wagon, hockey stick

You gain a bonus die when searching for clues and interacting with any local authorities. You also begin the game with a brightly colored, mid-sized van called the Mystery Wagon.

Ted Bones

Not that you know it, you're pretty humble after all, but you've always been the cool kid. Good grades, good at sport, good with people. You're just so damn... good at everything in life. When you found out there were some pretty bad monsters out there that actually enjoyed scaring folks, you decided to make it your mission to protect people from them. And you know what, you're good at that too. With your faithful friend, Rooby, at your side, there isn't any paranormal investigation you aren't willing to tackle.

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GINGER

Ginger is a cat with a skilfully questionable set of morals and a morally questionable set of skills.

Having all the tell-tale signs of the typical pampered cat, Ginger accepts affection only on her terms, thinks little of how her actions affect others, and believes she is entitled to anything she can see.

On top of this, she is skilled with the use of lockpicks, is agile enough to scale buildings, and has the skill (and common sense) to remain unseen when performing these activities.

None of this is to say she is irredeemable, however. She risked her life freeing others from MOON LABS on the night of the escape, and even stayed behind to attempt to talk an old friend, Rex, into coming with her. He refused, and since then she has had difficulty trusting those around her, despite a strong desire for a genuine emotional connection. Though she would never admit that desire exists.

Name **GINGER**

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role **EMOTIONALLY DISTANT CAT BURGLAR**

Health **2** Defence **12**

Stat Dice

Smarts **2** (Botany)

Moves **4** (Thievery)

Style **4** (Persuasion)

Brawn **2** (Brawling)

Gear: Sharp claws **2** (1 damage), Lockpicks

Agile and sneaky though you are, your main power is your nine lives! Roll a die; that's how many lives you have left. When you would normally be Knocked Out, instead you remain at 1 Health.

Sneaky does it! Up that wall, through the window, crack the safe! Locks mean nothing to you.

AZURE

Azure is a peacock with a massive train of tail feathers, rivaled in size only by their ego.

Azure is completely obsessed with themselves, their image, their fashion, everything. They have dedicated most of their life to preening, designing outfits, and partying. When a new subject is broached, you can be certain Azure will find a way to make it about them.

While this attitude might sound off-putting, it's actually Azure's strength; on paper they sound irritatingly vapid, but there actually seems to be some credence to their assertion that they're the most important person alive. Of course, they're not, but it's easy to forget that. The way they hold themselves, the way they speak, their mannerisms, all obviously so practiced, and yet so endearing. Azure could talk a slug Hybrid into buying salt.

After spending enough time with them, that's the most irritating thing about Azure, though. A more modest person could do the same thing but wouldn't think they're MOON LABS' gift to humanity because of it. Those close to them consider Azure somewhat of a siren; listening to them is intoxicating but will only lead to a fatal consequence: in this case mild irritation and perhaps a bout of second-hand embarrassment.

Name AZURE

ACE! ID CARD

Trait/Role NARCISSISTIC PEACOCK CON ARTIST

Health 3 **Defence** 6

Stat **Dice**

Smarts 3 (Empathy)

Moves 3 (Shooting)

Style 5 (Fashion)

Brawn 1 (Tough)

Gear: Throwing knives 5 (1 damage)

You can fly (a bit). That's good, isn't it? You have to land each turn though. Also by displaying your tail feathers you can make a Style vs a target's Smarts, or they are fascinated for a turn and can do nothing but stare at you in awe. Rightfully so, frankly.

Liar, liar, pants on fire! You have a collection of very convincing fake IDs, and can pull out any one you need at a moment's notice.

HAMMY

Hammy is the hamster mom friend, who, fortunately, has not heard that hamster eat sometimes eat their young.

She has a lot of trouble letting go; much like the massive assortment of things she keeps in her cheeks, she becomes extremely attached to those around her and finds it hard not to micromanage and obsess over "helping" them.

The litany of junk she hoards in her mouth can be extremely useful, however. She is just as capable of pulling out a broken bicycle tire as she is a stun baton. Sometimes, she'll even retrieve something wonderful, like a high-tech tracking device or a unicycle! The unicycle is, admittedly, not incredibly practical, but still very cool.

She is extremely clingy. Ultimately this is because she cares; she is so invested in the lives of those close to her, that she can sometimes (read: all the time) involve herself a little (read: a lot) too much. Those around her can feel smothered or even manipulated. Ironically, this is what tends to drive a wedge between her and others, despite her best intentions.

ACE! ID CARD

Name HAMMY

Trait/Role CLINGY HAMSTER CHEF

Health 3 **Defence** 9

Stat	Dice
Smarts	3 (Cooking)
Moves	3 (Driving)
Style	3 (Disguise)
Brawn	3 (Eating)

Gear: Twin rolling pins 3 (1 damage)

You can spend 1 Karma and automatically pull out an item with a target number of 10 or less.

You can cook up an amazing meal in an hour, which gives everybody 1 Health back. Plus you do +1 damage with knives.

BRIZ BANE

The history of fisticuffs is rich, and the fascinating figures involved with it are fascinating specimens, but Briz Bane is neither. A porcupine convinced he comes from the Land Down Under, he speaks in a broad Australian accent and considers Crocodile Dundee to be an historical figure.

His total dedication to the craft of pugilism is admirable; while he is not exactly known for his powerful punches, his opponents know that to strike a target covered in spikes really hurts! Briz Bane has won multiple fights simply by standing there.

ACE! ID CARD

Name BRIZ BANE

Trait/Role QUIXOTIC PORCUPINE BOXER

Health 7 **Defence** 9

Stat	Dice	
Smarts	2	(History)
Moves	3	(Surfing)
Style	2	(Singing)
Brawn	5	(Tough)

Gear: Shooting quills 3 (1 damage)

You're covered in spiky quills. Whenever somebody makes a melee attack against you they automatically take 1 damage.

With a quick One-Two, and swift K.O., you really know how to punch. Your unarmed damage increases by 1. And also, once per day, when you would normally be Knocked Out, you can choose to remain on 1 Health.

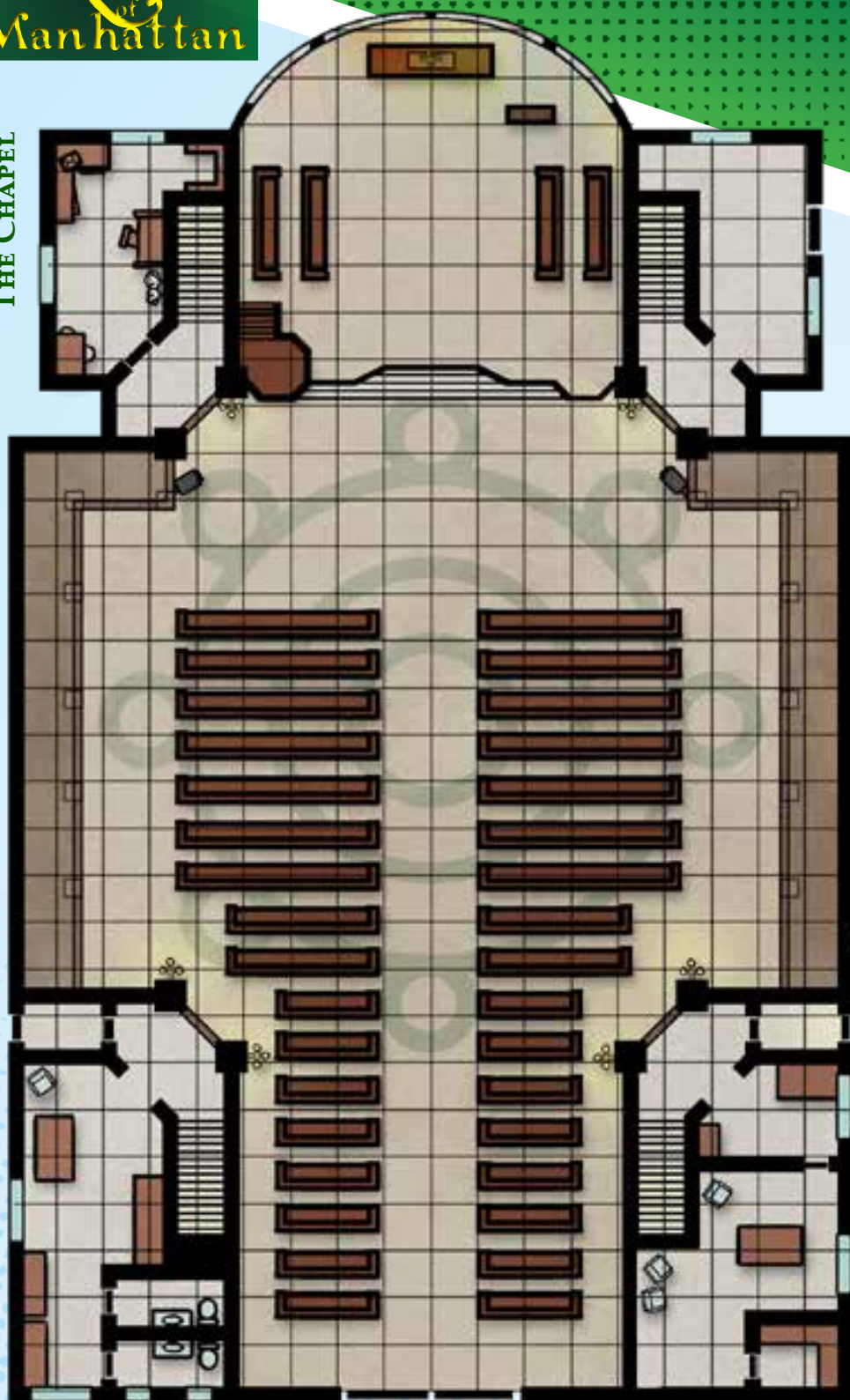
The background is a blue-tinted comic book illustration. In the upper center, a T-Rex is roaring with its mouth wide open, showing sharp teeth. Below it, a soldier in a helmet and armor is visible. In the lower right, a woman with long hair, wearing a tactical jacket and a belt with a skull emblem, is holding a long rifle. The overall scene suggests a high-action, sci-fi or military-themed environment.

ACE!
Extras

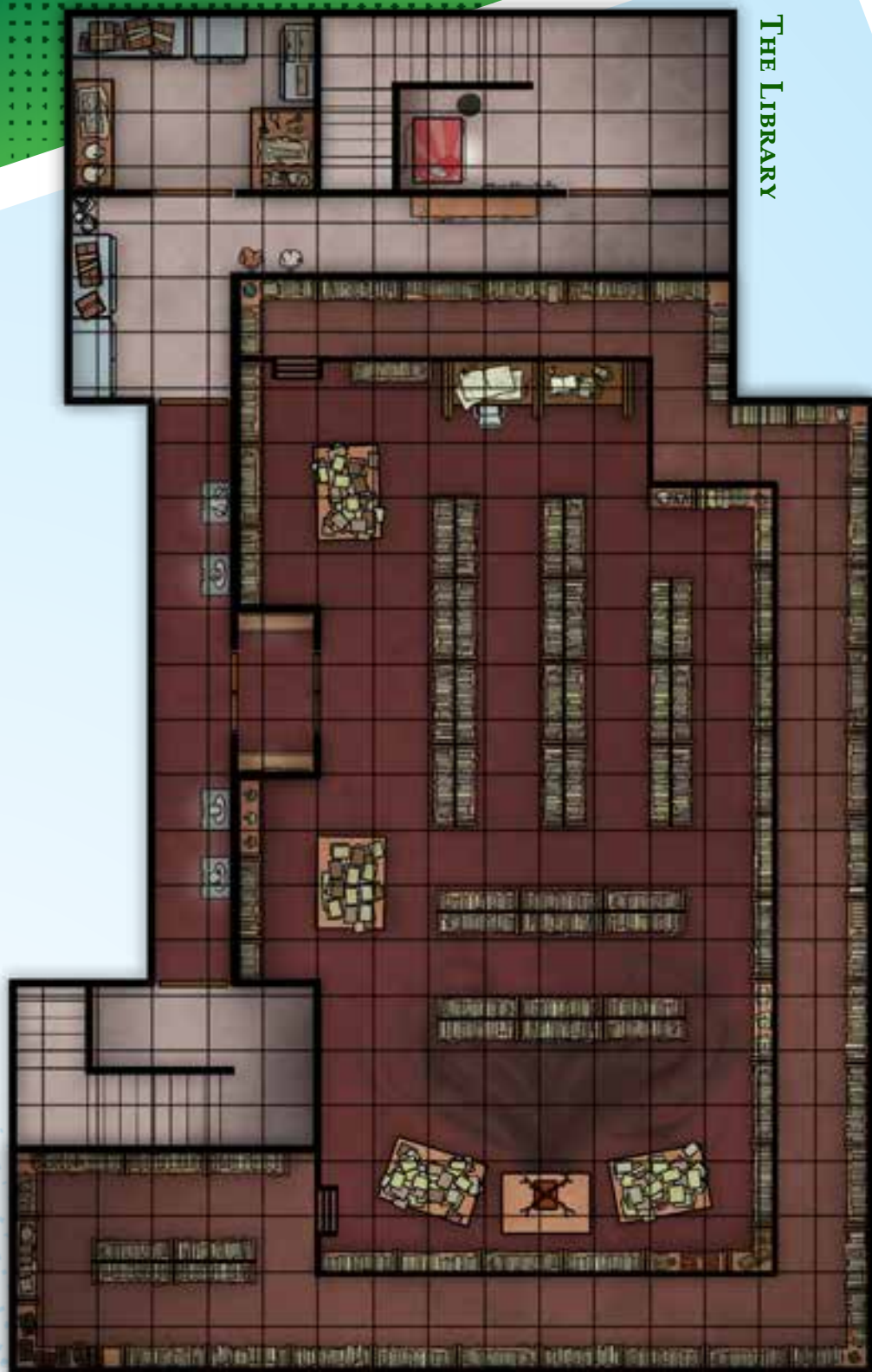
Battle and Area Maps

SPIRITS of Manhattan

THE CHAPEL



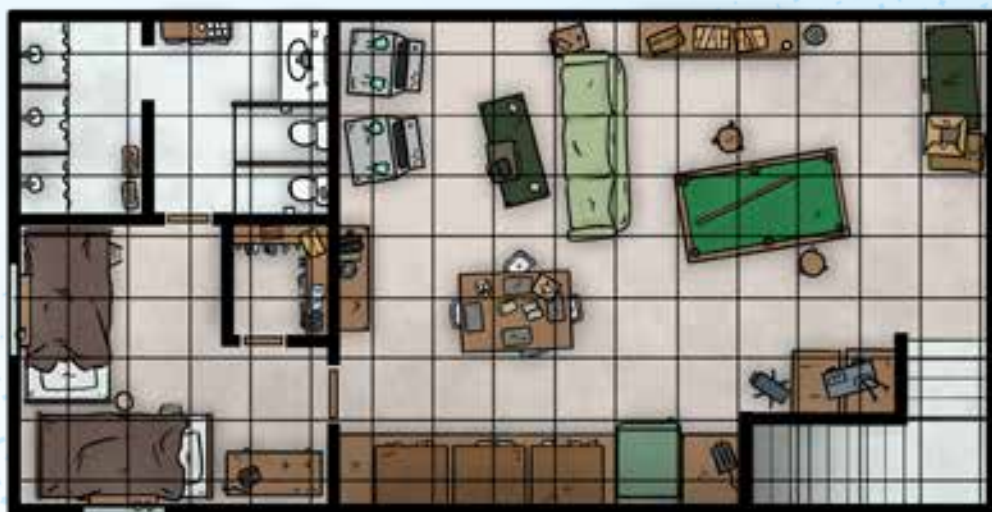
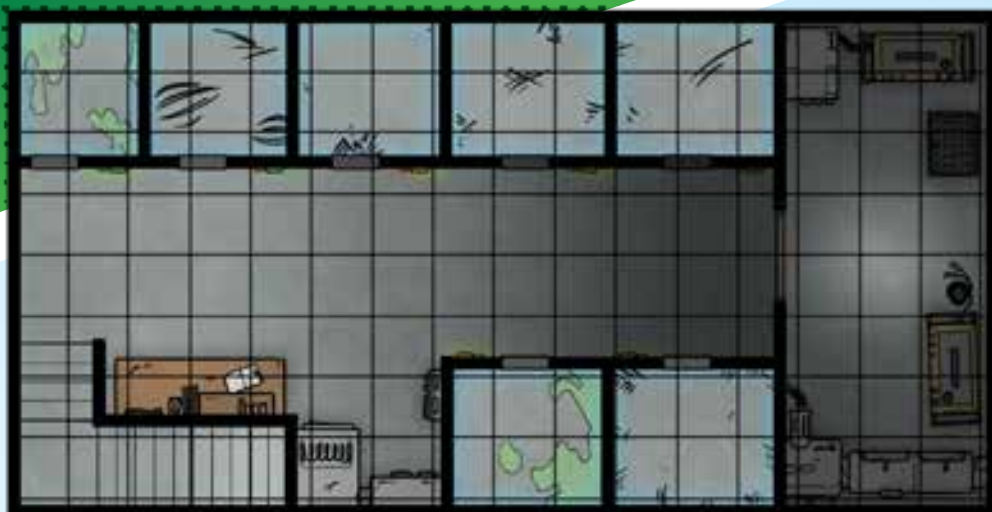
THE LIBRARY



THE GLITZMAN HOTEL

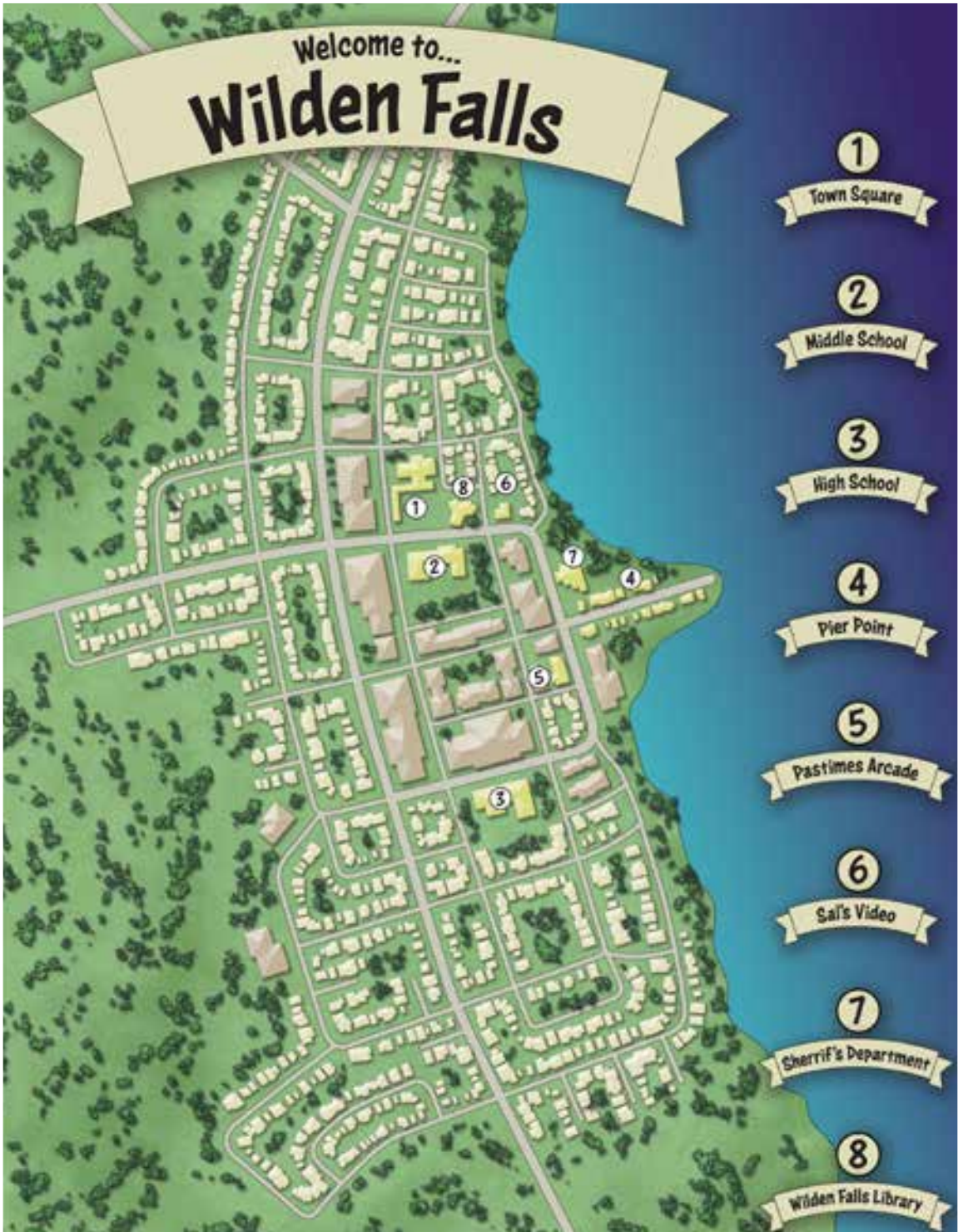


ENGINE 30 FIRE STATION



GHOSTBREAKERS HQ



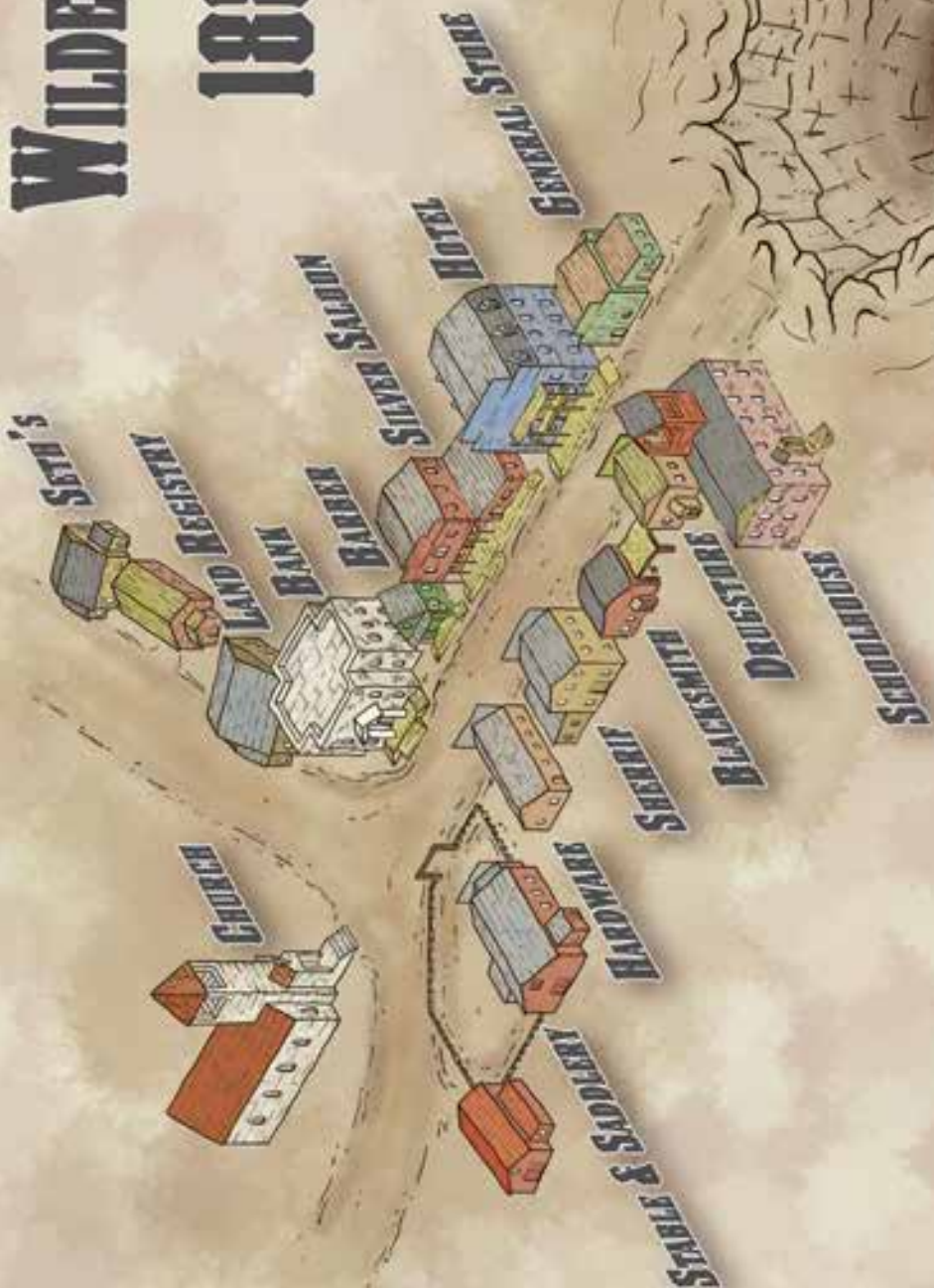


WILDEN LAKE



WILDENVILLE

1884

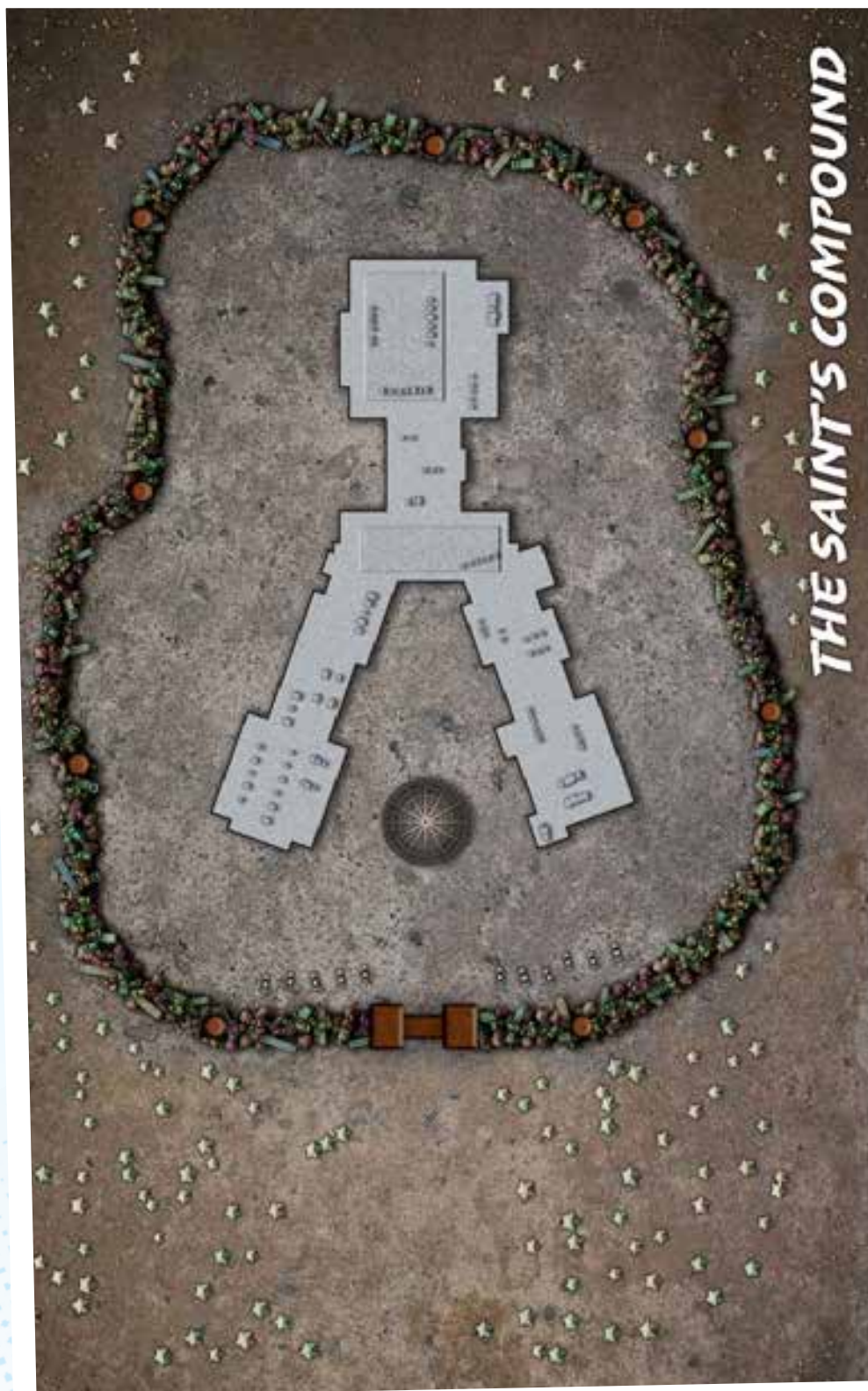


A.C.E.!
AWFULLY
CHEERFUL
ENGINE

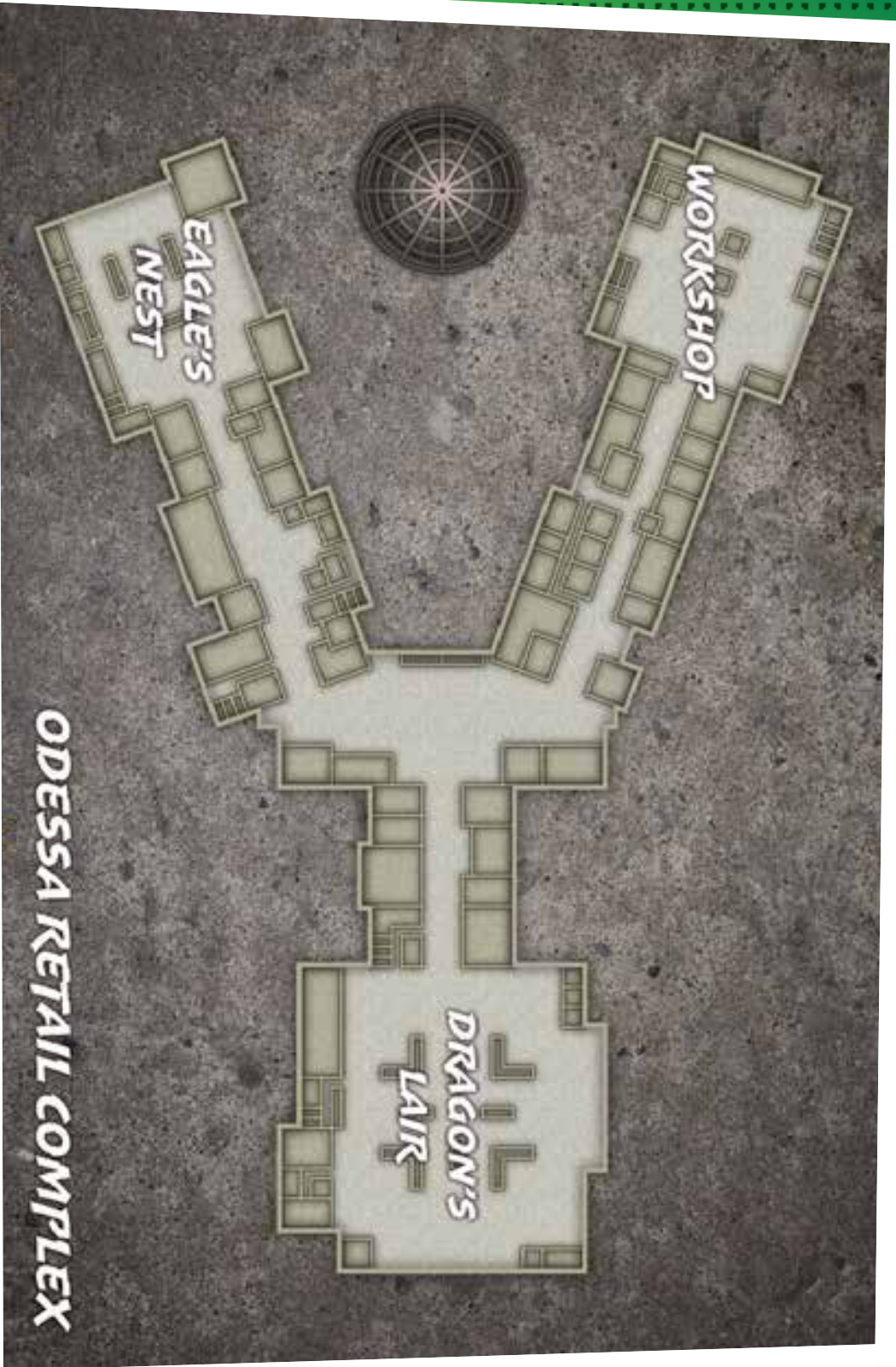
MONARCH'S SPIRAL



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THE SAINT'S COMPOUND



ODESSA RETAIL COMPLEX

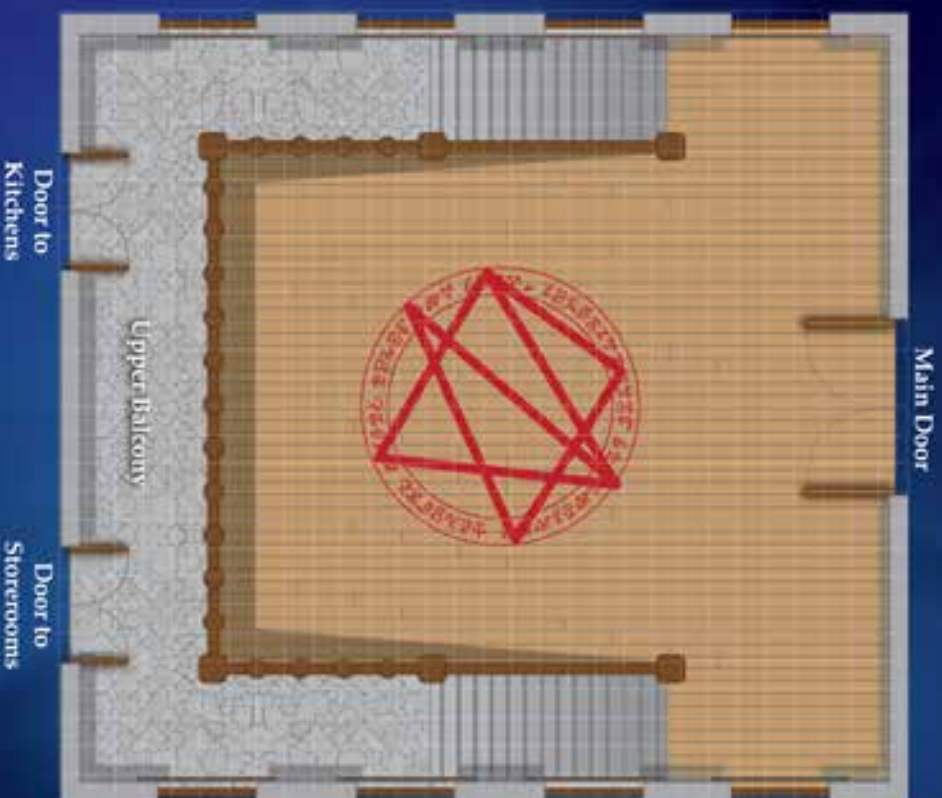
Bite
Me!

A.C.E.!
AWFULLY
CHEERFUL
ENGINE

Subterranean Sewer Set Up



The Hall of the Draculas!



ACTION! ADVENTURE! FUN!

Welcome to the Awfully Cheerful Engine, a cinematic tabletop roleplaying game of comedic action.

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In this hefty tome you will find a full compilation of *ACE!* Issues 1-9, which provide you with the core rules and hours of hilarious gameplay.

